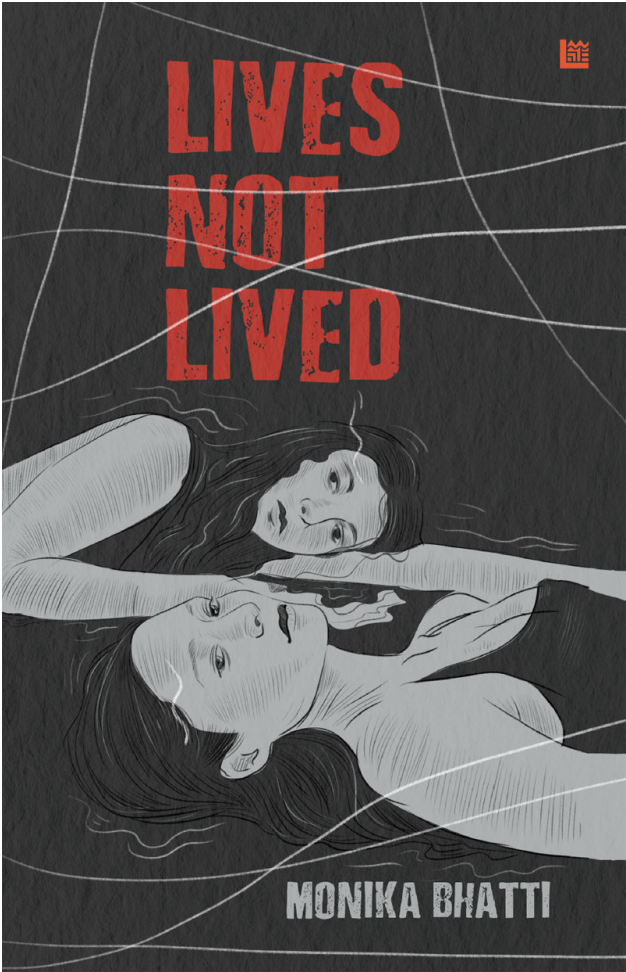




LIVES NOT LIVED



MONIKA BHATTI



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To all the women who suffered in silence.

To all the children who grew up in violence.

■

Naked I walked the streets, in layers I lived.

■

One covered my breasts, another looked between my limbs.

Some took me to their home to feed, some feasted on me.

I met GOD at one point, and as I turned Satan waited for me.

Naked I walked the streets, in layers I lived.

Last night, I walked naked on the street. The fire inside me was unbearable and I did not know how to ease it. The concrete below scratched my sole, but it felt good. Cold and prickly! Just like it used to feel when I was a kid. I still remember that rough touch.

There was only one light on the street, a yellow bulb at the far end. I could see a cluster of particles moving in circles under it, mosquitoes chasing each other. It's been years since I had seen that ring below that bulb. As a kid, I used to think that the bulb is vomiting the light. Stupid me! How many different notions I had about so many things!

I wish I could cut my hair before my mother took the scissor out of my hands. It would have been better. I could have felt the fresh air on my scalp as well. I feel my head is always heavy with my long hair. Every strand on my head hurts. It feels as if they are pulling themselves up, leaving my scalp all red and swollen. But my mother stops my hands when I try to pull them down or scratch my head. She says that I look stupid when I do like that.

Mental people do like that, she adds. I want to ask her,' Who are mental people?' But, I don't. I don't want to say anything to anybody. Words just don't come out.

When I cry for help my mother doesn't answer but she comes after some time. I hate her for not helping me. But I love her too, sometimes!

But I'll cut my treacherous hair the next time she leaves me alone. She hardly leaves my side these days. I always find her eyes looking at me. Many faces come and disappear but she remains constant. Her stare stings me. She tries to look beyond my face, probably, inside me. She wants to see her real daughter because the person she is looking at is not the one who came out of her. There is a stranger inside her daughter.

She looks old now. The last time I saw her, she was young, standing in the kitchen making rotis for me. She was youthful and active, walking with quick steps from one corner of the house to the other. I always found her finishing one chore and then picking up another. But these days, she sits with me for hours, keeping the one-side conversation alive.

There is no breeze. Not even a single leaf is moving, yet it's cold. I can feel it on my bare back, my breasts, my arms, and between my legs. I raise my arms in the air to feel the coldness in my underarms. My pubic hair under my arms and between my legs are sweaty and wet with all the heat my body has been generating. This coldness is soothing the fire in my body.

Whoever comes into my room puts the blanket on me. I keep throwing it but they keep putting it back on me. I hate it. I take my feet out of the blanket and let them get cold. But then my brothers come and rub them, and warm them again before putting them back in the blanket. I don't understand why they all are doing these things. Why don't they just leave me to myself and themselves to be like they always had been? Unconcerned and unloving! All the care they are pouring on me is making my burden heavier.

Nobody knows that I am out. I double-checked before leaving the room. My mother was sleeping, her face was covered with her dupatta. She always slept like this; I don't know why. She says that a woman should always cover herself wherever she is. It keeps the evil eye away. My father was

sleeping on a single bed which is a bit small for him. His legs were folded like a child's. His hand was under his head, like a pillow. He never uses a pillow, they hurt his neck.



All the doors of other rooms were shut when Naina had come out of her parent's room. She walked out of the house in slow and soundless steps. Her body has been burning with a fever for two days. She held her kurta from the corners, raised her hands, and took it out from over her head. She looked at her bra for a while. Her hands reached her back and undid the hooks. Pulling down the strings from her shoulders, she guided them to the end of her arms and then dropped them on the floor next to her shirt. After wiping the sweat from under the skin of her breasts, she untied the knots of her pants, and slipped her legs out of them one after the other. The sleeves of her pants gathered like rings around her bare legs. Her underpants followed the pants

and she moved out of her house. There were no locks on the door, just a latch that secured the house.

When Naina stepped outside of her house, it must have been late at night. It was pitch dark. One could hear piercing sounds of crickets and dogs barking from far away. There was only one yellow bulb glowing at the far end of the street. She looked around her.

The old neem tree in the neighbourhood looked like a giant man guarding the street. Everything felt different to her. As if space had shrunk within a few days. The last time she was out, the streets were bigger. There was one more tree next to the neem tree or maybe Naina was just imagining it!

She saw the wires above her head. Stretched from one end of the street to the other, overlapping each other. Some hung so low that she could even touch them if she stepped on her toes and raised her hands. But she knows her toes did not have the strength, to hold her weight. They are weak as paper.

The sky above looked cut in half by the wires, like a broken mirror, that had fallen on the floor and a few straight cracks had appeared on it.

She felt the pain rising from her heels to her calves and then reaching the end of her spinal cord. She walked slowly. Raising her left leg and limping with the other. There was a blue bruise on her right calf. There were bruises on her back, too. From a distance they looked like leaves on a stem, her backbone being the thin stem and bruise marking the leaves. Her shoulder blades ached when she raised her hands to feel the coldness around her underarms. She opened her legs a little to let the feeling pass her inner thighs as well. After a few steps, she realised that she couldn't walk like that anymore, the pressure on her left leg was causing excruciating pain. She winced for a few steps and then brought her feet back together and continued walking while limping.

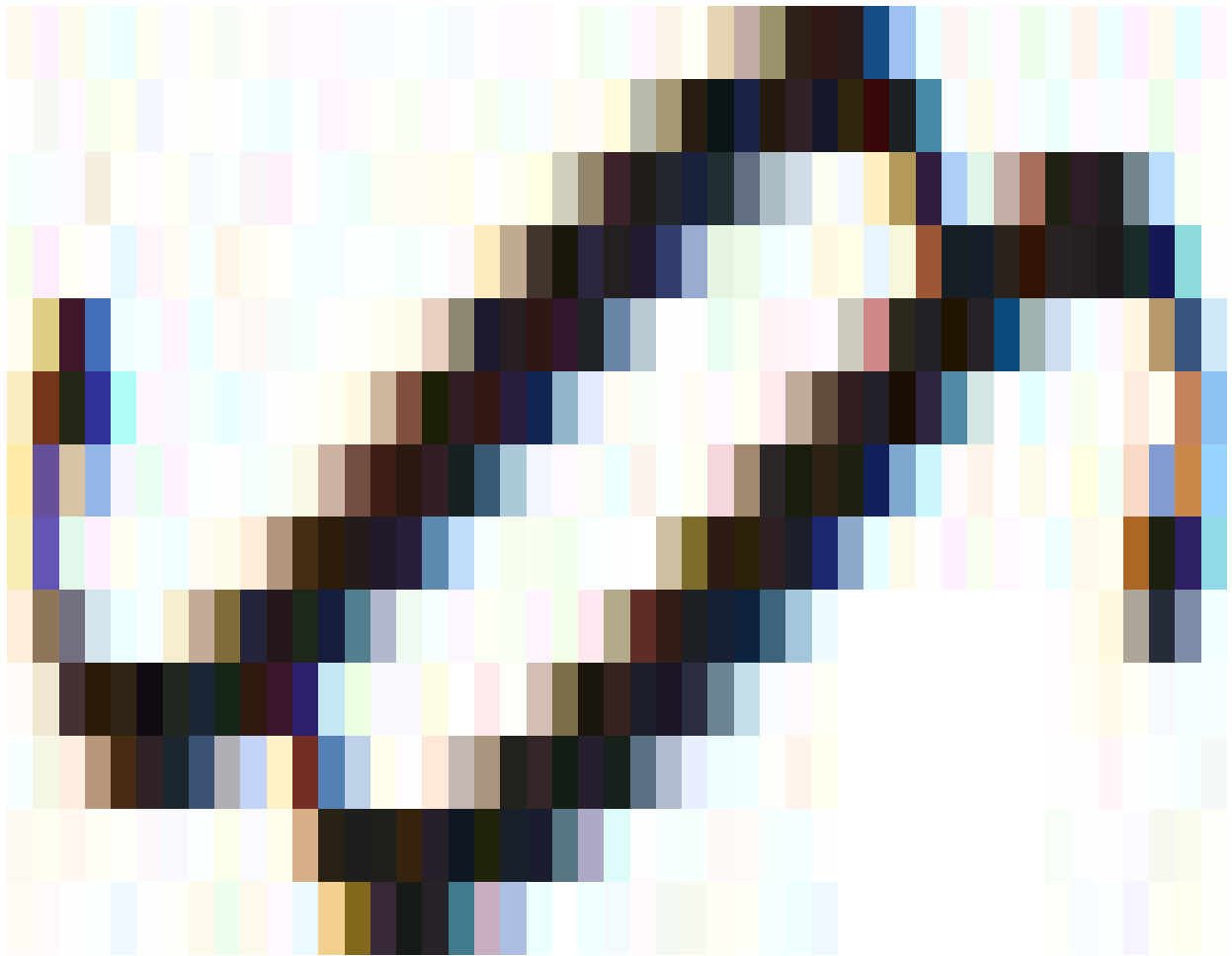
She had reached the corner of the street when her uncle, brother, father, mother and aunt came running to her. She was looking at the dust particles and mosquitoes moving under the yellow bulb. When she saw them, she wanted to run, take the next turn and then run across to the next crossing, where the market started. She could easily hide inside any shop there. She

knew some of the unconstructed buildings there. They had been like that for years. She used to play in them and hide whenever she sensed any danger around her. She saw herself splitting in two and one of the parts of her ran across the street. She saw that image taking the turn and then running again till the end without looking back at her.

Her mother took off her shawl and wrapped it around Naina. Her father, uncle and brother kept their eyes down till her mother covered her breasts securing the shawl on her shoulders. “What are you doing here and why have you removed your clothes?” Her mother whispered in her ears. Her brother looked around to check if anybody had seen Naina in this state or not. He nodded at his father after confirming that there was no witness to that event.

Naina did not say anything to anyone. She passed her gaze from one person to another - reading their faces. Her mother was crying silently. ‘She has been crying a lot these days’, Naina thought. She looked at her aunt. One of her hands was on Naina’s shoulder. Her mother and her aunt were holding her hands on the two sides and their other hands rested on her shoulders - to stop the shawl from dropping. Her aunt was looking down at her steps. “Why aren’t you wearing your slippers?” she asked looking at her. But then realising something, she looked at her feet again as if she had just remembered something.

Her uncle and father were walking in front of them. Their heads hung low as if they are searching for something on the street that they had dropped while running towards her. Her father looked back at them when he reached their house entrance. Naina and others were still very far. He looked around and then above to check whether any head was peeping out of a window and watching them. Once assured, he ran back towards Naina and picked her in his arms like a baby. As soon as her father picked her up, Naina closed her eyes. She could not look at his face; the realisation of being naked in his arms was overwhelming. Her mother secured the shawl again. Naina’s legs were hanging lifelessly; she had lost a lot of weight in the last four days. She was light as a feather in his long arms. Taking brisk steps, he entered the house.



I know my mother is sleeping next to me. She is not crying right now. But she would, after some time when my father would come and lock both of us in the room before going to his bed. He had started it after I walked naked. I will hear small, restricted sobs behind my back. She will call my name again and again, but nothing will reach me. Her words will die down before reaching my heart. They will get stuck between us. She calls me by different names these days, “Doll, My Moon, Jaan”. She had never called me like that before. She always used my name as plainly as she could. Her tone was never harsh yet never too sweet. But now, her voice is all sugary and juicy. It makes me cry sometimes but my tears do not come out. I know that I am crying. I can feel that something is breaking inside my body and then maybe blood is coming out of it. When she touches my shoulder to turn me, I close my eyes and pretend to sleep. I am unable to talk. My words are stuffed in my chest. I don’t know how to bring them further up.

“I am scared of her,” I heard my uncle tell my father. How can he be scared of me when it was always the other way around?

My throat aches whenever I try to speak. There is an itchy feeling in it since morning. I got it from the constant vomiting. It's been three days since I stopped eating anything. My whole body aches every time anyone touches me and even when nobody does. I have not left my bed in seven days, but it feels as if I have been walking constantly without food and water. I think of everything or maybe I never forgot anything at all. I can't tell the difference between these two now. I can't differentiate between when I am dreaming and when I am seeing things for real. Whether I am living the moment or imagining it, I don't know. It's more like I am just a spectator who doesn't have any control over the things which are happening in the play.

It seems that my eyes have lost the power of changing over between the worlds of imagination and reality when I close them. The curtain which separates these two dimensions has turned transparent. I can see all those images and moments in front of me that only I know that I have kept locked inside me. I never dare to see them when I am alone. It's my collection of dark memories, which I never want to see, even on my loneliest day. But now it seems that somebody has crept inside me and has opened the box, and the images are roaming freely in this world with new life in them. And this time, they are way more painful than the actual moments.

Every night I think of different ways to die. A secure enough way to make it look like not a suicide. I don't want my parents to think that I gave up my life due to some distress. I want them to cry over me and forget me after some time. With my death, all the secrets will die and nobody will ever have to live with them.

Even after planning my death, I wake up with an unknown hope that maybe someday, something will change and this pain will disappear. I heard somewhere that everything happens for a reason and maybe my soul is waiting silently for those reasons, which have landed me here. Maybe those reasons will bring me peace. But little did I know that all the answers which I am looking for were already there in my past. My past, I fear going back. But no matter how much I fear it, it's always with me. I can see it, from the corners of my eyes, standing next to me, waiting for my attention. It's

written on my skin, but I choose to ignore it. Yet the words glow and come alive at night. I close my eyes to ignore them, but they appear behind my eyelids.

CHAPTER

■

02

■

I lost myself,

The day I met you,

Now sometimes,

It's you in me,

And sometimes,

Only memories of

Who I was.

I see unfamiliar faces in my room. It feels as if my room is always full of people. When I ask my mother about them, she denies that there is anybody in the room.

Often, I see him smiling at me. Sometimes, I see him sitting next to my bed, but he disappears like a bubble when I try to touch him. I hear him calling my name from somewhere near, but when I look around, I don't find him anywhere.

Today, he is wearing the same white shirt that he wore the day I saw him for the first time.

Every detail of the day is still fresh in my memory. I can't wipe it out even if I want to. Every time I think about that day, I add some more details to it. Things that I missed at that time keep popping up, and now things are as clear as glass, as fresh as morning.

He was wearing a white shirt. And that day, I did not realize that white will be my favourite for the rest of my life. Before him, I did not know that anything could be my favourite. It's amusing how love adds details to your life. It layers over you such things that are not yours but you claim them as if they have always been your part. I know, I breathe his spoor even though he is not around me. He is now part of me and will always remain so. Like a canker, this part of me will ache from time to time and I'll live with it.

I remember telling him once that it was my favourite shirt of his. He had smiled at me holding the edges of its collar and said, "Mine too!" But today, he is not saying anything. He is just looking at me.

He still has those black circles around his eyes. Only that they have grown a little darker and thicker. He always has had problems with sleep. He could not sleep at all at night and would sleep only when the first rays of the sun came up. We spent our nights talking till dawn when both of us slept, to the rhyme of each other's breaths.

On that day of our first meeting, even before talking to him, I knew that we were exchanging something. I don't know what, but there was an unusual restlessness in my body with him around. When he looked at me, I shuddered under my skin as if he had touched me without my permission. He must have noticed it, for I could see his eyes turn confused and concerned as if asking me, "Did I touch you wrong?"

He somewhat half-smiled at me when my friend introduced me to him.

"She is my friend, Naina", she said without looking at me, pointing her left hand at me in a hurry. I knew she wanted to talk to him alone. She had been following him for a few days. And he had been actively responding to her flirty gestures.

Astha kept pacing up and down in the hallway, crossing his classroom and passing smiles at him from the window while I was sitting alone under a tree in the college park, waiting to leave for home together.

“I’ll stay a little late today in college. You can leave if you want to.” She said, while coming toward me. I had started gathering my bag and books to leave.

“Why? Do you have any more classes? I’ll wait for you.” I said, sliding off the bag.

I didn’t want to go alone. I couldn’t go alone. Being alone is the only thing I dread. Anything can happen when you are all by yourself. There is nobody to help you. There is no one to hear your screams. I did not want to tell her that I was scared. I feared everybody around me.

“No, I don’t have a class, you stupid!” she had said, a little irritated with me being clung like a baby to her all the time.

“There is a guy, remember, I told you about? He will talk to me today. So, I will wait for him.”

I looked at her. I could see a whiff of confidence in her eyes and a gleam of victory in her charm, something that I never felt in myself.

“How do you know he will talk to you?”

Details! I was always hungry for details of everything. I wanted to know everything about everybody. How did they live, what did they do, and what did they feel when in love?

“I just know,” she said, smiling or blushing, I am not sure. “See! I am giving him a chance. If he takes it, he is intelligent. But if he doesn’t, then he is just unlucky.” She flicked her hair in the air and winked at me. And I wondered! I kept staring at her while she blushed and giggled thinking something. Maybe, she was imagining that he came out of class and kissed her.

Whenever I heard anyone talking about boyfriends, I always pictured them kissing each other. I eavesdropped on others' conversations in the restroom, in the washroom, and the canteen. Girls smiled and talked in whispers while reapplying their lipsticks, rimming their eyes with multiple layers of kajal and telling each other how their boyfriends kissed them in the movie hall or secluded alleys of the library.

“He was about to kiss me on my lips but I turned my face so his lips touched my temples,” one of my classmates was telling others about her date last evening while we were waiting for the next class. Her friends were sitting circling her whereas I was just outside the circle. If someone looked at us from the top, we would be looking like a balloon with me as the tail.

I was never part of these conversations. Not because I didn't have anything to say but because I felt that I didn't even have a right to say anything. For me, it was a privilege that they let me be around them and that they at least let me have a glimpse of their lives, albeit with a silent warning of maintaining a safe distance. So, I always listened carefully taking a fill of the other world from their words. A world unknown to me, a world I knew, I'll never be part of.

“Look! He is coming.” Astha said in a low voice, not more than a whisper. She quickly turned her back on him and holding me at my shoulders turned my face in his direction.

“Did he see us? Is he coming towards me?” she asked, jumping on her feet. The restlessness and excitement in her voice made me very nervous.

“Tell meeeeeee...!” she nudged me again before I could even spot him in the crowd. So many students were coming, boys and girls in groups. A group of seniors was coming toward us. She had told me a few days back that one of the seniors had a crush on her. I looked through them. ‘Is anybody looking at her?’ But, before I could spot anyone like that, she turned on her heels and said, “There.....!”

Look at your right! In front of the Administration wing! Can you see a guy in white there?”

I followed her eyes. There was a group of five, two girls and three guys. Out of them, the boy in white was conspicuously striking.

“The guy in a white shirt!” she stressed to make sure that I saw him. And before he could see her, she again turned her back towards him and stood facing me.

Little did she know that she was not just describing him to me, but she was inscribing those words in my mind forever. This moment was getting etched in my memory with the tag, “The guy in a white shirt!” Later, I started looking differently at people who wore white colour. I want to see whether they also complement this colour as he did. Can they also deceive the purity of white as he did?

At first, I could not see his face. Soon his group started walking towards the park, where we were standing. Sun reflecting from his white shirt made it difficult to see where he was looking. I pretended to be casual, but inside I was stiff and alert.

“They are coming towards us,” I mumbled, my heart thudding in my chest. The proximity of strangers always scares me, more so when it’s friendly. I wanted to disappear before they could reach us.

I had always been invisible to people around me. Even when I tried to grab their attention with pranks or silly jokes, they ignored me. But that day, I wanted to be invisible of my choice.

I knew I was different, but I could never understand what repelled people from me. Nobody told me and I never dared to ask either. The only attention I ever got was because of my eyes. My eyes! I don’t think they even suit my face! They seem to have been borrowed from someone else, somebody who is long dead. What people see in them is not my reflection. In my eyes, they see his or her soul, whom I don’t even know.

“Your eyes are beautiful,” some say when they meet me for the first time. Others just stare at me so long that it becomes awkward for me. I must move my gaze from them. And they retreat to themselves as if they have

seen something sinful in my eyes. They appear to be running away from me before I sucked them in through my eyes.

I have heard many things about my eyes. Words that keep ringing in my ears and I spend my nights thinking and asking myself, “What is it that I don’t know about myself that other people know? Which part of me is not available to me but stands naked in front of others? Why do I see a different person in me and others see someone different?”

“Excuse me!” a guy from the group came and tapped on Astha’s shoulder.

“I was wondering if I could talk to you for a minute?” he said with politeness, so fake that even his smile could not hide it. Astha turned towards him and said, “Yes!” in a mechanical response, her eyes wide open in curiosity.

However, even before he answered, I saw all of them walking toward us. I took two steps backwards and virtually hid behind Astha.

“Hey! I am Veer,” He said, shifting his car keys in his left hand before holding out his right hand to her.

“Hi! I am Astha.” She smiled with her eyes this time.

“Meet my friends Abhishek, Yukti, Prerna and Samrat.”

I could not see his face but I knew from his hand gesture that he was pointing at his friends while taking their names.

“Hi! Hello! Hey!” everyone greeted as their names were being called.

There was silence for a while before she realised and introduced me to them.

“She is my friend, Naina.” She had said without looking at me, pointing her left hand at me in a hurry.

He tilted his head to the right and looked straight at me. I noticed that his half-smile had suddenly turned into a look of confusion. I was confused. I

felt that my eyes were giving away something that I had held but was not aware of. At that time, I did not know what I was walking into. But someone inside me knew it and was stopping me from going ahead. I dropped my gaze quickly to the ground and my 'Hello' got stuck to my lips.

"So, what do you study?" Astha asked him before I could say anything.

And as it happened always, I again became invisible to everyone. Except him. He held my gaze till we departed and left through the college gate, his eyes following us till we disappeared into the crowded bus.

■

*On this earth, I came in pieces,
God sent my body and then came my heart.
When world lifted my veil, they saw my skin,
My heart remained untouched, hidden within.*

Ashok lifted Haree's skirt to her knees. Haree woke with a start when she felt his rough fingers between her legs. It was still dark but she was sure that morning was not far. He always came before dawn, when the night is in its darkest phase. She opened her eyes. All she could see was a silhouette near her mat. It looked as if someone had drawn an outline of a human being and then filled it with solid black colour.

Her eyes were fully open, Haree was trying to soak every possible detail of his blank profile. She saw his hands moving, undoing his pyjamas. His movements were swift and effortless as if his hands had their own set of eyes. They could see in the dark. He freed his legs from the loose cotton pyjama and hung them on one of the nails on the wall without even looking at it.

He tapped again on her right knee when he came over to her. It was his signal for asking for more space between her limbs. She opened her legs for his bulky figure. She had stopped resisting the process, unlike in earlier days. She had understood that she had to pay her side of the bargain. A

price for all the happy days she had lived so far, and was dreaming to live in future. This is nature's way of compensation. Apart from her body, there was nothing she could offer to him, and there was nothing else that he would accept.

She pulled her skirt above her waist and clutched it in a tight grip on her two sides. When he pushed himself in her, she clenched her grip, all her power held in her fists, like anchors which held her body down so that she should not fly out of it. She could feel her nails digging into her palms, the thin fabric of her skirt crushed between them - unable to breathe, like her.

“What happened to you? Where is your garma? Haan?” He asked her while moving up and down in slow movements over her.

She always covered her face with pallu whenever he was over her. Even though she knew that he could not see her face in the dark, she wanted to hide it from him. She didn't want to let him have the slightest pleasure of seeing the despair on her face. But her eyes remained wide open, behind that veil. She could not see his face, nor could she not read his expressions. But she could see the moving silhouette and hear domination in its voice.

“Speak up you whore? Have you cut your tongue this time?” he would speak in a croaky voice. “Now you like it, I know!” “I always knew you wanted this. I saw it in your eyes, you dark pussy!” He kept saying things to her until he finished himself off.

She had never seen his face eye to eye. It was always from behind the veil that she caught glimpses of his face. She wondered, when did he see my eyes? She didn't remember removing her purdah in presence of any male in the house.

“It's good that you have accepted it. Now you are a good raand!” he said, disgorging his pleasure inside her. When he got up from her, she saw him wiping his limp penis with her skirt. A thing he always did before leaving. They looked at each other in the darkness. She knew that he was grinning at her and he knew that she was looking at him.

It's been three years since she started living in this room, a room without a door. An old kitchen was turned into her room. Haree had stitched a curtain from pieces of old sarees, bed sheets, pyjamas, shirts, petticoats etc. and hung it at the entrance after the first visit of Ashok. Her shift from her bedroom to this four-by-four space was slow, almost invisible to the eyes. It happened gradually over the years. Nobody asked her to shift, but everybody made sure that she did. It started with twenty-one days of stay during mourning. But then, it never ended. Days turned into weeks, weeks into months and months into years, but she did not move out. Her new world grew, died and rotted in that room.

When her husband died, her mother-in-law asked her to sleep in the kitchen till the last rites were performed.

“Deceased's soul roams around the house for thirteen days. It tries to find its way back. If you sleep in your room, he might never leave. I want my son to go peacefully now. You did not let him live. At least after his death now, let him go peacefully,” she had said.

In the evening, Haree was bringing a mattress from her bedroom to the kitchen, when her mother-in-law broke into a howl. Rhythmically thumping her chest, she cried, “Here, my son has died, and this queen wants the pleasure of a mattress to sleep!”

Haree had never heard her mother-in-law talking like that before. It took Haree years to understand the reason for that sudden burst of emotion. Love and loss of children can do such things to a mother that only she can understand.

So many relatives had arrived. All the women, aunties, and wives of cousins gathered around her, looking at her with scorn. Some of them consoled her mother-in-law, and some just talked amongst themselves in whispers. Haree could not hear what they were speaking, but their voices entered her ears sounding like hisses, popping up and vanishing like a snake's tongue.

When the men of the house entered the veranda, all the women pulled their scarves over their faces. Their chests were still heaving in and out with their

cleavage exposed, but their faces were covered.

Haree stopped in a freeze, her eyes glued to the floor and the rolled mattress resting on her waist. A few seconds later, she felt somebody's hand over her head. The wife of one of the brothers was pulling her scarf down to cover her face. She felt a rude jerk at the back of her neck, but she remained unmoved. Her green eyes had turned glassy and empty behind the veil. She wanted to shout back at whoever had dared to touch her. How dare she touch her? But she remained still like a statue, standing there, holding the mattress, waiting for the moment to pass so that she could go and sit alone somewhere in the corner.

"It's okay, let her sleep on the mattress." Her father-in-law said to her mother-in-law, who immediately burst out.

"Haye Ram, I don't know what magic has she done on everybody in this house. First, she has eaten my son and now even you are taking her side, bringing more misfortune by breaking the rituals."

She continued in a frenzy, "I don't know what sorcery she has in those green eyes! She has not shed even a single tear and now she wants the pleasure of a mattress."

"Bring the mat," she shouted.

A young boy, who was standing with the males, ran down to the hall where men had been sitting during the day. He rolled up a mat the size of a single bed and came back with it and stood there holding the rolled-up mat on his waist, waiting for other instructions.

From behind her dupatta, Haree could only see pairs of feet around her. She could recognize them. Her mother-in-law was standing right in front of her. Next to her, was the younger brother of Haree's husband. On the right side of the room, her father-inlaw was pacing to and fro. Although she could not see, she knew that all the other ladies were standing behind her.

She could hear them whispering, sometimes amongst themselves and sometimes directed to her.

“Don’t know what has gotten into her that she is behaving like this?” one of them said.

“My father would kill me if I were in her place.” another said.

“I can’t even imagine that she is fighting over a mattress, how can she even sleep?” another voice said.

Everybody probably expected her to free the mattress from her body. When she did not let it go, her mother-in-law signalled the same boy. He threw the mat on the floor and snatched the mattress from her. He took it back to her bedroom and came back running to enjoy the rest of the scene.

Later, when everyone had left, Haree sat in a corner in the veranda, where women had been sitting all day long for mourning. She hadn’t picked the mat. She did not have the strength to do anything. She pulled her knees till they touched her chest and looked at her feet. Her toes looked different.

Yesterday, when she was cleaning them while taking a bath, there were silver toe rings with red stones on them. They shone in the sunlight. But now, her toes were naked. Instead of rings, there were ring-shaped marks on them looking at her like strangers. She stared at them for a long. When she could not bear the emptiness, she picked her skirt from the corners and spread it around her feet and covered them.

She must have dozed off sitting there because when she opened her eyes and looked up, it was dark. There was silence all around. Probably all were in their rooms. There was no light coming from any of the rooms. A lantern was spreading dim light in the veranda. She breathed relief in the silence and darkness of the night. ‘Now, I can be myself.’

She removed her scarf from her head, opened her braid, and let air pass through them. Her mind snugged a memory of how her husband used to undo her braid before going to bed. “I like your hair open. They make you like a goddess. My Goddess!” he used to say. She would blush and let him play with her hair until he slept.

But soon the silence scared her. She wanted to run away as if that silence would engulf her. She went towards her bedroom out of habit. The door was closed. She wondered if somebody was there in the room. Stopping at the door she listened. Was there any sign of life inside? Suddenly, the realisation of the death of her husband made her shudder. She was supposed to sleep in the kitchen. She had to cross two more rooms to reach the kitchen that was at the other end of the veranda.

Before entering the kitchen, she took off her slippers. Baskets of onion and potato were hanging on one wall and three shelves built on the other wall plates, bowls and pots were neatly sitting upside down.

She lowered herself in one corner on the hard floor. Yesterday, she mopped the floor with clay and cow dung. Marks of her hands, moving in half circle, were still present there. She lay down curling herself into a foetal position, her knees touching her chest and hands wrapped around them. Her body touched the cold and rough floor. The thought of the mat that was lying untouched outside came to her mind for a moment, but she didn't mind the scrapping on her skin. It was not as painful as the other pain she was going through.

The next day, she sat in the corner again, when other women gathered to mourn. Her mother-in-law was sitting next to her, crying aloud whenever a new visitor came in. Haree sat there, silent like a stone, untouched from the streams of tears flowing around her. Women took turns coaxing her to cry.

"Cry Haree, cry! Cry, else you will go mad," one of them said, pulling her head onto her shoulder and tapping. The moment she was free from the grip, Haree slipped back to her place and sat like a statue.

Another came and taking Haree's hand in her hands said in a voice filled with pity, "Look at your wrists, Haree! They are empty. Now you are a widow. Your bread earner is gone. He is not coming back if you are waiting for him." Pushing Haree's hands towards her eyes, she nudged her again, "See!"

Haree looked beneath her veil. She saw her bare wrists coming out of her white shirt sleeves rolled up two folds. She always kept her sleeves rolled

up to make space for her bangles giving them space to move freely and jingle as wildly as they could. She liked their clinking while she worked all day long.

Two days ago, there were more than a dozen red bangles on her wrists. She did not remember when she had removed them. Did somebody else remove them? Was it yesterday or the night they came to know that her husband was no more? She did not remember. Now, when she was looking at her hands, they too looked different, just like her toes. She could not recognize them as though they were not hers. Somebody had replaced her beautiful hands with these ugly ones while she was sleeping. She was not accustomed to seeing them like this. She stared at her hands for a while and then crossed them around her chest.

“Hiding them away won’t do any good, Haree!” the woman hugged Haree and cried, rocking her to and fro in her arms.

But Haree didn’t cry.

Her eyes were as dry as a summer day. Everything was stuck inside her, tied up in different knots. Knots of denial in her heart, knots of acceptance in her head, knots of words in her throat, knots of tears in her eyes! She needed time to untangle them. It seems as if every corner inside her was choked. Nothing could go inside her and nothing could come out. It was like she was living in a bubble. She could see others but was unable to recognise their faces. She saw them talking in silent words with weird sounds coming out of their mouths.

At night when everyone left, she went back into the kitchen. The mat was standing rolled and propped against the wall. A folded bed sheet was also lying near it. The green and red coloured mat and the blue bed sheet with colourful big flowers on it became her first possessions in that small space.

She unrolled the mat and lay flat on her back using the bed sheet as a pillow. She looked around. The open veranda looked big at night. A lone neem tree standing in the middle of the courtyard looked like a giant ghost. Her mother used to tell her stories about ghosts and she would be scared as

hell. But that day she wasn't feeling anything. All her emotions seemed to have left her. With her tears, they had also dried up.

When she got tired of looking at the tree, she rolled to her right side and curled up like a baby. She brought her left hand to her head and moved her fingers in her hair like her husband used to do until she slept.

■

*A secret unfolded in my ears one night,
Tears of my mother held me tight,
Slaps on her cheeks cried and yelled at me,
Rise and conquer the world she did never see!*

On her first day at college, her whole body was shaking when she entered the classroom. When she spoke, words seemed to be in a hurry to come out of her mouth. They were not connected. They just came out as different individuals. It was like she had overeaten a few random words and was now belching out. She was out alone in the world for the first time, confronting a rush of unknown people around her. All life she had lived within the safety circle of her father, uncles, and brothers. Even that day, her father had sent one of her brothers to college. He was standing in the corridor, waiting for her signal to come and help her if anyone tried to harm her.

A maze of people kept appearing and disappearing from different directions, like hundreds of multi-colour balls rolling around freely. Windows of classrooms were wide open. Groups of young boys and girls were sitting on top of the desks on the back side of some classes. Some groups were sitting on the stairs.

Everyone there looked the same and different at the same time. Some teachers were also moving around, coming out of and going into classes,

keeping their heads low. As if they didn't want to see anybody around them.

Before that day, she had never been allowed to deal with outsiders. Everything was pre-set and pre-talked by her father, uncle, and her brothers. They decided what should be her career and all her forms for college were filled out by her brother. Naina was used to moving through the burrow of life, holding the hands of males. She was secure and suffocated.

"Teaching is the best career for any girl," her father had said. All the males in the house were sitting together to decide the next decision of her life and she was standing in the corner, holding admission forms Journalism and Mass Communication courses.

"Journalism and Communication have a lot of fieldwork. And it's a tough job. You need to talk to people who know what kind of people you meet while doing this journalism-vernalism. This is not safe for girls," her younger brother, who was still in school, said.

"I can go for B.B.A. as well. My other friends are also going for this. I can get a degree in Business," she tried to negotiate.

Her uncle let out a sarcastic laugh, clapping his hands and then stopping abruptly when her father started speaking.

"What business do you think you can do?" her father asked, still turning the brochure of the selected college.

Before she could comprehend the question from her father, her uncle interjected, "And why should you do any business? We will find you a rich man to marry. All you need to do is get a degree for that." He looked at her and then at her father, who was still reading something in the brochure.

"Who knows what kind of house is written in your fate? Maybe your husband won't allow you to do a job. That's why I am saying, teaching is the best career for girls. You can teach in a school or can take tuitions." Her father offered rationale, "This way you can also give time to your family and unlike your mother, you can at least teach your children."

Thus, it was settled that Naina would graduate in teaching. And the admission forms of Journalism etc. kept lying for days on the corner table and were later thrown away in a dustbin with other waste.

The day her results for Class 12th were to be announced, she woke up early, a rare thing for her. She had not been able to sleep all night. She had kept thinking about her exams, tallying marks for all the papers in her head again and again. Even though she had done this exercise many times before, that night she felt unsure of every calculation. Her Economics paper had not gone well. She remembered having somehow managed to attempt it fully. 'What if my answer sheet is lost? What if I wrote my roll number wrong there? What if the teacher checking my copy, is a frustrated man and takes out frustration on me?' She tossed and turned waiting for the sun to rise.

After breakfast, her father was sitting at the dining table with the newspaper in his hand. She held his phone tight to her ear. She was on hold for the last twenty minutes.

"Please wait, you are still in the queue" a computerized voice was repeating incessantly with scratchy music in the background. The wave of restlessness in her body since last night was getting intensified and turning into pain. The irritable music was equally painful to her ears, so she kept shifting the phone frequently. In front of her lay the piece of paper on which she had written her roll number.

A few minutes later, a voice started giving instructions to key in her roll number. She freaked out and gave the phone to her father. Her father flattened the paper with the base of his palm and signalled her to bring a pen by joining his thumb, index, and middle fingers together as if he was holding an invisible pencil.

"English ... Sixty.. Two," the voice said pausing between words. Her father immediately started writing, holding the phone between his left shoulder and head.

"Business Studies.....Seventy.. Four," the voice continued and the tip of her father's pen moved frantically stopping intermittently. "Accounts..

Seventy... Five.” Naina could hear the voice faintly. Her eyes didn’t leave the tip of the pen and her legs were shaking below the table.

“Economics.....,” the voice was extremely feeble. Naina covered her face with her palms and shut her eyes when she saw her father was writing “Eco” on the sheet.

She was mumbling prayers behind her hands when her father tapped on her shoulder with the pen. He moved the paper towards and said, “Chalo! At Least you passed your high school.”

Naina looked at the sheet. The big slanted letters in running hand read,

1.Eng - 62

2.BS- 74

3.Acc - 75

4.Eco - 60

5.Maths - 80

Naina beamed and looked at her father. He was smiling back at her. She ran to the kitchen and, pushing the sheet in front of the eyes of her mother, said gleefully, “More than seventy percent, Mummy!”

“Good, very good,” her mother said, but before that, she had run out of the kitchen. She ran downstairs, skipping steps in between, and showed the sheet with her marks to everyone in the house.

Her uncle was getting ready for work. She hugged him and yelled, “Uncle, I got more than seventy percent!”

He put his hand on her head and blessed, “Good girl! Keep growing like this always and make us proud.” He freed himself from her grip, and Naina ran to her grandmother’s room to tell her.

She kept running in the house, from one room to another like a train, for nearly an hour spreading the news throughout the entire house. She was laughing uncontrollably and making squeaky sounds in between while telling stories about the economics exam.

Her smile didn’t leave her face the whole day. Bubbles of happiness and excitement kept floating and dissolving in her stomach. At night when she lay down on her bed, a smile still lingering on her lips, her body was weightless, as if it was made of cotton, soft and light as a feather. She had become the first girl in her village to pass high school. Most of the girls in her village never crossed past the ninth standard. Some dropped out themselves, while many were forced to drop out of school.

“What would you do in school? You have studied enough. Now learn some household work from your mother. This is your real education,” parents used to tell them. And almost all agreed without saying anything.

Naina remembered Shanti. They were in 7th standard when Shanti stopped coming to class. The first day when Shanti didn’t come to class, Naina was very happy, because she had the first bench for herself. The two of them were not friends, they were competitors. Always in a fight - for sitting on the first bench, for being a volunteer for helping the teacher, like collecting notebooks from students for checking, leading the team in game periods, etc. They were always fighting for being ahead of each other.

On the fourth day when Shanti didn’t come, Naina went to Shanti’s best friend’s bench and teased, “Had she died? Or is she just scared of me that she is not coming to school these days?” She waited for the answer with a greedy grin on her face.

“She is getting married” Words of her friend were heavy and soaked in sadness. It appeared that it took a lot of her energy to speak the four words.

Naina went back to her seat, her face white as chalk. She squeezed her stomach as if something might come out of it anytime if she didn't hold it tightly.

When the recess bell rang, she didn't run to fight over the ride. She sat quietly in her seat and opened her lunch box. Her mind got busy with thoughts about Shanti, 'How would she be feeling? Was she crying? Will she ever come back to school?' Her lunch box remained half-eaten.

These thoughts went with her to her home and stayed with her the entire night.

She was quite uneasy when she reached the school the next day. During the assembly, she kept looking across her shoulders to check whether Shanti had come. Maybe she was just sick and her friend was lying. She waited until the start of the first period for Shanti to appear and fight with her for the bench. Her eyes reached the entrance whenever she heard a footstep.

It became an irresistible impulse for Naina to keep waiting for Shanti and thinking about her.

Seven days later, when Naina came into the class, she saw Shanti sitting with her best friend on the second bench.

Naina stopped at the entrance -moving her eyes slowly on Shanti. She was different. She was wearing big gold hoops in her ears and a big nose ring with two tiny glittering white stones on it. Henna stains were still there on her hands. Her eyes were swollen.

'Maybe she was crying before I came,' Naina thought as she approached the first bench. She kept her bag on the first bench and waited for Shanti to come over and start arguing with her.

She expected things to go back to normal again, as it was before Shanti's marriage. For the first time, she hated herself for being rude to her all the time. Had she not been always fighting with Shanti; they would have been friends. Then, instead of anyone else, Shanti would have confided in her. She wanted to talk to her, but she didn't know what to say to her.

Suddenly, there was no pleasure in sitting on the first bench. She hated it.

Naina eavesdropped on the conversation on the second bench between Shanti and her best friend. Shanti cried many times during the day and her friend kept consoling her, "Everything will be okay."

"He pulled my hair and sucked on my neck and breast," Shanti was whispering during English class.

"But why did he beat you?"

"He didn't beat me. He said that it was love. That's why girls and boys get married."

"Love?" her friend didn't seem to understand anything.

Their conversation drowned in the yelling of the teacher at them for talking and disturbing the class.

Naina's head started spinning when the words of the conversation repeated themselves in her head. A picture appeared in her mind. Shanti was lying on her back with her husband above her, digging his face in her neck and between her breasts. She closed her eyes tight. Her eyelids started aching with the pressure of removing those pictures, but they kept appearing on her eyelids.

Tears rolled down her cheeks. She had lost the strength to control herself. When the teacher asked her why she was crying, she let loose herself and broke into uncontrollable sobs.

"My.....my.....chest.....is hurting. I have pain here," she said, lifting her hand towards her chest, her words coming between sobs.

Her tears didn't stop till the next period and she continued to sob with short breaths. She was sent home with a senior student.

After that day, she stopped sitting on the first bench. She exchanged her seat with a girl who sat on the third bench in another row. She could not bear the conversation between Shanti and her friend. It made her sad and sick. From

her new seat, she observed Shanti. Her speed of doing everything fast and before everybody was missing. Her hands moved slowly, towards her bag to fetch books or notebooks. Moving slowly around the class, she spent every moment lavishly, as though, somebody had stretched the time for her, and she had ample of it at her hands. She spoke every word at slow pace, as if placing them carefully on her lips before letting them out in the air.

But time has its speed. Tests were there, exams kept happening as per schedule. But, as time passed, Shanti's grades dropped. Her answer sheets, in which teachers used to write compliments about her beautiful handwriting and her hard work, were now filled with remarks of low performance and lack of focus. Red circles were all around marking her mistakes.

Teachers asked her the reason for her poor performance and lack of interest. She just stood silent, keeping her head low, till teachers exhausted themselves and asked her in dismay to sit.

Before the final exams, Shanti went absent again for a few days.

Visions of Shanti with her husband on her returned to Naina's mind. This time, they were more frequent and violent in her head.

A few days later, before assembly, Naina saw Shanti's mother talking to her teacher. She tried to overhear their conversation, but she could not. The teacher did most of the talking. Shanti's mother appeared uneasy, as if she wanted to end this conversation and leave as soon as she could. Shanti came the next day, but after a few days, she stopped coming to school altogether.

At night, lying awake on her bed, Naina was thinking about her again. What kind of life might she be living? What would she be doing? Had her husband stopped doing her things that made her uncomfortable?

Her smile faded and the happiness of her result turned sour. It was the same when she was sitting on the first bench and Shanti had not come to fight her.

She felt selfish at that moment. How could she enjoy this happiness when all her classmates were going through the pain of marriage? Most were already married or were about to be married.

In later years, whenever she thought of that night, she wished that she should not have passed the exam. And like others, she should also have gotten married. But that night, she didn't know how her life was going to turn. The dream of college and living a free life washed away her discomfort. That night, the possibilities of living her dream became alive and ablaze. The hunt for a perfect college started. She kept checking newspapers to find the cut-off marks of the colleges at Delhi University. She noted down all the possible courses she could apply to as per her marks. She filled applications for so many colleges, sometimes consulting her father and sometimes on her own.

The entire process seemed like a dream to her as if it were happening to somebody else in some other world. Deep inside her, she knew that she had just postponed her fate but like other girls, she would also get married someday. She will also be handed over a set of responsibilities. But before that, she wanted to see the world. Before going into the confinement of the house, she wanted to breathe a little, to peek into the world that was forbidden for girls, but somehow it had got open for her for a while.

Admission lists of colleges came out. She was ecstatic. One of her wishes was about to come true. She was going to college.

She will see the world, the world shown in TV and films. She will have new friends, will have all the fun and fights, and will live her life fully.

And today, when she stood at the entrance of the college, her heart was jumping. She was excited, happy, and scared, all at the same time. Different emotions were emerging and merging like rivers inside her.

Today, she was the one, who was standing at the front, handling her day with her own hands. Taking micro decisions. She felt that the whole world had turned upside down.

A conversation with her mother popped up in her mind. “Don’t be like me. Read and write so that nobody should call you illiterate so that people respect you,” her mother had said to her on a night when they were sleeping together. Naina had nodded, having questions in her head that she could not ask about the reason behind it.

In the college, Naina was searching for her class. She had imagined that like in her school, there would be boards outside classrooms about different courses. But all she could find were numbers written with white paint on top of the door of each room. Towards her right along the corridor, numbers were in ascending order while on her left they were descending. She didn’t know the room number for her course.

She went to the notice board near the stairs in the corridor and looked at the papers pinned there. Each thumbnail pin was holding a stack of papers under it, white typed sheets above old yellow ones. Pins had left a brown mark of rust on them, but nobody had removed them.

She was still looking at the timetable on the board searching for the room number of her class when a group of boys came and huddled around her virtually over her head. She bent down, covered her head with her hand to shield it and tried to come out.

Her face touched the chest of a boy standing just behind her when she turned around.

“Oops! Sorry.....yyyyy....,” he said in a weird accent, moving a little aside to give her space to escape. Naina responded quickly. Clutching her purse to her chest, she took one big step to her right and came out of the semi-circle formed by the boys. Behind her back she heard the group burst into loud laughter with one voice screaming repeatedly, “Sorrriyyyyyy!Sooorrrriyyyyy!” mimicking the first boy.

Naina reached the corner and rested with her back towards the notice board and her body leaning over the parapet surrounding the periphery of the floor. Her heart was still pounding heavily. She felt a sensation on her forehead, where it had touched him. She tried to divert her mind and looked around. There was a mini park with newly laid turf. From above it looked

like a carpet of big sheets of green marble placed together within a boundary of trees.

It was half past nine and she was sure that she was late for her class. She hadn't been able to even find her class. Though she was looking outside, her ears were intently listening to the noise behind. The boys kept talking in whispers and laughing loudly for quite some time. When she didn't hear the noise for a few minutes, she turned around and saw that they had left and the number of torn papers had increased on the Notice board. She looked on her left and her right to confirm that the boys were not around and nobody else was approaching.

She went near the Notice Board again and started searching some sheets with her name or the name of her course, 'Bachelor of Arts.' Holding her index finger in the air, she was virtually touching the sheets one by one. But everything around her seemed puzzling. She was reading something and understanding something else. Words appeared dancing and running on the paper. After reading multiple papers back and forth, she could find that her first class was at 9 am. She had already missed it. Her next class was at 10.00 am. She glanced at her watch. Its hour hand was on 10 and the minute hand was pointing at 10.

She took out her diary from her bag and noted down the schedule. She stared at the timetable for a few seconds, tears welling up in her eyes. She was missing the circle of security around her. She took a long breath and put the diary in the bag.

She still had 10 minutes for her next class. Her heart was racing in her chest as she started moving toward Room Number-23. Probably it was the last room in the row on the same floor. On her way, she stopped to tell her brother, "Bhai, my class is at 10, and my last class would be at 1," her voice shaking with some unknown fear.

"Okay, then when should I come back to pick you up?" he asked. With helmet in hand, he was ready to leave.

"Come at 1.30, I will meet you outside the college gate."

“Okay.”

“Don’t be late,” she called out as her brother reached the stairs. She thought of her school days and nervousness rose in her body. Her introduction to the world had never been pleasant, and her body knew that. It triggered all the warning signs within to alert her.

When Naina reached her classroom, she was glad that she had successfully reached it on time. She peeped inside through the window. The class was full of students sitting on long benches arranged like a horizontal ladder, exactly the way she had seen in movies. Amongst all girls in the room, only three boys were sitting on the last bench. Everyone was looking straight ahead, whether towards the teacher or the board. She could not see. Some of them were nodding in affirmation, too.

The door that was ajar allowed her only a limited vision. She craned her neck and looked inside. The teacher was already there, and the class had started. The teacher was standing on a cemented-elevated platform with a piece of chalk hanging between her middle and index finger, and an opened book in her left hand. She read something loudly from the book and started explaining. Her strong voice filled the room. Her words were crisp and were defining her presence. It felt as though there was a hidden warning in every syllable. Students were hearing and probably accepting as well.

Standing there, she was not able to decide whether to enter the class or not. She had already missed the introductory class and now she did not want to become a latecomer on the very first day. She stayed there, frozen now, taking her time to calculate the risk of entering the class and missing it.

“Yes! Do you need anything?”

Naina was stunned when she heard the teacher’s voice. She sensed the anger in it and understood that it was a mistake to stand right at the door.

“Will you say something or just keep wasting time?” the teacher yelled again.

Naina pushed the door a little and took two steps forward. Standing in the doorway she looked towards the crowd of students. Every eye was on her as if she was a thing of amusement.

“I...I come... for class,” she said, her voice shaking and her head dizzy.

“Oh, haven’t you come quite early?”

The teacher put the book on the table with a thud. Glancing at her watch she said, “We still have five minutes left!” She crossed her arms around her chest, and that made her big tummy quite evident now.

Naina could hear the stifled laughs of students. Some were smiling partly covering their faces, some looked at her in disgust, and some were happy that they got a respite from that teacher. There was something for entertainment at the last minute of the class.

The teacher waited for her to reply, her anger escalating with every passing moment. But Naina stood there in silence, looking at her feet, letting the embarrassment drench her and waiting for it to pass.

“Close the door and wait for me in the corridor”.

Naina slowly closed the door, afraid of making any noise and aggravating the anger of the teacher.

Her next dilemma was to decide whether to wait for the teacher to come and scold her again or to just run away from there. She took out her diary and went through the schedule again to crosscheck if she had missed the timings of the class.

Her second period was supposed to start at 10.00 am. She looked at her watch. It was two minutes to ten. Closing the diary, she took a sigh of relief. She looked around. The room next there was empty. The bell rang, indicating that class was over.

She ran into the empty room and stood behind the door, listening attentively to the voices outside. Was the teacher asking anyone, “Where has that late

girl gone?” There was a sudden rush outside. She imagined students coming out, looking for her, ‘That stupid girl!’

Maybe they could suck a little more fun out of her.

She pictured them waiting outside the class with the teacher, looking here and there to find her. She was being dragged outside and presented in front of the teacher. The teacher slapped her across the face - leaving everybody relieved and happy. She thought of the day when one of her school teachers had slapped her, leaving a print of her fingers on her face for the rest of the day.

She waited for the voices to settle down. She wondered whether punishing or slapping students was allowed in the college like it was in her school.

■

I never thought you were different,

You were a part of me,

Everywhere my eyes see you,

Even when I am not looking for you,

“I wish I could bottle the time. All the favourite moments are filled in tiny bottles. Big days like weddings, births, long hugs, the moments when we shed tears of happiness, in big glass jars filled to the brim and locked somewhere safe- like hard-earned treasure.

“Life would have been a little easier this way. Whenever you feel sad, just take a sip from the bottle and you would wake up better the next day. If there is something which can’t be cured by the little ones, sniff the essence from the locked treasure in big jars. They always work.”

“But how many could I have saved? Yesterday, I got married, and today I am a widow. There are just a handful of memories which I could keep. Only a few drops or sips may be, and those would have got used up within a few days.” Haree was mumbling, whispering her thoughts to herself.

And then, without a warning, she burst into giant laughter, slapping her hands on her knees. She fell silent after a while and then her laugh erupted again.

It was the last day of the mourning rituals. Women from the village had gathered for this final process. All the belongings of Haree's husband were to be distributed to the poor.

After the prayers, the widow's brother needs to put silver bangles on her wrists and ask God to give her side of pain to him, and his share of happiness to her. After that, the brother would ask her to come with him to his place and if the widow wishes, then she can go with his brother to their native place. All this so that she can start her new life peacefully.

Haree did not have any brothers. She was the eldest of seven daughters. Two of them had died during birth. Her mother could not bear a son even after many trials. So, her father brought a pair of silver bangles and some pairs of light colour shirts to pair with her mother's old salwar.

"I think she has lost her mind," one of the ladies said when Haree laughed again. The devil laughed too.

"It happened to one of my aunts as well," she continued. Suddenly interest in the story grew and other women gathered around that dramatic speaker to understand what would happen next to Haree.

"Then, my uncle took her to a guru. The guru said that she has left her body with her husband and now some random soul is inside her."

She was speaking, covering her mouth with the edge of her long dupatta. Her voice was low but was audible enough to reach the waiting ears of the woman who circled her.

"Ohh, then? Did that guru give her some Bhabhut?" one of them asked. Two of her front teeth were missing and her upper lip shivered when she spoke.

"Yes, he did," the voice of the storyteller dropped to whisper and then rose again, "Guru ji said, there are too many spirits in her. It will take time to get them all out."

“Yes, these spirits are very rigid. They don’t go so easily.” said one of the listeners agreeing with her.

“You should go to some guru and seek his blessings. Things are not going well for your family these days,” the first woman said to Haree’s mother-in-law.

“What do I have now to seek blessings? She has eaten my son. Now no guru can bring my moon back.” She let out a wail, beating her chest repeatedly.

The first woman hugged and rocked back and forth with her until somebody else came and scolded them for crying on the last day.

“Let him go now. How will he go peacefully if you keep crying like this?”

“Hayeyeye... how can I not cry? My baby, my son, has gone before me.” Her wailing increased.

“Nobody leaves without God’s permission. You and I can’t decide who stays and who goes.”

Their conversations broke when a young lad, who had snatched the mattress from Haree’s hand, came running to the women’s area and called to her grandmother, “Maa, Chachi’s papa is coming,”

Haree’s mother-in-law immediately freed herself from the hug and went to Haree. Haree was still mumbling something when her mother-in-law hugged her and started crying.

“My poor daughter! What will you do now? I wish God had taken me instead of him. What good an old lady is doing in this world! My poor daughter, I can’t even look at your face. Hayeye!!!! What has God done to this girl?”

When Haree’s father looked at them, she went silent. Haree looked across his shoulders for her mother, but she was not there.

“She could not come. She had to stay with girls,” he said in his raspy, sand-type voice, soft yet frictional. He had read the question in her eyes.

When Haree’s father talked about her marriage for the first time and told her mother that he has asked friends and relatives to find a suitable match, she resented, “She is just 13 right now, and she hasn’t even bled yet. Why are you in a rush?”

Her mother was 3 months pregnant with her seventh child. It was their last attempt to produce a son for the family. But that didn’t happen.

“What do you know about the burden of a father? If you had given me a son, he would have taken care of everything. But now, I must unburden myself. It’s better that I start early. This is my fate. God is punishing me for something. I want this punishment to get over soon so that I can die in peace.”

Haree was sleeping in the same room, with her sisters. Two single mats used to be joined. Three of her younger sisters were 4 and 6 and 8 years old. The youngest one was born a year before Haree’s marriage. It was her duty to take care of three sisters after her fieldwork and tuck them into bed. The youngest one still slept with her mother. Her baby lips always mouthed around her mother’s nipples at night.

Her sisters lay flat on their backs and she slept turning her back toward their parents. She had learned very early that turning her back to their parents is the safest trick to avoid their secret meetings at night. It was rare for her parents to talk at night. Usually she heard only sounds of heavy breaths and panting.

The first time, when she had woken up to the sounds, she was still half asleep. She half opened her eyes. Her mother’s cot looked like a giant heap of clothes, and then it started moving to and fro. Haree screamed and called out for her mother. Things shuffled and a few minutes later, Haree saw a figure running out of the room hastily. Its skinny legs covered the distance before she could recognise it.

“Maa!” she called out again, “What happened? Are you okay?”

“Haan I am good. Your sister is not letting me sleep. Nothing else! You go to sleep.”

“Who went out?”

“Nobody! Now, don’t make noise. Let your sister sleep.” her mother said and shushed her.

A few days later, she woke up again to the sounds. She stood up silently and went to her mother’s cot to check on her. Her father was on top of her mother. The baby was sleeping peacefully, her lips wrapped around her mother’s nipple.

“Baba, what are you doing?” she had asked innocently.

Her mother had pulled the sheet over and covered her face.

“Go back to sleep, you shameless girl,” he had snarled.

She ran back to her mat and closed her eyes shut. After a few more heavy pants and rustling sounds, the room went silent.

She heard her father cursing her mother and leaving the room, “Both mother and daughters are of no use. I don’t know what I did to deserve this. A man can’t even get two minutes of rest in this house.”

After that day, she started sleeping with her back on her mother’s cot. Her mother hung a saree and partitioned the room, still, Haree did not turn her face towards her mother’s cot. She didn’t dare to upset her father again. She knew that she could still see his body moving above her mother beyond that thin saree. And she was also sure that her father was always looking at her keeping a check on her.

But that day, there were no noises of heavy breaths. No rustling of sheets and clothes. There were only whispers, dripping into Haree’s ears as clear as the wind. Invisible yet evident!

“But I need her help to take care of the girls if I get pregnant again.” Her mother had said.

“No, I don’t want any other mouth to feed. I have understood that you are not good enough to give me a son. I can’t add to the pile now.”

When Haree heard them, she thought about her dead sisters. She often wondered why they died when all the others survived the same process.

“They were not ours. God delivered them at the wrong address.” Her mother used to say when she asked her what she thought about them.

Haree missed them even though she had never seen them. She occasionally imagined their unknown faces in her head.

But today, she was relieved that they died. that they were not there, that they were safe somewhere with GOD.

Her father slipped two thin metallic bangles into her hands and kept a folded set of salwar kameez over her head. It was his responsibility to claim her as his daughter again.

“Now that your owner is no more here, you belong to me. I’ll share my bread with you. You will always have a place under my roof. I’ll take care of you if you wish.” He said and then waited for her answer, his hand resting on her head.

Haree saw the burden in his words. She could see the emptiness in his voice. His words did not lack empathy, but they were dipped in fear and helplessness. His voice was the only thing she knew about him. A picture of his father was painted in her life only through some sounds.

She knew him only by the sounds. She didn’t know how his father smelled, how a morsel from his hand would taste in her mouth, how his arms around her would feel, what kind of sleep she would have on his shoulders. She had no answer to all these questions. Even when she tried to imagine, she could not fill in the missing details. After a few futile attempts, she had stopped it all together. Her father had never taken her in his arms. She could not pull even a single strand in her memory, which took her to that moment when she was in her father’s arms.

Her eyes and ears were the only sources through which she knew about him. In the absence of the feeling of palpable concern and love, his words and his looks were the only things that she could relate to her father. And with these, the image of her father in her mind was that of a man half alive with real eyes and a distinct voice but with a skin of plastic.

His voice turns musical when he is happy. He speaks and smiles simultaneously. His eyes are wide and sparkly, his words swing rhythmically in the air.

When he is angry, his voice becomes a little thick and heavylike stone. When these stones hit, they hurt, leaving bruises for days. And his eyes look like they are staring at you even when he is not in the house.

But the voice in which he was talking right now was the last addition to her details about him. He had started using this voice recently, the time he started searching for a groom for her.

And since then, his other voices faded. They started becoming dimmer and dimmer. This new one became his new companion, slow, sad, and permanent. Like old age!

“No, I’ll stay here. My husband’s house is my real home Baba,” Haree said.

This decision of hers shocked only two people in the crowd. First was her mother-in-law, who was covertly waiting to get rid of her. After the death of her son, Haree was just a reminder of the emptiness her son had left.

And the other one was Haree’s father. He didn’t expect Haree to choose to remain there. When he had left his house this morning, he was sure that he would bring the burden back and this time it would be much heavier, a burden that his entire family will have to bear for life.

However, people forget the amount of love and sacrifice a woman can carry in her heart. She will give, even if a lot is being asked from her end.

Later, when Haree was folding the sheets on which women had been sitting in the veranda, Haree noticed her silver bangles. She stopped folding and

ran her fingers on the bangles. When they jingled, they made a sad and hollow sound. They didn't slip smoothly on her skin like her glass bangles that talked and laughed. But these silver ones only moaned in pain.

'What is it that makes them so dull?', she thought. She wished they didn't make any sound when she moved her hands. They constantly reminded her of things which she didn't want to think about.

It was her last night in the kitchen. It would be the last time that she could talk to him.

"Spirit roams around the loved ones till 21 days. After that when the family stops crying for them, they leave." Pandit had said on the first day of the prayer.

Since that day, she had been trying to talk to him. The first few nights, she waited passionately for him to appear at night. She imagined their conversation. He will hold her hands and will take her in his arms. First, she will refuse to talk to him and will complain. And then later, she will cry her heart out in his arms. She will ask him to promise her that he won't leave her alone again ever. And if he wouldn't agree then she would tell him that he was the only one, whom she had loved and the only one, who had loved her back. That she would do anything to please him for the rest of her life if he promised her to be with her always.

Initially, she woke up with jerks at night at every sound, hoping to see her husband's shadow at the door or sitting at her bedside, waiting for her to wake up. But she didn't find anyone. Slapping her face hard as punishment, she cursed herself for falling asleep. "Haye meri Maa! What have I done? What if he had come and called my name, but I continued to sleep!" she slapped herself.

"You randi, you want to sleep when your husband wants to talk to you!" one more slap. Her cheeks burned with the hurt. The sensation on them felt like tiny crackers bursting on them.

She continued cursing and slapping herself to complete her self-punishment, which she never thought was enough. Only God could decide

when to end it. She continued to slap her until her hands gave up and refused to move further, until both her cheeks burnt like coal on the fire, and until her jaw hurt when she tried to open it to curse herself.

Some nights later, her cursing turned into threats. "I'll never talk to you if you keep playing this game with me. I am telling you," she said one night, pointing out her index finger at no one.

Looking frantically here and there to find someone appearing after her warning, she yelled, "You think that you can hide, but you can't. I know you are teasing me. But if you don't need me, I also don't need you. Go... Get out of here." And then darted towards the entrance of the kitchen to check if her husband had been waiting for her but had returned after her scolding.

Each night, she uttered her threats in multiple ways. Sometimes making them sound like a baby - rolling out her lower lip, and then suddenly pushing all her anger in them, she roared in the room. But no one appeared. Each night she repeated and tested new ways to lure her husband's spirit, but nothing worked.

When she ran out of tricks, she started her new regime of selfpunishment. Now, along with slapping herself, she started pulling her hair. Clutching them with both hands, she pulled them until they came out in her hands from her scalp, leaving patches on her head.

As nights passed, her threats got replaced by requests. "Please, my love, come to me," she would beg, looking at the ceiling.

Holding her hands in front of her chest, she pleaded, "Please come to me once, I beg you. I'll cook your favourite dishes and will feed you with my own hands like you always wanted."

She tried multiple ways to plead and beg, but nothing worked. Her face remained swollen for days and patches kept increasing on her head.

For last three nights, her request turned into mumblings. There was calmness around her. She spent her nights talking to her husband, many

times laughing in between her imaginary talks.

“Everybody thinks that you are dead. They say you are not coming back,” she spoke, then started smiling and continued, “I think it’s good like this. Now Only I can see you and you can be with me all the time.”

She would say with surprise in her voice, “You know, they ask me to cry over you. But I don’t. Why should I? Why should I cry when you are sitting in front of me, fit and fine,” and then chuckled again.

“He came to meet me yesterday,” she said the other day to a woman who had come to attend the mourning gathering.

“No. No. Don’t cry. He is not dead.” Haree said to another and then gave her a small smile.

Surprised, the other woman looked at Haree’s mother-in-law, who simply brought her index finger to her temple and wiggled it, gesturing that Haree had lost her mind.

“She has gone mad.”, someone from the crowd said to clear the message.

Spontaneously, several small groups started discussing and sharing similar experiences.

“My sister-in-law also behaved the same way when her son died. She too didn’t cry the first day. And after some days, she lost her mind.”, one said and others nodded their head in affirmative.

And Haree sat there, silent, calm, and smiling at everybody.

■

My tiny little heart,

■

My tiny little dreams,

My tiny little world,

All shattered one by one!

It was Sunday. The day of doing household chores!

Naina woke up when her father came into the room and called her name. Her grandmother's new trick was to wake her up early on Sunday mornings, yet her father didn't call her name until the clock struck 8. He ignored his mother's orders by pretending that he had forgotten to wake her up while talking or doing something else.

Sometimes, he said clearly "Let her sleep, Bibi. After marriage, anyway, they need to wake up early. A girl sleeps peacefully at her father's place."

"She is not a child anymore. She is 19, grown-up enough to start a family. That's how you ruin their life, by providing all the love and comfort here. And later, at their sasural, when they don't do any work, their mothers-in-law complain and curse us.", her Dadi admonished her son.

"She is just a child, Bibi. She will learn with time. Like other girls, she will also understand her reality and her destiny."

“At her age, I would have cleaned the entire house and would have cooked the food for my four children. Our fathers didn’t ruin us like you are ruining your daughter.”, she said, anger rising in her words. But her father ignored it by smiling at his mother.

“I am sure your father taught you how to fight.” He replied, and when he could not push further his mother’s desire, he finally stood and went towards Naina’s room.

As soon as she heard her father’s voice, Naina said, “I am already up, Papa!” sitting up on the bed, flattening her messed-up hair with both palms.

She cleaned the kitchen first, and then swept the floor and mopped. Her mother had gone to the fields. On her return, Naina would accompany her to the backyard and help her finish the cattle work. While her mother would feed them, Naina would collect little piles of cow dung into a big one in a corner. After finishing feeding and bathing the cattle, both will make little cakes of the dung, mixing it with waste and leaving them in the sun on the floor to dry.

Her younger aunt, Bua used to do all this work with Naina’s mother before her. But she got married a few years back and the work got shifted to Naina like an unsaid rule. It was already decided as has been the system in their household. Nobody needed to tell Naina that she needed to fill the space of her aunt. It was known. Tasks of every woman and unmarried girl in the family were predecided, well understood, and well adjusted. All the married women would do major chores like cooking, washing clothes, feeding, and cleaning cattle. And all other work that didn’t require precision fell into the lap of the unmarried and young girls.

It was the first Sunday after her Bua’s marriage. Naina was nine then. She was sleeping, when her grandmother yelled at her, “Wake up...! The sun has come on my head. My daughter used to wake up at 5 and till now, she would have cleaned the entire house. And, here you are still sleeping? Like a dead cow. I don’t know what your mother has taught you!”

She kept yelling in between her talk with her husband, who was smoking, sitting next to her. She kept taking turns to reply to her husband and check

on Naina with a yell till she woke up reluctantly.

“What great would happen if I woke up at 5? Everything will get dirty again and will have to be cleaned again. So, what’s the point of doing it early? Bua was stupid I am not.” Naina said, maintaining a safe distance from her grandmother.

“Move your hands like you move your tongue.” she stared at Naina.

“One day this girl will bring shame on us, with this tongue I am telling you.” she then said to her husband, who looked at Naina and then got busy again smoking his hookah. Clutching the noose of the hookah, he took a long drag and let the smoke blow from his nostrils and mouth.

Naina took the broom and started sweeping. She knew her grandmother’s eyes were following her. She went inside the living room to clean. When even after an hour she did not come outside, her grandmother went inside to check.

Naina was sleeping on her father’s cot, curled like a baby in his blanket. The broom lay on the floor as if it was also sleeping.

One slap and Naina’s eyes were wide open. It took her a few seconds to soak the slap and sense the pain. A dry cry burst from her mouth, her hand covering her sore cheek.

“Now, it’s good you are fully awake.” Her grandmother said and left the room.

Naina had observed her Bua doing the work. The pattern and ways were clear to her. But her hands didn’t flow like her Bua. Her wrists ached and she kept shifting the broom in her hands every five minutes. After 15 minutes, she declared that she had cleaned the room. Her grandmother was surprised and came in to inspect. Her daughters worked for hours to clean the house and here this girl cleaned it in just 15 minutes.

“What is this?” Dadi barked. “Who will fold bed sheets and beddings? Who will pick up the utensils which were pushed beneath the cot after dinner?”

“You didn’t tell me that I have to do it,” Naina said, pushing her shoulders up, broom still hanging in her right hand. “I have only cleaned the floor,” she said, clearing out any doubts about her task.

“Yes...yes! Your father will come and clean other things. Let me call your Baap and he will tell you.” She raised her voice further and yelled, “Krishna..... Oh Krishna,” calling Naina’s mother and continued without waiting for an answer, “See, what your daughter has done. That’s what you have taught her.”

When Krishna did not appear in the hallway, Dadi yelled again into the open space, “Both mother and daughter have decided to ruin this house.”

It took two slaps, some chasing, and some painful ear pinching from her Dadi to teach Naina the correct way of sweeping. Next weekend, Dadi followed her all through the process of cleaning, telling her to pick up the unclean utensils from all around the house and put them in the kitchen. Naina slipped on the stairs and all the utensils in her hand came down clanking on the stairs, with Naina tumbling and toppling over them.

Naina cried a little more than necessary, feigning an injury in her wrist. After a while, when she saw nobody paying attention, she took the broom and started sweeping again, cursing her grandmother under her breath, “This budhiya doesn’t even die. She sits on my chest, torturing me.”

After the first few close inspections and instructions, Dadi, when sure that Naina had learned the things, stopped following her. She let her work alone and went out to her weekly tour of the village, meeting her old friends and gossiping about their daughters-in-law. However, before leaving, she always reminded Naina to do the cleaning properly and warned that she would check when she would come back.

“If I find dirt anywhere, I’ll pull you with your hair and will make you lick the floor to clean it properly,” she would say before going out. Naina learned new ways to finish her work quickly. She rolled the bedding, rustled sheets from yesterday night and threw them in the cupboard. She collected all the utensils and tied them in an old bed sheet and then took the entire heap in one go to the kitchen. Instead of sweeping the entire floor, she

picked up the pieces of paper or wrappers and threw them in the dustbin. She closely watched the floor to find stains that can be seen. From the doorway to the end of the room, she walked slowly, her shoulder hunched and alert, watching the floor carefully looking for spots and dust. She cleaned the spots immediately with the wet mop. After cleaning the room according to the standards of her grandmother, she turned the TV on and played songs at full volume and danced imitating the moves and expressions of the heroines. This would go on till her calculated time of grandmother's arrival.

When she saw her grandmother turning into the street she would start cleaning again. Her grandmother always found her mopping the veranda. On her arrival grandmother would walk through the hallway inspecting Naina's work in other rooms. All neat and clean to her eyes!

She looked at Naina in admiration, while Naina continued mopping the floor stretching her arms wide. Her breaths were still heavy with all the dancing and jumping, but her face would be serious. She avoided looking at her grandmother, pretending she was so engrossed in the work that she did not notice her presence. She only looked up when her grandmother complimented her, "Very good! Yes, that's how you should do household work. See, it was not that difficult. How easy! My beautiful girl."

And Naina put on a blushed look and continued to mop.

She hated doing household work or any work that involved physical activity or required accuracy. Anything other than dancing, singing, and playing didn't attract her. Mopping floors, cleaning dishes, and serving food to her father and uncles, she hated all such tasks. While performing these chores, she dragged her body like a snail, her mind filled with excuses she could make and skip the command. Whenever anyone called her name, she waited long enough for callings to die down. 'They will think I am not home. Maybe they will think that I am asleep. How can I answer when I am already sleeping? When they will think that I am not here, maybe they'll call somebody else...' she argued with herself, happy with her arguments.

Sometimes it used to happen that after a few calls, the name got changed - from her to her mother's or any other aunt who was visiting them. Naina

would let out a sigh of relief when that happened and continued with what she would be doing.

But such lucky days were very rare. Normally, yelling would grow, from normal to angry and then finally furious. Naina knew that she had the chance to present herself before the tone turned furious, once that reached, there was nothing that could save her. Then, it would land her into two-three slaps and a lecture about being lazy and disrespectful to elders.

In a very short time, Naina had grasped the pattern quite well. So, she had developed a definite plan for every stage which depended mainly on two things. First, who was calling her, and second, what she was doing or how she was feeling at that moment. If her father or any uncle would be calling her, then she would wait to hope the name to change till she would sense the heat of anger. Then she would run to them jumping two stairs at a time to reach them before they could turn fiery and red. But, if it was her grandmother calling, she would not wait that long and present herself faster. However, if she was dancing to some song, she would let the voice become furious. She would then run to the terrace and from there jump on the roof of a neighbour's adjacent house and before anyone could catch her, she would be out on the streets running, feeling the wind on her face. By the time she would return, everybody would have forgotten why they wanted her. Her tricks always worked.

Naina was eight when her grandmother had declared her grown up enough to do the household work. Shammi, her father's sister, was assigned the responsibility of training her.

It was the first week of May, the first day of her summer holidays. The previous day, she had entered her house, running and shouting, "Yayyyyaa... Chhuttittteeee..... Mummy.....Chhuttteeeee!"

"You look beautiful in your school dress." Her mother always said to her and she clung to that compliment like a little girl holding her doll all day long. She never missed a chance to wear it. All that she wanted was to look beautiful, to be different from others. She never changed her dress the day before Sunday or any holiday, it was like a ritual to her. She would keep the bag, eat her lunch and go out running without changing her school dress.

She had just finished her lunch, still in her school dress, when her grandmother called her. Naina ignored the call, but when her Bua came to summon her, she got up and followed her.

“Naina, from today, you will go with your aunt to clean the Baithak. After that, you will help your mother in spreading clothes on the clothesline in the sun.” Dadi ordered.

Naina looked at her aunt, who was holding her hand. She was smiling at Naina mischievously. Her smile irritated Naina.

She had already planned her day. First, she would go and play with her friends, then she would play cricket with her brothers, and then she would make gudda and gudiya using carved legs of a broken wooden table.

“Why, what happened to Bua? Where is she going?” she asked, yanking her hand out of her aunt’s grip.

“Nothing happened to her. Why would anything happen to her?” Dadi snapped.

Dadi’s huge tummy wobbled when she talked. She was 6 ft tall, and her voice complemented her personality. She had never raised her hand at Naina, but her warnings were sufficient for Naina to get scared.

“Nothing has happened to anyone. Now you need to learn the household work. It’s not your age to roam around like puppies on the street. Have some sense now. Your mother doesn’t bother about you. But I’ll have to teach you.” She said.

Naina kept looking at her belly jumping up and down while she talked.

She could never understand the reason behind it. When Dadi spoke from her mouth, why did her tummy move? It appeared to be supporting her, like an honest assistant, yelling at Naina with equal enthusiasm and anger. Naina had noticed that it didn’t move much whenever Dadi talked to Naina’s grandfather, father, or uncles. At that time, it moved softly, as though nodding silently and agreeing with the conversation.

Out of curiosity, once she tried checking her stomach to test whether that happened with her as well. Did she also have that special power like Dadi? She pulled her t-shirt up, clutched its edge with her teeth, and then sitting on the floor with her back on the wall, she called out, “Naina.....”, mimicking her Dadi. The sound came out but was all muffled because of the t-shirt stuffed in her mouth. She blew out the t-shirt and held it in her hand and then called her name again, “Nainaaaaa.....”, a little louder this time. She looked at her stomach which was sunk in her waist. She called out again. The skin around her navel barely moved. She tried again with all her energy. Her navel flickered a little like a wick, but the movement died before she could notice it.

Disappointed, she gave up. She closed her eyes, joined her hands and prayed, “Hey Bhagwan! Please give me powers to move my stomach like Dadi.” but God never answered her prayers.

Naina was still lost in her thoughts about Dadi’s belly, when Dadi struck her at the back of her head, “Are you listening or not? What am I saying?”

Naina looked at her, thinking before announcing her decision as if mattered.

“I won’t. I’ll complain to Papa.” she threatened thinking it may work.

“Go, call your father. Let me see, what will he do? I’ll see how you won’t. Not only you, your Baap will also go with you.”

And then it was her Bua’s turn. She bombarded orders, “Pick up the bucket, mop and broom and let’s go.” and Naina obeyed heartlessly,

They left for Baithak, Naina following her Bua. Bua had a delicate walk, one hand holding a bucket and the other swinging in sync with her steps, hand up - right step, hand down - left step, unlike Naina who usually stumbled upon her steps. She would be walking while looking somewhere else and would bump frequently into people, cycles, and carts of vendors. Her eyes were continuously looking at the world, curious to know what was happening in the houses where she could not go. She was lost in listening to the sounds, weaving her own stories out of them, and then telling them to her mother and her friends in the neighbourhood with her imagination

added. If she didn't find anyone to share her stories with, she repeated them to herself and her imaginary audience, changing voices while doing so. A multitude of characters of different stories lived in her or she lived in them. There was no telling, Naina listened and talked to them. She asked them to play with her, spent hours teaching them the rules of her games, and fought with them when they cheated or forgot the rules. There was a different world outside and an entirely different world inside her, a world she could pack and unpack whenever she liked, whenever she needed.

While trudging behind her aunty to the Baithak, she had decided to meet her friend, to tell her that they would play after an hour. After they had finished the cleaning work, she told her aunt that she would be back in two minutes and ran off before aunty could respond or stop her.

She was running with her slippers, slapping her heels rhythmically. She took a right turn and let out a loud heart shrieking cry.

She hadn't heard the bell ringing while turning and had bumped into a cycle. Its front wheel had hit her hard in the stomach and the steel brakes of the handle had hit her below her right eyebrow, just an inch from her eye. She fell back with her head landing on the ground with a thud. The man on the cycle lost his balance and fell to his right, his right leg tangled under the cycle. Packets of biscuits and chips got scattered all over the street. Some fell in the drain also, floating like paper boats in the filthy water.

Out of nowhere, some children appeared, hurriedly picked up the packets and ran away. The treasure was open to them and they cleared it within minutes. They disappeared as quickly as they came, like a magical spell.

Somebody picked up Naina and supported her stand up on her feet. He inspected her for any injury, moving her head smoothly from left to right, up and down. He looked down to check her legs and knees.

"Nothing happened, it's okay! See, you are all okay." the stranger said.

Naina didn't look up. Her head was still spinning, and her vision blurred.

“Can’t you see? Are you blind or what? Running like a ghost around the street,” The biscuit seller was yelling at her, picking up his cycle.

Dusting off the dirt from his pants, he was blabbering, “Oh My God, my biscuits! Those scoundrels have stolen everything.” His anger had turned into despair.

Naina kept looking below, not able to decipher what was happening around her. Her mind was still trying to balance itself inside her head.

“You damn girl, what did you do?” someone was shouting. Naina moved her head slowly to look. It was her aunt, jolting her shoulders. Naina’s frail body moved like a flag dancing on a high pole.

“Don’t you have any sense? Can’t you walk a little carefully?” Bua was furious.

“Didi....Look.... Look... what has happened? All my stuff is gone,” the biscuit seller said, opening his big bags with both hands. “Now, what will I do? How will I feed my family? That was my monthly stock.” He kept talking and showing his empty bags, and pointing his hands towards the packets floating in the drain and stuck in the clutter of polythene and other filth. Blackwater was still flowing at corners.

After some time, the man who was holding Naina left without saying anything. Passers-by looked at them. Some stopped for a while to hear the story and then went their way. The audience kept changing, one lot after another.

“These kids these days. they are so naughty. They don’t care about anybody. No sense at all. I don’t know what their parents teach them?” one stranger said. “They should be given a good beating whenever they behave like this. These little monsters understand only that.” He continued to talk to the unknown crowd, “See, now what will the poor man do?”

“I am sorry Bhaiya, for whatever has happened. See, she is a little girl. She didn’t do it by choice. It all happened by mistake. An accident can happen to anyone. It’s nobody’s fault.” her aunt said, with a plea in her voice.

“Easy for you to say, Didi! You are big people. For you it’s nothing, but for poor people like us, it’s a matter of life and death. Tell me, how will I feed my children now?” he said, not directly to her aunt but the crowd.

“Ohhh Bhैया, we are no big people. We are also like you.” Bua said raising her voice and at the same time raising her right hand she slapped Naina across her face.

She had not noticed the swelling around her right eye, where the handle had hit. Naina shrieked in pain.

” Now why are you crying?” Bua asked looking below at her.

Naina looked up. A big red mark of bruise below her eyebrow and the swelling around the eye was visible. Bua started regretting and moved towards the biscuit man. “Yes, tell me what I can do if this has happened. Should I kill my daughter for you now? See what you have done to her. Look at her eyes.” Her aunt shouted at everybody around as if they were all responsible for it.

Bua held Naina’s hand and started walking. Splitting the crowd in the middle, she made her way out towards their home. Naina followed her like a tail, walking haphazardly, nearly running to keep pace with her aunt. Naina turned back to see what the crowd was doing. Her curiosity was alive even then in her.

Biscuit man was following them, calling her aunt, “Didi... Oh, Didiiii.....!”

Bua pulled Naina’s hand and increased her speed. Naina stumbled once but immediately picked up the speed.

“Let it be Bhैया, there is nothing you can do now. These big people are like this only. And so are their children.” One from the crowd said, moving his hands in the air, signalling everyone to leave.

When they reached their home, her uncle was sitting with her grandfather on the sofa in the hall, engrossed in reading newspapers, Punjab Kesari and

Dainik Jagran, respectively. Following them, the biscuit seller also reached their house behind them.

“Bhai, look at this man! I don’t know what he wants?” Bua said to her brother.

Naina’s grandfather and uncle looked at her aunt and then their eyes moved in sync towards the entrance. The biscuit seller was standing there with hands folded in Namaste. The moment he saw the duo, fear appeared in his eyes. He tried to plead before them,

“Babu ji, my whole month’s supplies have gone to waste and stolen. What would I do? Where would I go?”

Wiping his eyes with the cotton towel on his shoulder, he sat down at the entrance.

Naina’s grandfather looked at her aunt. Reading the confusion in his eyes, Bua started narrating the entire episode.

“Bhai this Naina did everything. She was running in the street like a mad dog.”

While saying so, she gave Naina a little nudge on her back.

Naina moved two steps ahead and stood silent. Muscles on the right side of her head were still twitching. Her fall had left black and brown marks on her school dress. While her uncle was talking to the biscuit seller, she tried to dust them off, but they did not budge. She glanced around for her father. Her uncle was the strictest member of the family. He always ended up raising his hands on everybody, children, his wife, his sisters, and his younger brother.

Naina remembered how he had slapped her hard when she took his pen. She had found it lying in the drawer of the TV cabinet. For her, it was like a treasure. The ink was leaking from its bottom. She applied layers of tape to fix it and then for the next three days she wrote with it, signed on newspapers, and made drawings on walls when nobody was around. But

then one evening, during tuition hour, his uncle came unannounced and asked everyone to show their diaries and notebooks. An unexpected check-up on them!

Naina was not a studious kid, not even an average student. She did only what was necessary depending on the nature of the teacher. She studied only if there was a threat of being beaten in the class, else she would have excuses till the last warning. That day she was happy. She had already finished her homework in beautiful writing with her favourite pen. She stood up first to show her diary. Her new pen was in her hand. While checking her homework, her uncle asked her questions about it and she answered. She was nervous, although there was nothing which could ignite his anger.

She looked gloatingly at her brothers and cousins when his uncle gave his approval and asked her to give him a pen to sign her diary. She proudly took out the pen and gave him thinking that he would praise her for fixing it so beautifully and making it work again, an intelligent renovation out of waste. But the smile on her lips didn't last even two seconds. Closing the diary, he slapped her hard with his left hand. His big palm covered the entire right side of her face, from her ear to her lips.

Shocked, she looked at him, her eyes wide open and pooled with tears.

“Don't you have any shame that you stole it? I have been looking for this pen for three days. How dare you touch my shirt to take it?” and he slapped her again.

This time, it was the back of his hand and it struck hard on her mouth. Her teeth cut the lips internally and the bleeding started instantly. She tasted blood but; she did not open her mouth for it might trigger more slaps. He took the pen, removed the tape, and put the pen back in his pocket. A stain appeared on his pocket. He immediately yanked it out and threw it at her, along with her diary.

“You take it now.”

Later that day, Naina smashed the pen with a brick. She kept smashing it till it was crushed completely.

Naina saw her uncle hitting the biscuit seller as they argued. She felt a burning sensation on her cheeks like she had felt that day. She shuffled at her place, agitated, and worried. She wiped her eyes. They were getting wet again and again seeing the biscuit seller, who was also crying and pleading. It was like she was reflecting on him. She was also squinting her eyes when he did so. His words were getting smeared on her face.

After a while, her grandfather intervened. He went to the gate, taking out his wallet.

“You don’t know these scoundrels, Baba!” her uncle said, trying to dissuade his father.

Her grandfather ignored him and started talking to the biscuit seller.

“How much do you need?” he asked while swiftly shuffling hundred-rupee notes, between his fingers.

“Just 500, Saab!”

“Haaaan 500? Your biscuits were made of gold, hai na? Has your Baap even seen 500 rupees in life?” her uncle retorted. He was furious at his father, who had ignored him in front of a stranger.

Her grandfather gave 350 rupees to the biscuit seller and swiftly closed the door.

The seller kept pleading and crying. “Babuji.....this won’t be enough. How will I feed my family Babuji? Think about this poor man.”

The door didn’t open. After some time, his voice faded and then disappeared completely. He must have left. Naina pictured him waiting outside for some time, crying and then turning back to collect his cycle.

“What do you think you were doing?” her grandfather asked her uncle.

He did not reply for some time and then countered, “What do you think I was doing?” “Don’t you dare talk to me in this tone!”

Instead of replying to his father, her uncle turned toward Naina and shouted, “Why are you still in your school dress?”

She shivered; tears were running uncontrollably on her cheeks now.

“Come here Naina!” her grandfather called her and she ran before her uncle could say anything more.

It was a great relief, the kind words of her grandfather. He kissed her on her cheeks. The smell of tobacco in his breath made her puke, but she enjoyed the attention. She waited for her uncle to leave. Soon, both his uncle and aunt left, and she leapt out of her grandfather’s lap and ran out of the house.

Throughout the day, she and her friend made dolls of broken legs of the stool and played. Something in her was telling her that might be that was the last day when she was playing freely.

From that day, till the last day of her summer vacation, her Bua taught her the nuances of cleaning. Whenever Naina ran away, she would go searching for her in the neighbourhood, asking them and then would drag her with her ear to finish the work. Since then she started hating holidays, the days which had turned boring and hectic from being fun.

And then came Diwali! She loved the festival, but the days ahead of it were troublesome for her. It was an occasion when the entire household turned into a cleaning marathon. Her aunties would drag her along with them, hovering over her head, barking orders to clean windows -first with soap and water, then with a wet cloth and finally with a wipe made of a dry towel.

She used all kinds of ways to delay or stop working.

“My head is spinning Chachi. I will take a rest for a while and then start again,” she said once to her eldest aunt while Diwali cleaning fever was in full swing.

“You will get better in one slap, don’t worry! All the dizziness will vanish right away.” her aunt had said without looking at her while balancing herself with one leg on a wooden stair and the other on the kitchen’s slab.

Naina sometimes wondered why nobody believed her when she gave excuses. Where was she lacking? Still, she tried every possible reason she could come up with to skip the work.

She was always on the lookout for an opportunity to run away and play. One break from her aunties and she would run without slippers like a cat into the streets. Many times, she would still be holding a piece of an old sheet that would have turned black cleaning shelves.

Once in the morning, two days before the festival, her father had called all the children to the hall and assigned them duties for cleaning. The boys were asked to clean the fans and also the men’s sitting area, which Naina used to mop on every Sunday.

Naina was asked to stay with her mother and help her in cleaning the doors and windows.

“No, Papa, I’ll go with you. I don’t want to work here. I’ll also clean the fan and paintings.” She had said, wrapping her hands at his waist.

She looked up, waiting for him to answer. She knew that with her father she won’t have to do much work and she could go to play whenever she wanted.

“No! You work here.”

Naina knew there was no point dragging it further. Her aunty assigned her the task of cleaning the windows.

“First dust them off with a dry cloth, then with soap water, then with a wet cloth and finally again with a clean dry towel,” she instructed.

Naina’s hands moved slowly around the ply and the glass. Shuffling between different types of clothes, she got confused and wiped the cleaned

glass window with the piece, which she was using for initial dusting. Her final stroke left marks in the shape of a rainbow on the window. She kept staring at the window, not knowing what to do next. She took the bucket of dirty water and splashed it all over the window. It took her another 2 hours to clean the window glass again. By the end of the day, she was panting and crying, her wrist was aching, but the glass was shining spotlessly even in moonlight.

At dinner, everybody made fun of her. Bua said, “Bhai, she cleaned only one window in the entire day and ensured that it’s the only window shining.”

Everyone let out a hearty laugh.

Naina looked out the window. It was also mocking her.

She swore at it, “Haramkhor...., Kutiya....., Kamini....., BEHENCHOD!”

■
Two hearts are beating inside me.

■
One is dying slowly, the other is learning to breathe.

Thousands of worlds I'll bring, thousands I'll kill,

And all those time that you couldn't live,

I'll live!

'I don't know which is more difficult, being you or being me.

Lines between me and you vanished long ago. Now I don't know whether I am turning into you or you are melting into me. I speak your words. In the mirror, my eyes search for my face. I touch myself and reach you. I have lost myself somewhere between you and me. The road to you is difficult. It has torn me. My pieces lie scattered around and I don't know which one to pick first. Or should I even pick them at all?' Haree was writing in her husband's diary. He used to maintain his accounts in it.

This red diary, a green half-used pencil, and a black and white picture of their wedding were the only possessions of her husband she had with her.

Its yellow pages had started turning brown at the edges. A couple of pages still had remnants of Ram's writing. Names written on them had gone blurry and amounts in front of them had almost disappeared, as though they

knew that now there was no one to claim them. She closed the notebook. Its thick red cover felt rough. She ran her fingers on the thread sewn into a running pattern all around it. Then, impulsively, her hands started moving animatedly. She held up the diary, touched the edges to both the eyes one after the other, then on her forehead, and then kissed it-like Ram used to do.

When she had first seen him doing this, she had giggled and asked, “You love your kitaab more than me, kissing it every time you open it.”

It was after a few days of their marriage. Haree had come back from her mother’s place after some days. Her hands were stained with Henna, big reddish-brown circles at the centre of both palms and on their back, and the ends of her fingers looked as if she had dipped them in a pot of red colour and taken them out.

Ram had spent the last two days at her house. In his absence, his younger brother had collected payments and made entries in the diary. He was recalculating them.

Ram was the eldest son. He got his name due to his soft features. He walked with ease and calmness around him. He ate slowly and talked slowly, as if placing his every word carefully.

His eyes smiled and talked even when he was silent. When he smiled, his lips moved a little to the right, giving an impression that there was something mischievous behind.

When Haree saw him on their first night, he was looking at her. He moved his eyes after some time, but she kept staring at him. There was something different about his face. Something delicate! Something, unlike the men she had seen around her. He did not have that suffocating air around him, the air that she felt around other men in her life. In their presence, she always felt trapped as if she was locked in an invisible glass box and she could not breathe.

But in his presence, the air felt light and safe.

She had been crying silently every night since the day she had come to know that her father had fixed her marriage. Her mother had not told her the name of the groom. He was just an image without a face, without any name, just an owner of Haree. She had seen her mother, wincing in pain when her father slapped her. At night, she heard her mother crying when he cursed her womb for producing girls. Sometimes Haree wished she had died instead of her other sister. But then she used to feel selfish. How would her mother have managed if she had died?

A few days before her marriage, her mother taught her the nuance of married life. She corrected her manners, and her cooking, and taught her how to make pleats of saree.

Once while making pleats in saree for her she had said “Don’t talk loud there. Do as others say. Wake up early, before everyone. Don’t eat much.”

She kept telling her many such things and Haree kept nodding her head.

“And,.....don’t cry when he comes into the room. Do as he says. Never say no to him.” her mother’s words were hurried as if it was forbidden to talk about it.

Haree heard her, and pictured a faceless man over her, panting hard like her father. She felt sick thinking of somebody’s hands over her body.

On the night after their marriage, her heart was throbbing when she was waiting in her room. She wiped her tears. Her face was burning, but her fingers were ice cold. She rubbed them, not sure about what might trigger her anger toward her unknown husband. She stopped and pulled her veil a little more when she heard footfalls outside. She tried to follow the voices. People were talking and laughing.

The door opened, and some people giggled. Door bolted. Somebody had come inside but didn’t walk towards her. Maybe he was standing at the door. Moving her eyes only, she looked at him through her veil, the red Dupatta.

He was still standing at the door. His back to her, he was fumbling with his hand in his pocket. He was wearing a white kurta and a white churidar, a red shawl hanging on his right shoulder. He took out something from his pocket and turned.

Haree dropped her eyes immediately as if he had caught her looking at him.

The cot creaked when he sat down. Two cots had been laid together, white bed-sheet with red flowers on them spread over it to make it look like a double bed. Haree wondered if he could hear her heartbeat even in that silent room from that far.

They sat still in silence, without any movement, both waiting for the other to say something.

Haree's back started aching due to sitting for long. She moved up to straighten it but then stopped midway, becoming aware of his presence.

“No.....No.....it's okay. You can lie down if you want to.”

He said, tapping the cot a few times.

Frozen in that position, she waited. He was looking at her. His eyes tried to catch a glimpse of her face beyond that thin layer of her veil.

Confused and unsure, Haree shifted and dragged herself towards the wall on the side of her bed. Ram took her pillow and adjusted it against the wall for her. Relief ran in her body when she rested her back on the soft cushion. For a moment, she forgot where she was, closed her eyes, and enjoyed the pleasure.

“You can uncover your face if you want to,” he said, getting comfortable in his cot.

His words were now calm, as if he had been waiting for her to get comfortable first. He laid flat on his bed and adjusted a rolled bed sheet under his head. His feet crossed at the ankles and his eyes still soaking her in.

Not knowing what to do, Haree moved her hand up and lifted her Dupatta. She held the Dupatta as if taking a pinch of salt and then pulled it back until it showed half of her face. Then she crossed her hand on her feet, waiting for his next instruction.

“No.....No.....you can remove it completely. There is no need to hide your face from me,” words came out of his mouth, but he seemed to immediately regret them, “No I mean, if you want to.”

He placed his hands at the back of his neck and moved them back and forth, left, right and then clockwise, as if releasing the tension of his muscles will release the tension between them also.

‘Should I remove all of my clothes? Should I get down and remove my skirt first?’ she thought. She remembered her mother, wishing she were there to tell her what to do, how to do it. She recalled the instructions her mother had given her, but she didn’t find anything about what to do at this moment. Scared, she started crying. She covered her mouth to stop her sobs, but she could not. Her shoulders moved up and down with every breath.

“Arey....arey,” Ram got down from his cot on the other side and ran towards her cot.

“Are you cold?” he asked her with surprise when he held her hands. They were freezing.

When her sobs died, she looked up at his face. She could feel that he was worried, and was searching her face for answers. But she could not say anything. Everything she had been thinking faded away.

He is different, that’s all she could think. Her eyes glued to his face, she noticed a birthmark on his right cheek, a streak of a mix of black and blue, as though a paintbrush had accidentally touched his face.

“Are you okay?? What happened?”

She saw his lips moving, his hands wrapped around her hands. Her mind was telling her to move her gaze away but she couldn’t. And then she

nodded in response.

His lips moved to the right. 'Mischievous,' she said silently to herself.

They did not know when the wall between them evaporated in thin air. Her hands in his didn't feel strange. They talked till morning, words running from her mouth as if she had not talked in years. Secrets and dreams spilt all over the room, things she had not dared to talk even to herself, she let them slip out effortlessly.

He nodded, asked, replied, and smiled in between. Her voice dripped in his ears like rain pouring softly on the roof, musical and soothing.

Their eyes didn't tire soaking each other.

The next morning, when she woke up, his hand was still wrapped around her thumb. She looked at him and murmured, 'He is not like my father or other men. Even his birthmark looks beautiful.'

But then her fear returned, maybe they are all like that at first and then change with time. She had seen his father talking sweetly and then turning bitter another moment. She had seen how he used to bring sweets for them at noon and the same night he would come drunk and beat their mother over a burnt Roti. Sleeping on the mat on the floor, she used to wonder how a man, so beautiful, can turn into a devil.

During the day, Haree noticed Ram. He looked different. He was holding his face straight while getting ready. When he had woken up, he did not say anything to her. The ease and comfort she had felt last night had disappeared as if last night had never happened and they were strangers. Haree shrieked within herself. The walls which she had lowered last night stood up again. Strange confinement appeared again. He left the room without a word, and rings of confusion and fear started moving in circles around Haree.

'Did I say anything last night?.....Maybe he is upset because I didn't undo my blouse last night.' She had seen her mother removing her blouse

whenever her father came to her bed late at night. Her heart ached for the love she tasted last night. The fear of losing it made her cry.

The day before yesternight, everything was different. She feared him and his touch. But today, he craved for his one glance, his attention. She would let him do whatever he wanted to. She would not mind even if just came and did what her father did to her mother. Any action which showed her that he claims her, she would welcome it.

She looked at her reflection in the mirror, trying to look at her in his eyes. Her green eyes were rimmed with kohl but they looked pale and tired. A round red bindi of the size of a fingertip was sitting between her eyebrows. Her mother had taught her to make it using kumkum. Collar bones protruding out where her slim neck ended, were highlighted by a thin necklace of black beads and a small gold pendant in the middle.

She looked at the pleats of her sari. Her stomach was flat as a board, there was no extra fat on her body and the pleats of her sari were gathered thick around her waist. That was the only budge on her body.

There was nothing in her which could be considered beautiful. She was ordinary, like others. She had never hated herself, but at that moment she did. Why did God not give her anything which she could cherish about herself? If He couldn't give anything else, a pair of beautiful lips or fair skin would not have harmed Him.

Thinking about him all day long, she regretted the moments she had wasted crying last night. She wished she could relive and change the events of last night, turn them into something else.

“Haaye....Bahu! Don't cry, I am also like your mother.” her mother-in-law said when she saw Haree crying.

Haree could not tell them that she didn't miss her mother. She missed Ram, his presence, his hands to hold hers, his eyes looking for her.

Her eyes kept searching for him throughout the day. When he came for lunch, her mother-in-law sent her inside the room to take a rest.

She wanted to stay there, to serve him food, to ask him what was wrong in what she did that night. However, she walked slowly, turning her head to have a look at him. She waited for him to come and see her. Maybe just a glance in which she could read him. Maybe a look that could remind him that she was still there.

Time dragged itself as though it was not interested in moving forward. The evening took a lifetime to envelop the world in darkness. Sitting on her cot, she was thinking that so much had happened in the last 24 hours; she had turned into a wife from a daughter. Last night she had wanted to run out of the room and sleep on her mat. But today, the same room was the place that would bring her the cure for her aching heart.

Sitting there, she tried to relate the sounds to the activities outside. Utensils clanked, and water splashed. Maybe they are doing the dishes.

She pictured her husband having dinner with his father and brothers. His plate was having a serving of potato curry and purees and a bowl of kheer with a pinch of crushed cardamom on it. She had cooked the kheer during the day, her first cooking in her new home.

Haree had started cooking when she was 9. It came naturally to her. She used to follow her mother all around the house. There was nowhere to go. When her mother worked in the kitchen, she would sit in the corner, rocking her younger sister in her lap. Her legs moved up and down to an inaudible rhythm and her eyes followed the movements of her mother. How she chopped vegetables into small pieces, how she lit a fire with cow-dung cakes without using wood. Sitting there, she used to imagine herself at her mother's place, cutting potatoes in different shapes, sometimes square like dice, sometimes long slices like fingers.

Her imaginary self soon turned real self when her mother's stomach started swelling again. It was like they switched places with each other. Her mother would sit in the corner, cradling the baby and observing Haree's hands moving. She winced and closed her eyes whenever she felt that knife might run over Haree's delicate fingers.

Mirroring her mother's moves, Haree's little hands moved swiftly cutting vegetables, stirring curry when it started boiling and flipping bread on hot tawa. Her knuckles went deep red while kneading flour. Hunched over a big steel plate, her tongue stuck out in concentration, she would press her small fists in the soft lump of flour, as if punching it. At times, she had an urge to make figurines of that mud-type flour but would control herself, and then happily give a small piece of it to her sister, who would roll it between her palms and make a face on it. All the things a little girl should do, she skipped and passed on to her sisters.

While blowing into the fire to keep it alive, when her eyes burned, she closed one eye as if winking at the fire and continued changing sides of chapatis.

She felt the sting from afar.

If she hurt herself while cutting vegetables or burnt her hands while cooking, she never let her mother know about it. Not even a sound came out of her mouth. Her face remained calm and soft all the time as if her hands did not send signals of pain to her mind. She healed her cuts with a paste of turmeric and mustard oil. And for burns, she would apply coconut oil at night, like she has seen her mother doing it.

Whenever her mother noticed a new mark on her skin, she would make a new load of paste for her. Old cuts healed, and new ones appeared. Their appearance and disappearance were as normal as breathing, as natural as day and night. Like new seasons come and go, they came and disappeared. And every cut sank deep in her skin and in her consciousness like a lesson.

She had seen her mother perform household chores like an experienced worker. Holding one of her sisters in arms, her mother could knead the flour with one hand for chapatis. Even while lighting fire, she turned the baby in her lap to change the nipples, when the baby had sipped the first one dry. Her every move was effortless and smooth. Her every expression and every move got imprinted on Haree's mind. Whatever Haree knew, came from her mother. And the rest of the things she learnt were with her eyes.

We all create a different picture of the world in our minds. Every world is different from others. Same world but still different!

“My Bahu has the hands of Annapurna!”

Her mother-in-law blessed her a million times when she had tasted the kheer. The aroma of cardamom filled the kitchen like it used to fill when Haree’s mother made it in her kitchen. She took out a note of one rupee from her blouse and moved it in circles over Haree’s head and then kept it again in her blouse.

“I’ll give it to kudewali in the morning.” she had clarified.

Haree imagined Ram dipping his two fingers in the bowl of kheer and then taking them to his mouth without spilling it. The way he had talked last night, his manners did not seem clumsy to her. A person who places his words so calmly as if keeping showpieces on the shelf can’t be clumsy.

She imagined the taste of kheer melting in his mouth. What would he think? Maybe he liked it and asked for more serving. Or maybe he didn’t even touch it, anger still frothing under his skin.

She opened her eyes when she heard the noise of the door being opened and closed again. She must have slept, because everything outside was silent now, as if nobody lived in that house. Her head felt a little heavy and dizzy. It had been 48 hours since she had slept or eaten properly. In the last two days, she had slept in breaks and had eaten just bread with tea.

The day before her wedding was the last time she had eaten a proper meal. Her mother had fed her with her own hands. Tears streamed down from their eyes as if they were talking through them, exchanging their goodbyes with tears and her mother pouring love through the morsels she was feeding her. Haree did not remember when was the other time her mother had rolled a piece of chapati, soaked it in curry and then put it in Haree’s mouth. She could not remember. Maybe she never did. Her mother was scarcely available to her and she had accepted that fact without any resentment towards her.

Haree remained unstirred on her cot. Only her eyes moved when Ram changed clothes. The restlessness he had left in the morning subsided. She was too exhausted to think of anything. All her questions, all her confusion, all the fear had taken a back seat. Her body seemed to be saving energy only for breathing and for her eyes. If anything else demanded it, it could not be entertained right now.

The ease in Ram's demeanour had returned, as though he had changed it with his clothes. He had taken off the stiff aura, ripping it off from his body, slipping out of it raising his hand above and then taking it off from over his head. Tucked it into the nail on the wall, took his shirt of calmness and slipped into it. He reached to his cot and then waited for her to say something. He looked at her; she was seated; her back leaning on the wall and eyes effortfully shut.

"Are you angry at me?" he asked, leaning closer to her.

She opened her eyelids slowly and then turned her face towards him.

"You are not talking today. So..," he continued, looking into her eyes.

"Nothing, I am just tired," her words came out without any feeling in them.

She did not have the energy to show puzzlement in her voice. She wanted to take her time to understand him before arriving at any judgment, before putting a type on him and pinning his final picture in her mind.

"Are you okay?" he nudged her again.

She stared at him, thinking about her next step. How should she proceed? And then without a warning, she sat straight, her eyes looking at the wall in front of her. White paint was flaking at various places - brown surface peeking directly at her.

She removed her pallu in one clean move, first from her head and then from her shoulders. Her hair was a little unkempt over her head but from her shoulders, thick folds of braids secured her long tresses.

She leaned forward; her hands reached back. Her back was bent from the middle like an arc. She unhooked two hooks.

“Beautiful.....! You.. ahhh.....mmm... have long hair,” his voice trembled.

He tilted his head to look and then moved his eyes away to her face. His heart was beating fast in his chest. She was struggling with the third hook when a finger touched her skin. She shuddered and in reflex moved her back forward a little. Immediately, he took off his hand as if he had touched a live wire.

“I am sorry,” he mumbled.

Even though the momentary touch was over, Haree kept feeling his finger in the centre of her back, as though it was still stuck there. The skin, where he had touched, had lost the power to fade the sensation on the skin. And it was still breathing there.

Years later, when Haree would think about that moment she won't remember who unhooked the third and last hook. It would be all foggy in her memory as if that specific moment was skipped by time.

The next thing she would remember was that the sensation which she had felt on her back soon spread across her whole body. Wherever his hands reached, the sensation ran and grew like ink spreading on paper. Starting from her back, his palms ran all over her bare skin, his index finger sliding smoothly on the knots of her spinal cord. And she realised the purpose of those knots! When his hands reached the front and cupped her breasts, she let out a long sigh. He played with them the way he wanted, and she let him do so. Goose bumps rose on her skin, in attention or in excitement. She didn't know. Losing grips of control over herself, she flowed with the moment.

She would remember the soft touch of his lips on hers. How rough his cheeks had felt when he rubbed them against her neck. His whiskers made the skin on her neck sensitive, as if her skin had sucked them deep inside and now, they could not be separated. How his long fingers were laced with hers. When he came over her, she looked so small beneath him. Her eyes

never left his face and nor did he. Every part of their body was having a conversation with one another.

His fingers talked to hers, his eyes to her eyes, his tongue to her tongue. It was a different language that only they could understand.

Later she would talk to herself and blush, thinking about it, 'How could she be so shameless, to look directly in his eyes? She should have closed her eyes. But if she had, she would not have been able to read him and save his face in her memory. How would she have relived that moment again and again?'

When he entered her, the pain mixed with pleasure ran through her. And the moment she felt the first hit of pleasure, it felt as if every part of her body was melting inside her and running out from between her legs, her body light as a drop of water. The sound of their breathing and moans would echo in her ears for years.

Afterwards, he held her in his arms like a delicate flower, tucking strands of her hair behind her ears. All the shame had come back to her eyes. She did not look at his face till he slept. He dozed off, leaning on the wall and holding her in his arms, her head on his chest. She could feel it rising and falling, his heartbeat in her ears.

Late in the night, when Haree was sure that he had slept, she looked up and took a glance at his face. His skin looked golden under the yellow light of their lantern in the room. She lightly touched his cheeks, whose friction was still alive on her face and neck. Looking at him, she mused that everything had happened in a dream, not to her but somebody else.

She ran her finger on his lower lip and Ram suddenly opened his mouth to let it slip inside. Ashamed, she covered her face with her hands. Her bangles clinked vigorously as if trying to catch up with Haree.

They made love again. When Haree woke up the next day, her body was aching. Her thighs were sore and tired as if she had walked miles. She had a pinkish-red mark on her neck and one right above her left breast.

Ram had worn his stern look again, as if drifting into some different world. He talked less and after finishing his breakfast in the kitchen with his brothers and left for the fields.

Within days, Haree understood that the moment Ram stepped out of the room, her husband turned into a son, a brother, and the sole bread earner of the family. But at night he always came back to her as a husband. No rights of others on him at that time. He belonged to her.

Every day she looked forward to the night to come. Nights...., nights of her world in which she could be with him. While she sewed and mended clothes, he would sit across and write something in his notebook. Her needle would dive inside the cloth, disappear for some time, and then come out again on the surface like a fish in the pool. From the corner of her eyes, she would watch his fingers move swiftly. How he gripped the pencil in the middle and moved it across the paper and that little pencil moved as per his orders. She wondered what he might be writing. They would talk for hours. Ram would tell her all about his dues and payments which he needed to make and collect. She started knowing them all by name.

She would go through his notebook whenever she found it lying on this cot. Running her fingers on words, she would try to make some meaning out of them. She always conjectured that they looked back at her in disgust, as if she had desecrated their purity. Emotions sentient in them vanished, and they died one by one under her touch.

‘When did he learn to read and write? How does it feel to draw all those different shapes on paper? Is it difficult to remember so many words?’ She kept all her questions and curiosity bundled inside her. She could not gather enough strength to ask him about his school. That was the only topic she avoided, ashamed that the discussion will bring out an ugly comparison between him and her.

She did not dare to face the truth that she was nowhere near him. She did not have charming looks like him and she did not have the skills like him. She was of no use to the world. She was nothing in his comparison.

But then one night, when they were sleeping after making love, Haree turned and stretched her hand to feel Ram's body. She kept moving her hand to reach him, but she couldn't. She opened her eyes and tried to look for him, her eyes half open and half closed. He was not on the bed. She looked around. He was not in the room either. Worried, she got up to go check.

She found him sitting at the entrance of the room under the dim light of a lantern hanging low from the hook of the door. The circular glow of the lantern on his lean figure looked scary from behind. His back hunched over his account book, he was holding it like a student holds his class notes. He was scribbling something and then counting on his fingers, redoing the calculations.

"Suno!" Haree called him in a low voice, afraid of waking others up.

She took her dupatta from the bedside and covered her head and walked down to the door.

Her bangles clinked softly when she kept her hand on his shoulder.

"Haaaaaan," he was startled, shocked by the sudden touch.

"Sorry..." she whispered.

"Why are you here? You will catch a cold?" he said in a low voice matching hers, "Come on.....let's go inside." he closed the book, tied the white thread around it, and touched it to his eyes and forehead, before kissing it.

When they had returned to their bed, she asked him, "Why do you love that book so much? I always see it tucked under your arm. Is it your favourite Kitaab?"

Holding her hands in prayer and touching her forehead, she further said, "Is it about Bhagwan Ram?"

"Hahaha.....! No, it's not about Bhagwan Ram," he said with a subtle but hearty laugh.

She looked at him, waiting for him to explain.

He took her hand in his hand. She noticed how small her hand looked in his palm. He could hide it completely in his fist if he wanted.

“It’s my Bahi-khata,” he said, moving his finger around the henna design on her hand. And then suddenly interrupted his own words, saying quizzically, “Why did you make the circle, why not any flower?”

“I don’t know how to make a flower. This is the only thing I know to make.” Haree said without relenting, “but, leave that, tell me about your kitaab.”

‘Arey, it’s not KITAAAAAB. It’s my Bahi-Khata.” he said, sitting up.

“Baahi- Khataaa,” she copied him as if swallowing the words in her mouth, wondering what kind of taste they will leave on her lips. “What do you read in it?” she asked.

“I don’t read, I write in it.”

“Write? Story?”

“No, not a story! I don’t know any story,” he smiled.

“Then?”

“Nothing, just my hisaab-kitaab.”

“But you just said it’s not Kitab?”

He looked at her to read her face, expecting hints of humour there, but when he didn’t find any, he laughed with his gaze fixed on her. How innocent she looked at that time. She blushed under his gaze.

Haree watched him working on his accounts at night, black lead moving furiously on those long white papers. But, late at night when he sat down with his diary, leaning his back on the wall, his hands moved slowly over it as though making love to it. Haree watched his fingers moving and

stopping, thinking, and then writing again. Every night, he recited a few lines to her while undoing her braids. She heard them intently, closing her eyes, repeating every word after him without producing any sound.

It was during those talks that one-night Ram was writing and she had her head on his shoulder. Her eyes were moving with the pencil. She was observing the arches and the curves he made. Some of them looked like tiny sticks, some like rounded stones. She was imagining pictures of birds, vegetables, fruits, etc. trying to match them with his letters, trying to understand them within the limits of her knowledge of the world.

Ram raising his head and looking lovingly at her, moved the diary towards her and said,

“Now read it, it’s complete now. Here.”

“I ... I can’t read.” her words made the moment heavy. “Ohh... I thought you were already reading while I was writing.”

“No,” she moved her head left and right and then went silent.

With a surprise, Ram asked her why she didn’t go to school, which she liked so much to read.

“Why do I need to read?” she said and hung her head low in shame, as if an ugly secret about her has come out that should not have. Something about her seemed to have disintegrated in that confession.

Of course, Haree knew numbers. Her mother had taught her. When they used to sell their cow, dung cakes to the villagers, she learnt to add and subtract, using her fingers. They never crossed 20, and all her calculations ended before it.

“Numbers, that’s all you need,” her mother once said to her, keeping a big basket of cow dung on Haree’s head, “Rest is nothing. You don’t need anything else in this life. Learn to add and subtract and you won’t be less than a master.” “1,2,3,4,5,6,7,8,9,10,12,13 ,16,17,.....” Haree counted

every day until she learned them like a parrot. Not knowing their shape and their meaning, she chanted them like some holy words.

“Why don’t I go to school?” She had asked her mother one day. She used to see children from her village coming out of the school while they came back from the fields, the hot sun shining on their heads.

“What is the need for school? What would you do with all that knowledge?” her mother had said looking straight on the road.

Haree had waited for her to say something more, but her mother did not say anything. When children passed them, she turned her face in their direction. The boys were chasing each other. Their laughter filled the empty noon. She smiled at them and kept looking at them until they disappeared.

Haree did not ask her mother further. She knew that her mother did not have any answer. Whenever Haree asked anything that she could not answer in words, her mother filled it with silence. Unlike her father, who filled it with beatings. Whenever her mother asked him anything that he did not want to answer, he either ignored her or beat her up as a reply.

“I’ll teach you,” Ram broke the heavy silence.

He taught her how to hold a pencil. Her hand moved slowly as if they were tired and wrote the next letter only after taking a break. Seeing black tiny sticks and pebbles appear on pages, she smiled and cried at the same time. Every letter she wrote on paper made her cry harder.

“I will not teach you if it’s that painful to you,” Ram said, stopping in the middle. And then suddenly both laughed. Her eyes were still filled with tears when he wiped them. All her questions seemed to be running out of her eyes and Ram became the answer to all of them. He filled the gaps of her missed world, even without her asking.

They spent their nights’ teaching, learning, reading, and writing. At first, her words were crooked, some small, some big. Ram laughed when he saw some of them upside down.

She spent her days practising writing in thin air on an invisible page. While spreading clothes on the clothesline, her index finger moved as if she was holding a magic stick. Before kneading the flour, she wrote on it.

At night, Ram used to check her work. He smiled, corrected, and complimented her. Her eyes beamed and turned sad depending upon his comments.

It was their first anniversary when she gifted him her first poem. She had been writing it for one month. Writing and then rewriting it all over again. She couldn't hide it from her husband, so she had torn a few sheets from his notebook and threaded them together. After finishing her chores, she would sit in her room writing them. Hunched over the pages, she used to write, her tongue sticking out of her mouth.

She wrote, finding different words to rhyme, not knowing that her words will become true someday. Unaware that years later she will curse herself for writing those words, for encouraging her husband to teach her. Not fathoming that someday she will cry for days thinking about this day. That she will request God to give her powers to go back in time and rewrite her words. That she will spend nights thinking about what made her write those words. Had some devil possessed her that day or she was the devil all that time but she didn't know it?

But while writing, her heart was pounding in her chest. She was scared that the loud rhyme might shake the wall. She had rolled the paper after finishing and tied a red ribbon around it.

Two hearts are beating inside me.

One is dying slowly, the other is learning to breathe.

Thousands of worlds I'll bring, thousands I'll kill,

And all those time that you couldn't live,

I'll live!

■

*Once I tiptoed on a conversation of God,
He asked somebody to fix the Devil in my skin.
He opened my heart and slipped jealousy in it
Then patched my skin with hunger of love sprinkled over it.*

Naina had a very strange relationship with nights. It's like two people who have known each other for years but still can't decide the relationship between them. They are not lovers; they are also not strangers but certainly can't keep their distance from each other. Now, they have known each other so long that it seems impossible to separate them from each other. They are just two people in contact, and their feelings about each other change every day.

She never liked sleeping alone. The darkness of night scared her. She would often wake up after a terrible dream.

Sometimes, they talked like lovers, one sharing the deepest secrets and another listening and absorbing them like soil absorbs drops of water. Sometimes they fought, saying mean things to each other. If their words could hurt, both would have ended up cutting each other in tiny pieces with blood oozing from all over their bodies, and then crying in frustration, waiting for their bloody fit to get over.

After those kinds of nights, Naina always woke up with pain in her body, as if her fight with the silent night was real and now there were multiple bruises on her body, not letting her move her limbs. They were broken and askew.

Like extremists, they either loved each other passionately or ripped each other apart. It was rare when they would meet and would not talk at all. But it happened sometimes. Nobody would bother each other, not in anger but as mutual decisions. The night would come and go without talking to Naina. And, Naina would stare at the ceiling, listening to the weird and unfamiliar sounds of life, sounds which she had never heard before and which she could not comprehend where from they were coming. She would look and listen with absolutely no thought of the past and future in her head until her eyes refused to stay open.

On those blessed nights, she would sleep peacefully, at least for a few hours before waking up with a violent jerk and then sleep again.

Tonight, was one of those nights, where the darkness around her did not bother her. But her mind was not empty, unlike other such nights. She was lying on her bed but her mind was still in the college.

That moment when Veer had looked at her for the first time was playing in a loop, like a song bug, that keeps playing in your head throughout the day. No matter what you do stop it, it keeps popping again and again. And before you realize it, you start humming it aloud.

But Naina did not try to stop that, instead, she intensified it, looking deeper into her memory, and then adding details that she might have missed at that moment.

‘He also looked at me from afar. His hands touched mine intentionally. Maybe he smiled at me. He was also feeling that there was something odd that day.’

She was certain that Veer had noticed her uneasiness. At the same time, she hoped that her friend had not. Her friend always tried to keep Naina away

from the boys she liked. She was very particular about it, an invisible line that both knew and followed as well.

During the day she did not have the courage to accept her behaviour, but in the company of night, she can let her heart wander wherever she wants. In her imagination, she went back to the time when she was sitting next to him. Generally, she would make an excuse and leave when the boys arrived, but today at the canteen, Veer and his friends caught them off guard in the canteen. They sat all around before Naina was able to escape from the scene. Naina read the discomfort in Astha's eyes when Veer sat next to her facing Astha.

“Hey,” he said and she did not know to whom.

She waited for Astha to reply to him, and she did. But then he looked sideways at her and called her name.

“Nainaaaa..... I said Hi.” his words sounded beautiful.

If his tone could have been a visual, they would have looked like bubbles floating in the air. His words aroused the same rush of feelings she had felt when she had heard her name for the first time from his mouth. Somebody should tell him to stop calling my name like this. She thought.

His eyes were on her face when she looked up. His brown eyes looked a little tired, dark circles under them as if he had not slept for days. She said her ‘Hi’ quickly and looked surreptitiously at Astha to check the effect of her having crossed the defined boundaries. But Astha's eyes seemed normal. Naina was relieved that Astha had not noticed whatever had happened between Veer and Naina.

Astha was the daughter of a friend of Naina's father. Not the best of friends, but yes, her father and Naina's father knew each other. The day they had met to introduce the girls to each other, Naina could tell that they were not friends. They just knew each other somehow and were forced to come together for the sake of their daughters. Neither of them wanted to send the girls to college on their own. Maybe both of them were scared. It was a new thing for them.

Before college, the girls had not stepped out of their house without their father or brother. The school was okay. There was no fear. Children were under the strict observation of teachers. It was safe for their daughters. But college! It was different. It was like an open field; nobody was under any control. There were no rules and if at all there were, nobody followed them. And nobody could force them to follow either.

The young people there were free to do anything with their minds and their bodies. Human beings are not dangerous either when they are kids or when they are old. They are dangerous and unpredictable when they are in their youth. They think that they can fight with the world single-handed and can win over any situation. They believed that so far no one has had the courage to change the world, but they have. The line of control diminishes and they taste different kinds of desires and freedom. They simply flow with the rush of growth hormones, without knowing the consequence of their actions.

Naina used to think that it was only in her house, but for the first time that day, she was relieved that she was not the only one who was struggling with the boundaries. Naina didn't find Astha intimidating like her school classmates, who wore their skirts above their knees and talked in a language with a diction that Naina could not understand and acquire. They made fun of her and sometimes she did not even understand their pranks. It was only when the class burst in laughter looking and pointing at her that she would understand that something had happened.

Astha was wearing a green suit with white salwar. Her hair was tied in a high pony, and her face was slim and long. Her features were as plain as Naina's except the eyes. Her eyes were livelier and more confident whereas Naina's eyes were curious but dull. Naina's green eyes stared at the world in wonder as well as in confusion, as if everything she was seeing was new and she didn't understand it. She had grown up without gathering knowledge of the world around her.

They met at Naina's home. After a brief exchange of pleasantries between their fathers, it was decided that Naina's father would drop them at the college. An effort from his side to seal the deal of taking care of her daughter for at least three years. Later also, whenever they missed their bus,

it was always Naina's father, uncle or brother who dropped both at the college.

Naina never saw Astha's father after that day. She did not even remember his face. But to her mind, every father looked the same. Tired, attentive, authoritative, talked less, and smiled even less. The only difference was that some of them wore moustaches and some did not.

Naina had noticed that there was an ease in Astha's body language. She looked freer than Naina. She did not slouch in the back seat. She looked out of the window confidently as if she knew all the roads and buildings. When Naina's father asked her about the schedule of classes and how she went to college, she told them about bus routes and their timings and their numbers. Naina did not know till then that there were two kinds of bus services, one govt, which was cheaper for students and the other private buses, which charged the same for everyone.

The way Astha looked in the rear mirror to contact her father's eyes made Naina uncomfortable. She knew that her father was also thinking the same. A girl so bold to talk so freely to a stranger, even if he is her father's friend, was not a sign of cultured girl.

"Girls should be silent like an ant, which works hard the whole day without disturbing anybody," Naina's father used to say.

And whenever she heard him telling that, she thought about the story of the elephant and the ant. The ant sneaked into the elephant's trunk and created havoc inside it. The elephant kept crying and running for help in the streets. Why did her father never talk about that ant? She always wanted to ask him but could not. What if her father just smashed her beneath his palm like she used to smash ants when she was a little girl?

But Astha was a different kind of ant, a red one, which leaves a little bump on your skin when it bites. Naina wished she could be a bit like her. There were so many people she wanted to bite, maybe not like killing an elephant but a tiny red bump, harmless but satisfactory.

It was clear from the first meeting that it was more about concern for their safety that they were together. However, Astha was unconstrained and used to go to college all by herself. It was Naina who needed protection and a controlling eye over her. Naina also was relieved to know there was somebody who could be with her in college. She could easily hide in Astha's shadow and follow her around and see the world rather than feeling the heat on her face. For her, Astha would be like a layer of safety between her and others.

Though they were in the same college, their classes were different. Naina was pursuing her graduation in Arts while Astha was studying science. Naina's was the course that students below average opted for, or should I say that was the only option for them if they wanted to go to college. The science students held a different kind of position in the teachers' eyes. Astha had topped her school with 98% marks in her Board exams.

Naina and her father sensed that she was better than Naina in any sense.

Though it bothered Naina, she chose to remain unconcerned. Since ever everybody had been better than her. She was no one nowhere already. Astha's presence was merely a reminder of it.

Before dropping them at the college, Naina's father shifted in his seat, as if trying to form words which were reluctant to come out. He was looking at the two of them through the rear mirror. Astha got down and was waiting for her to come out, when her father said, "Always remember that a girl carries the weight of name and reputation of her family on her shoulders. I am trusting you with it, keep it safe."

With his eyes piercing through her, it was more like a warning than just a statement. Her father had that power in his tone that delivered a warning wrapped in subtle words. She nodded and left the car. All her excitement had evaporated. Suddenly, the college looked like a battlefield, where she will have to fight hard to save her family's honour.

"Come with Astha today. She will tell you the bus you need to take to home," he said, in a tone that was normal as someone else's father, friendly and joyful.

Astha smiled at him and waved, while Naina stared at him with blank expressions, as if he had ordered her to stay until he disappeared.

“So, what is your course?” Astha had asked in a cheerful voice.

Her tone and her question both irritated her. She kept walking before answering, thinking Astha would forget or change the topic of discussion. Silence has always come to her rescue since childhood.

Give time to words, they will themselves disappear. Be patient. You don't need to answer every question. You don't need to show that you have heard everything. Sometimes pretending and not acknowledging is the best thing you can do to yourself.

There are two types of people. One who defends and protects themselves with words and the loud presence of their personality around them, play every ball life throws at them. Others are those who protect themselves with silence, dodging the situations with their invisible personality. Naina was more of the second type.

Astha kind of fell in the first category, though her body language was not that loud. She was more like a challenger, who knew how to handle every ball. No matter how tricky, she would have a move in her mind to deal with it. She laughed, talked, and joked like it was an extension of her body. Self-Expression came naturally to her.

On the other hand, Naina, sometimes could not decide where to put herself, in her own created second category or somewhere else. Whenever she looked at Astha, she found her images in her. But those images belonged to some other Naina. Now she remembers that Naina only in her faded memory. She is like a person standing far and you can just make out the silhouette of that person but can't see the details.

Over the years, she had lost confidence in her words. They never saved her. Never came to rescue her. In fact, the more she tried to express herself to them, the more they created trouble for her as if they were angry at her and were taking revenge on her. Whenever she said anything, somehow the feel of the words would suddenly change when they came out. And, Naina

would stare at them, questioning them about their bluff. They never came out with the feelings she would plan to say. Who was manifesting these different meanings to them inside her? Who knows?

Silence looked more profound to her. Simple yet powerful! It created a kind of mystery around her. It saved her the damage she could make with her words. Life is tasteless without words, however, with silence, it was peaceful and less dangerous. On the other hand, it gave her time to observe others. Read others' eyes. More than her ears, she used her eyes to listen to others. Her eyes would take in every tiny detail of another person and then later at night, she would dissect them layer by layer, trying to understand the actual meaning of them, rather than the meaning that suited her.

Once they reached the first floor, Naina asked Astha to show her class.

"I would come to your class, for lunch," Naina said and Astha held an expression that said that she didn't like it. Naina read it clearly before Astha replaced it with a gentle smile.

"NO! I'll have my lunch in my class, between breaks. I can't come. I have back-to-back classes till 3.00. I'll see you here at 3 then." Astha said and quickly walked towards her class.

Naina heard but did not process the words in her mind, for she knew it was simply a fib. It was not the first time Naina had been rejected. She had been eating her lunch all by herself. At lunch, she would wait for other girls to open their tiffin and sit at the desk. Then she would take out her steel box and would sit at the same desk but at a distance, pretending to be part of their group, yet keeping her privacy intact. At least the onlooker would think that she was one of them. She didn't realize that she was embarrassing herself openly. It seemed that along with her words, her actions had also started turning against her but she did not know it at that moment. Even after becoming aware of her moves, she remained unconscious of them and their effect on her and others.

The first time when she had sat for lunch with them, all had looked at her in confusion. Before that, they had not noticed her. Maybe they had, but Naina didn't know it. She thought that even this time she would go unnoticed and

she would be able to pull this stunt easily. But as soon as she sat on their desk, all of them turned their heads in unison. Scared, she looked at them, as if she had entered their private territory without their permission and they were all asking for an explanation.

She smiled at them sheepishly. They turned back their heads, let out a stifled laugh together and then continued eating and talking.

Naina heard them but pretended she didn't. She ate her food, which suddenly had lost its taste. It seemed stale, as if she was eating paper instead of chapati. She ate only half of the lunch and kept the lunch box open on her lap until the other girls finished theirs and left the classroom to take a stroll outside.

Naina closed her lunch box, kept it in her bag, and then wiped her hands on the bag of the girl who had looked at her first during lunch. Yellow curry marks on the new white bag gave her the satisfaction that she has been craving. A perfect balance of silence and revenge, she thought. Even if it didn't make her feel better, but at least eased off the strange discomfort they have caused her.

“Ohhh Fuck! Shit! My Baaaaagggggggg....,” the girl screamed when she returned from lunch.

Her gang stood circling her, taking their turns to look at the stained new white bag. Naina was sitting on the last bench, eyes down but ears on every word they said. She could imagine the associated expressions on their faces. Some were shocked while some were scared that girl could blame them for it.

A song started playing in her head, and she tapped her one foot to the rhythm. Enjoying every beat of the silent music as she heard them intuitively.

It was not her favourite song, but she was enjoying it because it suited the situation. She had never seen the video of that song, nor did she even remember where she had heard that song. All she knew was that it was an old song from a movie from the sixties. But whenever she saw someone

reacting to her tricks, her mind would automatically start playing it in the background. Just the single line kept repeating until the feeling of happiness filled her heart to the brim and poured out.

But that feeling never stayed for long. It was always short-lived, yet enough to pull through a few hours without the uneasiness that she always carried inside her. The restlessness invariably returned whenever she saw anybody staring at her or nature forced her to be in front of anybody. Her anxieties and insecurities returned in multitudes, like waves, soaking her deep, going away momentarily, and then again coming back more violently.

She would wear her silence at these moments. Nobody told her how she looked at that time but, in her mind, she visualised herself as a small insect, trying to hide in its skin on sensing danger and then moving slowly once it knew it was safe.

For the next few days, she tried to mingle with the girls in her class, asking them about the schedule of class even though she remembered it. She could recite it in her sleep. She would offer them her food, plain chapati and curry that her mother used to give rolled in an old newspaper. When she unwrapped the chapati, the faces of heroes and heroines would come out stained with ghee. She would remove the newspaper, fold it like a ball in her hand and hide it before offering the food to others. But small imprints of newspaper on the chapatti gave her secret away. Girls always refused her food, sometimes after looking at it and many times even without looking at it.

They would just mumble, “No thanks!” barely audible to Naina and would continue to eat, shifting a little further from her.

There were some girls who talked to her initially, but they too soon left her. She could never know why that happened.

The girls mostly talked about their families, their studies, and the small courses they were taking on weekends. Naina was always out of words in their midst. There was nothing she could tell them to keep up the conversation. She could not tell them that she helped her mother clean cattle shit on weekends.

Whenever the girls decided to meet outside college after classes, they never told Naina about it. They did not even say “No” to her, but the way they talked about the plan, it was clear that she was not part of it. Naina would be glued to them, listen to them talk till the end of the class and then they would disappear without even saying goodbye to her.

She didn't mind, at least they allowed her to share the space with them. She was happy with that. If there was nothing to gain, there was nothing to lose also. She was not looking for friends and even if she did, she never let that thought cross her mind. She knew it would hurt her. Throughout her life, she had believed that there was nothing loveable about her. Her struggle was just to prove that she was not disgusted at least.

That day, when Astha refused her offer for lunch, she was not surprised but upset. Why did she let herself out so easily, ever hungry for attention and security? Her classes finished at 1 o'clock, so she kept waiting for Astha to stand in front of her class. She started eating her lunch, standing in the corridor itself. Food tasted like soil in her mouth.

‘Why does this food taste like this? It tastes different at home,’ she was in her thoughts when the door behind her opened and boys and girls came out rushing, like peanuts spilling out of a torn packet.

She quickly packed her lunch box and stuffed it inside the bag. There cannot be anything more embarrassing than a girl eating her lunch all alone in the college corridor. It looked like a beggar eating on the street because he doesn't have a proper place to eat.

When Astha came out, she called her out. Astha came near her, told her that she had 2 more classes, and then quickly left with her friends, talking, and laughing. Naina stood there unsure about herself.

She saw Astha coming back after 15-20 minutes with the same group. A guy wearing white shirt and black trousers looked more than his age, and a fat girl moved her neck more than usual. Naina thought that the girl would fall sick if she talked for more than 5 minutes. All the movement of her head would certainly make her dizzy and she would throw up. Everything in her stomach would come out without constraint.

When they disappeared into the class, there was nothing to do for Naina. She turned towards the corridor boundary. From the first floor, she could see the classrooms at the other end of the corridor. It was all empty and silent. There were only a few students, mostly boys hanging around. Her eyes scanned the rooms one by one. She saw two students sitting at a desk in a room, looking out of the windows on their side. At first, it looked like they were just talking, but then their heads came closer. They started kissing.

She turned down her eyes. It felt as if she had breached their privacy. But then curiosity took over and she looked at them again. Their heads were still joined. Guy's hand started moving down the girl's shoulder and then it came down to her right breast. He was feeling it through her top.

Naina thought that the girl would remove his hand and would slap him, or she will at least cry for help. But, to her surprise, she didn't. Naina looked around to check if anybody else was looking at them as if she was the girl in there and wanted to make sure that nobody was watching them doing that.

Her heart was racing now, her head was telling her that she should not be looking at them, she should not be even standing there, but she could not tear away her eyes from them. They were glued to them. When the guy didn't feel resistance, he slipped his hand into her T-shirt. He squeezed her breast. Naina winced at her place. She could not see his hand moving inside her shirt, but her mind drew a vivid picture of his actions - how his palm might have clutched the soft flesh and squeezed it until it started hurting her. Naina shivered.

It had been a long since she has had this feeling. She did not have a name for it. No one ever described this kind of feeling. Not even in movies. It was a feeling different from pain. It was sharp and twitching. Her stomach would hurt as if she had been punched hard many times. Her heart would race like she had been running away from something, and had just stopped to breathe, to fill her lungs with oxygen. And now again, she needed to run to save herself, because if she was caught, it would rip her apart.

She would get such a sick feeling that she could vomit anytime. Her stomach would churn at a scary rate, and she had to keep sipping water now and then to control it.

This feeling of unease would last only a few minutes, but the fear of returning would linger for days. She would lose her appetite, her body would feel heavy, and she would find it difficult even to go to the bathroom to relieve herself. She marked those as the worst moments of her life. Whenever it happened, she wished she should die. Once and for all, that torture would end and she would never have to go through that faceless torture again.

She sat down, clutching her stomach in her hands. She could feel her nails digging into her skin. There was no visible sign of the attack she was going through except signs of a little discomfort, like some minor pain on her face. But inside, it was like everything had been tossed upside down. Her heart seemed to be somewhere in her abdomen, the space between ribs appeared to be blocked with no way for air to go inside. Things were moving in a different direction altogether.

When the attack passed off, Naina sat on the floor with her back reclining on the wall. Her legs were widespread, stretched in an ugly posture. Her breath was returning to normal with short breaths but taking full air in. The space between her ribs had opened. Her heart had come back to its proper place, beating almost silently now.

She heard the bell ring. The class would end at any time and students would come out. She didn't want them to see her like that but her body resisted. 'How does it matter? Who sees you anyway? They don't like you. There is no harm sitting here a little more.'

She waited for a few seconds but then slowly stood up when the commotion increased inside the class.

That was the moment when she hated the idea of going back home with Astha. It was much better when her brother used to come to pick her up. Always on time! She would find him at the college gate, waiting for her. But then she hated it, she never got time to explore other colours of college

life. However, today she was missing her bed, her room, and the comfort of her house.

Her body was still shivering from inside when Astha came out cheery and happy. Naina wondered how a person could be so happy and lively all the time. 'Doesn't she feel exhausted?' Secretly from within, Naina wanted to be like her or other girls. And, she hated the fact that she could not.

On their way back home, Astha talked about friends, her group, and her family. She told that she was the eldest of her siblings, and three younger brothers were still in school. She was one year older than Naina as well. She had dropped one year to prepare for some competitive exam, about which Naina didn't have any idea. But when Astha couldn't clear that, she decided on the course she was studying.

Naina heard her half-heartedly. Her mind was still there in the corridor. She was trying to move away from that image by looking around.

She was sitting in the third row. Astha was standing next to her. Naina's right cheek was touching Astha's waist. Astha had let her sit today in the lone empty seat, next to an old lady. She had orange hair and she was constantly looked out, holding the steel bar of the seat in front of her. Her hair was tied in a tiny braid. It looked like a dead lizard whose body had dried up. Looking at her, Naina wondered, 'Where might this old lady be going? Doesn't she have a son who could take her wherever she is going? Her grandmother would have never travelled like that.' The bus was not crowded but there were no more vacant seats. 4-5 people were standing holding grab poles. Naina looked around - different people, different faces. Everybody was free to look at everybody. People, who were standing, were looking around, their eyes moving from the first seat to the last, as if it was their right to look at anybody. They stared at people while they ate or read or counted the money to buy a ticket. Everybody's world seemed to be merging. People would hear intently the conversations that were not meant for them at all.

It was the first time that Naina had witnessed such openness. She liked that everyone on the bus was equal. Nobody was above or below the other.

But in the coming years, she would see the ugly side of that open world. Someone would flash his penis at her and hide it back when somebody looked at him. Eyes would rip her clothes and would try to look beyond them. Constant gaze on her chest would make her sick and uncomfortable. And those instances would remain in her mind for years. Later, all those faces, eyes and hands which touched her would come back again and again and would haunt her at night.

For the next few days, Astha taught her the timings and numbers of the buses which ran on the college route. “See, bus no 33 will directly take you to the college. You don’t need to stop anywhere and it comes at 9.10. You need to reach here by 9.05 so that you can find a seat, okay!!” She said.

Naina noted down the bus number in her mind, listening to Astha intently as if she was sharing some life-saving mantra that could be used whenever she was in danger.

Astha also taught her how to get on the bus and how to get down from it. “Hold the bar first then get inside and then hold the bar with both hands, else you fall on your head, flat on the road.

The bus won’t wait for you to get in, it will start moving once you hold the bar. And never get out of the bus when it’s still moving, okay? Wait for it to stop and if the driver does not stop, shout at him. He will stop immediately.”

Naina had not understood anything when she was telling all this, but within days she understood every word of it. Whenever she heard any girl scold the driver, she laughed. It was so amusing. The driver would lash out his anger, passing comments on them till they got down. And the girls also responded with full power till the bus disappeared.

They were standing at the bus stop, waiting for their arrival. They were late today. Bus number 33 had already left. Now they were waiting for the next one.

“See, bus no. 273 is coming,” Astha shouted, looking towards the right side, from where the traffic was coming.

Naina moved forward and turned her head to the right. ‘Where the hell is bus 273?’ She thought. She could not spot any bus with that number.

“Areyy look beyond that green truck..... See..... can you see it?” Astha said, her hand on Naina’s head, forcing it to look in the correct direction.

“Ohh...That one?” Naina said although she could not see any bus coming, she accepted, ashamed of her lack of knowledge.

“We will take this bus and leave it at Park stand and then we will take another bus to college,” Astha said, still looking at the road, moving her head left to right so that she doesn’t lose sight of it.

The bus came into vision of Naina only after it reached the bus stop and everybody started running towards it. Till then she was just moving her steps in sync with Astha, who was making her way toward that invisible bus.

“Never sit behind the conductor’s seat. They keep shouting. Do you have a student pass? Today we will go to the Bus Depot and will get you a pass. Then you don’t need to buy tickets. You can just show your pass whenever any checker comes and demands it. Understood?”

Astha explained and confirmed what a mother does to her children. Here is your pencil and where is your lunch box in the bag? And like that ignorant kid, Naina heard and nodded, not fathoming the importance of those instructions.

Whenever they met, it was always Astha who talked. She always had many stories to tell. Naina didn’t look forward to them, yet she liked the positioning. She would listen and Astha would talk. Naina did not want to scare her away with her weird talks. At the same time, she felt that Astha was also looking for someone to hear her out. She talked like there was a creek inside her and Naina had widened it a little and now she just couldn’t stop pouring out from there. She talked about everything she had in her mind. Without any filter! About her family, she would tell how her father reacted when he found out about her relationship with one of her classmates in high school. And that her mother was stricter than her father.

She used to come to drop Astha off and would wait till Naina reached the bus stop. Initially, she had looked at Naina with curious eyes, observing her clothes, the way she made her hair, how she spoke, everything. She came for a few days and studied Naina with those scrutinizing eyes, but once she was sure that this new girl couldn't affect her daughter in any negative way, she let Astha come alone to the bus stops.

Astha's mother often asked Naina to come to her place, and Naina used to nod silently in acceptance of the offer. But both knew that it was not a real invitation, but just a way to break the ice between the two. Naina knew that she was not allowed to visit any of her friend's houses and that Astha's mother wouldn't like it either.

When Naina was in her final year of school, her father and she had gone to a parent-teacher meeting. Her friend Mini had also come. Mini asked her to join her birthday party the next weekend. Naina was excited that she was being invited to a birthday party. She wanted to go, but she could not accept the invitation without her father's permission. So, she asked Mini to convince her father of the same.

When Mini told Naina's father about it, he smiled and said "Arey..... jarur. She will come for sure. I'll drop her at your place."

Both the girls were happy. The entire weekend they planned things they were going to do at the party. Naina kept thinking for hours about what to wear for the party. Except for an old suit-salwar of her aunt, there was nothing in the almirah to wear. Finally, she decided that she would wear the school dress itself. It was the only way she could save herself from the shame. She would tell that she didn't know that they were supposed to wear casual clothes.

Naina could not sleep the preceding night. The excitement of being at the party kept her awake. She wished morning to come quick, and that day she left her bed without anybody calling her to wake up. She took a bath, and washed her hair. Combed them carefully and tied them in a high pony.

When she reached the drawing room to tell her father that she was ready, she found him reading the newspaper. She struggled with her words for a

while, looking for appropriate ones to speak.

“Papa, I am ready. Do tell me whenever you are ready. We will go then,” she tried to say as casually as she could.

Her father folded the newspaper a little to look at her.

“Where?” He looked at her for two seconds and then returned to his paper.

“Papa. Today is Mini’s birthday. She told you last Saturday when we were in school for the PTA. She invited me and you had said you will drop me at her home.”

“Oh that....,” he said without his eyes leaving the paper.

Naina waited for something else to come but it didn’t. She called her father in a low tone, “Papa.....!”

“Hmm...” His response was like he was somewhere else at that moment and no conversation had entered his ears.

“Beta..... good girls don’t go to others’ homes.” His words were soft but sharp from the edges and they pierced her somewhere inside. “I didn’t say anything that day because it was not necessary. I thought I’ll tell you later about the rules of our house and then I took that you knew it already.”

Naina kept her eyes down while he spoke.

“Have you ever seen your aunt visiting anybody’s home?” He asked.

Naina wanted to say ‘yes’ because her aunt used to visit her friend’s house but without his knowledge. She always took permission from her mother. And she always took Naina with her as her bodyguard. Once they had gone far, they had to take an auto to her friend’s place, but Naina didn’t know the name of the place. But she chose to remain silent.

“I think you are already intelligent enough that you should have yourself said NO when she invited you. You should not have brought this thing to me in front of everyone. And most importantly, you should stay away from

this kind of girl. Friends are worthless, they are good for nothing. They just spoil you. Talk to them only in school, don't bring them home or go to their place. Our daughters don't do these kinds of things and you should have known it already." His tone was now a little harsh and angry.

She didn't understand how, suddenly, it had become her fault and how she hadn't handled the situation carefully that let down her father.

She left the room without saying anything. Went upstairs, changed her school dress, and slept till noon. When her mother asked her to eat, she refused to say that she was not hungry. Her friend called her a few times. She told her that she was not well. When she reached school on Monday, her friend was upset with her. She didn't talk to her till lunch. During lunch, Naina made up a story and told her that she was in a high fever. Her father had taken her to the doctor and she was there till noon.

"Why didn't your brother tell me that? I called your home so many times. I was waiting for you."

"My brother was not at home when I left the house," she kept adding details to the story and then said, "I'll come next time for sure."

It was rare that anybody invited her but whenever someone did, she repeated the same words knowing deep down that that next time would never come and she would never go.

At the bus stop, Astha would remain silent and cautious till her mother was there. But once she left, Astha would change. It was like she was hiding somewhere inside her and came out only when her mother had left.

"I don't know why she keeps doing that." Astha once said after her mother left.

"But why does she come only on some days, why not every day?" Naina had asked.

"Oh, that? She comes to check on me, whether I am meeting someone. She thinks that I have a boyfriend." Her eyes were on the road and her words

came out effortlessly.

Before that, Naina had never had a conversation about boys. She didn't know whether it was appropriate to talk about boys. She didn't know how to continue the discussion, she had nothing to talk about. She kept guessing whether she could ask about her boyfriends. She waited for Astha to speak further but she didn't.

With time Naina came to know that Astha was not in any relationship, but she was actively trying to get the attention of boys. She would drop obvious hints to the boys she liked and when they did not respond, she would turn to somebody else.

One day, they were sitting in the garden. Astha was laughing and giggling. Naina kept pretending to read. There was nothing else she could do.

“You know what I did?” Astha asked and then started replying, “I have written my name on his bike. And you know what.....?”

She took a break to laugh and then continued again, “While I was writing, he saw me and he started walking towards me. I have come running from there.”

She continued laughing.

“Who?” Naina asked, looking above Astha's shoulder to check if somebody was coming to them.

“Areeeeyy... you don't know him, I'll show you. He is super senior.”

“Super senior?” Naina had heard this term for the first time.

“Haven't you seen those guys who handle the events in the college? “

Naina searched in her memory to remember such boys. There was a group of seniors who had passed college years ago, but they used to come to the office regularly as if they were still students.

They would pass their time mostly in the canteen and patrolling the college whenever they wanted. They would stand in a group when classes would finish. They would scan girls from top to bottom and would number them.

Till then, Naina had not noticed them but after that day, when Astha had told her about her crush, both would wait for them to appear. Then they would follow them across the college and sit at the table next to where they sat. Naina didn't like the way they talked and the way they looked at them, but there was nothing she could do.

When Astha's efforts went futile, she changed her love interest. She kept trying but nothing happened. Naina watched her from a distance while she played her little games with others. She never wanted to be part of it and Astha too, did not want her to get in. Although they were like shadows of each other, both were alone in their worlds.

That night, lying on her bed, Naina thought about Astha. They were friends, but there was something strange between them. Naina did not know how Astha felt, but she knew about herself that she did not feel the way probably Astha felt about her. No matter how much Astha tried, Naina could not cross that line to reach her. She won't accept her and make her a part of her world, and at the same time, she did not even wish to enter Astha's space. She was obstinate about both the facts. She knew from the beginning that she was just using Astha for her survival.

Lying still on her bed, she wondered, 'Why do people meet? What is the reason that they feel connected? Why is that so many times words can't make a bridge between two people while sometimes, even silence gives answers to the question, for which we have been seeking answers all around?'

Even after knowing that Astha liked Veer, she could not stop thinking about him. Her mind kept exhorting her that she should not be thinking about him. That night Naina discovered one thing about herself. She was a selfish and disloyal person, she could turn against anybody for her own sake, and the hungry devil inside her had awoken.

CHAPTER

■

09

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A dream is travelling,

From his eyes to mine;

A burden is shifting,

From his shoulders to mine;

Time will tell who will survive.

The burden or the dream in our eyes

It is strange how some person's presence can change your life. You would be doing great without them before but when they come into your life, you realize that you were waiting for them. They take all the space in your life, the space which you never thought existed in you.

Their words dive deep into your skin, and before you know their words slip out of your mouth as if they had always been yours. Their touch feels like your own. Their body seems like an extension of yours, like it had always been your part. They merge in you like water and now you don't know how to separate them from you. You live in them and they live in you. You share life with them as one single being.

When you look back at the time that you had lived without them, it looks like it had happened in some other dimension of the world. You can only

imagine that part of your life as a far-gone memory, faint and almost illusionary to your mind.

When love comes, it brings all those beautiful feelings which you had never experienced before. A new person comes out of you. And you can't believe that the same person did exist within you all those years. You learn to cry, you start understanding the language of eyes, and you start hearing your heart talk. Your fingers dance when you hold that person's hand as if a sweet current was passing through them. They would giggle and dance and stay awake the whole night with you when you relive the memories. Apart from that, love also brings so many other things. Like it brings a secret parcel and hides it somewhere in your heart amidst all those beautiful feelings that you can't see it. You see it only when those sweet emotions die down.

When that person leaves you, you look inside yourself and stand facing the blank space in you. That's when you see that parcel. Some people don't open it. But not all are that intelligent. They go ahead, walk into the space, pick up that box, and open it. All the pain, fear, loss, and the gone-bye time hidden in it come out. They pour on you like rain. It never stops, it never ends. Exactly the way you had thought that love would never end.

How a person comes into your life and then changes your life! He pours into you, even though there is nothing to fill, and then that same person can leave an endless void in it.

It surfaces as it had always been your part, but you did not see it before. Once it happens, that blank space is all you see around you. Things start to lose meaning. Desires die down. The time that used to fly, feel less, and made you crave more gets unusually long. You don't know what to do with all the time you have. Every minute drags and stretches itself into hours or sometimes days. How many days you start living in a single hour, you don't know. Initially, you try to keep track and understand the speed of it, but soon you give up. Time tends to move slower and slower as if the only motto it has is to torture you.

When you love somebody more than yourself, fear arises in you. The fear of losing that person and the fear of a void that would open in you when he

will leave you. All the space that you have made inside yourself for him would be empty and the mere thought of that gaping blank space scares you.

Haree realized this emptiness inside her, whenever she thought about Ram. Some days, that void made itself visible, louder, and more violent.

Before Ram, Haree was a complete person. She had been living her life all alone till then, although her family was around her all the time. Her world revolved around only three people, her mother, her younger sisters, and sometimes her father. Her world was small, in which sometimes even she didn't exist. She never had a conversation with her father but still, she knew that she would do anything for him if time demands it at any point in time.

A mother who was scarcely available, a father who never made himself available, and her sisters, who did not care about her or was it that they were not grown enough to care for her? But Haree never minded them. She never felt the need for their time. A place on her waist was marked to hold them. One after another, they kept changing, but the space was always occupied.

Before meeting Ram, she never felt the need for sweet words or need of touch.

She was like a blank canvas, nothing written on it, nothing drawn on it. Whatever colours or dirt life had thrown on her, never stuck on it. Everything got swept on its own as if that canvas was coated with some magical oil. Or was time to create some strong colour to paint the canvas? A colour that will never leave her, a colour that she will never be able to hide, and a colour that she will never be able to absorb!

It was only after marriage that she started discovering herself. It was with him that she came to know that her favourite colour was Blue, the colour of the sky. When Ram had asked her, she was answerless.

“What is the point of a favourite colour” she asked him back. The idea of having a favourite colour seemed absurd to her. There are so many colours in the world, why would she pick just one?

“Everyone has a favourite colour. Maybe you don’t know it.”

“How can I not know if I have one?”

“I don’t know but I believe, there is not a single person in this world who doesn’t have a favourite colour. And if there is one, he is either lying or is a yogi.” Ram had said, in his usual calm tone.

Haree thought over his words. She was not lying and she was not a yogi yet she didn’t have any favourite colour. She didn’t have any feelings about any colour.

“What is your favourite colour?” she had asked with curiosity.

“Mine, Redddddd,” he said with a wide smile and then continued, “Earlier it was brown, but now I love Red, the colour of your bangles.”

Her bangles clinked when he ran his finger on them.

“How can I know which is mine?”

He had smiled listening to her innocent question. He took her face in his palms and said, “Your eyes..., your heart will tell you which one is yours. Just look and listen.”

“Eyes and heart,” she repeated his words, although unable to understand what it meant. How come eyes and heart can tell her?

The conversation was over, but the question remained unanswered in her mind. A new window had opened in her mind. From that window, the world was different, unknown to her. She started looking at things with different eyes, observing their colours and the feeling they evoked in her.

The next day, she took all her clothes out of the almirah and spread them on the bed. Most of them were old. Her mother had been collecting them over the years. Whenever she could save some money, she would buy suit pieces in bright and vibrant colours and keep them in her trunk. Dark Red, Deep Orange, Fuchsia, Haree kept staring at them with one hand on her waist.

“Your eyes and your heart....” she murmured.

She took one piece at a time and touched it to her cheeks as if touching a newborn baby. She felt the friction of the sequence of the dress on her cheeks and she remembered Ram. The feel was nowhere in comparison to his. The prickling she got from him made her hungry for them, whereas this touch was rude.

The bright and loud colours were making her eyes glare. She didn't like any one of them. She gathered all of them with both her hands and threw them in the closet.

“Useless! Waste of money. They are worth not a penny,” she said to herself.

During the day, she took more time than usual to finish her chores. Her eyes moved around slowly and looked deeper at things, things that she had been seeing since her childhood, but now she looked at them as if seeing them for the first time. She observed that the shade of green capsicum and the green colour of peapod are two different colours, and wheat flour is not white, it's creamish. For the first time, she observed her hair. They were not black; they were dark brown.

She asked her sister-in-law about their favourite colours in the kitchen. At first, all of them laughed and then after thinking for a while, said, “Mine is green,” and “I like yellow,” they kept naming the colours one after the other. Then thinking again and naming another one.

Throughout the day she kept diving into this different world, but could not find an answer to her question. Whenever she spotted a new colour or got to know of one, she repeated the words ‘Your eyes and your heart....,’ but she did not get any answer. A few days later, she let go of the question thinking it might be not for her. There was nothing special about her anyway.

It was after months that the answer revealed itself to her. It was mid-September. For the last two days, rains were pouring. Ram was unable to go outside for work. He spent his days at home, eating and resting. At night he wrote poems about rain and then recited them to her.

And Haree spent her days sitting in the veranda, looking at the drops falling. She looked at them intently as if she and rain were talking to each other. Rain was telling her all the things she had gathered through the year and Haree was hearing and nodding.

It was their first rain together. Ram looked at her from the window of their bedroom.

“Ohh..... so, you like rain!”, he said, looking at her through the iron bars of the window. Haree turned to look at him. His face was visible in pieces, as if she was looking at a half-complete puzzle. His right eye was hidden behind one of the rods. She could not see his lips but look at his eyes. She could tell that he was smiling at her.

He came outside and sat with her in the veranda, a little away but close enough that they could whisper. And that’s when looking up she said in a low voice, “I like the colour of rain. That’s my favourite.”

With Ram, she learnt that she was a morning person and Ram embraced the silence of the night. Along with herself, she read him, too. He liked his chapati a little warm and Haree liked them hot, directly from hearth to her plate. But that rarely happened. Ladies used to eat after everybody had eaten. When Ram came to know about it, he declared to his mother that now he would eat fresh chapatis only and he would come home at lunch. He insisted that he be served food hot.

“Don’t tell me that now, how you want roti. Go tell your wife. She will cook for you. I have done enough. Everybody goes crazy after marriage. Even this innocent boy of mine has gone all mad. I don’t know what they get between those legs, that they lose themselves.” His mother said.

Since that day, Ram made sure that he came home late at noon for lunch, so that both could eat together on one plate. And at night he would keep strolling through dinner time with excuses until everybody retired to their rooms.

At night, Haree would get up, feeling his presence against her skin. Nobody had ever loved her the way he did. All the love that she craved all her life,

Ram, gave her more than she could handle. Sometimes she could not believe whether she was living a dream or it was real. How could she be so lucky?

Haree didn't know whether Ram was changing her or recreating her. He was adding layers and layers of new things to her, things which she never expected. Every passing day was like a soft stroke of a brush of a new colour on her blank canvas. And it left a deep and vivid mark on her.

It was like she was a shapeless puddle of mud and Ram was shaping her. He gave her new eyes for the new world and new hands to feel the texture of life, which she had not felt before. He fed her mind, soul, and heart and Haree did not even know that she had been that hungry. That she had all that space in her. His words and his presence were the food for her survival.

Haree's eyes always looked for him. She would wait for him to return home. Her eyes always reached for the door whenever she heard any noise around it. Ram's family was into agriculture and farming. Although they did not have big farms and fields, they had more than enough. Being the only man who had passed the high school, he managed the accounts of the business. He tracked all the details about the market in which they could sell their fruits and vegetables at better prices. It was only because of him that their business was growing so much, that they started dealing with other wholesale markets in town.

Ram was quite innovative and cautious about his work. He started helping his father when he was young. Like Haree, he was the third child after two sisters. Both of his two brothers were younger than him. While growing up, he had seen his father struggling for money. There had been days when they went to bed without eating anything. His father had a very small piece of land in which he grew sugarcane, but somehow his crop never yielded the results they wanted. They did not have tractors to plough fields in time and they never had the means to buy fertilizers. Their manual efforts took time.

His father sold half of the land they had when Ram's sisters got married. Ram was studying in high school. It was a small school within the boundaries of the village. A retired doctor used to run that for free or with minimum fees. Ram was a bright student, His teacher always used to

encourage him to go to town and study further to become an accountant. Ram was very good with maths. Even he wanted to go but could not digest the idea of going to town leaving his family behind. He could not imagine his brothers leaving school and going hungry to bed, while he studied in the comfort of town.

He decided to drop out after his exams. He did not even wait for his results, to see if he had achieved the required numbers to get admission to college. His father resisted and scolded him but he didn't budge.

It was at dinner one day when Ram declared his decision, "I'll join you Baba. I don't want to study further. I don't like studying. It's enough now, it's time for me to work now," he said, faking a smile on his face.

"Do you think I am not capable of feeding my family?" his father had roared and threw his plate in the air. His plate hit the wall and fell to the ground. Ram's younger brothers, Ravi and Ashok, were sitting next to their mother. Their eyes followed the plate. They looked at it in attention and out of curiosity when the plate whirled on the floor before stopping.

The contents of the plate, two chapattis and a peeled onion cut in half were lying on the floor like dead bodies.

His mother got up quickly, picked up the bread and dusted the soil with her hands. Then she picked up the pieces of onion, wiped them with her dupatta and kept them on her plate.

"You think I am good for nothing, and now you have come to rescue this family by sacrificing. Haan.....!" His father was shouting continuously looking into the space, not at him.

Ram was listening to him. His face had a calmness which showed that everything was good. He did not reply at all, there was nothing to argue. He knew in his heart that it was his father's duty to stop him from ruining his future. But he also knew that he was doing right.

Any argument with his father or any further conversation would only bring shame and pain to both of them. When his father left the kitchen, he also

stopped eating and left.

Ram had always been his favourite son. Ram's father had big dreams for him. He had even decided to take a loan from one of his friends to send Ram to college for further studies.

"My son will just study and become a bada afsar" he used to tell his wife whenever he found Ram studying at night, under the dim light of the lantern.

He was upset with Ram. Due to the incapability of his father, Ram, his son was ruining his future.

He did not want any of his sons to be in the farming field. Lying on his cot, his tears were streaming down. He was continuously pressing the corner of his eyes with his muffler to hide the tears, but they did not stop. At least not till his wife came to check on him. They sat in silence for some time. She sat on the floor beside his cot. A little later, he turned his back to the wall and went to sleep. There was nothing they could talk about or do to change their lives.

The next day, Ram got ready to go to the fields. He found his father waiting for him. He gulped down the leftover chapatis from the night hurriedly and went out with him. On their way, his father showed him the places, pointing at the shops, ration offices, and fertilizer suppliers. His tone was softer than last night, but still harsher than the usual tone that he generally used with Ram.

Ram spent nights understanding the nuances of the work. What could he do differently? How could he break the chain of poverty and introduce new changes? He needed to get rich as soon as possible. He did not have the luxury to waste time thinking and waiting for things to turn good on their own. His brothers were still in school, but in two years, Ravi would pass high school. They would need money to send him to college and a year later Ashok would join too.

During the lunch break, he would go to shops to talk to people, read and understand the market. 'What are the other things he could grow with

minimum investment and could sell in the market at a good price?’

He always carried an old notebook with him. He would write down all his findings and knowledge in it. At night, he would flip the pages, reading them to and fro, looking for some magical plan to emerge out of them.

He was a polite talker. His tone and his educated manner gave him an edge, an upper hand above others. Very soon, he became known to everybody in the market. They would call him out and wave at him when they saw him coming. In the evening, before returning home some of them would ask him to read letters of their relatives living in distant cities or some legal documents they would have received from authorities. On such occasions, he would ask his father to go home and told that he would join him at dinner. His father would walk home, thinking about him and smiling, ‘Maybe this is right for him, his destiny.’

His meetings increased in number with time, they stretched in time as well. With time his father started coming alone from the field and Ram entered the house only after everyone had retired to bed. Along with his professional area, his social area also increased. Soon, he rented a small piece of land, where he wanted to grow different kinds of vegetables according to the weather.

“You all have gone mad. Tell your son that we don’t have so much money in our pocket that we can afford to buy new land and do experiments on it, just for the sake of fun.” His father was furious at knowing it. He continued, “Just because you have read a few classes, it does not mean that you are a master of everything. That you know everything in this world!” He did not throw his plate this time. Ram’s popularity has toned him down.

“We haven’t bought it. We have just rented it. Taken it on lease for some time,” Ram said, looking at his plate. He could never talk to his father by looking into his eyes. He believed that it would be insulting for his father, that the son, whom he raised could look directly in his eyes and question his authority. So, he always kept his voice and eyes low while talking to his father. His father secretly admired him for this.

“We! Who are we??” his father’s tone had turned to surprise. The anger in it was replaced by worry.

“I am working with my friends,” he said, his words close to whisper.

“Friends? You don’t have any friends in the business. Remember that. They can turn into enemies anytime.”

“Nothing will happen like this. And we must do something different, we can’t wait for things to get better by themselves. Nothing has happened in years,” Ram blurted out and regretted his words immediately.

It was not his nature to say things before calculating them in his head. Every penny which he spent and every word which came out of his mouth was always calculated. Where is it going? What will it bring back? Is it worth it or not? But today, the words came out without his permission, at their own will. And he did not know what those words would bring back.

Everybody remained silent and they ate their dinner in silence.

“I think I should retire now; my son is capable of doing things on his own now. When nothing has happened in years, what can I do now in the numbered years of my old age?” His father said before leaving the kitchen.

Ram stopped eating to listen to him and then got up and washed his hands, leaving his half-eaten plate on the kitchen floor.

‘Peace!’ That’s what his uncalculated words had cost him that day.

The next day, Ram waited for his father to wake up and get ready to go to the fields. He wanted to show him the land he had bought.

“Baba, aren’t you well?” He called out, entering his father’s room.

His father was laying still, his face towards the wall.

“Baba,” Ram called again, touching his shoulder.

His father's eyes were closed when he turned. Ram did not remember when was the last time he had stood so close to his father. However, he noticed that his father's face had changed in years. New lines had appeared. Ram did not remember seeing them before, or maybe he never noticed. He had been busy with himself so much that he did not have time to look at other things. The skin around his mouth was sagging. He looked tired, as if he had been sick for days.

"What?" his father said, his voice still harsh as it used to be. Maybe he was getting old from the outside, but inside he was still that stubborn man.

"Ah.....! I wanted to show you the new piece of land we have rented and what vegetables we are growing on them."

The words come out slowly, as though they were also aged. His father thought for a moment, then got up to get ready. He remained silent all through till they reached the field. It was bigger than the land he had. Different square blocks were arranged systemically. From far, it looked like a colourful chessboard, with a different shade in every block. It seemed like his own dream had become three-dimensional. He could touch it. He was able to feel the happiness he felt whenever he imagined it.

His Son did not just make his future, but he fulfilled his father's dream. Tears started streaming down. He didn't even try to wipe them. They were not of helplessness, they were of happiness, a rare kind of tears. All the anger he had last night dissipated. The pleasure of seeing the land of his dream was far beyond any other pleasure in this world.

When Ram came back from his errand, he stood next to his father. He looked taller than him, standing straight with confidence while his father stood with his shoulders a little slouched but relaxed. It seemed that he had just kept down the weight he has been carrying on his shoulders and now they don't have the strength to return to their proper place.

When the first instalment of vegetables grew, Ram brought the baskets full of cabbages, potatoes, and fresh tomatoes home on a cart. His mother looked at them in surprise, wondering whether Ram had stolen them from somewhere and people might soon reach their door chasing him.

She ran and bolted the door and came running back to him.

“What is this?” without a word coming out of her mouth, her eyes asked.

Ram laughed, and put his right arm on her shoulders.

“No, I didn’t steal them,” he said and then again started laughing, swinging his head back and forth.

It took his mother several minutes of reassurance that all those baskets were real and belonged to them. She touched the tomatoes, and ran her fingers around them. She looked at them as a mother looked at her new-born baby. A figure which was inside her all nine months, but now she can take it in their arms.

While cooking, she wondered whether she had forgotten to cook curries. For years, they had been eating their lunch with chilli-garlic chutney and dinner with sauteed onions.

Only when her son-in-law visited them, they would cook curry with potato and tomato. But that was always insufficient for the entire family.

Ram had seen his younger brothers, crying, and slapping their mother’s back to give them the curry. When their mother signalled Ram, he would take them out to play. Mostly they would go with him happily distracted, but on some occasions, they would cry till their throats dried up and eyes tired of crying. They would look into space, their tiring eyes heavy with images of the food they had seen inside. On such occasions, Ram would pray to God to make their hunger vanish or at least make his brother-in-law eat less so that his brothers could eat the leftovers.

God granted his wish on some days. When he went inside to the men’s hall to collect the dishes, his eyes would look into the bowls in which curries were served, whether they were empty or some curry was still left in them. His eyes would sparkle and a smile would appear on his lips on seeing little pieces of mashed potato dancing in the watery curry while he picked up the plates. His mother would make the curry of thin consistency with water subjugating the potatoes. It cost them less. Before calling his brothers for

dinner, he would pour the leftovers into one single bowl. He would swipe his finger in each bowl to collect every drop of it. The definition of luxury is and has always been different for the poor and the rich. For one it's saving, and for another, it's spending.

He never let his brothers see the dirty plates. Memories of eating leftover food would haunt them in the future like they haunted Ram. He would never let it happen to his brothers. He asked them to continue playing outside till guests finished their meal.

When Ram called them inside, they would come running and sit crossed legs on the mat. Their eyes would look around impatiently to get a glance at the dishes they couldn't wait to eat. It was nearly impossible for them to wait for Ram to bring their lavish food. Ram would serve them or sometimes feed them with his own hands.

But that night, when his mother called them for dinner after having cooked for the new arrivals, she could not hold her excitement. She yelled the names of all the dishes she had prepared, "Ram, Ashok, Ravi, come fast! See what I have cooked, Daal, Aloo sabji, Paranthe, and Kheer."

She was so loud that Ram was afraid a neighbour would come to join them. But he did not say anything to her. It was not the right time to remind her about manners and control.

At dinner, his mother looked at them with a different eye, refilling their plates with multiple servings even before they finished the last. She appeared to have just heard their cries for food they had been asking for years, and now only it had occurred to her that she needed to feed them. They kept saying no repeatedly to stop the tsunami of food but she did not stop. Their hands covered the plates to stop the food from overflowing.

Ram wished he could shoot and record this moment. He would frame it and hang it on the wall as a memento of his first victory. He would play it on repeat. He wished he could see their mouths chewing and could read the glitter in their eyes whenever he wanted.

When everyone had retired to their rooms, he opened his notebook and struck through the first item on the list.

1.Good food every day.

2.Cycle for Baba.

3.College fees.

4.House with different rooms.

5.Marriage.

6.A little girl :)

CHAPTER

■

10

■

I had a desire,

Dead and buried in my heart.

He pulled it out and stroked,

Bringing it to life again.

It's been three days since he has not come to college. Astha waits for him every day. I sit with her while she keeps checking in the canteen and his classroom. I don't know what I want. I want to see him, but I also don't want to see him. It's different. It's not that I want to talk to him, but I am waiting for him. I don't know why.

There is something unusual about him. I am worried about him. The college looks empty without him. Suddenly, without him, it has turned boring and lifeless. I wonder how Astha feels about it. I can't read her these days. She looks normal. I can't say whether she is pretending it or she is not feeling anything. How can she be so calm about it when even I have been struggling with his thoughts? I can't keep him out of my mind, not even for a minute.

I don't know what I will say to him when I will see him. All I know is that all I want is to see him right now. Just want to make sure that he still remembers me.

Both of us were sitting in the canteen when I saw him entering. He stood there, tall and straight. His eyes were searching for a familiar face. He was rolling his car keys on his index finger while looking around.

My heart must have skipped a few beats when I saw him. I know it because it still misses them whenever I think about that moment. Even when I am thinking about that day, I can go back to that time and feel it. It's still real.

That day, I wanted to tear my eyes off him, but I could not. There was a hunger in me to memorize him. I wanted to click this picture in my mind so that I could look back at it freely. There was nothing else that I could have asked more from God that day. And now, when he was there, I couldn't even look at him properly. I dropped my eyes before he could see us. I felt a pain in the centre of my chest. An icy kind of feeling rose inside me before I tore my eyes off him.

With the restricted vision of my lowered eyes, I could tell that he had seen us and was coming to our table.

My heart was thumping in my chest. I don't know why, but I was scared. I wanted to hide somewhere, but I wanted him to see me as well.

"Hey!" he said when he reached us. From the corner of my eyes, I could see his belt. It was of brown-beige colour, its buckle hooked into the third hole of it. His one hand was resting on his waist. He did not have hair on his knuckles, strange. His fingers were long and neat, nails cut in perfect shape.

I wished I could run my fingers on his hand right then and could feel the touch of them. How did his skin feel? Were they cold like mine? Were they rough? They didn't look rough, though. How his grip would feel around my fingers? I knew I should not have been thinking about that, but I didn't have any control over it. My own heart and mind had their own heart to follow.

Naina had once remembered her first interaction with Veer.

"Hey!" Veer said softly to somebody. But no reply came. Naina could not see the face. She realised that he was talking to her when Astha tapped on the table to get her attention. Naina looked up, her eyes on his chest. His top

two buttons were undone and a few strands of his chest hair were visible. They were not dense like she had seen on other men's bodies on the bus and in her village.

"Hi!" she said, her voice coming out a little squeaky. She held her hands under the table to stop them from shivering.

Veer's eyes were on Naina. She could tell that he was looking right at her. His eyes were glued to her. She could feel sparkles on the left side of her body, the parts that were facing him - her hair, left cheek, the tip of her nose, her gold nose-pin, half of her lips, her left arm.

She could feel his eyes moving from her shoulder to arm and then disappearing beneath the table. It was not the first time that a guy was eyeing her. She had seen men looking at her chest or her back on the bus and the streets, and that made her uncomfortable. Their eyes triggered an impulse to cover every inch of her skin from them. But his gaze was different. She had never felt the way his eyes were making her feel. Usually, she would shrink inside and would ignore the stares, but today she did not want to ignore his eyes. She wanted to hold it. To look deep into them to see what was different in them. To move her attention from one to another until she knew what made them so special. In the past few days, she had imagined herself looking at him. His arms wrapped around her waist, she holding his face in her palms and her eyes darting into his.

When he was done following her frame, he pulled a blue plastic chair. Naina saw his gold bracelet on his wrist. It had his name engraved in English. When he sat down, he took out his wallet and kept it on the table with his car key. His wallet was nothing fanciful. The dark brown matte leather texture gave it a rich look.

At the folds, it showed little use of it. 'Maybe it's not that old,' Naina thought.

"You want to eat something?" Astha broke the silence.

"Oh, No! I am full. Thanks anyway," he replied. His eyes were still on Naina.

Naina was relieved when his friends came looking for him. Now she could disappear from the scene and escape his direct attention. They joined them at the table. They ordered a plate of spring rolls and two samosas. "Let's go to class." One of the girls in his friends said after they were done eating.

"No, I don't want to attend the class." Veer said, playing with his car keys.

"Why do you even come to college when you don't even attend a single class?" she said in a teasing tone that suggested something else.

Veer smiled at her and then looked at Naina and then towards Astha, who was also smiling looking at that girl. His friends left and Astha, Naina, and Veer stayed there with that awkward silence between them.

"Let's take a walk." Veer suggested.

Astha took her bag and stood up. Naina remained sitting silently. She did not budge. Veer started to walk but then turned to look back at her.

"Isn't your friend coming?" he asked Astha as if he was also aware of the line which divided them.

"No, she doesn't like being around boys," she replied.

After a few steps, Veer looked back again to check on Naina. She was standing there looking at them. He wanted to go back and ask her, but he did not. Naina stood there, watching them walk and disappear after a while.

She sat in the college park, plucking at grass, thinking about Veer and Astha. She was waiting for them to come back. For some reason she was uncomfortable. She waited for an hour but they did not come back. It was getting late; she should have been at home by now. Her classes had ended two hours ago. But this one last hour had felt like another day in itself. She felt tired of living two days in a row without rest. She looked back in the direction where they had gone, but there was no sign of them. She took her bag and walked out of the campus towards the bus stop, looking back again and again to find a clue of them.

Standing at the bus stop, she kept her eyes on the college gate, ready to wave if she spotted Astha. She let go busses of her route one after the other, making excuses to herself. 'This one is too crowded; I'll go to another one. This one is running too fast.'

The first bus passed, the second bus passed, the third bus passed, but Naina did not board any. She had never been so restless about anything before, but today she was not in her control. She had faced being ignored many times, and she knew very well how to handle that, how not to let that affect her. But somehow, she did not like being ignored by Veer. She never felt so unloved and ignored. All her hunger for love came back rushing at her.

Another hour of impatient wait passed at the bus stop, but there was no clue of Astha and Veer. Naina boarded the last bus and came back home. But her heart and mind were still in that moment when she had seen them walking away from her. She relived every moment in her mind, spent the whole night remembering every little detail about him.

His shirt, how he made her hair, how he played with his car keys. She relived the moment when he was talking to Astha but his eyes were on her. How his eyes left her vulnerable.

Naina was never so excited to attend college, but more than excited she was impatient and silent the next day.

In class, she chose the last seat which opened to the campus gate and her eyes were glued there only. She knew that his class timings were different from hers but her eyes did not listen to her brain, they used their own.

Her class got over but she did not find him anywhere. She felt irritated at herself. Why was she feeling so anxious? She wanted to go home but she did not. She went to the cafeteria where Astha joined her after her class.

"Let's go home, I am not feeling well," Naina said.

"No, not now, I am waiting for Veer."

Naina's eyes sparkled as she heard that.

“You can leave if you want to, but I will wait for him,” Astha continued.

“No, no, I won’t go alone. I will go with you. It’s ok! I am not feeling that bad.” And she smiled internally. She did not know why his name made her heart race, but she took her first breath of relief of that day.

“Tell me, how do I look? Is my kajal okay? Astha asked her while applying shiny lip gloss.

“Am I looking beautiful today?” Astha asked again.

For the first time, Naina looked at her carefully. She had never seen her that way. She didn’t know whether she was beautiful or not. She didn’t know that about herself, even. Do both satisfy the standards of beauty?

She thought of her classmates. Sandy was the most beautiful girl Naina had met. Naina could not take her eyes off her when she had seen her for the first time. She could not believe that God can make somebody so beautiful. Her skin was spotless, glowing. Her thin lips were naturally pink. She used kohl to brighten her eyes. Naina would always notice her in the class, how did she talk, what did she wear, everything. Other girls in the class were far more beautiful than herself. Even with plain features, they looked presentable and decent.

Unlike herself, Naina always found herself in inappropriate clothes. Naina wore her aunt’s old dresses to college. Her aunt altered them to her size. They were mostly of bright colours, with embroidery on them. They hung loose on her skinny body even after the alteration. On her birthday or any special occasion like marriage in the family, her aunt would stitch new clothes for her but of the same patterns as before, full sleeve kurta with loose salwar.

Naina would stand with her hands stretched horizontally till her aunt finished writing down some numbers on the paper. Aunt took her measurements. Her grandmother would be giving suggestions from behind, “Make it a little loose from chest and waist. Girls should always wear loose clothes. There is no point showing off the curve until she is married.”

Naina did not mind wearing them till her school. But college is different. There your clothes decide your standards in the world. They decide the treatment you would get from others. And with those clothes, Naina was nothing in comparison to her classmates, who wore beautiful clothes. She stood alone in her competition.

It was not like Astha wore some exquisite dresses and stood out from the crowd. But still, her dresses looked more fitted to her body, suited her age and place.

She was taller, fairer than her. She had a long neck. Her fingers were long and lean. Although there was nothing special about her, Naina could tell that she was better than her. She was decent.

“You are looking beautiful,” Naina said after a while.

“Should I make my kohl a little darker?” Astha asked and then took out a small round mirror and her kohl pencil from her bag. And before Naina could answer, she rubbed the kohl pencil on her lower waterline and darkened it. Her eyes did pop up a little more. They looked livelier than before.

Naina had never used kohl ever. Nobody had explicitly stopped her but she knew that it was not allowed in her house. Growing up she had understood her limits. The list of things she could do was less than the list of don'ts. From the way of she laughs to what, where and when she should eat, say, go, everything had defined boundaries.

They were sitting at their usual table in the cafeteria and their eyes were glued to the gate. After half an hour, they saw Veer entering the cafeteria with his friends. Naina looked down before Veer could spot them.

“Hey,” he waved at Astha.

“Hi,” she waved back.

“Hey!” He extended his hand toward Naina. Naina and Astha, both did not expect it. Naina froze right there. She did not dare to look up, her eyes stuck

on her feet. Her mind could not tell her how to respond.

Astha stared at Veer in surprise and Veer was staring at Naina.

“Hi!” Astha finally grabbed his hand.

“How are you?” she asked. Her words came out in a hurry as if she wanted to hide something behind them.

“I am good,” he replied and sat next to Naina.

Naina felt as if her breaths were stuck and her heart would blast inside. She wondered whether he could hear it when it happened. She looked up to read his face, but to her embracement, she found Veer’s eyes already on her. As if he was also trying to read her face. Naina immediately moved her eyes away and glued them again to her feet. Unlike last time, today Astha was feeling unwanted and invisible.

“Let’s go outside.” Astha interrupted and got up.

Veer joined her, but when Naina did not move, he called her out and said, “Let’s go!”

There was an authority in his voice. It was more like an order, not a request.

“No, leave her, she is not well,” Astha replied before Naina could get up and she quickly walked out of the canteen. Veer followed her.

Naina saw them leaving. A part of hers wanted to join them, but she did not move. Veer looked back at her and held his gaze as if asking her to come. Naina averted his eyes. She did not know what she wanted.

‘What is wrong with me? Why can’t I ignore him? I know I can’t do it; this is not correct.’

‘No, I can’t do it. I’ll have to get rid of this. I should not be here.’ She was fighting with her arguments. She took her bag and walked out of the college.

For the next few days, Naina ignored Astha, thinking that this would lessen her restlessness. She won't be uncomfortable. And her feelings would vanish if she stayed away from Veer.

She would sit in the empty classroom after lectures were over, waiting for him patiently at her beloved window.

She saw them walking together every day. She always wondered what they would be talking about. Did they mention her in their conversations?

'Does he ask about me?'

'Do I even exist for him?'

'Does he also feel like I do?'

Such questions haunted her continuously. These questions would play in her mind like a stuck song. She would wake up with these questions and sleep with them. But she did not feel uncomfortable anymore. She was satisfied seeing him every day. It was enough for her and there was nothing else she wanted.

But the ripples of restlessness came back when suddenly Veer stopped coming to college. At first, she assured that he might be busy or maybe he did not have classes. But when days turned into weeks, she felt as if her life had stopped.

'Where is he? What happened to him? Is he ok?'

The set of questions changed in her mind. The silent worry became rigorous and violent. Her eyes looked for him everywhere.

Veer's absence made her more restless than earlier. She would wait for him, sitting alone in an empty classroom. She stopped attending her classes, and even if she did, she did not hear anything that the teacher said. All she wanted to hear was his voice.

She was sure that she would cry when she would see him again someday. She wished she could have gone on a walk with him when he had called her

that day.

After a month, she gave up on her waiting. Other than waiting, she could not do anything, and waiting was becoming more painful every day.

She joined Astha again, to check if she could get some information about him. But Astha never discussed him as if he never existed to her. How could she be so unconcerned about him whereas Naina was dying to see him? Astha talked and laughed like before. She told her about her new crush and how she had been talking to him lately. There was not even a faint sign of tension on her face.

“What happened to that guy?” Naina finally asked the question that she had been suppressing for months.

“Who?” Astha replied, thinking in her mind which guy was she talking about.

Naina stared at her, trying to read her expression. Was she playing with her or she seriously did not know?

“Which guy?” Astha said again and Naina came in present.

“Oh Veer?” she answered, as though she just remembered about him.

“I don’t know,” she said with a hint of anger in her tone.

Naina listened to her, waiting for her to say something more.

“He is very arrogant. I don’t know what he thinks of himself. After a few days, he started ignoring me and then stopped coming to college.” Astha said with a little irritation. She continued, “I liked him, but I don’t know about him. Initially, I thought he also likes me, but then suddenly he drifted. I called him many times but he did not reply. And then I also stopped calling him.”

Naina did not know what to say.

Both of them sat silent for some time. Then Astha said again, “You should never believe guys. They just want to pass their time with you.”

Naina could feel that Astha was hurt. She could understand that feeling of being unloved, of not being treated the way you want.

“My story is over with him,” Astha said and started looking out of the window. Naina was left wondering wondered about their story. Whether it had ended or was it never there? Was it just she who had forced herself to write it?

■

His eyes fell on me,
Like rainfalls on a desert,
And I soaked him all,
He was my rain, my only hope!

Veer disappeared from their lives as magically as he had appeared. They both came back to their previous routines. Naina would wait outside Astha's class after her class ended. They would take a bus together after eating their lunch at the canteen. Naina always had Samosa and Astha ate her home mode food.

Months passed, but his memories did not fade from her mind. On some days, when she could not stop thinking about him, Naina would skip all her classes and sit in the cafeteria for hours. Although knowing that he won't come, she would wait for him to see unknown people coming in and going out. She would go to that spot in the park where she had seen him for the first time. In her imagination, she would replace Astha with herself. Imagined herself walking with him, the way Astha did. She did everything to calm her heart with such imagery. It was easy this way. She could be with him and not be with him.

With time, she became dull and silent. She could not understand her relationship with him. How come somebody could live in her mind for so

long? How without meeting and talking to him she could have a conversation with him going on, how without exchanging a touch, she could blush thinking about that.

She was sitting in the park at the same spot when she thought she saw his face in the crowd. Astha was sitting in front of her with her back to the college gate. Naina focused her eyes to see him, to make sure that it was not an illusion.

There he was, in the middle of his friends. It seemed that they had been standing there for a long. They had that ease in their body postures, comfortable and phase of exchange of greetings passed long back.

Her eyes stuck on him. She felt that her whole body had stopped working, her heart stopped, her eyes did not blink, and she didn't smile. She just stared at him with blank eyes. When he turned his face in their direction, he held his gaze when he spotted her sitting there. She was sure that she would explode. Her insides won't be able to handle all the excitement.

Naina could not understand what he said to his friends, but his gestures told her that he was asking them to join Naina and Astha. They all looked in their direction. And then talked and laughed before walking towards them. Naina and Veer looked at each other without blinking while he with friends was coming toward them as if they both were in some kind of spell. His friends went inside to attend their classes and Veer turned right to join them.

When he greeted them her spell finally broke. She was on the verge of crying. She never felt so overwhelmed seeing anyone ever. Her eyes pooled up and before she could wipe her eyes, tears fell her cheeks. She wiped her face immediately with the back of her palm to avoid anyone seeing her tears, but Veer and Astha had already seen them.

Astha looked at her in surprise. She had never seen her cry before. She could not understand the reason for her crying at that time. Veer was looking at her as if he understood the reason for her tears. There was a kind of acknowledgement in the way he looked at her. There were mixed feelings of happiness and sadness in them.

After the wait for months, she did not know how to control her tears. They kept pooling up and she had to keep wiping them again and again.

“What happened? Why are you crying?” He finally asked her, placing his hand softly on her shoulder. Naina was not ready for this. She was startled by that sudden touch. She took a few steps back, looked at him, and then lowered her eyes to her feet without answering him. She was shivering inside.

Veer moved his questioning eyes towards Astha.

“She must be missing her boyfriend,” she replied and giggled.

Naina looked up at Astha in utter surprise. She did not expect this from her. ‘How could she say that?’ ‘No, I don’t have any boyfriend.’ She wanted to say but words did not come out. She did not have enough strength to speak. She was angry at Astha. She wished she was not there at that time.

“Oh!” Veer said. His voice was heavy with surprise and dislike. He put both his hands in his jeans’ pockets. Naina understood the meaning of his action. Moments ago, she had been feeling that he was around her, but suddenly he was again beyond her reach.

“Let’s go for a walk.” Veer extended his hand toward Astha indicating in the direction of their usual walk path. His eyes looked straight in distance. His smile had also disappeared by then. Looking at his face she felt as if he was punishing her for something.

They did not exchange words but somehow, they talked, their eyes talked. Their manners talked although the silent conversation which they shared was not pleasant for either of them. At that moment it seemed as if their love story had ended before starting.

Naina saw them walking out of the park as usual. Astha looked back and gave her a smile that Naina could not understand. Was she happy that she and Veer were back again or was she mocking her? But she knew that her smile was hurting her, like a punch in the gut.

After that day Veer always called Astha from a distance. He never greeted them at their table. He would call her name and wave at her whenever he saw her.

He acted as if Naina was unknown to him. She also did not seem concerned about him. There was nothing she could say. There was nothing she could explain. Sometimes, his thoughts followed her but she controlled them by sleeping or reading. This was not the first time that she was handling herself this way. She had been hiding her things from the entire world since she remembered. She did not have anybody to share it with, she anyway had to handle it on her own. But still, there was an uncomfortable feeling in her heart. Something ached continuously there.

She was waiting for her bus. Astha was on leave that day. Naina rarely attended college without her but the final exams were going on and their exam dates did not match. It was cloudy when she left the college. The sky was clear in the morning but it turned windy and cloudy by noon. Naina was afraid that it might rain.

She did not like the rains. The last time when it had rained, she got all drenched. Her white kurta stuck to her skin, leaving her nearly naked and open. She had to cross the market street like that. She had covered her chest and back as much as she could with her dupatta, but still, her half back and her legs were visible. Water had made the fabric transparent and thin. No layers of clothes can hide you when you have hungry eyes on you. Naina could not dare to look up while she crossed the street, as if it was her fault that rain had poured and now her clothes were insufficient to cover her honour.

It started drizzling. Naina was standing with many people under the shed. More people stopped their bikes and came inside the shed. Naina shifted and stood in the corner, her hands holding the bar. She saw the raindrops on her skin - cold and soft. She felt something moving on her back. 'Rat or lizard' she thought. She looked back to see but found a middle-aged man smiling back at her. He was scratching his head. She was familiar with these kinds of smiles. She had seen men touching young girls and ladies on the bus. They would throw themselves on them when the bus stopped with sudden brakes. They would try to press their penis on their behind when the

bus was crowded, as if along with the public bus, the bodies of the women were also available for public use.

She moved forward a little to avoid his touch. Half of her body was out of the shed now. Water dropped on her sleeves and shoulder. She felt his hand touching her back. He moved his hand up from her buttocks to her spine. A quick move that ended before she could turn. Naina gave him a stare. She wished she could slap him right there, but she could not. She did not have the strength to even raise her hand. She was alone. What if this man followed her and did something else? Her body trembled with that thought.

Her nameless attack appeared. Her stomach started to hurt. Her heart raced. Her body raised all its security shields. She took a long breath to fill her lungs with oxygen. Coming out of the shed she started walking to find an auto. She walked slowly, holding the ground, sipping the water dripping from her head every few seconds. Everything was spinning. She wanted to sit down and rest to let her breathing get back to normal, but she did not have the time and place to do that. She continued to walk while stretching her arm and signalling passing autos to stop.

People under the shed looked at her with curiosity. There was no other entertainment in the rain. A girl getting soaked in rain and looking for a ride was the most amusing thing they could see at that time.

It was a running road where cars were racing and bikes were hustling to find space between them. The autos were either already full or rejected her request for some reason or other. She looked at her watch. Water drops were like splotches of ink on its dial. She wiped it and looked hard at the numbers. It was half past three. She had time; it won't get dark soon. But still, she was worried about the rain, which was now pouring.

She moved to try to find her way between the running cars. She looked and walked carefully to her right side to avoid getting hit. She heard continuous honking behind her. Without looking back, she moved a little deeper to her left side to make space for that car to pass. But that car did not pass. The honking became more violent.

Her heart was pounding. She had seen in movies how girls got kidnapped at the bus stop. She looked to her left to check if there was space where she could stand out of the way of that car. Her body and heart were trembling in anticipation. She was missing the comfort of the security of her house. She pulled her scarf on her breasts. Her tears and sweat on her face merged with the raindrops.

When the honking did not stop and she saw the car approaching her, she clutched her bag and started to run on the road.

She thought of crossing the road to go back to her college gate. That was the only safe place around her right now. She could easily go there, call her brother to pick her up and wait inside till he came. She looked to her right to check the traffic. There were few vehicles. She could cross if she ran at her top speed.

She hurriedly looked at that black car which was following her. She imagined the driver of the car looking at her, reading her moves from behind the windscreen. It was still moving in her direction.

She was in the middle of the road when that black car stopped right in front of her. Its tires screeched on the surface. People shouted at it looking at Naina to see if there was an accident.

She felt that her heart would come out of her mouth. She looked around for help but for the first time, she noticed that nobody was looking at her. A face flashed in her mind for a second and she went numb after that. She could not run; she could not scream. Her eyes were on the bonnet of the car but she was not seeing it. She was somewhere else.

“Hi!” a voice came and the driver slid down the passenger side window.

“Can I drop you somewhere?” It was Veer craning his neck to his left side from the driver’s seat. His eyes looked at Naina with curiosity.

Naina’s tears were now pouring down her cheeks. She had never felt so happy seeing anyone. She hugged him when she got in the car. Tears still rolling from her eyes, she hugged him so tightly that she could feel his chest

pressing against hers. Veer was stunned at her reaction. His one hand was still on the steering and the other was on the headrest of the passenger seat.

“Naina,” he said slowly, “I need to drive. There are cars behind us.”

People were honking at them from behind. Veer looked in the rear-view mirror. A bike rider was yelling at him, throwing his hands in the air.

“I am sorry!” she said and moved back from him. She settled on her seat, squeezing her hair and her dress.

Veer looked at the traffic towards his left and turned the car. He stopped the car in a corner and leaning towards her said, “I am sorry too! My intention was not to scare you. I saw you walking alone, so I just came to help you. But I guess I scared you.” His eyes were glued to her eyes as if trying to read them.

“I am fine now,” she said, embarrassed by her reaction. How could she be so weak and give up herself? She averted her eyes. She did not want him to look at her like that, in such a situation. All weak and scared!

Veer started the engine and looked at the road.

“Where do you want me to drop you?” He sounded casual, looking out for the cuts and turns he might need to take for the new destination.

“Take me wherever you want.” She blurted out. Her head was now resting on the window glass. Raindrops were marking lines on it. Her breath had turned normal. The spinning of the world had stopped. Everything was turning to normal again.

“I mean, drop me at the next bus stand. I’ll take the bus from there. You don’t need to bother much.” she said again after analysing her initial words.

“Ooooookay!” he said, taking time to understand her initial words.

“I’ll drop you at the bus stand. But do you mind if I eat something first? I am famished.”

She nodded, looking at him. It was the first time she was so close to him. It was the first time they were talking to each other.

Their car took a left turn to find something to eat. Veer continuously looked to both sides. Naina could hear the raindrops on the car roof. She had never thought that rain could be that melodious. She looked out, and a smile made its way to her lips.

Naina always liked roads. It made her feel free. There was a different kind of freedom in them, a continuous flow. She smiled, looking at shops on the roads, people walking, and children playing in the rain. She had seen rain before but it was the first time she was feeling it.

She was never allowed to go anywhere except to her college. And today she was seeing the world from a different window.

Confinement makes you realize the importance of small things. People understand the importance of freedom only when they don't have it. A few minutes back, she was fighting her fear of being alone and now she felt free. Little Naina was fluttering with happiness inside her.

“So, how is your so-called boyfriend? Why didn't he come to drop you?” Veer asked, his eyes looking at the road. His arms were straight and stiff on the steering wheel. His sleeves folded up a few inches above his wrists. His voice brought her back to the moment, and she realised that she was with him. It seemed that he had been trying to ask this question for a long time, phrasing and rephrasing the words in his head while she was looking out.

“I don't have any boyfriend,” she replied in a low voice, looking down at her hands.

“Oh.”

Veer took time to grasp her response, turned his face toward his side, and then smiled and blushed altogether.

Naina saw his thumb and index finger moving on the volume knob. The Interior of the car was all brown. There was a wooden frame around the

music player. So far, a song was playing in the background in a low voice but she could not recognize it. Singer's voice was barely audible, but the Sufi tone reverberated in the car, like light travels and brightens the room instantly.

The singer was praising a girl's eyes. Naina had never heard that song before.

"It's from the latest movie," Veer said sensing her confusion.

Years later, whenever she would hear that song in the market or the car, she closed her eyes and went back to that moment. She would see him, talking in the same manner. The dampness of the rain would cover her senses. She would try to stop the memories, but they would come flooding, one by one, making her weak and numb for the rest of the day.

But at that moment, she was feeling that something was filling her heart. It satisfied a kind of craving, a kind of emotion she had never felt before. She did not know what to name that moment, and she could never find words to express that feeling. A kind of intoxication, which started in his presence only.

They reached the takeaway booth at McDonald's. Naina had never seen those kinds of booths where you don't need to get down from your car. You order something at the first gate and you can pick it up at the next. How convenient! How many things she had not seen? How many wonders were still hidden from her? She wondered.

The lady at the out gate gave a brown bag, tissues stuffed in it on top. Veer took the bag and kept it between the two seats, near the gear stick. A salty and buttery smell of burgers and fries filled the car. Naina had never smelt anything like that. She just assumed that the burger must be tasty. They did not say anything for long. The singer's voice was the medium between them. He was doing the talking on their behalf.

"You said you are hungry. Why aren't you eating now?" Naina asked when Veer did not touch the brown bag. His eyes were somewhere else as if he was not present at that moment and was thinking something else.

“No, I am not hungry now.” He said looking directly into her eyes. This time Naina did not move away her eyes. This time, she wanted to read them. Although her mind was telling her to avert there was no way she could do it. It was like she was tied, unable to move her eyes. He had small brown eyes, black rings under them, which gave them a sad look. Naina felt heat rushing up her face. Her cheeks and neck burned. The moment lasted a few seconds, but Naina would remember that forever. This first exchange would be saved in her most precious memories. One of few, she would relive again and again.

On their way back home, they did not talk much, yet they had a silent conversation. They exchanged something which only their hearts and eyes knew.

When she would think about him later, she would understand that love entered her life on that rainy day. Every rain afterwards would remind her of that day.

They exchanged something which Naina never had. Love! She had never felt so happy being with someone and she never felt so wanted with anyone. She realised that her presence mattered to him as well.

By the time they reached her home, the rain had stopped. She asked him to drop her at the bus stop, where her bus used to drop her off every day.

“Drop me here,” she said, pointing at the bus stop. He looked at her. She continued, “I don’t want anybody to see me in your car.”

He nodded and stopped the car at the bus stop.

She quickly got down, took her purse and shut the door immediately. She started walking towards her home, her eyes running around to see any familiar face. She turned her face one last time to look at his car. He was still standing there waiting for her to disappear from his vision.

That day, when she came home, she didn’t know that she was not the same Naina who had left home in the morning. The world around her had

changed one more time, and she had walked straight into it. Without knowing that her life will never be the same!

She was at home but in her mind, she was still with Veer. She could smell him when she went to the bathroom to change. She sniffed over her shoulders again and again just to feel his smell. She could not recognize the perfume he had used but she fell in love with that instantly. She spent the next 30 minutes in the washroom talking to herself, blushing, smiling all the way. Her lips did not let go of the smile which was stuck onto them. She tried hard to stay calm but all efforts went in vain.

She spent her night thinking about him. She repeated that little conversation in her mind more than a hundred times. She relived that smile of his that he let go of when she told him that she had no boyfriend.

Everything was magical around her as if she had never felt any kind of pain all her life. Love was taking over her and she did not know what would come next. For now, she just wanted to be in that feeling forever.

She had hardly slept last night, yet she woke up early. She took out her favourite black kurta, which her aunt had stitched for her last birthday. It was the only piece which fitted her properly. She went to her mother's room and slipped her kohl pencil into her bag. She would apply it in college, she made a mental note of it.

She was certain that he would come to college. During class, she kept constantly looking outside. Her heart jumped at every car that entered the parking lot. Time dragged itself. Hours stretched as if they did not want to end that day. She ran to the girl's room after her classes were over. She rimmed her eyes with kohl which she had brought with her. She looked at herself in the mirror. She did look beautiful today in her own eyes.

She saw him in the park, with his friends, when she came out with Astha. He waved at them. Naina gave him a half smile. Astha waved back at him. When they reached the park, Naina noted that the proximity that they had shared the previous day had disappeared. The wall of shyness and awkwardness stood again between them. He did not look at her as he had done last evening. He maintained a distance from her in front of everyone.

He met her as if nothing had happened between them. Naina felt stupid, standing there. 'How could she think that he will be different today? Yesterday was just a gesture of being a good man. He saw you on the road and helped you. How can she be so stupid to think otherwise?'

Naina stood silent there. She did not say anything when he left with Astha for their usual walk. Her eyes followed their backs but Veer did not look back at her today.

Astha was in a bad mood when she came back after half an hour.

"Let's go," she ordered, took her bag and walked out of the college. Naina was clueless. She quickly took her bag and followed her. She turned back to see him, her heart racing in her chest.

'Has he told her everything?' she thought to herself, 'No, no! Nothing happened between us. We did not say anything to each other.'

'What would I tell her if she asks me about last evening?'

Naina followed Astha anticipating the reason for her anger. They boarded the bus in silence. She waited for her to speak, but she did not say anything and every passing minute spiked Naina's stress.

'Should I say sorry directly? What if he has not told her? Maybe they fought for some other reason. Should I tell her that I like him? No, I should not.' Train of her thoughts didn't leave her.

The bus stopped at her stop. She looked at Astha to bid goodbye, but she was looking outside. Her eyes were at something far distant. Naina got down from the bus. She looked at the window one last time to catch a glance of Astha's eyes. But she kept her eyes unmoved.

Everything was normal the next day. Astha came with the excited smile that she always carried as if she was the happiest person on earth. Naina could never understand how come she was always happy. How she could overcome her problems in just one night? She always behaved as if nothing had happened and everything with her was so perfect. She also had the

same life as Naina. She was also not allowed to go out, party with friends, make friends, or visit their places. But still, unlike Naina, she was alive. She lived whatever life was offering her. But Naina, could never agree with those terms, she wanted a change, she wanted explanations and reasons, and her share of the equality. Though she could not do anything still she did not accept what society offered her. And that's what kept her always in a fix.

“What happened yesterday?” She finally asked Astha on their way to college.

“Nothing, he just said that he does not feel the way I feel for him.”

Naina waited for some time for her to speak more, but Astha did not say anything.

“That's it? Did he say anything else?” The question automatically slipped out of her mouth.

“I didn't ask him anything after that, I left.”

‘Should I tell her now? Why didn't he tell her?’ Naina felt as if she was cheating on her friend. But she could not tell her anything because first, nothing had happened between them and secondly, she didn't want to hurt her. She was afraid that if she told Astha, she will ask her to stay away from him and she won't be able to say ‘No’ to her.

Naina didn't want that at any cost. She could not lose both of them in one go. She kept mum about her meeting with Veer. Though she never told Astha anything about herself, she was not obliged to share her things with her, but this secret sat heavily on her conscience. It was hers too. She could not hide it.

Her heart pounded thinking that if Astha stopped talking to him she will not be able to talk to him as well.

“So, will you talk to him?” she asked, hoping for a positive answer.

“Yes, if he does, else I won’t!” Astha never accepted it but Naina knew that she liked him so much. She never missed an opportunity to talk to him. There was something in him that pulled Astha and Naina alike.

They met him normally. Though their solo walks had stopped, Astha tried to be more friendly with him whereas Naina would shrink within herself closely observing him. How his hands moved while he talked, how he looked at her after every two seconds. He would purposely keep talking to Astha so that he could make Naina stay longer. Knowingly or unknowingly they both were using Astha as a medium for their silent meetings.

Veer tried so many times to talk to her but they could never go beyond formal greetings. Whenever he tried to talk, she would just nod or replied in ‘yes’ or ‘no’ thinking about Astha. She did not want to corner her. Sometimes, she also felt that Astha had sensed Veer’s inclination towards Naina, and to win him back, she talked to him more than necessary. She kept laughing after cracking a joke or would bring new topics to continue talking. Whenever Naina tried to reply to him she interrupted and answered on her behalf and turned the conversation back to her. Naina noticed it.

“So where are you going to celebrate your new year?” he asked on the last day of college before the winter break. Though he was facing Astha Naina knew that the question was for her.

“I don’t know. Maybe I will go somewhere with my friends.” Astha replied casually, kicking a tiny pebble with her right leg.

Naina looked at her in amazement at how beautifully she lied. Naina knew that like her, she was also not allowed to party, even in the new year. There was no way her parents were letting her go out to celebrate.

“What are you doing on New Year’s Eve Naina?” he said.

The way he took her name always made her stomach flutter. Her lips stretched in a sweet smile, a smile which came only with him. All natural and heartfelt. She just could not stop her lips from forming a curve in front of him.

“So where are you going?” Astha interrupted, throwing a question at him when she saw them smiling at each other.

“I am going to Jaipur. Give me your number. I’ll call you to wish you on 31st midnight,” he said the last line looking at Naina. He took out his mobile from his pocket and then raised his eyebrows, first at Astha and then towards Naina.

Holding his phone in both hands and looking down at it, he waited for them to share their numbers. But none of them said anything. None of them wanted to tell him that they didn’t have mobile phones. How could they tell him that jeans, phones, friends, all these were forbidden? All their lives they were taught that these things will make them characterless, and will bring shame to their families. Girls from good families don’t have them. But Naina never understood these reasons. She could not settle these justifications in her heart. Though she did not rebel she did not accept them as well. How can wearing Jeans and having a phone decide the character of a girl?

Sometimes these things made her feel embarrassed. She could not strike a balance in her dual life due to these restrictions. She always stood her grounds, alone on. At home, she refused to accept the limitations and at college; the world did not accept hers.

Astha initially ignored the question as if she had not heard it, but after a while said, “I have your number. I’ll call you to wish.”

Astha had escaped, replying to his question. He looked at Naina but she did not say anything. She could not give him any number nor could she ask for his in front of Astha.

“Oh, that was an old number. I have changed my number.” He said when Naina did not say anything.

He gave his new number slowly, to make sure that Naina could remember it. He looked at Naina with every number falling out of his mouth. Astha noted down the number on her palm while Naina just took a mental note.

She repeated the number in her head. It got etched in her deep memory.
Later in her life, she could not forget that number even when she wanted.

CHAPTER

■

12

■

When life goes out of me

Remember that I may be gone,

But the life inside me is unfulfilled,

A life that remained unlived.

There was only one night which Naina remembered. Perhaps her first and the last conversation she had with her mother lasted more than a few minutes. Krishna spoke very less as if there were only counted words inside her and she must be very careful while using them. Unlike Naina, who stopped talking only in her sleep.

Naina was down with a fever that day. Although she was a thin girl, it was rare that she got sick. But that day her chest was full of cough and her lungs made a wheezing sound when she inhaled and exhaled.

Her mother was giving a hot compress with a cloth on her chest. Hot tawa sitting next to her bedside, Naina was lying on the bed, her open shirt showing her bare chest. Naina's eyes followed the movement of her mother's hand. She was holding a piece of cloth folded in multiple layers. She first pressed it lightly on the flat surface of tawa and then checked the warmth with her palm before pressing it on Naina's chest. Naina's breaths were slow and laboured. A creaking kind of sound came when her chest heaved up and down.

“Mummy, tell me a story,” she said. It was rare that her mother ever told her any story. She found her mother always busy. And the stories which her grandmother told her had gone stale and boring. She had heard them so many times that whenever her grandmother told them, she would keep telling the next sentence herself.

“I don’t have any stories to tell,” her mother said. Her words spilt out without any hint of emotion; a plain statement, just like her.

“Why? Didn’t your mother tell you any story?” Naina asked. Her head rested on her mother’s lap while the warm cloth moved on her chest as if a surface was being swept.

“Stories,” she paused before speaking again as if some memory triggered in her mind,

“No! My mother never told me any story. She didn’t have any. And my father? He also never had anything to share with me.”

“Did you ever ask them to tell you one?” Half of Naina’s words were lost in her breaths.

“No, I never did.” Her mother’s words came out very slowly. As if they were heavy on her tongue.

“They would have told you if you had asked them,” Naina continued, “Don’t you like them; tales of queens and kings, beautiful angels who dance around the moon at night?”

“No! I never felt the need for such tales. Now go to sleep.” Her mother buttoned her shirt and then pulled and adjusted it. She then lay down with her.

“No, I want you to tell me some story. I have to share it with my friends. They always tell me what their mothers told them and I am the only one who never has anything to share with them.

Make a story and tell me.” She crossed her leg over her mother’s waist. Determined not to budge.

“Did I ever tell you about your birth? What happened when you were about to come out of me?”

Naina looked up at her mother’s face. Her eyes sparkled.

“Yes, yes! Tell me my birth story.”

“Close your eyes, then only I’ll start,” her mother said. Both of them closed their eyes.

Krishna thought of the day when Naina was born. In her mind, she went back to the time when her belly was swollen like a perfectly round ball.

That day she didn’t feel Naina’s existence inside her womb. There was no moment in her belly, as if the baby was in deep slumber or was too lazy to move. The Sun had reached over her head when she started having pain. The skin around her waist was stretching. A silent pressure was building inside her. She felt as if somebody was pumping hot air into her body, and she would burst at any moment. Her mother-in-law sent her eldest daughter to call the maid who helped in delivering babies in the village. She was a 60-year-old woman and her daughters-in-law helped her the work.

By the time the midwife with her two daughters-in-law came, Krishna was already writhing in pain. Both her hands were on her stomach as if holding it to stop it from bursting.

Some quick arrangements were made in the room. Someone was shouting, “Bring the sheets!”

“Bucket and one big bowl,” came another voice.

Voices were changing. Krishna could not tell who was speaking to whom. Then somebody held her shoulder and said something in her ear in a low voice. She could not hear it the first time but then she heard it.

“You need to push down,” said the old lady. She had deep wrinkles around her eyes. They were so sharp that you could count them on your fingertips. Her eyes squinted when she asked Krishna to push. She showed me a demo of how to do it. She matched her grunts with Krishna’s as though a baby was also coming out of her belly.

When Krishna looked at her, she held her gaze. There were unspoken words in her eyes and she knew what Krishna was trying to ask. The old lady was able to read them very well. This was not the first time she was attending to Krishna. Similar nights had come and gone with the same silence and worry.

It was the third time that Naina’s mother was on the labour bed. Out of the earlier two babies none survived and the destiny of the third one was yet to be declared. Krishna’s first baby had come out as a still lump of flesh - with a perfect body but no soul in it. When she held the baby in her hands, his little blue pout sent pains to every part of her body, as if someone had taken a hot knife and slit her into two parts. Starting from her head up to her abdomen, and now she was into two pieces.

He was a boy. His fists were closed like a cotton ball. She looked at him in surprise. How come this beautiful body does not have life in it? She kissed his forehead, but he didn’t move. She looked at her mother-in-law with questions in her eyes, but her tongue could not roll out the words she had in her mouth. How can a mother even dare talk of it? How come such a thought can even occur in a mother’s mind? Her mother-in-law took the baby from her hands and passed it on to her son like a parcel. It was nothing more than a bundle of skin and flesh.

Nobody said a word and their firstborn disappeared from their life as silently as he had come. It was as if he had never happened between them. But Krishna felt the emptiness he had left in her life. A space that she had for him was now all blank and dark.

When her belly grew a second time, she would rub her stomach every day. It was as if caressing the baby, as if her touch was reaching inside and her baby could feel her hand touching his small head. She talked to her belly when nobody was around. In those imaginary conversations, she always

asked her baby to make a promise to her. “Promise me, you will never leave me. You will always be around me,” she would say and then smile as if the life inside her had accepted her every word.

She was in the fifth month of her pregnancy when one night, she woke up with wetness between her legs. She touched between her legs and then lifted her petticoat to see. She let out a violent wail when she saw a round mass of flesh coming out of her body.

Her baby was in front of her. Curled up like a small ball. Its spine bent in U-shape, head without hair, and hollow spaces where its eyes should have been. It was lying there, between her legs, lifeless. A broken promise!

Her husband picked it up with fragile hands as if it could breathe with life at any time. Any rough touch could break the half-grown hands. Krishna remained still; her eyes focused on the splotch which was still increasing.

Her husband left the room. Other ladies were waiting outside, their faces covered in veils. He and his father wrapped the body in a white sheet. The same night, he dug a pit in the veranda, the length of his palm and laid down the baby in it. His hands were shivering all that time. He feared that the boy might fall from his hands. He filled the pit. With every portion of the soil, the baby disappeared and soon there was only uneven soil around his feet. He flattened the surface with his hands, wiping his eyes on his sleeves all through.

Late at night when everybody went to their beds. He laid down on his cot in the veranda. He imagined both his children holding hands beneath the earth, sleeping next to each other. He saw their bodies facing each other, their hands curled around the other's wrists.

For days, he did not go back to his room. Even Krishna didn't wait for him to come. She spent her nights curled up in the corner of the bed and he spent his nights in the veranda, imagining his children beneath the surface.

They did not know whether they healed themselves with the distance or layered their grief with that silence between them. But when finally, they met, their closeness felt more like a process, like work that needs to be

done. There were no moments of love and care or passion between them. He did not hold her in his arms when she cried. She did not stop him when he left the room, once the process was over. They were hurting each other or hurting themselves, they did not know. And it seemed that they did not want to know either. They thought of letting time decide for them. With fear and hope in their heart they just waited for another piece of life to come into their lives.

She missed her monthly cycle again a few months later. This time when she kept her hand on her stomach, she did not say anything. Instead, she caressed her belly silently. At night, she didn't close her eyes out of fear. 'What if she closes her eyes and once again blood spills out when she is not awake to stop it?'

"I missed my monthly cycle," she said when she saw her husband untying his trouser. His hands stood still on the knot while he processed her words in his mind. He looked at her, straight in her eyes. It was the first time that he had looked at her like that since that night when he had buried his second baby. Her eyes shone like black coloured marbles in the dim light. Transparent, dry, and as scary as they were the last time, he had seen her that night.

He left the room after a while; he could not breathe in there. It felt like at that moment, the two were crammed inside an invisible bubble of fear. What if they dared to smile and express themselves, and the moment goes away? He left the room with heavy and slow steps, her words still ringing in his ears, "I missed my cycle". His heart was racing in his chest and the same feeling of pain and helplessness as he had felt that night covered him.

This time Krishna's belly didn't swell like earlier times. Just a small bump with very little movement in it. She didn't utter a single word during those months. She kept herself locked inside a room, away from any noise. She was at the mercy of this child. She did not want to scare him or her in any way. She kept this baby untouched from herself and others. It was as if her two children had died under the weight of her own words, a promise which she had asked for was too heavy for them to carry and it crushed them. It was she who killed her children.

The night, when her third child was about to come into this world, her eyes had the same question. When the baby slipped out of her, one of the helpers of the old lady checked the pulse and breathing of the baby. And then a piercing cry filled the silent room. It travelled through the doors and reached the ears of her husband who was waiting outside.

Along with the baby, Krishna also cried, as if both were crying from the same source. She let go of all the tears she had kept locked inside, tears that were rotting her from inside.

Her baby looked like a miniature human body. For a while, Krishna couldn't believe that she was real. She looked more like a stuffed toy. Her eyes and fists closed and her breath was barely audible.

She could easily fit in her father's palms. Her movements were so slow that for the tiny creature, the burden of lifting her arm was too much.

For days, Krishna didn't let anybody touch her girl. There was still a shadow of fear in her. A thought she could not put in words.

At night, she would wake up and check the breathing of the baby many times while she was sleeping. She would touch her tiny toes and fingers and when the baby twitched, she would smile and the knot in her head would relax. Her husband didn't come into her room. The tension between them was dissolving, yet they were afraid for the child. What if God takes her away if they came close or celebrated?

Her eldest Bua was cradling her in her arms when she opened her eyes for the first time. She lifted her feather-like eyelids for a while and then closed them half again as if she was still in sleep. Sunlight was too much for her eyes. She blinked to adjust her eyes before opening them slowly again. Maybe the world captivated her because she looked all around. She was looking at everything as if she wanted to know everything this world had to offer. She looked at her aunt with her emerald-coloured eyes, moving them to the left and then to the front.

"See, she has a green eye!" Bua said, smiling at the bundle wrapped in her arms.

Krishna let out a faded smile. Too much attention to her baby was scaring her.

After a few months, when Krishna started doing the household work again, she would take little Naina with her everywhere. On their way to the field, Krishna would hold her in one arm, Naina's head resting peacefully on her shoulder. Krishna would adjust it now and then. Naina would sleep or would lie silent looking at the trees and birds around her when her mother worked in the fields. On their way back, they would come back in the same manner, like a well-planned routine.

At home, Krishna would come over in the middle of her work to check on little Naina. She always found herself looking at the ceiling or playing quietly with something in her hands. She never disturbed her mother, as if she knew that even if she created a nuisance, the availability of her mother's attention would be scant. It was enough for her to have a look at her mother frequently.

After Naina, Krishna gave birth to two boys, she watched her mother's belly growing and then growing again. A special place which she held changed and her two brothers filled the place.

Naina was 7 years old when her second younger brother was born. She was playing in the veranda when a rush of cheerful laughter and noise filled the house. She ran inside to see. Her father was laughing and crying at the same time. When he saw Naina, he lifted her in his arms and threw her in the air and then caught her again saying, "You lucky soul, you brought two brothers with you."

Naina laughed with her father without understanding the meaning, without understanding the heaviness of those words.

Soon her laughs changed into silence. All the attention shifted from her to them as if she had never been there. Naina grew up in midst of uncles, aunts, grandparents, cousins and two siblings. Yet she felt alone and unloved. She craved her mother's attention and observed her from far taking care of her brothers, waiting that someday her mother would turn to her again and would love her like before.

Naina was different from her other siblings and cousins. She turned out to be a slow and quiet child. She had her world in which she was the only person.

Free like a chirpy bird, she just couldn't stand in one place. She would talk nonstop to herself and her imaginary characters till she got tired and would sleep in the middle of her virtual conversation. She was an observant but slow kid, who took time to observe and fill everything in her. She loved enjoying little things and felt happy doing so.

Sometimes she would lie down for hours on the veranda with her arms fully stretched, touching the floor, and feeling the freshness and frigidity of white marble. She kept rolling over and changing her sides from time to time when the surface under her became warm due to her body's heat. She played this game of hers like a ritual. Every Sunday, after her mother mopped the floor, she would come and lay flat on her stomach, hands fully stretched, all fingers open, and legs spread wide apart. After a while, she would shift a little and turn on her back to feel the cold marble against her skin. Once she has covered both the front and back of her body, she would get up, wear her shirt and pants, and go out running to play.

She would see everything which happens around her with wide eyes and soak it like a sponge. She firmly believed everything she saw and whatever her parents or anybody said.

"Naina, why do you sit so close to the TV?" her father asked her once. He had been regularly asking her to sit at a distance, but Naina did not listen.

"I can't see their faces and clothes from that far Papa." She said turning her face to her father and turning back again to face the TV. There was no fun watching TV from far behind.

"Okay, I'll send you inside the TV. Then you can see them all you want." He said and continued, "Tell me, do you want to go inside it, huh?"

Naina remained silent for a few seconds and then asked, surprisingly, "Can you send me inside?" Her eyes were wide with the piece of knowledge she had just gotten.

“Of course I can, wait I’ll show you and then you won’t be able to come out ever. Come, I’ll send you inside the TV,” he said, holding her with her wrist and dragging her towards the TV.

“No! No Papa...! Please, no papa! I’ll never watch TV from close. I promise papa.” She said. The thought of not coming back out of it scared her.

“Please papa, don’t send me in.!” Fear emerged in her eyes while she tried to free herself from the firm grip of her father.

“Okay, I am letting you go this time. But if I ever find you so close to the TV, I’ll send you inside it.”

Naina wiped her eyes and moved her head left to right in agreement.

Since that day she maintained at least four feet distance from the TV just to make sure that not even by mistake TV could suck her inside.

For years, she believed that Tom and Jerry were real and she looked for them in her kitchen, on corners of her house, and in the neighbourhood. Whenever she would spot any cat or a mouse, she would scream “TOMMMMMMM. JERRRRRRRYYYYYY,” at top of her voice to check whether they responded to their names or not. That was her trick to check their identity.

She would hide and look at them for hours, waiting for them to walk on their two legs as they did on the TV. But they never did and she never found her Tom and Jerry.

Once her uncle asked her to eat chillies that were drying in the sun for making pickles.

“You will grow like a tree if you eat these chillies,” he told her. She looked at the red chillies spread out in front of her.

“How many do I need to eat?” she asked, kneeling. Her knees touched the cemented floor and scratched her skin a little.

“At least four!” His voice had the truth, which she wanted to hear, and she believed him anyway.

“Fourrrrrr?” She looked at him, feeling the burning sensation already in her mouth, tears welling up in her eyes.

“Yes, four! I ate twenty when your father told me this secret. And look at me!” He opened her arms wide, pushing out his chest.

Later that night, she jumped out of her bed and tiptoed into the kitchen. She untied the knot of the sheet in which her mother had collected the chillies after the sun had gone down.

‘Just four! I need to eat just four and by tomorrow morning, I’ll be as tall as a tree. Everyone will be surprised to see me in the morning.’ She thought and giggled at her victory.

Naina picked a tiny chilli and gulped it down without chewing it. She took another and gulped it down without chewing. There was a vomiting tendency but she suppressed it. She took another chilli and gulped it down. By the time she vomited, she had already eaten eighteen. Her grandmother and mother found her in a pool of her vomit when they heard her vomiting. Yellow paste-like liquid was drooling from her mouth.

Somehow all her aunts always knew what to do, what to say, what not to say. When to do household chores and when to play, unlike Naina who never had any direction for her. Like the wind, she was everywhere all the time, jumping every moment like a butterfly. She talked and talked and talked till she fell asleep at night, unlike her mother who did not talk at all and used her words only when required.

Later in life, when Naina thought about the similarities and differences between her and her mother, she found that she had never seen her mother talking much. She had never seen her laughing aloud with tears in her eyes till her stomach hurts. And she never let Naina laugh like that as well.

Naina tried to recall things her mother used to say to her that did not make sense at that time, but now they made sense to her. How naive she was to

believe everything, whatever someone said. How her mother scolded her whenever she saw her eyes wandering around.

“A girl’s eyes should always be down.” She would say to her and Naina would ignore it, with a kind of anger breeding in her heart.

“You laugh like a devil; girls don’t laugh like that.” her mother would say to her, but Naina never listened. She always did whatever her mother asked her to stop. All the restrictions which she poured on her created a distance between them. In those restrictions, she did not remember when she lost her mother.

CHAPTER

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13

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Like a drop in the ocean,

I want to merge with you

I don't know any other way,

To love and to be with you.

His room was dark when Veer came home drunk. Stumbling around in his room, he reached his bed. He slapped the wall to find the switches. He made his way to his bed with his phone's light when he could not find the buttons.

He was still sleeping when his phone rang at 11.30 pm. He was lying on his stomach. His left hand reached for the phone. He looked at the screen, his eyes half closed due to the brightness of the phone. An unknown number was flashing on the screen. He tried to guess the number and then kept it faced down without answering. He already had two missed calls from that number.

It stopped ringing after some time before vibrating again with the ringtone. He looked at the screen, irritated this time. It was a different number. He was getting calls from two different unknown numbers. He looked at the time and got up with a start as if something urgent had come to his mind.

Astha was calling him from under her bed sheet. She had borrowed her father's phone.

"I want to call my friends to wish them a happy new year," she had said to her father. He looked her up and down and gave his phone to her reluctantly. She had been trying to reach him since late evening, but he didn't answer her phone. She called his number twice more; it rang but nobody answered. Disappointed, she went back to her parent's room and kept her father's phone on his bedside table.

That day, Naina was sleeping with her grandmother and grandfather. All her cousins had gone to a wedding. They would come back by morning. She waited for everyone to sleep. She did not know where she got the strength to use the phone that late at night. She knew that if anybody saw her with that, there would be nothing she could say. There would be nothing to explain to anybody. But that time she did not think about that. All she could think was Veer. She just wanted to wish him, as if that was the only thing that would keep her alive for the next day. She dialled his phone. It played a busy tone. She dialled again, and again it played the busy tone.

'Should I wait? Should I go? What if someone finds me?' Her heart was racing but to her, the call was as important as oxygen. She dialled the number again

"The network you are trying to reach is currently not reachable," said the lady on the other side in a recorded message.

'How can I be so unlucky?' She thought.

She kept the phone back on the table in the living room and came back to her bed. Sleep was nowhere near her; she spent the next one-hour tossing and turning on her bed. She looked at the wall clock which was striking 12.30.

'I'll wish you at 12!' His voice was continuously ringing in her ears.

'Maybe now, his phone will be reachable. Is he thinking about me like I am thinking about him? He must be waiting for my call. That's why he had

shared his number.' thoughts kept raising their head.

She got up and looked at her grandparents. They were sleeping peacefully. She slipped out of her bed and tiptoed towards the living room again, took the phone and got back to her bed running on her toes. The floor beneath her toes was cold and dusty.

She lay silent for some time to check if someone had seen her and was coming to inquire. But to her relief, nobody came. No door opened. The whole house was in deep sleep. The rush was in her heart. Anybody could hear it if one pressed one's head against her chest.

Veer's phone rang again and he picked it up on the first ring as if he was also waiting for it. She held her breath, her heart thudding aloud.

"Hello," came the voice from the other side.

"Hi!" she answered in a barely audible voice.

"Naina?" he asked. She had never heard such a musical version of her name in her life. And she missed her beats. It felt like a mild pinch in her heart.

"Hello, are you there?"

"Hi, Happy new year!" she said. Words came out in a hurry, slipping and overlapping each other.

"Happy new year to you too!" he replied.

Naina could not read the expression in his voice. It sounded plain and blank. 'Maybe he was expecting something else from me.' Naina judged his tone and words. 'Maybe I should not have called.' She felt stupid and embarrassed.

An awkward silence lingered between them before Veer started speaking.

"You called very late. I was waiting for your call," he said.

Now she heard the complaint in his voice. She could read the wait in his words.

Veer was sitting on his bed with his back, leaning on the cushions lined up against the wall. He looked at the TV mounted on the front wall. He could see the reflection of the street light coming into his room through the semi parted curtain of the window at the corner. The reflecting light moved every time the curtain moved with air.

He waited for her answer.

“I was trying your number, but it was not reachable.” She said, holding the phone tight to her ear and mouth. She spoke slowly this time. She pictured him lying on his bed, looking at the ceiling.

“I was waiting,” he replied.

Naina blushed. Her cheeks burned and went pink. She blushed as if Veer had touched her cheeks while saying it. She could feel the stretch of the skin around her ears when she smiled. Every cell in her body was smiling. She could feel it. Her heart, her stomach, her eyes, everything was happy.

“I... I tried your number so many times but your phone was busy and then went out of coverage.” It took her some time to reply.

“Oh, I was getting calls from Astha. So, I was avoiding them and then maybe my network had some issues,” he replied and paused before speaking again.

“That day you were looking beautiful,” he said.

Naina’s ears burned when she heard it. His words took her by surprise. She was not ready for that.

“I wanted to say it that day but could not say.” He continued, “I love your hazel eyes. There is something in them, which pulls me towards you.” His words were slow and clear in her ear. Her heartbeat was rising with every pause he took in between.

“Naina...!” he spoke slowly. “I haven’t felt this way ever with anyone.”

The way he spoke her name, the voice reached her heart. It touched the right chord. She felt that music inside her.

Her throat went dry when she whispered, “Thank you!”

Words fell short, her mind all blank and dizzy. She did not want to ruin the moment by saying something which she should not.

“Naina!” He whispered her name.

She let out a deep sigh with her whole body as if every part of it was letting go the control. Her heart raced.

“Naina.....!” he whispered her name again. “I love you!” he said, pressing his phone to his mouth and ear as if that gesture would travel through the phone and would reach her. They both fell silent. She tried to control her heavy breathing but could not. She was afraid that Veer might hear them, too. Their breaths were sharing the same rhythm as if they were dancing on a single beat.

Her voice choked in her throat. Her hands were shaking. She removed the phone from her ear and pressed the red button to disconnect the call. She kept the phone on her chest and looked at the ceiling. His face kept flashing in her mind. The day they had been in his car. How she felt at that time. Nervous and happy! The smell of rain took over her senses.

Her phone rang again after one minute. His number was flashing on the screen. She stared at the phone’s screen, the light coming out and fading in as if beating like a heart. She picked up the call after two missed calls.

“Naina, do you love me?” he asked without wasting any time. She sensed the eagerness in his voice.

“I don’t know!” she replied with heavy breaths, “I..... I..... haven’t thought about it. I don’t know anything.” She wanted to be alone at that time, to think, to understand the rush inside her. There were so many things she

needed to ponder before saying anything. Love is such a heavy word! All her desires and all her controls were crashing and rising again. Even though she knew the answer, something in her said that she should not say it.

“Just say Yes or NO...!” His voice had that authority which she had felt when he had asked her to join. As if he already owned her.

“How can I say yes or no? I don’t know anything about it.” she said hesitantly, “I don’t know what I should say.” Her last line came slowly. She lacked control over her own words.

“Naina. do you love me??” Her heart was melting with every word.

‘Why can’t he understand my silence?’ she thought.

“Okay! Then disconnect the call if you don’t love me.”

She could hear the irritation in his words. She did not disconnect.

“Veer, we will talk about this later. It’s getting late now.” she somehow managed to answer.

“Just say that you love me. I know that you do. I can feel it. You also know it. Then, what’s stopping you? Why are you making things difficult for me?” he pleaded.

“I’ll talk to you tomorrow about it. Ok!” It took strength to control the words which were sitting on her lips.

She was scared of her family, her father, and her brothers. What if they came to know about it? How could she say things which she knew she could not fulfil? How could she cheat her family’s trust and their love?

“I love you Naina.....! I love you....! I love you....! I love you....!” he kept on whispering.

“I love you..!” Naina did not know when she started to respond to him. Her words came in whispers, as if she was saying them to herself, not to him. She acknowledged her voice. All the restrictions which were holding her

disappeared. Their knots loosened and she felt as if her heart was getting heavy and light at the same time. His words felt like music to her ears. Music, she could hear every moment of her life.

They talked till dawn, confessing their love a million times in between. Repeating those three words in rhythm became their thing.

Naina tasted love for the first time that night, and the love dipped conversation she shared with him changed her life forever. Even after years, she would remember his voice, his silence, and her heartbeats as clearly as if it happened the previous night.

The next day when she woke up, the world looked more beautiful and brighter. All the colours popped up. There was nothing which could make her sad. His words kept coming and ringing in her head. 'Naina.....I love you!' she could hear his voice. She looked in the mirror. 'Your eyes are beautiful,' she repeated to herself.

From nothing finally she became something for someone. Somebody in this world wanted her. The way she was, he found her beautiful. He waited for her. Veer pulled her towards him by an invisible thread. A thread which only she could see! Veer became everything to her.

They started meeting in the college. Astha saw them sitting together. She also came to know about them from her other friends. Naina would miss her classes, and Veer started coming to college early. On their way home, Astha did not say anything to her but maintained a distance from her. She talked less. They would come and go in silence. Naina also did not try to explain anything to her. But her heart was getting heavy and burdened with guilt. She could not look into Astha's eyes and say anything. Every day, she waited for Astha to start the conversation but she never did. After some time, Naina stopped bothering about anything. Anyway, she hardly talked to anyone. She was barely visible on college premises. She missed her classes as if she was not even part of the college.

She would spend her days with Veer, sometimes out of college, sometimes in the college's park. Being in college she was always out of it. Within a

week or so, the whole college knew about them. Naina was not popular but Veer was. Nobody noticed her but they did notice him.

“Oh, finally she has a boyfriend.” one of her classmates said. They were standing in a group outside the canteen.

“I don’t know how wide she would have opened her legs for him,” another one of them said.

“I don’t understand how this kind of girl can get such boys?”

“Either that guy is blind or he is getting something else.”

“Look at her. She looks so hungry. She must be getting some real action with him.”

“Eee……Aww! I can’t even imagine her hairy legs, Yuck!!” they kept saying and others let out a noisy laugh, sharing high-fives.

Naina did not bother anybody, but she broke down in tears one day when Sandy also did not talk to her for so many days. She was the only girl who talked to her in her class. She would share her lunch with her sometimes. She was the one who taught Naina how to apply kohl properly. It was Sandy, who had come to sit with her when she had noticed her sitting all alone at the back. She had explained the chapters to Naina when she could not understand. Once, while coming to the class, Naina heard another girl talking to Sandy about her.

“She is weird. Have you seen her talking? How does she swear so openly? Why do you talk to her? She will ruin your character as well.” The girl continued after a pause, “She doesn’t even attend classes and now she has started roaming with that guy.”

Naina could not see the faces but she could tell by their voices, who was talking. Naina waited for Sandy to reply to something in her support. But Sandy remained silent. Naina pretended to smile when she opened the classroom door and came in.

Though Naina did not tell her anything about Veer, still she thought Sandy would understand her.

“Do you also think that I am a characterless girl who just wants to roam around with boys?” Naina passed the paper to her in the middle of the lecture. She attended the lecture so that she could talk to her.

“No.” Sandy wrote back. Naina looked at her in amazement and with relief in her eyes.

“Then why aren’t you talking to me?”

“Because you did not tell me anything, I came to know from others. People are making fun of me that you cheated on me as well. I considered you my best friend, but you did not share anything with me. I am hurt that I am nothing for you.” Naina had tears in her eyes while she read those lines, as if all the love from the world had suddenly turned towards her. She always thought that Sandy stayed with her out of mercy. But right now, she was overwhelmed, happy, and heavy at the same time. How she could not see Sandy’s selfless love towards her. The feeling of being loved filled her. The world had made her believe that she couldn’t be loved but still, there were few people in this world to whom she mattered, who didn’t judge her weird ways of talking and dressing.

“I love you.” She wrote and passed.

“I hate you.” Came the reply.

And they giggled between their breaths, holding hands below their desk. At that moment, Naina decided and promised herself that she would never let go of Sandy and that she will cherish this friendship forever. But everything was about to change and Naina would not be able to hold anything in her arms. Everything would slip before she could tighten her grip. But Naina did not know it then, she could never guess.

With Veer, her desire to be loved and to be accepted had been satiated. For her, her entire world revolved around him. Her little heart was happy and

satisfied with him. What else did she want? Her days started with his thoughts and ended up thinking about him.

It was around one month later after their confession of love for each other that Veer took her out for a drive. Usually, she would avoid going out alone with him. She feared being seen with him. They would sit in the canteen and park from morning to evening talking about everything, mostly about Veer. Naina always avoided topics about herself. There was nothing she could tell him about her. And she was embarrassed to share her things with him. What if he leaves her after knowing that she was different from him, that at home, her world was different and suffocated? But that day, she could not refuse him.

She had worn a red jacket over a black kurta with a black legging. She had smeared her hazel eyes with kohl, which anyway were sparkling with love. When she got inside the car, she found Veer's eyes glued to her face.

"You are looking beautiful," he said looking into her eyes.

She smiled and nudged him on his shoulder after a while when he did not turn his eyes off her.

She understood the seriousness of the moment when he leaned forward and cupped her face in his hands. The panic started from her stomach, as his face came forward. His eyes were on her lips and she was looking directly at him. She put her hands on his chest and pushed him so hard that his head almost touched the window.

For a long he had been telling her that he wanted to kiss her. Naina had been ignoring him. It was not that Naina did not like it when he talked about it, but then whenever he tried to come close to her, her body unconsciously repelled his touch. The panic would start to rush in her body whenever she found him close to her. She would constantly wipe her sweat beads from her upper lips and forehead. She would sweat even in the air-conditioned car.

A few days back over the phone, when he had asked her to kiss him, a current had run into her body. She imagined him kissing her a million times.

But today, when she was just a few breaths away from that kiss, her mind and body did not support her. Her breaths quickened as his hands touched her face and something in her head told her to move out of that situation. And before she could argue with it, she had jerked back, pushed him away and got free herself from his soft hands. Sweat beads appeared on her forehead in January.

“What is wrong with you? Why don’t you let me touch you?” he asked, flaring his hands in the air and yelling at her.

She had never seen him like that before. He slapped his hands on the steering wheel many times.

“I am sorry, I don’t feel comfortable,” she said without making any eye contact with him. “It’s just....., it’s quite open out there....., people could see us.” she continued looking at him now. Her eyes were looking for assurance on his face.

After a long stretch of silence, he moved his body towards her and took her hands in his hands. He brought them up and placed a soft kiss on them to soothe her down. Naina looked at his hands as they moved towards her, she wanted to pull her hands back but she did not. She shut her eyes tightly when his lips touched her skin. They were soft yet disgusting. When Naina did not react this time, he moved up her arms. Moving sleeves up her elbow he started kissing them. Every time his lips touched her, she pulled her toes inward, her eyebrows knitted and her eyes clam shut.

That was one of those days when her body was saying no, but her mouth could not say it. Her “No!” was stuck in her throat. And it was not the first time that she was letting somebody use her body like that.

Finally, when he reached her lips, she again pulled herself back.

“This is not the right place for all this,” she said while faking a blush on her face.

He smiled and his smile reflected the power he had over her. Naina could see the victory on his face. He was happy that his touch had made her blush.

Her denial made him believe that she was not accustomed to male touch. And all that was all new for her. He smiled thinking that he was the first one to touch her. But her skin knew how many hands had touched her so far.

“I love you!” he said while fastening his seat belt.

Naina looked at him with tears and pain in her heart. ‘How this person can love me so much even when I cannot keep him happy?’ she thought.

‘I am obliged to give him what he expects from me. Or else what kind of love is this when I can’t make him happy? I will do whatever he wants me to do. He loves me so much. I’ll also love him the way he wants me to. I can’t hurt him,’ she comforted herself with such thoughts.

They spent their day together, but there was some uneasiness in her. Whenever he came forward, she would shrink in herself. But she did not let him have any clue about her fight with herself.

Till late that night, Naina tried to sleep. She felt like vomiting, that feeling kept moving in circles in her chest. She rubbed her chest continuously to get rid of that sensation but it didn’t fade. She had not cried in years. But that night, everything came back to her. All those thoughts, all those images, sensations that her sense had gathered, all came back to her. She cried until she could not breathe.

She thought about him. Veer was everything to her. She wanted to pour all her love on him. He was the only person who made her feel alive. He understood her, when no one accepted her, he had come to love her. All her life she thought that she was not worthy of any kind of love, that there were some issues with her, and that she did not fit in this world. But now she had his love. And still, she was not able to let go of her past.

He often referred to her as “My princess!” and that would fill her empty heart with all the love in the world. They would talk the whole night like a cheesy couple, saying “Love you,” almost after every sentence. He would tell her everything he did and she would hear him without interrupting. She wondered when was the last time anybody had talked to her like that. Who did ever wait for night to fall just to share his time with her? Naina thought

about it, she could not find any such memory. She found herself always hungry for conversation, waiting for somebody to choose her to confide with her.

“Please don’t keep the phone down,” he asked her one night when after talking for 4 hours, she had finally given him the 100th kiss as a final goodnight kiss.

“Don’t you want to sleep today?” she asked him in that playful tone.

“I want to feel your breaths while sleeping.”

She felt a gush of butterflies in her stomach when she heard him. Even Veer did not know what his words were doing to her. With every passing day, he was overpowering her with his love. After that day, they never slept without hearing each other’s breaths. Her days would start hearing his voice and would end with the warmth of his breaths.

They spent their nights dedicating romantic songs to each other, sometimes singing for each other, discussing their marriage, and dreaming about their future babies. Once he told her about his ex-girlfriend “Neha”. How he had been madly in love with her and how she had cheated on him. He always compared Naina with her.

“You are different from her. She used to wear only a tank top whenever she came to meet me, unlike you. I like it that you wear a suit - salwar.”

His words filled her with pride. It’s amazing how love changes you. Naina never liked herself in a typical Indian Avatar. In college, she would see other girls wearing different kinds of western dresses and disdaining her for wearing those simple suits. But after Veer complimented her about them, she started looking down at those girls, whom she admired for their boldness and freedom. Now, she judged them as characterless and spoilt brats.

Naina was seeing the world from Veer’s eyes. She was losing her existence and identity in him.

CHAPTER

■

14

■

I stretch my arms,

To touch the new world,

Not knowing that the world ahead,

Was a ball offire instead.

It was late at night when Naina woke up. It was not because of any dream or nightmare; it was one of her body's habits. It didn't involve her mind. It was something that she couldn't control. It would wake her up at night, and she could not sleep after that.

As a kid whenever that happened, she would get down from her bed, walk across the hallway in her half sleep to reach her parent's room, open the door and slip next to her mother. Her right hand and right leg spread over her mother as if her mother was running somewhere and Naina was afraid that she would leave her behind. She would sleep, snuggling her mother, peacefully like a dead horse.

When this habit started, nobody noticed or thought that it was strange. They didn't talk about it, nobody even observed it initially. It seemed like a one-night exception. Maybe she saw a dream or got scared and did not want to sleep alone. It was her grandmother who noticed that it was her daily habit to sneak out of her bed around midnight. Something her body did on its own.

All the children used to sleep with their grandparents. Her eldest aunt, who was married and visited them, often also used to sleep there only. It was like a common room for all those who didn't have any specific room assigned to them. There was not enough space in the room as well.

They had five rooms in the house, each one assigned to the sons of the family. Naina had two uncles and two aunts - one elder to her father and the other younger. She had had one more aunt, whom she had never seen. She had died of pneumonia when she was 3 years old when she had just started to speak. She was plump and pink until the fever caught her. By the time of her death, that little chubby had turned into a thin stick and she left the world one day without saying anything.

Nobody did tell her about that dead aunt of hers. She learnt all of it by hearing her grandmother and father talk sometimes at night. She had seen her grandmother crying and sobbing late at night. Sometimes she overheard the conversations between her grandmother and her married aunt. Naina would sit with them, playing around with her stuff, half listening to their talks. They talked about the in-laws of her aunt. What her mother-in-law said, what her husband's sister does, and so on. Naina would listen to them for a while and then would get busy with her imaginary games.

Once she picked up the slippers of her aunt. Wrapped a piece of cloth-like saree on one and covered it from above like pallu. Then she lit an imaginary fire making the sound, "Whooooosssshhhhh!" Then moving her hands like she was holding a spoon pouring oil in the fire, she started chanting, "Ommmm... bhurashua'.... ommm ... bhurashua....!" She continued pouring the spoonfuls into the holy fire and closed one of her eyes as if the fire was causing it to burn. Then she kept the spoon and took the two chappals in her hands and made them move in circles around the fire. Her tiny hands clutched one slipper in each hand. Slippers jumped up and down and completed the circles.

After the marriage ceremony, Naina kept the married slippers in a corner of the bed and covered them with the same piece of cloth that the bride was wearing. Then she smiled at them and tilted her head a little as if saying something to them. She moved her hands in the air and bolted the imaginary door of their bedroom.

She found her aunt and grandmother in tears watching her do these chores. She looked at them for a while, reflecting her aunt's expression on her face. Like her aunt, her eyebrows joined and her face intense as if something was hurting her. A forgotten pain in her arm or some part of her body started breathing again. Tears pooled up in her green eyes and her lower lip turned down revealing the pinkish skin.

She did not care about her grandmother. She did not like her anyway. Her tears irritated her. They made her uneasy. It didn't match the image Naina had of her grandmother in her eyes. She felt incapable of showing any sympathy towards her. She was upset and irritated with herself that she had made her aunt cry with her useless talks. But the thought that something could make her grandmother cry gave her some satisfaction.

Naina loved her aunt. She could not see her in tears. She cried continuously for two days when her aunt got married. She was not letting her sit in the car. Her father had to pull her loosening her grip. Later, when she did not stop crying and started waggling her hands in her father's arms, her uncle slapped her. Whenever her aunt visited them, Naina would stick with her like glue. She would eat with her, go around with her, and sleep with her. And she would cry heavily to go with her aunt when she left for her inlaw's place. Her aunt always loved her more than others. She would give her one rupee every day for treats. She never raised her voice or hand at her. That's what Naina liked the most in her aunt, the only person who did not frighten her.

And even if she scolded Naina sometimes, her words didn't sound harsh to the ears. They never stuck to her heart.

"I sometimes hear her voice at night. She calls me for help," her grandmother had said. Her voice was shaking and she broke into tears at the end of her sentence, her shoulders moving with her sobs.

Her aunt sat there silently. Her eyes were blank and dry. She was looking at the floor as if seeing something there. Glimpses of another world that her eyes could see! Naina looked below. There was nothing, just different colours of marble looking back at her.

“It’s okay Ma, don’t think too much. Now that’s gone,” her aunt said.

“Hmm....,” her grandmother said at the mattress the way her daughter was looking at the floor. Naina looked at that, too. She found nothing, just faded red flowers and yellow curry stains staring at her.

Naina used to sleep with her aunt before her aunt got married. Her right hand and right leg crossed over her aunt’s body, and her head was on her shoulder. Her aunt and her mother were the only ones who let her sleep like that.

When her aunt got married, she told her mother that she would sleep with her, but her grandmother interjected, “Ohhh. What! Are you a baby?? Do you need to suck your mother’s nipple so that you can’t sleep without her? You will sleep with me.”

Naina had giggled, imagining herself sucking her mother’s breast. She saw her mother lying on the bed with Naina sleeping next to her and her hands curled, fists closed. Her mouth in a rhythmic movement gulped the milk.

“You are a big girl now. You should sleep with me,” her grandmother said.

Naina’s giggle had softened her tone. She did not know that she could make Naina laugh also. Whatsoever Naina did always irritated her, and she ended up either slapping her or swearing at her when she ran out of her reach. She would threaten to punish her whenever she would see her next.

“I’ll cut you into pieces, next time I’ll see you.” she would say to her.

The reason was that Naina was not like the other girls in the house. They had all been obedient and respectful to her. But Naina! She was like a train in the house running on broken tracks. For a while, she would run straight and then would stumble over anything. Her grandmother had given her the name “Pagal Ghodi’ because she was always found running here and there.

There was nothing she could argue about. Although she didn’t like at the idea of sleeping with her grandmother, she wanted to prove to them that she had grown up now. Her grandmother’s tone was sweeter than sugar when

she called Naina to sleep. All her brothers and cousin were already in bed at their respective places. Her youngest aunt was also already asleep with her cousin. She was the daughter of her grandmother's sister. Naina didn't like her. She reeked of cattle shit.

There was an empty cot with a white mattress spread on it. The cot was smaller as compared to others. Only one person could sleep in it freely. Naina thought of the bed she used to share with her favourite aunt. It was also a single bed, but both slept on it comfortably.

“Dadi.....! Who will sleep on this?” Naina asked her grandmother about seeing that empty bed.

“My princess will sleep on it, right beside me,” the grandmother said tapping the white mattress and smiling at her.

Naina was confused about two things. One, she didn't like the idea of sleeping alone. Somehow, the cot looked a lot bigger now. Two people could easily sleep in that. That space was more than enough for her to sleep all alone. Something in her told her that it was not good to sleep alone.

Second, she was confused about her grandmother's words. How could Naina refuse her when she was talking like that? Princess.....! She had never called her that before. There was something sweet and magical about that word. She could not resist the urge to taste the rest of the words that would come out of her grandmother's mouth if she agreed to sleep alone. The hardness in her heart towards her grandmother melted.

She looked at her bed and then at her grandmother, who was still smiling at her. Grandmother's lips appeared to have gotten stuck and seemingly couldn't come back to their normal position. She wanted to run away and go to her mother. But when her grandmother asked her to lie down, she hopped on it. She kept looking at grandmother's face when she undid the folds of a bed sheet and spread it over her up to her neck.

Her eyelids danced when she closed her eyes. They appeared like they were shivering due to the cold. Nine people were sleeping in that room, but she felt as if she was sleeping all alone on the road and there was no one to hear

her. There would be nobody to help her if any ghost appeared at night. She missed her aunt, the touch of her body. With her, she was never scared of ghosts. Her aunt did nothing to make her sleep. She never told her any stories, caressed her head, or ran fingers in her hair. Even Naina did not demand any special treatment. She never had any problems sleeping. She used to fall asleep within a few minutes while playing only, her hands up in the air, moving in different gestures and different expressions coming on her face. Nobody knew what she played or what she mumbled. Her words were more like whispers, tangled with each other. Only she knew what she was saying.

When her hands became heavy and she could not keep her eyes open, she would end the game abruptly saying, “Now, we will play tomorrow, okay!” as if the imaginary players may get angry with her if she didn’t promise to play the next day. She would wrap her arm around her aunt and sleep. At some point in her sleep, she would raise her right leg a little and then let it rest on her aunt’s waist.

On her first night sleeping alone, it must have been late at night when she woke up. It was all dark around her. She never knew that they slept with all the lights switched off. She had always slept under that white light of a big tube in their room and woke up to the same light. When her eyes got adjusted to the dark, she could see the people sleeping around her. Though she could not see the faces but by their shapes and the position of the beds, she knew who was who. Grandmother was sleeping next to her. She had her face to the wall. Grandfather was sleeping near the entrance of the room. His bed was opposite her cot. Her younger aunt and her cousin were on a cot next to Naina’s cot and after that was spread a long trail of four beds with her cousins sleeping on them.

Naina had slept comfortably till then, but suddenly she felt the need for that touch of skin and that comfort that she used to get from her aunt. She looked at her grandmother and tried to imagine herself sleeping with her hand and leg wrapped around her. But the image did not develop. Somehow, she could not just imagine it. And when she could do it after some time, it did not feel right somewhere in her heart.

She got off that cot which had turned magically large for her size. It creaked when she jumped out of it. All the lights of the house were off, except one at the far end of the hallway. Her mother's room was in the opposite direction, and it was pitch dark there. She counted to 3 and then ran. Her feet covered a wide space between them. She did not dare look back. What if somebody was following her and may catch her? She was panting when she reached her parent's room. The hallway never looked as long and scary during the day as it looked right then. When Naina looked back, she imagined a giant monster looking at her with his mouth wide open.

She placed her palms on the door and pushed it. It was locked. She closed her palms into a fist and then started banging the door while her eyes remained on the hallway. Her face turned back, her mouth open and scared.

"Mummmmyyyyy..... Mummmuyyyyyyyyy," she yelled and banged.

She was sobbing when her mother opened the door after a few seconds. But Naina felt that she had been standing there for eternity.

"Naina...what happened?" her mother asked and took her inside without listening to her answers. There was a double bed in her parent's room and a cot next to it. Her father used to sleep on the cot and her mother shared the bed with Naina's younger brother. He was only one-year-old.

"I was scared mummy," she said between the gasps of her sobs.

Her mother picked the baby and shifted him to the other side of the bed and let Naina lie down next to her. Naina clung to her like a baby monkey clinging to its mother. Her arms around her neck, her leg rested on her hip and her face pushed into her mother's neck. It took her sobs a while to die. When her grip loosened around her mother's neck, her mother carefully removed her thin hands from her neck and placed them straight beside her.

After that day, it became her daily routine to get up at night and walk to her parent's room. The first few nights, she used to run in the hallway to reach their room and found it locked. Her mother would get up and open the door after a few seconds and would ask her the same question in a surprised tone. But after two weeks, both got used to the routine. The darkness of the

hallway did not scare Naina anymore. She would walk slowly with her half-closed eyes and open the door with a gentle push. Her mother would call her name and confirm that it was she said, “Naina, have you come?” as if she had been waiting for her to come and Naina was late. She would shift and make space for her to sleep. And Naina would sleep hugging her till morning.

Nobody questioned her when the first day she had woken up in her mother’s room. However, she asked her mother how did she reach here?

“How am I sleeping here, I was sleeping in that room?” she asked her mother pointing with her hand in the direction of her grandmother’s room. “Mummy, did you take me to your room?”, She continued while her confused mind kept trying to figure out the shift.

It was all good and was going smoothly till one day her grandmother strictly prohibited her from going to her mother’s room.

“Beta, you should not disturb your parents late at night. They are tired and they need good sleep.” She had said to her and Naina had agreed to her. She never disagreed with anyone.

But still, Naina would wake up at night to go to her parent’s room. Sometimes she found them on the same bed sleeping and sometimes she heard some rustling inside the room before her mother opened it for her.

It was only after her grandmother started locking her into room that Naina’s visits stopped.

She woke up and went to the door. Her hands moved effortlessly as rehearsed steps of a ballerina in the dark. She held the handle and pulled it. The door rattled a bit but did not open.

Years later, whenever Naina thought about those nights, she would like to go back in time and run from that room and sleep with her mother. She would curse God for making her stay there because it was in that room that the door of a completely different world opened and Naina went inside it without her knowledge. After that night, it became difficult for her to reach

her mother. That locked door stood between them for years, as if somebody had manifested it with some magical power.

It took her years to unlock that door, and when it opened, nothing was the same. That world beyond that door had become different, like a faded memory. Her mother had changed, she had aged. Her father was not the same. He had become distant, almost out of her reach.

And Naina! She couldn't tell what had happened to her. She could not decide whether she had broken into pieces or had turned into a stone, whether she came in the category of the living or the dead. The things her eyes had seen after that night never left her. It was like she got frozen in that time frame. Years came and went by, but Naina did not grow. Her life had got split into four different time frames.

Later in life, sometimes when Naina thought about her life, she found four different versions of herself. All four are locked in four different time frames. They looked different from each other and probably did know anything about each other. Each image of her was a stranger to the other.

The first one was the innocent one. She took the world at face value. She believed every word she heard and believed everything she saw without a question in her mind. Maybe that's how every child feels or maybe not, probably no one can tell. Although this version was her favourite, for her at least the world was beautiful and soothing. It was alive and she felt a cool breeze touching her face, her eyes closed and a smile on her face. That imaginary world ended that night when she could not open the door and had to go back to her bed, alone and scared.

Second Naina, who felt like the world was spinning around her every minute and she was trying to reach for something to hold and stand still for a while to make sense of that whirlwind storm. She couldn't see anybody around her. It was like she was all alone in that dimension of the universe. The previous world she had belonged to had disappeared, or maybe she somehow got shifted into a new place that she could not recognize.

After the storm passed, she found herself all bruised and bloodied. Her pieces scattered around the ground where she stood. It took her years to

collect the pieces and make sense of the damages and then fix them the best way she could. Her whole internal structure remained broken and worked only for the requirements. Eating, sleeping, and breathing, but it lacked the strength to stand still and walk straight.

And the third one, which was a bigger version of the second one but a little tweaked. She had some strength to face the world and she could walk for hours without delving deep into it. Afraid of the storm, she would keep a distance and would take her steps cautiously. Her eyes looked for any hint of danger around her, she would always be on red alert. Her heart beat fast as if there was an invisible race and it has to win it. Her body was always tired and achy.

The fourth one didn't know whether she should call herself a version of Naina or just an image, an image which could not exist on its own. There was nothing real about her. She was like an illusion to the world. She appeared alive from a distance. She laughed, cried, and breathed but would crumble the moment you reached near her. Even before being touched she would deconstruct herself and her pieces would lie on the floor.

And she would reconstruct herself again once you took your steps back and looked at her from afar again. She would be all functional and living once again.

Naina would often think about the different versions, and try to connect them on a single stream. She would try to find in them similarities which could at the least prove that they all belonged to a single entity. But, no matter how much she tried, they would remain different. It was as if a different person replaced her for the time being within her own body and she did not know that until she looked back at her journey.

That night, when the door did not open after many attempts, Naina came back to her bed and tried to sleep. But she woke up again, this time to the sound of whispers. Somebody was talking in a low tone very close to her. She opened her eyes and she saw a silhouette of a man standing next to her grandmother's bed. Her grandmother was seating on the bed saying something to him.

“You don’t have any shame. Now all the kids have grown up and have their children and you have that thing still in your mind,” she said, anger and frustration clear in her sharp whispers.

“Where should I go then? Outside, tell me? Now, keep your mouth shut and move. It’s going to take only five minutes,” that figure said.

Naina kept her head down. Something in her was telling her that she should not witness this, that that conversation was not for her. Her grandmother shifted in her bed and her grandfather joined her.

The images changed in darkness in front of her but she could not make anything out of them. What was happening? She had seen her grandmother, messaging her grandfather’s feet, shoulders, and arms. But she had never anything resembling this picture which her eyes had in front of her.

He heard her grandfather make a heavy sound as if something was hurting him and he could not bear the pain of it. ‘Maybe he is hurt or unwell,’ she thought to herself. Afterwards, her grandfather came back to his bed and lay down. She saw him pulling a bed sheet over him and turning on his right side, his legs folded and knees out. Some shuffling happened at her grandmother’s bed also. Grandmother’s hands were searching for something in the darkness. After a while, she took her dupatta and covered her head and went out. Naina strained her neck to see where she went. She couldn’t see but heard water splashing.

‘Ohhhhhh....Bathroom!’ After she came back, Naina waited for something else to happen which could help her understand what had just happened. But after that, there was no sound and she did not remember when she slept off.

The incident came and went at regular intervals. She often found her grandfather waking up at night, roaming in the room without any purpose. Sometimes, she woke up to the same weird sound coming from her grandmother’s bed. Once, she asked her grandmother about it, but the grandmother yelled at her so hard that Naina ran away from there. And then she never dared to speak of it again. Her grandmother remained angry at her

for a long time after that. She even told about it to her father, for he called her and scolded her for the same.

“Kids, should not ask stupid questions to their elders. Understood! You are a grown-up girl now. You should keep your mouth shut when you don’t know anything. UNDERSTOOD?” he had said pointing his index finger at her.

Her mother was standing and her grandmother was sitting next to him. Grandmother’s eyes were on Naina’s face as if she was seeing the words from his mouth reaching her head and then getting saved somewhere and she wanted to make sure that they reached their proper place.

At the age of eight, Naina didn’t bother with any kind of anger until someone did not raise their hands on her. It was all good, nothing stuck on her. But little did she know that the dynamics were changing and things around her had started closing. Soon there will be no way to run away, and there will be no place to hide.

A few days later, she woke up suddenly. After her question to her Dadi, her place on the cots was changed. Now she slept on the bed next to her aunt. And Raghav started sleeping next to his grandmother. One night when she opened her eyes, she saw her grandmother slapping Raghav on his back vigorously while Raghav was gazing at her. His eyes were angry and fixed on his grandmother’s face as if he did not recognize her. He was doing something beneath his sheet. His bed sheet was moving up and down frantically. With every slap, he increased his speed but did not move his eyes.

Naina could not understand why her Dadi was beating Raghav at a late hour. What made her do that?

‘Did Raghav steal money from her Pallu?’ she thought to herself. She kept staring at them all confused.

“What are you looking at?” Dadi scolded her.

Naina lay down again and turned over. She overheard her Dadi abusing him till she went to sleep again.

“Kutta, Kamina, Haramzada.....! Fire of the whole world running in his body!”

Baby Naina was about to break her cocoon. She was on the verge of being a girl. There were so many things taking place around her. She was seeing things which she did not understand.

Mentally as well as physically, everything was changing. But she could not ask anything to anybody. She did not have the idea that she needed to ask anyone, nor did anybody care to tell her anything about those changes. She always wondered why everybody pretended as if they knew everything and, they did not need to tell anything to their children.

On top, everything remained the same, but inside her, she was changing with every passing minute.

Raghav was her cousin, the son of her eldest uncle. He was two years elder than her. Though there was not much of a difference in their age, Raghav's build was more like a grown-up man. At the age of 11, he looked like 16. He had grown strong and tall last summer. In the last few months, he had grown up like a tree. Naina remained thin as a stick.

‘What was he doing between his legs?’ she kept thinking the next whole day. When she met Raghav, he tried to escape her eyes, but Naina could not hold her curiosity and asked him, “What were you doing last night? Why did Dadi beat you? Did you steal her money?”

“No.....! ” he answered sternly, trying to hide his embarrassment.

Naina did not push the question further. She missed the earlier version of this cousin of hers. Though he did not tell her anything, at least didn't raise his hand at her. She could at least ask him anything without the fear of being beaten in the street.

But she didn't like this version of Raghav. He was very distant and different. Though Naina did not know what was different about him, she could tell in his presence that he had changed. He always bullied her. The softer edge in him had gone. They were in the same school. He was the tallest and strongest boy in the class. He would beat up anybody at any time without any reason. This new power in his body was making him crazy. It was good when he was small and more like a normal child. Naina would play with him and would share her food with him. She would share with him the money which she found while doing her daily search of the house at noon. But this change had turned him into something else, a different person altogether. All his concerns towards her had died as he had grown up.

It was Sunday noon after she had finished her cleaning chores. It usually took her half of the day to finish all the orders. By the time she would finish bathing and eating lunch, her friends would have disappeared from the street. Their mothers would have called them in the noon to take a rest or for their help in spreading the papad, chillies, and green mango slices on roofs to make pickles.

There would be no one except boys on the streets to play with her when she would come out. All the rush and activities would have had to die down. All the serenity and coolness of the Sunday mornings would have disappeared and it seemed that the Sun was dragging itself in the sky. Moving a little, then stopping, and then moving again, as if it was also tired and wanted to rest. Naina would spend her noon wandering in the house, checking all the drawers and shelves one by one. She would run her fingers beneath the newspapers that were spread on the shelves for protecting them from dust and stain. She had seen her grandmother and mother keep coins under them. Her eyes were looking for them. From one room to another, she would tip-toe and open the almirahs swiftly without making any noise. Her mother and aunts would be sleeping in there, shedding off the tiredness of the morning chores and getting ready for evening's chores. Fans and coolers running at the full speed were the only sound she could hear in the house.

That day her eyes twinkled with happiness when she found a one-rupee coin on the kitchen shelf. She put the coin carefully in her pocket like a

treasure.

After scanning the veranda, she quickly came out of the home and ran hurriedly to the local grocery shop.

A wide smile was sitting on her lips while thinking about the things that she could buy with that rupee.

Aam papad?? No.....No!’ she thought of the tangy taste. She felt the tangy sensation around her cheeks. She closed her eyes and shook her head to wish away that image. Pictures of everything were so clear in her mind that she could taste different flavours on her tongue. Her mouth watered whenever the picture changed.

‘Toffee?’ Taste of burnt chocolate. ‘No.. .NO’

‘Kachri?’ A salty taste in her mouth. ‘Haan... I’ll buy Kachri.....’

She imagined the crunch in her mouth. ‘No. NO.’

‘Sweet Badam?’ Something soft melted in her mouth. Not too sweet nor too salty.

‘Haan, I’ll have a sweet Badam.’ She imagined how it would feel between her teeth when she would bite it. Stuff would stick on her teeth and then she would use her tongue to get rid of the feeling.

When she reached the shop, the shopkeeper was sleeping on the floor. Boxes full of candies stood at the front. On a string from one corner of the shop to the other, colourful strips of various kinds of chips and wafers were hanging. It reminded her of the clothesline at home, washed wet clothes hanging on it. To her right, there stood a small fridge with a glass door. Colourful bottles of cold drinks in them were looking at her as if challenging her to touch them.

Naina stood still there, her mind busy eating Uncle Chips and her eyes having a treat. She smiled a little wider at seeing different kinds of chocolates, candies, and biscuits in front of her. She thought of stealing

something before the shopkeeper woke up. She could easily open the jar slowly, grab a handful of candies in her fist, and then put them in her pocket. She could run quickly before he could catch her and she would not have to spend even that one rupee.

Her fingers were moving in her pocket when she was thinking all this as if struggling hard to stop themselves from acting, but still waiting for orders from the mind.

“Yes, what do you want?” The shopkeeper’s voice startled her before she could act on her secret mission. She had not noticed when he had got up and come forward.

“Kya chahiye?” asked the shopkeeper again, with a sharp tone this time. Interference in his sleep had made him a bit cranky.

“Ek Kachri, Bhaiyya,” she replied when she came out of her world and handed over the coin to the shopkeeper.

“No..., No.....! Two sweet Badam,” she stopped the shopkeeper in the middle while he was tearing the Kachri packet from its trail standing near the string. He looked at her, sleep, and anger visible in his eyes. He would have slapped her had she been his daughter. Naina knew that look. Her uncle had it on him so many times.

He opened the jar on the front row and took out two coinsize white candies from it. He put them in brown paper, rolled it and passed it to Naina. She opened the wrapper and checked the contents. Both candies had a brown streak in the middle of them. They looked bigger in her tiny palms. She rolled the paper again, looked up at the shopkeeper, threw a delightful smile at him, and then ran back towards her home. She wanted to eat it on the roof, hidden from everybody; where she did not have to share it.

On her way back home, she saw Raghav, playing with his friends. She had not seen his face but she could tell him by his size. He was the tallest amongst all of them. Naina didn’t want him to see her. She slowed her steps and tried to escape his eyes. She turned back slowly with silent steps. But

before she could run, she heard running footsteps behind her. Raghav had already seen her and was now chasing her.

“Ohh..... Kutiya, Kamini!!!” He shouted. His hands closed in fists came to the front and then went back in rhythm with his.

Naina ran without looking back and pretended as if she did not hear him at all.

Raghav chased her through a few streets and finally got hold of her at the back of her shirt's collar. Naina stumbled on her steps but then balanced herself before stopping.

As she turned, Raghav slapped her across the face. His other hand gripped her neck.

“What are you doing here? Why are you running?” He asked with a long snort. His breath was still fast due to the running and chasing.

She could not reply, as Raghav was nearly choking her. She clenched the Badam in her palms behind her back and let out a dry cough when Raghav freed her from his grip.

“What are you hiding? Show me!!” He asked, his hands reaching to her back to grab her hands to see what she was hiding.

“Nothing! It's not yours.”

“Give me that, I say,” roared Raghav.

“Noooo...., I bought them.”

Raghav twisted her hand and tried to slide his finger into her fist to open it. She clenched her fists more tightly and did not let go of them. After several trials of scratching and biting her hand, Raghav pulled her hair in frustration.

“GIVE ME....!” he roared, his friends laughing at them from behind. Naina didn't know whether their laughter was directed at him or her. But in both

cases, it was hurting her.

“Leave me!!! Kuttey....yyyyy!” she said, twisting her fist in his grip. She pinched his skin with another hand, trying to stop him, but it seemed that it didn’t affect him. Her tiny pinches were not capable enough to save her. He kept twisting her fist.

“No....., these are mine.” she snapped.

Raghav slapped her hard 3-4 times. She felt the jolt on her jaw but did not give up. Raghav twisted her wrist violently this time, and her fist opened with a shriek from her mouth. He took the brown paper. Badams in it were all crushed and their juice had left a wet stain on it.

“Now get lost. Go straight home before I kick you” he said while pushing her.

Naina stood there, still, breathing heavily. She wanted to yell at him, but she could not. Naina’s face had turned crimson due to Raghav’s finger marks and the heat of her anger. She wanted to twist Raghav’s wrist the same way, but she could not. She felt as if her head’s nerves would burst. She was trembling with anger but her lips did not utter a word.

She knew she could not say anything to the elders or raise her hand at them. It was different with elders, but Raghav! He was her brother. He was supposed to love her. He was supposed to protect her from others.

When Naina did not leave, Raghav again pulled her hair and dragged her home. He pulled it so hard that Naina felt as if her hair would come out from her scalp. This time, she did not plead with him to stop, instead, she chose to fight back. She scratched his hands and tried to free herself, but she could not.

Some people on the way laughed, some ignored, but nobody intervened. Nobody even tried to stop Raghav. It was a normal scene for them. Raghav used to beat her whenever he wanted and wherever he wanted. By this he would show off his new gained strength to his friends and Naina could not

do anything except cry. But today he crossed all his limits. He had never hit her like this.

It was not her helplessness or want of strength that made her cry. It was her need for love that was making her cry. She could not understand why her brother used his power to rule over her. What was wrong with her that nobody ever talked to her with love? Why was she not special to anyone?

Naina spent the rest of the day wandering around. Her head was still aching due to all the pulling of her hair. Usually, she would wander the streets with excitement and curiosity in her eyes. But today, her eyes were directionless and her steps were slow. She wanted to rest, wanted to sleep for a while, but the feeling of going home seemed less interesting. She did not want to face anybody.

She met Raghav again at dinner time, when he was boasting about his strengths to other cousins. Everybody laughed aloud when they spotted her entering the room.

“Oye, ask her how were the Badam?” Raghav said to others and then continued, “Come on! Ask her..... Ask her. It’ll be fun.”

“Naina..... How were the Badams? Mummy Naina won’t eat

Roti today, she ate a lot of Badam in the noon.” And they burst into laughter.

Naina did not say anything. Somehow, there was nothing she wanted to say. She stayed silent all through the dinner. She went to sleep early. There was no other way she could avoid the confrontation.

She lay down and closed her eyes, but sleep was miles away from her eyes. All the tiredness came alive when her back touched the soft mattress. The feeling of relief was so overwhelming that tears pooled in her eyes, the only good thing that had happened to her that day.

She felt uneasy and kept tossing and turning on her bed. That was the first time when she had felt that way. Otherwise, before sleeping, she would talk

to herself. Sometimes she would imitate the slow news reader she had seen on TV, sometimes she would imitate her teacher, teaching the imaginary class. But today she did not feel like playing with her imaginary friends. She covered her face when everybody came into the room to sleep.

“Arey! Pagal Ghodi is asleep so early?” She heard her grandmother. She followed the sounds and guessed what was happening in the room. Somebody had spilt water, steel glass tumbled on the floor.

Her aunt and her cousin talked for some time before their voices faded. Her grandfather coughed and turned his cot. It creaked every time he changed sides. After hours of struggle, she did not know when sleep conquered her.

It was later that night when she felt something slipping inside her shirt. Something was crawling inside like an insect. A rough touch on her chest. Scared, she opened her eyes and saw her grandfather standing next to her cot and then he ran back towards his cot. She could not comprehend what did happen. But she understood it years later. The unknown reason for his grandfather running across the room, she understood it whenever she revisited that night or when that night haunted her.

Naina could not name the feeling she felt that night. Her baby mind could not understand that strange feeling, but that was the night when restlessness took over her, and then never left her. That was the night which broke something inside her, although she did not realize it that night. Those incidents left a crevice inside her. The words and touch stayed permanently on her skin and heart. They got glued to her and she found herself thinking about them now and then.

CHAPTER

■

15

■

Every word every touch

every thought which I did not accept

stayed on my skin like a living insect.

Her skin was papery and wrinkled. Naina pulled her skin in a pinch and stretched until Haree winced. She lowered her head, moving it left and right to have a closer look at it. With the wrinkles going up, it looked like a big tent being held by innumerable ropes around it. She giggled when the skin went back to its place, leaving a whitish mark on it after she released her pinch.

“Why is your skin like that?” she asked, looking at her, her eyes half closed due to the harsh sun of June... Sitting cross-legged in front of Haree with her hands in the triangle between her thighs, Naina looked at her face carefully. Deep lines around her eyes like spikes coming out of them, skin gathered on her upper lips, and the lines on her face were so deep. It seemed as if someone had taken a fork and carved them with force on her skin.

Naina got up and hunched over her face, her palms resting on her small knees. She moved Haree’s face to right and then to left with her four fingers. She observed her cheeks and bulges under her eyes. One of her eyes was blue. She poked her index finger in the bulge but pulled it back immediately when she heard a shrill cry of pain.

Naina looked at the blue colour on Haree's face, starting from under her right eye and running down towards her cheek. Haree stayed still like an obedient subject of art. She let Naina look at her, do with her face whatever she wanted. When her palm touched her cheek, Haree closed her eyes to let the feeling of touch go deep inside her. Naina moved her finger one by one on the wrinkles, counting them aloud, "1..2..3...4..5...6....."

"Forty-two! You have forty-two lines on your face," she said with a puff, sitting again cross-legged.

Haree looked at her with those blank eyes, listening to her speak but not understanding what she was saying. Her language was alien to her.

"Forty-two....." Haree repeated in her mouth. Naina had always found her repeating her words, and whenever she did that, Naina giggled, hiding her mouth with both hands.

They were sitting on the floor on the veranda. The same veranda where Haree and Ram used to sit when it used to rain and he would sometimes come home early for evening tea. The rooms around had turned old and rusty. Layers of paint and cement had come off from many places. A hundred-watt bulb hung on the hook on the door of her bedroom, the hook where Ram used to tuck the lantern. A long line of two wires, red and black, braided together in one, ran from the veranda to the kitchen where she slept at night.

Her bedroom was in the middle of the row of rooms. To its right was the room that belonged to her Mother in law. The rooms to the left belonged to Ashok and Ravi. All the rooms, which used to be filled with beds, almirahs, and children's toys, were empty now. Doors and shelves were layered with dust, not been washed for years. Spider webs of length larger than a full arm hung at the corners of the ceiling. Iron bars of the window had turned reddish brown with years of rust, flakes of which would fall when you moved your hand over them.

Haree was now living all alone in that empty house. Even with those many rooms there, she slept in that old kitchen., which has turned its entire room. At night, she could hear her breathe clearly, the only noise in the house. On

the first night alone in the house, she had woken up many times. Every little sound sent chills through her bones.

Her only possessions were an old trunk, a few skirts, and a few old shirts that the villagers had thrown at her while crossing her house, an old photo of Ram, and his diary - torn at corners. Its papers were coming out. Threads had turned yellow and dark. Some of the words on the pages inside it had disappeared completely. Paper had turned a little grey as if somebody had been rubbing a finger on them and the grey lead had got spread into one messy drawing. Pages where Ram had used a pen looked different. They were old, but still alive. His poetry was on the corners in the last pages, the skewed words still readable.

Outside the veranda, there was an open section for the cattle. A tapestry of blue colour covered it. But there were no cattle now to take care. They had either been sold or died a few years after the demise of Ram. Ashok and Ravi had refused to take care of them and their parents did not have the strength to take care of the cattle.

“We did not get our degrees to clean the shit of these animals. They stink. Their piss flows like water on the floor.” Ashok said one day, declaring his decision, “I can’t let my children grow here in this mess. “

Ram’s father looked at him with his ageing eyes. He did not have anything to say, and he knew that even if he had, he did not have the authority to say it. The relationship of respect and control that he had with Ram, did not have with the other two sons.

He was a mere figurine in the house now, moving aimlessly here and there, without any contribution and hold in the family.

The family started breaking down right after the death of Ram. There was invisible chaos in everybody’s life. The anchor that held them together had vanished, and they were all floating in different directions. Everybody trying to survive and catch their breath, clueless about the next destination, kept drifting apart. Ashok was the first one to get loose from them.

He was not ready to take over the farming business of the family. The things that Ram had created; he did not want to continue.

“There is nothing in farming. I think we should sell the property and open a grocery shop in the market,” he said one night while having dinner. His wife was serving food, she looked at him and gave a wide smile under her veil. But Ashok saw it.

“Baba..... are you listening?” he said to his father when he did not respond. His father was thinking about the day he had fought with Ram to let go of farming and concentrate on his studies.

It had been difficult for him to see his favourite son sacrifice his life for the family. And now, it hurt him again the same way when he heard his second son tear everything apart.

“Your brother did not die for this,” he said without looking at Ashok, his voice stern and sharp.

Ashok looked at him, his nostrils flaring with heavy breathing.

“So, you want us to die with him? That’s what you want, huh?” he shouted and pushed away his plate. His plate slid on the cement floor and crashed against the wall in the front. Curry in the bowl spilt all over rotis and rice on the plate. From a distance, it looked like leftover food thrown in the dustbin, everything mixed up with everything.

His father looked at Ashok, he was still staring at him like an angry bull. His fists closed tightly and his head jutted a little forward on his shoulders. He thought about Ram, how he never looked directly in his eyes.

“Do whatever you want to do once I die,” he said and left the kitchen.

“Ohh.....! Then I wish, we see that blessed day soon.” Ashok hissed, motioning his wife to bring another plate for him.

Later that night on his bed, Ram’s father cried like a baby, his shoulders moving and up down with his heavy sobs. He had not cried even on the day

of Ram's death. He remained restrained and strong for his other sons and family. But that night, he realised that he was not strong enough to take that burden. That he was not able to fill the emptiness Ram had left. He cried over his incompetence and his ultimate and the most fatal loss. A loss he could never recover from. He missed Ram's silent yet profound presence in the house. He missed his words of endearment and concern. How he used to come and check on him every night before going to bed.

Ram always enquired about his food and medicines. A jug of water was always placed at his bedside.

He cried for all those instances and he saw him in all those spaces.

After that day, he cried many times, on many occasions. When he saw his family breaking and spilling on the floor like beads, sitting on his cot, he would look around, and press the ends of his towel to the corners of his eyes to wipe them.

The ambience of the house changed fast with time. From free and fresh whiff of air, it turned into stifled and suffocated. Ashok became the new owner of the house. He would come drunk every night and then would create chaos on every small thing. Once he beat her wife when she refused to serve him food. She was one month pregnant with their first child. That day, when everybody had retired to their rooms, his wife was waiting for him to come. She had kept the fire alive in the hearth to make hot chapattis as soon as he came. She sat in the kitchen, with her back leaning against the wall. She had dozed off and when she opened her eyes; it was late. She looked outside, everything was dark and silent. The fire in the hearth was about to die. She put some wood dust and kerosene oil in it to revive it.

She took long breaths while blowing into it.

After making four chapattis, she took out the extra woods from the hearth and poured water on them, keeping them in one corner of the kitchen. She put some curry in a bowl and ghee-soaked chapattis on a plate, covered it with another and kept it near the fireplace, whose sides were still hot.

When Ashok came that night, he kept yelling her name until she came out and opened the door for him.

“What took you so long to open? Huh? Betichod...” he said, coming inside. His wife stepped aside the door to let him in and then bolted the door again behind him.

“Was your father fucking you, that you took so much time to open the door?” he shouted again.

She quickly disappeared from his way and went into the kitchen. He came stumbling behind her and sat on the floor.

He picked up a chapatti from the plate, tore it into two pieces and threw them at her. Pieces of chapatti brushed against her nose before landing on the floor.

“I am not a dog, that I’ll eat stale food. Go feed you Baap this shit.”

“They are not stale, they are fres..... aaaahhhh.”

He pulled her hair and gave her a big push.

“Don’t argue with me, tell your Baap all this. He will listen to your shit. Get up and make food again.” he shouted motioning her to get up.

“But I have just made them. The fire is also out,” she said, covering her head with her shawl that had slipped while she had fallen.

“Keep your mouth shut,” he charged at her with the full flow now, kicking her stomach again and again, “Don’t try to sit on my head.” He kept yelling and kicking until her cries reached every room and her parents and Ravi came out running to the kitchen.

Haree was already there when they came out. She had been there all the time, shivering in her place. Her hands crossed around her belly, like Ashok’s wife as if she was also feeling the blows, her eyes open wide and face wet with tears.

It took two men's strength to stop Ashok. When Ravi tried to stop him, he slapped and pushed him and when his father came to stop him, he pushed him as well. He raised his hand high in the air, eyes blood red and fiery, looking at the old face of his father.

"Yes! Beat me as well," his father said, trying to stop him. "Beat everyone, put some oil on us and then set this house on fire."

Ashok stared at him and then gave a final kick to his wife. It landed directly on her lower abdomen. She was not prepared for it. Not anticipating this final attack, she had removed her hands from her stomach, thinking that his anger had subsided. But when his last blow came and hit her, she felt a sharp pain in her pelvis and abdomen. She let out a horrible howl. Her body twisted on the floor; her legs folded with her knees touching her upper half. Clutching her stomach, she remained still there for a while, waiting for the pain to disappear, praying for her unborn baby.

Ravi and his mother helped her to get up. Holding her hands on their shoulders, they slowly helped her towards her room. She let a feeble cry at every step. The area above her vagina hurt with the slightest movement. Her mother-in-law tucked her into her bed and raised a bed sheet up to her chest.

The next day, everybody woke up to a sharp shriek followed by a series of violent wails. Ravi and his mother found her in a pool of blood. Half of the bed sheet beneath her was red, blood had dried up a little at the corners. Her skirt was soaked in blood, she must have been bleeding since that last kick.

It took Haree hours to clean the blood-stained white bed sheet. Her arms went sore. She had to stop from time to time to relax it. The red water in the bucket made her sick. She puked. Then she brushed the bed-sheet hard again to remove the stains. When she spread the bedsheet on the clothesline, she could see a yellow circle in the middle of it. The stain that blood had left was now permanent. Later that evening, when she went outside to collect the dried-up clothes, that yellow mark turned red again in her vision. She could see it growing from the middle and then slowly reaching the end, growing darker and darker.

CHAPTER

■

16

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Nobody told me where the devil lived.

I found him hidden in a human whom I believed.

Naina was six years old when she met Haree for the first time.

She was running with other children in the street after throwing stones at her. It was the new game for the children in the street. A few days back, a group of boys started this.

Naina did not know why they started it. One day, she heard a rush on the street and came running to her porch. A group of young boys was running in the street, laughing, and dodging stones coming hurling at them. She looked at them with her curious eyes, craning her head left and right, trying to understand what was that made them so happy and thrilled. Their loud juvenile laughter filled her heart with excitement.

Naina looked towards the other side of the street. An old woman was trying to run with hurried steps. She was throwing tiny stones at the children, but all of them landed here and there. She had a hunched back and was walking with the support of a stick in her hand. When the stones in her hand got exhausted, she picked up a handful again from the street and started throwing with her shaky hands. Boys laughed and clapped hooting her on every failed attempt of hers. When her slow step could not chase them, she cursed them and turned back towards her house.

Suddenly, a stone came from the boys' side and hit on her back. Naina looked at the boys, one of them was laughing and clapping. Standing on the porch of her house, Naina also clapped with him and jumped with excitement. It was the most entertaining game she had ever seen. Since then she would join the gang of boys, running and laughing behind them. She would join the crowd when it passed her street, but she never threw stones at the old lady. She would collect small stones and pass them to the boys. Nobody asked her to do it but she had self-volunteered for it. She collected small stones and pieces of bricks in the evening itself and kept a small heap ready for the next day.

One day, while running away, a boy turned and threw a stone at Haree, but it landed on a young boy who was running behind them. It hit him on the bridge of his nose. He let out a scream and cupped his nose with both hands. Haree was coming behind throwing stones at them but stopped when she saw a boy crying. Blood had started oozing from both nostrils and was dripping through gaps in his fingers. There was blood on his lips and when he talked, it ran on his gums and creaks of the teeth. It looked like he had eaten paan and that had stained his lips and teeth.

“Hayeeeeeee! What happened to my son?”

His mother came running into the street. Somebody had told her about the accident.

“Kutiya, Pagal Budhiya!” she hissed at Haree, who was standing there with her hand on her hunched back. Her white hair, unkempt and dirty, was coming out of braids. She blinked her eyes a few times, her white eyelashes joining and opening again and again. Naina looked at her, at her face tiny face, that looked as though it had shrunk and extra skin sagged there in layers.

This was the first time she had looked so closely at Haree. Before that, for Naina, she was just a silhouette, with hands and legs that moved slowly and stopped frequently. A silhouette without any feature on her face!

“Next time you touch my son, I’ll cut you in pieces and feed to street dogs,” the mother of the boy hissed at Haree. Haree kept staring at her as if trying

hard to understand her words but was not able to understand anything. After a while, she looked away and turned back. That woman punched her hard on her back. Haree stumbled on her feet and fell on the street face down.

Naina heard the thud of her head banging the concrete. Her stick tumbled away and fell in front of Naina. Naina felt the same pain that she had felt when the other day Raghav had dragged her on the street. Her eyes pooled up with tears on that memory. The boy and his mother disappeared quickly from the street. It took Haree time to get up on her knees and then to stand. She kept her one hand on the knee and the other on the ground for support. There was no way she could get up quickly.

Naina ran and picked up her stick. She was waiting for Haree to throw a stone at her, but then she saw tears coming out of the white lashes. She came forward a little and offered the stick, stretching her arm. Naina saw a few scratches under the mount thumb when Haree spread her hand to take the stick. Red skin was coming out from those scratches.

She saw Haree moving with slow steps towards her. Naina moved aside in fright, but Haree walked past her without even looking at her. Standing there, Naina looked at her, turning towards her house, her stick clicking on the ground with every step.

Naina spent her noon searching for something in the drawers of dressing tables and TV shelves. She searched for it everywhere but could not find it. She ran towards the stairs, taking leaps two stairs at a time. She found a white finger-sized tube inside his father's closet. She looked at it, turned it around, and then checked it again. 'Yes, this is the cream father applies whenever he cuts himself while shaving, or mother cuts her fingers while working in the kitchen.'

She ran again, jumping two stairs at a time and came on the street again, barefoot. There was nobody to stop her, yet she looked around to check if someone from her family had seen her.

She took a turn at the corner and ran like a horse on the street, squinting her eyes when sunrays entered them. She had never been to Haree's house

before, but she knew where she lived. She had learnt the way to Haree's home in the last few days while running with the boys.

Haree lived in her old house, four streets away from Naina's, just a few minutes' walk. It was a small street where Haree lived and was not open on both sides. When Naina turned inside it, she could see the brick wall at the other end. She pulled her salwar up, up to her calves, and then moved with slow steps, jumping amidst the pool of garbage and dirty water the residents threw on it. The stink was unbearable. She held her breath for some time but had to let go when she could not hold it further. She took a long breath and the smell of shit and garbage filled her nostrils.

Haree was sitting on her veranda when Naina reached the entrance. There was no door. It was more of a muddy passage which opened on the veranda. Naina craned her neck to peep inside. Her eyes moved from one corner to another to check if there was a heap of big stones that Haree could use to crush her head. She had heard stories about her, that she kidnapped kids and killed them and there was a room full of baby skeletons in her house. And that is why the boys threw stones at her, to keep her away from the streets, away from kidnapping children.

Haree was sitting with her skirt pulled up to her knees. There were scratches on her legs as well, more horrible than her hands. She was wiping the blood with a dirty piece of cloth. There were many bandages of the same piece of cloth on her calves. Looking at her, Naina thought about the days she chased her and boys threw stones at her. Sometimes the stones hit her on her legs, back and chest. Naina had not realised her pain at that time, but today when she was seeing her clean her wounds, she understood the reason for her slow walk and why she could not run at them.

A tiny stone came flying at her and landed a few feet before her. Even if it would have hit her, it would not have hurt her. She walked a few steps forward and then stopped to see Haree's reaction. Haree picked one more stone and threw it at her, but it also landed short. She did not have the force to reach her or maybe she just wanted to scare Naina.

Naina took some more steps and threw the white antiseptic cream toward Haree. It landed beside her. Haree looked at the tube and then looked at

Naina. She blinked her eyes the same way as she had when that woman was scolding her. Naina slapped her palm on her forehead and then pointed her index finger towards the cream then touched the area in her palm where Haree had the cut. She rubbed her finger on her other palm showing her how to apply the cream, her eyebrows stretched up expressing the seriousness of her actions.

When Haree did not follow her, she ran towards her forgetting that she was supposed to be fearful and attentive. Her legs moved as if she had come there many times. She sat down cross-legged on Haree's side. Mud was all around on her legs and in between her toes.

“Apppppplllllyyyyy..... thhiiss!” she said in a high-pitched voice followed by the motion which she was showing her before as if Haree was deaf and could only understand her gestures.

Haree didn't move.

Naina pinched the tube in the middle. White paste spilt on her finger bud. She moved her finger up and down to apply the cream to her both knees. Haree kept her gaze at the distance when she blew air on both of her knees. By the time Naina finished applying the cream on all her wounds, on her calves and palms, the cream was finished. The tube had flat due to the pressure of her fingers on it.

She gave a final look at Haree's legs, there were seven white spots on them., two on both knees and one on her right ankle and two on the toes of her left foot. Naina wondered which stone of hers had hurt her there. Her toes were red and swollen, two nails tore from the skin.

“I ... will ... come.... Tomorrow...,” she said standing up, moving and gesturing her hands in different ways to make Haree understand what she was saying. But Haree looked somewhere else, her eyes wide open with that same seriousness. And then she flew the fly sitting on her wounds.

Before leaving, Naina took a quick tour of the house. She peeped into each room through the doors and windows looking for the room with skeletons. There was nothing in any room, every shelf was empty and dusty. When she

reached the kitchen, she found an old rusty trunk in one corner with a red diary sitting on it. There was a green torn mat on the floor with a crumpled bed sheet on it.

On the shelves, there were no jars filled with pulses and spices like she had seen in her house, no basket of potatoes and onions in the corner. There were just a steel jug, a glass, and a small plate there. She entered the kitchen to have a closer look, and to find something to eat, but there was none. It smelt of stale dust and piss. She quickly came out and ran away waving at Haree on her way out. To her surprise, Haree waved back at her. Naina stopped and looked at her with astonishment, whether she was mocking her or waving at her. She could not tell.

After that day, it became her daily routine to visit Haree. Sometimes, she found her sitting on the veranda, napping on her mat, and sometimes sitting ideal with her back leaning against the wall, her eyes closed. Naina always stopped at the entrance and threw a stone at her to inform her about her arrival before entering inside. Then she would wait patiently, looking closely at her hands to check if they were moving to pick a stone or her stick. She would enter when Haree opened her eyes and looked at her. On many occasions, she brought, rolled in newspaper, chapattis with curry smeared on them. Sometimes Haree would eat them silently, but sometimes, she won't touch the food at all. She would just let Naina sit with her without saying anything. Naina would take out her notebook and pencil and draw faces on them and show them to her. Haree looked at them and then moved her eyes again to somewhere beyond the horizon.

It was during one of those visits, that she said something to Naina in whispers.

“Devil is coming.”

Naina did not understand anything and she looked at her with confusion in her eyes, waiting for her to say it again.

“Devil.....!” Haree whispered again.

“Hain.... Kya??” Naina brought both her palms open in front of Haree and made a gesture which said “What?”

Keeping her hands like that she followed Haree’s eyes, which were focused on the entrance of the house. Haree suddenly grabbed Naina’s hand and made her sit beside her. She spread her shawl over her and tried to cover her with it. Naina screamed and sprung to her feet. Her breath racing, she tried to look for the knife or stone with which Haree was going to kill her. But there was none around. Haree was still staring at the entrance, her hands moving in the air to catch Naina’s hand again and hide her. Naina took two steps back, picked up her bag, and left.

Haree started throwing stones in the direction of the entrance. Naina dodged them and ran, clutching the straps of her bag with both hands on her shoulders. Haree kept throwing stones even after Naina had disappeared from there. Her eyes were watery and full of scare had an image, a blurry image which did not disappear till late at night. Haree turned her back towards it but kept looking back now and then.

“Madarchod.....Betichod!” she yelled, picked up a big piece of brick and threw it at the image, but it did not move.

The next day, Naina came to meet her again after school. She threw a small pebble at Haree, who was sitting with her back towards the entrance. The image had entered her house, it was sitting at some distance from the gate. When Haree saw the pebble, she moved her neck only to look at the entrance with one eye. Her eyes widened when she found Naina standing there, she turned her eyes towards that image and then picked a stone and threw it at Naina.

“Bhag yahan se,” she yelled, “Don’t come to my house. Both of you!”

She kept throwing stones that fell a few feet away from Naina until she left with trembling lips and watery eyes. Haree was the latest one who had disowned her.

When Naina reached her home, she threw her shoes and bag and went straight to the terrace. She sat on the floor, hid her head in her knees, and

then cried for hours. Her shoulders moved with her sobs. It was the first time that she had cried without having any physical pain. This time, the pain was somewhere else. She could not tell where. She wanted her tears to stop, but they kept pouring and with them, her sobs became heavier and more frequent. Those were tears of being disowned and distrusted. She cried until her eyes burned and she could feel that they were swollen. Her eyelids become heavy with the weight of overworked muscles.

At night, when Naina thought of Haree, she decided to never visit her again. The love which she had had for her turned into anger. She wished Haree to die at that moment. “Saalee.... Behri Budhiya...,” she murmured, “You will die at my hands tomorrow.” talking to her invisible audience in the dark.

The next day, when she reached Haree’s entrance, Naina picked a pebble and threw it. When there was no movement, she picked up the red piece of brick which Haree had thrown at her yesterday. She removed the straps of her bag from both shoulders, and put the bag carefully against the wall as if there was some fragile glassware in it that could break with impact.

Haree was lying at the same spot where she had seen her the previous day. She looked at the brick once again, thinking to change it with a small pebble, but then she spontaneously pulled her hand back and threw the brick with full force straight at Haree. She felt a strong pull of muscles where her shoulder joined her arms. The pain was so sharp that she had to hold it with her other hand. The brick hit Haree at the back of her head and instantaneously an expression of pain appeared on Naina’s face. She regretted her decision. She stood there for a while, her right hand still clutching her shoulder. Her eyes were trying to read the stillness of Haree.

‘Maybe she is asleep.’ she thought. She imagined Haree opening her eyes to find a bigger piece of brick to throw at her. Naina moved her eyes quickly around the veranda looking for the piece before Haree could find it. But there was nothing which Haree could use to attack her.

When Haree did not move for some time, Naina took a pebble and threw it at her with her left hand. Her right arm was still aching. The pebble

bounced two-three times before stopping at Haree's legs. Her wounds were wrapped with pieces of dirty cloth.

When Haree did not move even after the second pebble, a rush of panic ran through Naina. She thought something was wrong with Haree, but she could not dare to go near her. She quickly picked up her bag and ran without putting it on her shoulders. She ran without looking back, her shoes hitting the concrete in a rhythm. She stopped only when she reached the Baithak of her home. Her grandfather was playing cards with his friend.

Naina put her hands on her knees and breathed hard. The sides of her stomach were hurting with all that running. She thought about the words which she had said last night.

"Sorry, Bhagwan! Sorry Bhagwan!" she joined her hands and looked up at the sky.

It was the next day when villagers found that Haree was dead. Her neighbours came to check when her body had started stinking. They found her lying on her veranda with her face down.

Naina cried uncontrollably, holding her mother. She wished she could tell her mother about what she had done. It was her stone which had killed her, but she did not kill. By night, Naina was burning with fear.

She slept holding her mother. If her mother tried to move, she would tighten her grip around her even in her sleep. It took five days for her fever to come down. She would follow her mother all the day in the kitchen and in the fields. On the seventh day when her mother woke her up for school, all the memories about Haree came back to her. She had not gone to her house after that day. She did not even talk about it when her mother told her that the poor old lady had died.

On her way back home, Naina stopped at the turn which took the street to Haree's house. She stood there, holding her bag's straps with both hands. She looked up at the sun with squinted eyes and then walked towards Haree house. She kept thinking about Haree's last word to her.

‘Bhaag yahan se.....! Don’t come to my house.’

Naina’s eyes pooled up. How could she abandon her like that? She loved her so much that she gave her food and brought medicines. She filled her pot with water every day. ‘How could she do this to me?’ she thought.

When she reached Haree’s house, she heard some noise and some sound of conversation coming from it. She had never seen anybody living with Haree in that house.

Two men were talking standing on her veranda when she entered. One of them looked like a manager, holding a file of papers under his arms. He wore a bright white shirt and black trousers. His manner and way of talking told Naina that he was some officer or somebody who was educated.

Another man was bulky and tall. Though his hair had gone white still, the way he stood showed that he was healthy and looked younger than his age. He had a long moustache which turned up from the corners. He nodded continuously with his hands crossed behind his back when the other man talked. They stopped talking when they saw Naina standing there. She gave them a small and scared smile. Her fingers moved in anticipation over her bag’s straps.

Naina saw the officer-type man leaves. He fumbled with her hair and gave her a soft, admiring smile when he passed her. Naina looked at the tall man on the veranda and widened her smile. He came forward towards her. He picked her up in his bulky arms and smiled back at her.

“Oh...so you have green eyes!” he said, looking at her eyes. Naina giggled and shook her head when he tickled her before putting her back on her feet again.

That was the first time she had met Ashok.

■

*I was fed on abuse,
So much and so profuse,
I had forgotten the taste of love,
And also the taste of my own kindness.*

It was in October, that Veer invited her to his house. His family had gone to a wedding and Veer wanted to show her his house.

Her visit to his house with detailed planning and imagining was the latest topic which they discussed every night.

“The moment you would come, I’ll stop you at the first step of the stair, lift you in my arms and take you to our future room,” he said, one night before their planned meeting.

“I can’t imagine how amazing that would be when I’ll be in your kitchen and will be cooking for you for the first time,” she added, genuinely feeling excited that she was going to her future house.

On her bed, Naina thought about it. The very next day she would finally go to her own house, her future house. She imagined the scene in her mind. How her room would look, how different jars would be set up on the shelves of the kitchen. There would be a swing in the park outside, and she

would sit on it with him. When the breeze would touch her face, she would smile at it, closing her eyes.

She kept thinking about her life after marriage. In that house, she would be loved every minute and she would also pour all her love into her new family, unlike other married girls who never receive the love and respect they yearn.

How many times she had seen girls around her crying and cursing their in-laws? Naina always avoided thinking about her early years. They made her sick. Every time she thought about it her panic returned. After meeting Veer, the panic pangs disappeared. She rarely thought about anything else.

But that day, when she thought about her marriage, everything came back, all those things that she had been avoiding. Things around her that she had been observing but never talked about then to anybody, not even to herself. But no matter how much she tried to be invisible, no matter how much she tried to be ignorant of them, she knew that all those conversations she had eavesdropped on, all those scenes that her eyes had recorded, and all the touches her body had accumulated were always running behind her. Like a hungry beast, ready to swallow her completely once it reached her. She had been running from them for years.

With Veer, she was very far from their reach. When she looked back, that beast looked like a tiny image of its own. She knew that the beast was looking in her direction, spreading its arms and hissing at her from a distance. But she was safe. That beast would never be able to capture her as it did once. At the same time, she was always scared and careful. Naina always made sure to maintain that distance.

Naina turned to her grandma's side, her eyes facing grandma's back. Whenever Naina thought about anything, she turned on her side towards her grandmother. Grandma had turned loving lately. Or maybe Naina had turned calm towards her. She did not mind her bitter words now. Even when she scolded, Naina laughed and hugged her from behind. She always kissed grandma's cheeks before leaving for college. There was a major change over the years. When she was a kid, she was close to her grandfather. She would kiss him every day before leaving for school and he always gave her

a coin of one rupee. He protected her from the scolding her uncle and her grandma, and sometimes even of her aunties. He always came to her rescue. But now, it was her grandmother who was the saviour, the one who fulfilled her whims and desires. Though her grandmother still exhibited the same strictness and discipline, Naina knew that it was merely a drama to make her learn things. Naina had understood it long back.

Looking at her grandmother, she thought about the things which were changing. The thought of getting married and leaving her grandmother was painful, but the anticipation of freedom and love made her stomach flutter. She couldn't wait to get married to Veer and start living her new life.

While growing up, she had always been made to behave beyond her age. She remembered how at eight she was made to behave like an adult, how her father had reprimanded her for not wearing a dupatta, when she had returned from the neighbourhood.

“Next time, don't leave home without your dupatta. Always cover your chest when you step out,” he said.

Naina was just eight years old at the time. She could not understand the meaning of his words. Right in front of him, she looked down at her flat chest and then looked at him in confusion. She wanted to ask, ‘Why? What is wrong with my chest? Why do I need to cover it?’ But something inside her told her that she should not. She could read the unease and seriousness in her father's tone. She understood that he was upset with her, but she did not know why. She left for her room but her father's words and her questions stayed with her forever. They always came back to her whenever she left the house.

Before that, she did not notice that all her aunts, her mother, and other ladies of the village always covered their chests and head. Whenever her aunt went to the market, she saw her taking out a matching stole and wrapping it around her chest before leaving. When Naina started using it, the dupatta kept getting wrapped around her neck and tightening over it. She used to feel choked and she would struggle for breath. One day when she was in the market with her mother, the corner of her stole got stuck in the rear tyre of the cycle, and she was dragged on the road. People shouted

and looked at her as if it was her mistake that she could not use the dupatta properly.

Later in her life, she would come back to that night again and again and would curse herself feeling stupid that at the age of 19, when she should have been thinking about her studies and career, she was planning her marriage. How the conditioning of society had planted that thing in her mind! Her kid mind did not even know that she had outgrown her childhood skipping the normal rate of growth.

She did not know when those painful memories put her to sleep. The next day, when she left her house for college, she felt less connected to her own house. Years of loneliness had made her believe that she never belonged in that house. She felt as if she was talking to a stranger when anybody asked her about something or even when her mother asked her about breakfast. The place where she was living was a house not a home for her. She had always sought relief and acceptance on roads but maybe that day, at least for some time, she would be at her own home.

She left her house, breaking the last connection with it in her mind. Every step distanced her from her roots, from the house where she spent her 19 years, the place which made her feel like some waste piece of furniture, not even a human being. A new bond was sprouting in her heart for her unseen home, where she would live, where she would fill her lungs with freedom and love, and where she won't survive on a handful of breaths. She looked up at the sky, closed her eyes, took a deep breath and thanked God for responding to her prayers.

Veer picked her up from college. Naina's heart was pounding. She didn't know what else was waiting for her. They had never discussed it, but somehow it was obvious to her. For her, it was like the next step or the obvious process that passionate lovers go through. Somewhere back in her mind, she knew it, that it was a thing which no matter whether she likes it or not she had to do to keep her love with her, that it was the only thing which would make any man instantly fall in love with a girl. Maybe if not love, at least sex will make him give some share of his concern or care to her.

She did not talk much on their way home. Veer was upset about something which he did not tell her, and she also did not ask.

“In just 15 minutes you will be at your home.” he gave her a feeble smile and a light pat on her thigh.

This did not make her excited as it should have. She had not slept last night in excitement. Night had seemed very long to her. But now, when she was just 15 minutes away from her dream home, her heart denied itself the happiness for which it had been pumping for so many days. An unknown unease took over her. She wanted that the plan to be changed to some other time. She was not feeling well. But then, she remembered how Veer had reacted on his birthday when he wanted to take her to his friend’s place and she faked vomiting and stomach-ache to run away from there. Veer had kept asking her to have a pill and relax for some time, but she knew that she should not have been there. She should have been somewhere out in public. The eyes of people around her would make the wall of safety around her. Veer kept yelling at her on their way home. He slid his window and threw the cake which he had bought for her.

“Listen, I’ll stop at the entrance of my house lane. First, I’ll go and will open the gate and you come after 5 minutes, Okay?” Veer said looking at her when they turned in his street.

“Don’t make eye contact with anyone. Just go straight and get inside as quickly as you can,” he said while taking the last left turn, and slowing the car he continued, “Here! I’ll drop you here, OK? Can you see that white and brown house? It’s mine.”

He pointed with his finger which Naina followed. Looking at that house Naina half nodded while memorizing in her mind so that she did not enter some other house.

“Now you get down and walk slowly till I reach there. I’ll keep the gate open, Okayyyyyy? Just come inside.” He said, stopping the car.

Naina nodded, scared, and confused. Car locks opened with a click. She got down from the car and his car zoomed off. She saw the car drive to the end

of the street and then turn right. She stood there for a while and then started walking, keeping her head down. It was a lazy noon of October. She looked up at the balconies to see if there was anyone there. There was no one. Even the plants on the balconies were standing still. Yet, she felt as if the whole world was watching her walking towards the fifth house. She continued walking slowly, still keeping her head down, thinking, 'What if someone comes onto the balcony and sees her face?' From the corner of her eyes, she could see a series of beautiful houses, with large gardens and parking areas. But all the cars were parked outside.

She had never seen such beautiful buildings. Her house was also big, but these houses were different. They were more urban and classier as compared to her house. The street was clean and drainage was all covered up. The difference between those buildings from others was the same that she had noticed when she had first seen Veer with his friends in the college. She could not point out what made him stand out from them. And similarly, she could not tell what made these beautiful buildings stand out.

Veer parked his car outside his house like others. He got down trying to be casual, but his whole body was shouting that he was nervous and scared. He dropped the keys twice before he finally could unlock the door of his house. He kept the gate open and went inside. He opened the main door, which led to a little gallery on the left and a staircase on the right.

He stood inside the house and waited for Naina to come. She entered from the iron gate, gave a glance around, and then entered through the main door.

"Did anybody see you?" he asked as he bolted the door behind her.

"NO," she said, wiping the sweat beads on her upper lip and nose.

Veer took her in his arms as he turned towards her. He was acting the same way as they had discussed and imagined multiple times on the phone. But Naina's body, mind and heart were not in sync with what they had discussed. Her body did not recognize his touch, her mind was telling her to leave that place ASAP, but her heart was consoling her that there was nothing right or wrong with being in the arms of her love.

He lifted her and took the stairs. When they were going up, Naina thought about the things which they had planned. They were supposed to see the home first, then Naina would cook for him, and after that, they would head towards his room where she will feed him with her own hands. But apart from that hug which he had given her, nothing happened as they had planned.

He kicked the door and it let them into his room, which they used to refer to as their room. He helped her to her feet. The first thing she noticed in the room was a giant double bed. A fresh bed sheet neatly tucked at corners. The front wall had glass windows but brown coloured curtains on them were completely drawn till the bottom. Sunlight could barely pass through them. Even during the day, the room did not have any sunlight.

There was a huge flat TV on the wall facing the bed. She had never seen a TV that big. The room was cold.

“I had switched on the A.C. when I left to pick you,” he said, noticing her expression as if he could read her mind.

She barely took 4-5 steps ahead. She did not cross even the middle area of the room. Her mind did not want her to stay there, and her heart did not want to leave. She sat on one of the corners of the bed near the room’s door.

“So how is it?” He came to her when he saw that she was not following him when he was showing the bathroom, the almirah, and the room.

“It’s beautiful,” she said, giving a glance at the room.

He sat next to her and placed his hand on the back of her hand that was on her thigh. She squeezed her hand and closed her eyes, her breath turning short but rapid. She felt as if hundreds of ants were creeping up her body. She closed her eyes tightly when he kissed her cheeks. She could feel his warm breath on her neck and his equally warm hand between her thighs. Her body was emitting heat like she was running a high fever.

He turned her face towards his and kissed softly on her lips. Naina did not feel anything sparky when he did that. All those feelings which she had

imagined, flutter in the stomach, the flow of current in the body, all that was a lie which she had been seeing in movies. Girls moaning and closing their eyes as if drowning in some bliss, Naina did not feel anything like that. She felt disgusted. His fluffy lips made her sick in the pit of her stomach. She knew that he wanted her to kiss him back, but her lips remained sealed. She was supposed to feel good; butterflies should have been fluttering in her belly at that moment, and goose bumps should have been all around her body by then. But she was not feeling anything, instead, his touch was hurting her lips, and his fingers were pricking her.

Naina waited for the panic to pass. ‘You will feel better after some time.’ she told herself. ‘He is Veer, not any stranger that you are reacting like this.’ she kept repeating in her head, waiting for her body to react normally as it happens with everyone. She loved him passionately, she knew it, and she wanted to show it as well. But her body did not want to.

When she could not bear his touch any longer, she stood up and said, “I don’t think we should do it. This is not correct. We are not married yet. We shouldn’t be doing it.” Her voice was trembling and fearful.

“What is wrong with you? Whenever I try to come close, you always push me back. Don’t I have any right on you? Do you think I don’t love you, or I am also using you like other boys?” He said in a tone which was not soft, but not harsh either. It was desperate.

She kept looking at him, trying to find words to respond, but they didn’t come. There was a lot to say to him, but she could not. She could have simply walked out of that door, but she did not know why she didn’t leave.

He got up and came over to her.

“I love you Naina,” he said softly, cupping her face in his hands. He leaned to kiss her again on her neck. When he cupped her breasts, she winced somewhere inside, and closed her hands into tight fists, but did not stop him. She remained motionless. She did not ask him to stop. He nuzzled his nose in her neck while his hands kept fiddling with her breasts, one after the other.

“You know what? I was wrong that you love me! You don’t.” he said, setting her free from his arms.

He pointed his finger at her, pulled his hair back with the other hand, and yelled at her. He took some quick breaths and then yelled again.

“Only Neha loved me! She would do anything for me. She always took care of me. She never said NO to me. I miss her so much! She was the only person who could do everything I told her. I thought you won’t hurt me, but you do. You all girls are the same. You need love, but you don’t know to give it back. Let’s go! I’ll drop you home.” he said, picking up his car keys.

“You know I love you more than anybody,” she said. Her voice choked when she spoke. Water in her eyes made his face blurred.

“No, you don’t! Otherwise, you would not have stopped me. You don’t trust me.”

“It’s not like that! It’s just.... it’s just....., I think we should not do it before we get married. I know you love me and I also love you. We can do it after we get married.”

Her pleading was visible in her eyes.

“Naina, I love you! Please don’t do this with me. We will get married soon, but it does not mean that I can’t love you till then.”

He motioned with his palm to stop her from saying anything.

“Ok, give me five minutes! I’ll marry you right now if that’s what you want.”

He went out and came back within two minutes with a small golden box of vermilion in his hand. He took a pinch of the red powder and put it on her forehead.

“Now we are married! Are you happy now?”

It was difficult for Naina to comprehend what was happening outside and it was more difficult to understand what was going on inside her. She felt as though someone was banging her head from inside. She was overwhelmed. Nobody had ever been so desperate to be with her that he did not think about his family. She could not believe that somebody could be so loving to her that he might decide this. And it was in that movement that she let her trust win over her again. The hunger for love made her obliged to him. A beggar's eyes sparkle when somebody throws in his empty plate, a sweet dish, something that he could only imagine in his dream. At that moment, Naina was the beggar and Veer had won over her forever. She wanted to melt in his arms and thank him for giving her the respect he had just given her. Yet, she did not feel anything exciting when he took her in his arms.

She walked with him silently when he took her to the bed. That feeling which had been holding her suddenly vanished at that moment. Confused between her heart and her mind, she let go of all the control over herself. She did not care to decide whether she should surrender or should get up and move out. She did not know where he was touching her as if she was made of plastic and his touch was not able to reach her heart. When he parted her legs and came over her, she did not feel the warmth of closeness. All she felt were pricks, pricks between her legs, pricks in her heart, pricks in her mind, and pricks all around her body. It was as if somebody was striking her heart on the same spot again and again, and she was bleeding, her muscles tearing up and flesh coming out from everywhere. She pictured her heart in that state - ripped apart yet pumping.

She did not know why she let that happen even when she could have stopped it, why she could not say "No" to him. She wished she could tell him. He was supposed to understand her. He was supposed to know that it was hurting her mentally, physically, and in all manners, anybody can think of. She could not understand why even love did not feel like love, why she didn't feel any warmth in his love, why for her that love-making was not divine like she had heard and read.

"What happened, you did not enjoy that?" He asked when he was finished.

She nodded with a fake blush.

“Just give me 15 minutes. Next time I’ll make you moan with pleasure,” he said, winking at her when Naina went to the bathroom to clean, trying to cover herself up.

‘Next time.....!’ That word got stuck in her head. All the stories from childhood popped up in her mind. ‘Is he going to do it 8 times?’

She cleaned herself. She heard the noise of the TV outside. When she came out, a young lady was undressing on the TV screen.

Her head was still spinning when he came over her the second time. In the background on the TV, that lady was moaning and screaming, in pain and pleasure together. Naina could not do any of them, she did not feel any of them.

“You will also moan like her. I’ll give that pleasure this time. I won’t stop till you don’t feel that pleasure of my love.” he said while penetrating her.

And she mimicked the sounds on TV. The story of fake orgasms started from there. As she moaned under him, she could see how his face changed, how his eyes portrayed the pride of being a man. When he finished this time, he lay next to her, panting.

“So, how was it? I am sure you enjoyed it,” he said, taking gaps to breathe.

“Yes, I did.” her voice dropped to a whisper as she kept her head on his shoulder, lost somewhere between her love and herself.

‘Was she right or wrong? Did she justify her love?’ she was thinking as she closed her eyes with a hope that as she had surrendered to her love, her love would now finally be with her. Now nobody could break the bond they had; she won’t let anyone touch her. Now, she belonged only to him. Her every feeling, every moment, belonged to him and him only.

It was 4.40 pm when Veer woke her up.

“Naina, get up, my family will be here in 30 minutes. Come on, get up! You need to leave.” He said, passing the clothes to her.

She was half asleep when she heard him. She opened her eyes in shock and said, “What do you mean by you need to leave? Aren’t you coming to drop me off? I don’t know the way to my home. How will I go?” Her voice had a helpless tone.

“Today you will have to go yourself, my princess. I can’t come to drop you off today.”

He was already at the door even before she got dressed again.

“Nainaaaaaaaa..... Hurry up!”

He called her name from downstairs. He stuffed a 500 Rs note in her hand saying, “You will get the auto from the corner of the street.”

And he closed the door behind her even without a formal bye. She felt a little odd but did not understand that. Should she feel insulted or cheated? Or was she just thinking too much? Her love-filled eyes could not see what was right and what was wrong.

As she walked, her thighs ached. She still felt the pricks between her legs. It took her half an hour to stop an auto. While waiting, she kept shifting her weight on her legs. Her throat was dry and her head was pounding. She remembered that she had not eaten anything since morning. She had left the breakfast untouched which her mother had served. She leaned on the seat of the auto, which kept bouncing on the road. She kept her eyes open and focused on the road looking for familiar scenes to become sure that she was heading the correct way.

She got down at the bus stop. Her house was five minutes’ walk away from there, but that distance seemed like an eternity that day. She realised how much she loved her home when she finally stepped onto the veranda.

Late that night on her bed, Naina saw the beast coming again running at her. It captured her in its grip and took her back to those days that she never wanted to revisit. But today, she did not fight back. She did not run away from it. She did not have the energy to even stand in front of it. She closed her eyes and let the waves of the memories soak her. All that pain that she

had been resisting all these years, she let it pass through her once again and accepted it as it is.

The first face which came to her was of Rati, her cousin. Rati was twelve when she got married. Naina had come back from school when she saw a gathering of women in her house. Rati was visiting them for the first time after marriage. She was sitting in the middle and they were teasing her about her husband.

“Oh Rati, tell us, what did your husband do?” one young woman asked, and they all giggled.

Rati looked at them. She told them that her husband made love to her eight times that night, and how she was smeared in blood the next morning. Rati bowed her head when she said that. Her face was long and expressionless. It seemed that everybody had been asking her the same question. She was answering in a practised tone.

One of the elder women in her thirties placed her hand on Rati’s head, smiled, and blessed her, “May you have a son as beautiful as the moon.”

Rati gave a faint smile in response.

Naina’s hands started trembling when she heard her. She was standing in the same place since she had entered the house. She felt bad for Rati. She wished she could undo her marriage and stop her from going back to that man again.

But that night, when she thought about Rati, she wanted to ask her a question, ‘How can she be so happy about what happened?’

‘Why Rati’s body did not react and repel like mine,’ Naina thought, ‘Blood? Did he hurt her so much that she bled?’

‘Did she enjoy bleeding? Naina was confused that night. She had millions of queries, but she did not have answers to them. To get her answers, she tagged along her mother, aunt, or grandma when they went to bless the new bride.

She remembered that one day she came back crying to their home. When she went to meet Mamta, the best friend of one of her aunts, Suman, with her. She had recently gotten married. When they reached Mamta's house, she dragged her aunt and took her to a small room. Naina followed them. Mamta bolted the door and started crying, hugging Suman.

Naina was behind her aunt. She could see Mamta's face from there. She clenched her aunt's salwar when she heard her sobs and looked up to see Mamta's face. Her eyes were pouring tears more than Naina could imagine. She could not understand how someone could cry that much for being away from her house just for one week. Her aunt caressed and patted her back while she unloaded the pain on her shoulders as if she already knew the reasons.

After crying for nearly half an hour, when Mamta's breaths steadied, both of them sat down on a cot, crossing their legs.

"What happened? Why are you crying?" Her aunt asked Mamta wiping her face with her dupatta.

"I don't want to go back to him," Mamta said, "He doesn't like me."

She again broke into tears. She told her that when her husband came into the room, he took out a CD from his pocket and played it on a video player. He had arranged it for only that night.

"See, what have I got! I was waiting for this night since the day I came to know that I am getting married. Today I'll tell you what real love is." He said in a tone that was far from loving and which could make any girl feel disgusted.

He undressed before the actors in the video could undress. While unhooking her blouse he almost tore it.

"What is this? That is what you got for me?" he yelled at her, seeing her bare breast.

When Mamta did not reply to his question, he squeezed her left breast like a half lemon until she winced.

“What would I do with them, Haaaan.....? Your parents have made a fool of me,” he said, violently pinching her nipples.

She kept her head down while he took out his dissatisfaction about her assets as if it was her mistake that her bosom had not bloomed up to her husband’s expectations, that her body could not please him.

However, when his lust took over him, he made her enact the scenes from the video as compensation for his loss. He forced her to sit on her knees and used her mouth for his pleasure without caring for her consent.

“You are my wife; you are married to me. I can do anything with you now. Good wives listen to their husbands,” he said while moving his waist to and fro, holding her head while she writhed on her knees.

Mamta’s eyes were continuously pouring when she shared all the minute details of her fretful first night.

“I... I I won’t go back there.” she could hardly talk in the middle of her sobs.

As Naina heard their talk, her expressions changed many times, from blank to sad and vice versa, and finally to disgust. She felt as if she was there in Mamta’s place. She felt the same helplessness which she had felt when her uncle had ruined her.

She dragged her aunt’s hand saying, “Bua chalo...,” crying profusely, trembling in fear. Suddenly she could not take the heat her body was generating. She kept wiping the sweat from her neck which was feeling like burning coal. Her aunt freed her hand saying, “What happened, why you are crying no? Why did you come with me then?”

Then she consoled her, “Will go in 10 minutes.”

But Naina was suffocating in that room. She wanted to run away from there.

“Bua chalo...!!”

She looked at her aunt with pleading eyes, nearly dragging her altogether. Mamta and Suman both looked at her trying to read her face. ‘What made her cry like this?’

Not even in their wildest of dreams, they could imagine what Naina was going through at that moment.

Suman gave Naina a stern stare as a warning for her behaviour, but at that time there was nothing which could control or soothe the convulsions in Naina’s head. She pulled her aunt by her hand and walked out of the room, dragging her aunt along.

On their way back, Naina kept fighting with her haunting thoughts. She could see her aunt’s rude face. And Suman also had tears in her eyes, thinking about Mamta. Both were crying, one from her heart and the other from her eyes.

CHAPTER

■

18

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When I met happiness years later,

It didn't recognize me

I didn't recognize it either.

Haree was asleep when someone entered her room. It was her brother-in-law, Ashok. There was not much of an age difference between him and Ram. He was just two years younger than Ram. But his build was different from Ram's. He was plump and healthier than him. When Haree's father was looking for a boy for Haree, he had first chosen Ashok. He was taller than Ram and looked more radiant than him. Unlike Ram, both of his brothers had grown smart and tall with abs and taut muscles around their arms. Blissful years of the full stomach had shown effect.

Right after the death of Ram, Ashok left his college midway and joined his father. Ram never allowed his brothers to indulge in the work.

"You are too young to understand all this." He would tell them whenever they came back during college breaks, "I'll take care of everything. You just concentrate on your studies and become Babu and sit in some govt. office."

He would buy a new set of clothes for them before the start of every session. Fine pieces of linen for trousers and cotton for the shirt. He would touch the fabric on his cheeks to feel the softness and pull it between his hands to check the sturdiness of them before buying. It was not that Ram was making money in abundance, but it was sufficient for all their needs.

He did not think twice about their college fees or their accommodation in the city.

Haree once asked him about his clothes. She was checking the cloth bag in which he had brought the cloth pieces.

“This white one is for Ashok and has matching grey trousers. And this blue one is for Ravi with black trousers. And this is another piece is for their kurta-pyjama.” he was saying as Haree took out the neatly folded pieces one by one and spread them in front of her mother-in-law.

In two years of their marriage, she had never seen him buying a new pair of kurta - pyjama for himself. He always wore the old clothes of his brothers. But with time, their sizes changed. Now when both the brothers grew into muscular young men, their shirts and trousers hung loose on his body. The trousers covered his entire feet, including shoes, and two people like Ram could fit in their shirts.

He knew that they were not of his size, yet every year, when his brothers came for holidays, Ram would replace their old clothes with new ones and would toss the pile of old ones in front of Haree, with a twinkled smile on his face. As if he had found some treasure.

Haree would alter them and fix them for him. Before Haree, his mother used to do it for him.

Later that night, Haree asked him about his clothes, “Why can’t you buy a set of shirts and pants for yourself?” She continued keeping her hands on her waist, “I don’t like that you wear all used and old clothes. I am not saying that you should stop wearing their clothes. But once a year, you can buy something yourself as well. I am sure that won’t cost much.”

More than anger, there was desperation in her voice. He looked up, placed the pencil in his notebook, and closed it. He reached for her hand and, moving his eyes, signalled her to sit with him.

Haree sat down reluctantly. She knew his tricks of melting the anger, but she was adamant about not letting go of that thing today. She looked down

at the cemented floor. He lifted her chin with his index finger and looked straight into her eyes.

“Haree, I have seen them wearing my old clothes when I was of their age. I know how their eyes sparkled when they wore my torn shirts. There was nothing much I could do at that time. But now, when I can do it, I want them to enjoy the real feeling of new clothes. And there is no such thing labelled among brothers. My everything belongs to them. Understand it like this, that they are my new clothes and I am giving them to use before me.”

He kept rubbing his thumb on her thumb while speaking.

“But still you can buy sometimes,” Anger had disappeared from her tone.

“Yes, I can, but when I wear their clothes, I find them with me. And I have seen my father wearing the same kurta for years. I don’t know why but my heart does not agree with wearing new clothes. I find them looking back at me with accusing eyes.” His voice had turned hoarse at the end and when Haree looked at him, she saw tears shimmering in his eyes.

“And I like it when you mend my shirts. You know, they smell like you when I wear them.”

His lips went all up on the right side of his face when he said. Haree always liked the way his lips moved up on one side. How mysterious he looked at that time. How could someone reject him when he smiled like that?

That night, when Ashok came into her room and took off his shirt, she thought about Ram. ‘And there is no such thing labelled as mine and theirs between brothers. My everything belongs to them.’ How true his words were? Maybe God took the challenge and proved Ram’s words to Haree, if in case Haree did not see the truth. God turned the events to do the same.

They got married two months after Ram’s death. After she had refused to go with her father, her mother-in-law prevailed upon her husband to get her married to Ashok. It was not an unusual thing. For generations, this thing has been happening. Wives of elder or younger brothers would get married to the next boy in the family to give birth and to raise children of their clan.

“A young widow is a bad omen in the family,” she told her husband one night.

He heard her silently. He was on his cot; his hands covered his eyes. She lay down on a carpet, with her hand folded under her head as a pillow.

“We will have a small ceremony and he will just give her his name.” she turned in his direction -her bangles clinked when she did that.

“I can’t let a widow stay in my house,” she said and then continued after thinking something. “Either you make her father take her or you ask Ashok to claim her.”

He listened to her carefully - thinking over her words. They roamed in the air, waiting to disappear only after his acknowledgement. She and her words looked at him. He could feel her eyes in the dark.

“I’ll talk to Ashok,” he said in a low tone, and then turned his back to her. His eyes were open and staring at the wall, his son, Ram, had fixed last summer. From mud, he had plastered it with cement to save it from dampness.

Nobody asked Haree about it. It was late evening while Haree was doing the dishes, that her mother-in-law came and told her that she would be married to Ashok and they had arranged the ceremony next week.

“Ram’s Ba..... Ashok’s Baba has gone to meet your father to decide the dates and other things.”

Haree’s hands stopped scrubbing when she heard Ram’s name from her mouth. How his name was also disappearing from the conversations now!

Late that night, she heard Ashok and his wife fighting. They had gotten married one year before Ram’s death.

“Why didn’t you tell your father that you don’t want to get married to her?” she yelled at him.

“I can’t say ‘No’ to my father.” His voice was as high as hers.

“Yes, why would you say? You want to sleep with that whore, don’t you?”

After that line, Haree only heard slapping and beating. She pictured Ashok slapping his wife, his long arm moving in the air and then touching his wife’s soft skin. One slap. second .. Third! Something fell on the floor; she heard the thud. ‘What could that be?’ she thought. Nobody came out of their rooms. After some more yelling and crying, the house fell silent as if that chaos belonged to some other night.

Ashok had started drinking in the first year of his college. Ram and his family came to know about it when he came home all drunk the very next day of his marriage. Ram had slapped him hard on the face when he had seen him stumbling towards his room.

It was late when Ram heard the hard knocking on the door. He woke up with worry, threw his sheet and went out of his room. He saw Ravi going towards the door. Ravi gave him a look and moved quickly to open the door. The sound of the iron chain knocking against the door kept rising.

“Were you playing with your balls all this while, huh?” Ashok shouted at Ravi while entering inside.

When he came into the veranda and saw Ram there, he tried to stand still. But his head kept moving back and forth. His eyes were blood red.

“Bhai.....My friends.....! They... they made me drink.” Ashok said, pointing his hands backwards as though his friends were standing there.

Standing at her room’s entrance, Haree was looking at them, her face covered down up to her nose. From behind that layer, she saw Ram pulling Ashok from the back of his collar, and turning his face towards himself. He raised his arm, pulled it back and let it swing in the air before hitting him. Ashok fell to the floor and nearly collapsed thereafter murmuring something, his head shaking on his sides as if he was saying ‘No’ to somebody in his dreams.

Ram kept pacing in the room when he returned after tucking Ashok in the men’s room, outside the house.

“Shameless,” he said looking at Haree, “How can he be so shameless to come all drunk in front of his wife?”

He sat down on his bed. His hand was on his temples.

“I never thought he would do this.” His head shook in denial.

“Where did I go wrong?” he asked, looking at Haree, who was standing next to him. She placed her hand on his shoulder and let him absorb his pain. There was nothing she could do or say. She had seen her father coming home drunk and all mad. She knew how it felt. There was nothing she could tell her mother, there was nothing she could tell him right now.

She never had anything to say to anybody. She soaked all the words inside her just to bleed them through her tears and blood someday. But one day, she would have to say and she will say, but that day was quite far. Unknown to time and Haree herself. That one day she would find her voice and strength before losing it forever.

With time, Ashok lost regard and deference to Ram. He would come late, drunken every night. Ram would slap him every time he saw him in that state. But when Ashok raised his hand on Ram one day, things came crashing down.

That night, Ram had asked him to stop drinking or to leave the house forever. That night, they were all in the kitchen, seated for dinner and waiting for him. He entered the kitchen on unstable feet and then vomited right at the entrance. Thick yellow paste came out from his mouth, splashing on the floor. Drops of it jumped and fell on the plates of Ram and their father. By the time he had finished, there was a big pool of that yellow paste on the floor. He wiped his mouth with his sleeve and was about to slip on that puddle when Ram got up and caught him with his hands on Ashok’s underarms. Holding Ashok’s arm on his own shoulder and with his left arm wrapped around Ashok’s waist, Ram took him to his room, their father got up to help him, but Ram shook his head and went ahead. He bolted the door behind them and took out his slipper.

Everyone gathered at the window when sounds of yelling and shouting started coming from the room.

“Who the hell do you think you are?” Ram was shouting at him and slapping his rubber slipper on his back and head. “How dare you vomit on Baba’s plate?” He yelled, a vein on his temples was pumping with a blood-rush.

“Bhai.... Bhai,” that’s all that Ashok could come up with. He used his hands as a shield in front of his face.

Everybody from outside was looking at them, craning their heads. “Stop it Ram.... Ram...!” his father called him, “Let it be.....!”

That’s enough.”

Ram looked at him, came towards the window and closed it with one forceful push. They heard the bolting of the window.

“Either you stop drinking the piss or get out of my house.”

The sound of rubber touching his skin continued for a while and then it stopped after last thud. Somebody had fallen on the floor. They could not tell what was going in the room. In that silence, they tried to read the sounds but there were none, as if there was nobody present in the room. Anger, yelling, pleading everything had disappeared.

Then they heard, “This is not your house. It’s my father’s house as well. And next time you raise your hand on me, remember that I can twist and break it even.”

The door opened and Ashok came out, gave them a furious look, and rushed out of the house with brisk steps. He opened pushed the main door open and then slammed it back saying, “Aaya Bada.....! Chutiya Ram!”

Ram was sitting on the floor with his one slipper in his hand and another in his foot. He got up and went straight to his room. When Haree came into the room, he shut his eyes and turned on his side. That night something had

broken inside Ram. He became very silent and reserved. He would wake up before everybody, get ready and leave for the field before meeting anybody's eyes. He talked less, smiled less. Whenever Haree asked him about it, he just left the room without saying anything to her. Ashok and he stopped talking and eating together. If Ram saw Ashok sitting in the kitchen during dinner, then he would turn and go to his bed without a word. Haree would take his food inside. Ashok would comment "Big people, Lord Ram!" When nobody joined his laugh, he would eat in silence with his father.

"I will distribute their share between them," Ram's father said one day to Ram. They both were in the fields that day, looking at their next batch of vegetables, which were ripe and ready for sale.

"Ravi still has one year left in his studies. After that you can distribute it." Ram said with a heavy sigh. His eyes were fixed at nothing in the distance. "You please ask them what they want and give them whatever they want." he continued.

"What do you want?" his father asked Ram, keeping his hand on his shoulder.

Ram looked down at his feet and said, "You can't give me what I wanted. And now, I don't know what I want."

He raised his head and then turned his face to his left. His father saw him wiping corners of his eyes with his index finger.

"I'll talk to them," his father said and then looked ahead, as if he could see what Ram was unable to see in the distance.

But before Ravi could finish his studies and come home, Ram's death cast a spell of silence on all of them. It was after a few months of his fight with Ashok that he stopped eating at home. He would wake up early and would come late. After that talk with his father, he had made his own plans to distribute property between Ravi and Ashok. There was a rush and fear in his heart that kept him awake at night. He bought two plots in the market to

build two separate shops for them. He did not want to wait for a year to finish. He wanted to be ready before time.

He would spend his days meeting his friends and landholders who could provide funds for the construction. He took a big fat loan from them. Once the funding was done, he did design and architecture of the buildings by himself. He would draw the layout in his diary. How many rooms, how many shelves, what kind of ceiling? How the electricity and water supply lines would be laid inside the walls? He thought through it all. He wanted both the shops to be connected and yet separated at the same time.

He made a blueprint for two floors, ground floor for the shops and first floor for their families to live. On the ground floor, he did not plan any kind of passage between the two shops. One had to come out from one shop and then go to the other by walking on the street.

But on the first floor, where he imagined their families would live, he planned everything in doubles, three rooms each side. Independent kitchen on each side and an open veranda at sides as a balcony, separated by one single door in the middle. They could come and go to each other's house through that door. Close that door and they would be in different houses, un-interfered and undisturbed. For the terrace, he made two separate roofs but connected them with a staircase from one building to another like a bridge which connected them. He made iron doors on both sides to secure and to put restrictions if anyone of them wanted to enforce.

For the storage purpose, he built a single basement with two different entrances. If they would want to use it separately, they might simply build a partition in the middle. In his heart he was seeing the future. Before anybody else, it was Ram who had seen the cracks in his family. An uneasy feeling in his heart kept telling him that he needed to finish the things at hand as soon as possible. In front of his own eyes!

For days, Haree had been noticing him, silent and edgy. The man she had married was lost somewhere. She saw him working with his notebook for hours, sitting at the entrance under that dim lantern till late. She would wait for him to recite two or three lines of his poetry but that didn't happen. When she held his hands and cuddled him on bed, he would move her hand

off and turn on his side. Haree would sleep lying flat on her back, looking at the ceiling. Her body and ear hungry for his touch and his words.

Every night he would write down the progress of the building and list things he wanted to finish the next day. Material and labours which would need to finish the construction on time. He started eating less and sleeping less. Food which Haree would pack for his lunch came back home untouched. They had their first argument when one day, Haree tried to hug him and he threw her arms back.

“There are other things to do in this life. I don’t have time for all this.” He said, irritated.

Haree looked at him surprised and heartbroken.

“Then why did you marry me, when you don’t need me. Am I here only to cook food and clean the house?” she said in frustration.

Ram stopped at the door, then turned back and said “I don’t need your body, I need you.” and left the room.

Haree looked at him, reading the meaning of his heavy words. How small she had felt that day, in front of her husband. How shallow her definition of love was, and how profound and true his words were! A new meaning of love he had taught her that day.

After that, Haree would patiently wait for him to come. She would ask him questions about the shops. As the work progressed, smile on his face returned. But he had lost a lot of weight in last few months, the charm on his face had faded. His eyes had started looking tired and old.

His appetite had lessened. He would eat only half of what Haree served him. He smiled at her, when she insisted. He had been complaining of continuous headaches to her. He had been experiencing sharp pain at the back of his head. First it happened once in fifteen days, but as the days passed, it became permanent. He felt his head heavy and dizzy all the time. Last week, after lunch, the pain became so sharp that when he started walking, he stumbled and hit his head on the floor. He vomited after some

time and his head felt little light after that but it returned the next day with the same intensity. Whenever Haree asked him about it, he would say that he was fine.

“I’ll go to the vaidya, once this work is done,” he said to Haree.

Haree would make him ginger tea at night and massage his temples before sleeping. She would look at him like he was a baby. He would turn to her side, fold his legs and then sleep peacefully in her lap.

Construction of shops was in its final phase. Only final touches of the painting then they would be ready. That night, Ram asked Haree to make Kheer for dinner. His smile was reaching his eyes. He had come early that day. He said that his stomach was rumbling with hunger. He ate with his father and told him about the shops. He ate the food between his words, coughed in the middle and then laughed at his own activity.

That night when they made love, Ram looked deep in her eyes. Like he was looking at her after years. He kissed her neck and lips like he wanted to have the taste of her skin on his lips for eternity. Their fingers joined together, sweating and twisting in rhythm. Haree moaned and gasped in between her body melting in his arms. They slept entangled in each other’s arms. Their legs crossed as if there was something still left to soak, something to hold.

Over years, Haree would have ample time to relive that moment. She saw her older self-looking at that Haree who was lying on the bed. She envied her and longed to be that Haree again and again.

Next day, when Ram was leaving for the shops, he had kissed her on her lips again, just like last night. Haree had blushed and run to the kitchen. Her shame laden eyes could not look into his eyes directly. Ram winked at her when she came to drop him off to the door. She had never done that before. But that day Haree did want to miss even a single moment to be with him. She wanted to see him, to be with him as long as he was in the house.

That night, she was waiting for him at dinner when heard cries outside. She leaped to her feet and ran outside. Her mother-inlaw was sitting on the

floor, Ravi holding her with her shoulders. She looked at Haree from behind her veil and then turned to her husband. Haree's eyes were wide open and confused, a strain of fear running in her blood.

“My son! My God like son!” her mother-in-law cried aloud.

Everything went hazy around Haree, sounds muffling and overlapping each other. She saw faces going blurry and then coming into focus again. Somebody was calling her name, but she did not know who. She could not reach the source of the voice. Everything became silent for some time and then it all came back again with a rush. Sounds so loud and piercing that she could not bear them. Her ear and head started hurting due to the pressure.

Wails of ladies increased violently like a sudden rush of waves, when four men came in holding four legs of a cot with Ram's body. Crowd moved aside to make way for them. Haree looked at them and at other people. ‘When did they come? Moments before, she was in the kitchen and now she was standing in a deluge of people. Has she altered the paradigms and reached some other world?’

She could not recall when she came out of the kitchen and when did all these people come. She was still looking at everybody in confusion when somebody pulled her by her hand and brought her to the front. She dragged herself, her eyes still looking at the people around, who were looking at Ram with curious eyes and talking in between. When she reached Ram's body, she stood there with a blank look. Hands that had brought her forward, she felt them again on her shoulders, pressing her down to sit. Her legs were stiff as a board. She did not know how to move her body. She did not know how to blink, how to walk, how to sit. The pressure of the fingers increased and she bent and then sat on the floor.

Her eyes were now in line with Ram's face. He laid flat on his back. With closed eyes he looked peaceful and calm as if he was sleeping carefree after the day's work. There was something sticky around his lips. Haree took the edge of her shawl, rolled it into a small ball and wiped his mouth in careful slow motion. His body felt oddly cold when she placed her right hand on his forehead. She removed it immediately. It was not Ram's touch. There

was something unusual in it. Then she put her hand again to tilt his face to her side and wiped the corner of his lips on the other side of mouth. After that she sat there crossing her arms across her knees and kept looking at him. She was waiting for him to open his eyes and smile in that mischievous style. She fixed her gaze at his lips, waiting for them to move to their right giving that smile. His smile, which could fix anything. Everything would be okay once he did that. People standing and sitting around her, would go back to their respective house. She would serve him dinner, bowl-full of kheer which she was making. She thought of the pot that was on the stove. She wanted to run towards the kitchen to check it but she was unable to move, as if somebody had locked her inside her own body. In her mind, she saw herself getting out of her, and then finding her way in-between sitting heads and standing people to reach the kitchen. Her invisible self, took the pot off fire with a kitchen-rag and put it on the floor. She stood at the entrance of the kitchen, looking at everybody, at herself, sitting in the middle of everybody - motionless and careless.

Haree looked in the direction of kitchen. Her image had disappeared. She tried to find her image amidst the faces around. When her eyes got tired, she moved her stare back to Ram's lips.

Over the years later, that image kept coming back again and again to meet her. She always stood there always silent and curious, watching Haree intently. It came every time Ashok came to her.

First time, it had come back when she was getting married to Ashok. It was not a marriage, just a simile. There was no celebration. Ladies did not smear turmeric and sandalwood paste on her as it was done when she got married to Ram. They did not gather to sing wedding songs at night, nobody teased her. She did not apply Henna on her hands. Ashok and she did not move in circles around the holy fire and also did not take the seven vows while pandit chanted the mantras.

It was just a simple process, not even a ritual. Her father had come, the only relative from her side to give her a new red sari which she was to wear after the wedding. Early in the morning, her mother-in-law had gone to a few neighbours to invite them for it as witnesses. Haree took a bath and wore the clothes her father had bought on the last day of mourning. Her silver

bangles danced on her thin wrists. Her mother-in-law made her sit on an empty cot under the giant neem tree in their front courtyard. The men were standing on one side and ladies on the other. Village's pandit was chanting something which Haree could not understand. She kept her eyes down - at her toes. They had blackened at the corners, stains of nail-polish she had applied had long gone.

Pandit had made a red paste of kumkum and water in one corner of a plate. He mixed it with his ring finger and then touched its tip on Haree's forehead. A red dot appeared between her eyebrows. She felt the coldness of it for a while. The feeling disappeared when it dried out.

Her mother-in-law brought a packet and gave it to pandit. Bangles clinked when pandit took them out of the packet and placed them on the plate. He sprinkled the red paste of kumkum on them, using his thumb and finger.

Haree looked at the packet on the floor. There was a picture of a woman with bangles laden wrists looking at her. Her hands were cupping and resting to one side of her head. Haree wanted to crush that woman but it was too far from her reach. She kept staring at her as if her stare would burn it out automatically.

It was then, that she saw her own image coming out of her again. It reached for the packet, picked it up, tore it in pieces, and then tossed them in air. The white tiny pieces fell on the pandit and in his plate like rain. She could not look up at her image, but she knew that the image was smiling at her, smiling at everybody there.

When pandit called Ashok, someone spat on the floor. Haree heard the sound. It came from the ladies' side. Ashok came forward from the men's crowd. Pandit gave him a few bangles and motioned him towards Haree while murmuring chants under his breath. Haree pulled her wrists back when Ashok tried to hold them. He gripped them again, tighter this time. He slipped all the bangles in one go on her right hand. He was still holding her hands when pandit passed him another set of bangles. He slipped them quickly. Haree saw red marks on her skin, where Ashok has held her. She had to try hard to not rub her skin and not throw the bangles right away.

Ceremony ended when Ashok took a pinch of dried kumkum from the plate, and smeared it in the partition of hair on her head. After Ram's death Haree had started tying her hair by pulling them back, but that day her mother-in-law has braided her hair. She parted them neatly, applied oil on both sides to stop their flurrying, and braided them tightly.

After the ceremony, her mother-in-law took her inside and asked her to change into that Red sari which her father had bought. Haree wrapped it around her and looked at her reflection in mirror. She missed her previous avatar. The plain clothes that she had been wearing for the last two months suited more on her. Somehow the bright red colour burned her skin, her eyes, her insides.

Everyone left and then her father also left. He told her only two words before leaving. He kept his huge hand on her head and whispered, "Be good!".

Haree heard the restraint in his words. She understood the meaning he had infused in the whispers. She nodded and went back inside. Late that night Haree thought about his words, 'Be good!' What good she could be now? What was there to be good now? There was nothing she could do. The worst had already happened. What else could possibly happen now? That would require her patience and silence. She just needed to wait patiently for her death to come so that she could meet Ram once again.

But she did not know that her patience and strength would be tested again and again. It was one week after that ceremony, when Ashok came stumbling into her kitchen for the first night, she did not know when he came in. She could never understand how could she not hear him coming in. She had woken up with a jolt when she had felt something crawling towards her thighs inside her skirt. He was sitting on the floor, cross-legged. Her skirt was pushed up her knees and his hand was stuck between her thighs.

In a state of confusion, she looked at him in utter surprise. How could he dare to come inside like that? How could he touch her like that? She immediately sat up, fumbling for her shawl. She pulled the shawl over her breast when she found his eyes stuck to them.

“Bhaiya.....! Do you need something” she said, standing up? She took a glass, dipped in the vessel, and took out with trembling hands.

“Water? Were you looking for water?” she asked, trying to make her words sound normal, but they still trembled.

“No, I don’t want water,” he said. He tapped on the mat and motioned her to sit down. Haree looked at his face and then at the mat, her eyes open with shock and fear. She looked outside if she could run and shout, but she did not have the courage to even take a step ahead. He gripped her wrist and pulled her down with one single pull. Water splashed all over and the glass rattled on the floor. Its sound remained in the air for some time before dying.

He pulled her legs with both hands and straightened them, crossed his right leg, and quickly locked them between his knees. He tightened his knees and pressed hers in under his weight when she threw and tried to move them.

Haree did not see the first slap coming. It hit her hard. Her right jaw and ear stung by the sudden impact. So many things were happening one after the other that she could not understand. She was being hit again and again. She did not know why and from where his hand was coming.

When Ashok pushed himself inside her, she did not notice the pain between her legs. The pain started in her heart, a howl raised from it and made its way up to her neck, but it came back inside again into her heart. Ashok kept her mouth shut all through with his heavy palm. The howls arose and died with every stroke he gave her.

After he released himself inside her, he slapped her one last time, as tight as the first one and then left. She did not understand the reason for the beating that day. But, in the next few nights she understood at it was his habit. He derived pleasure in it. He would call her names. Names that she had heard from her father’s mouth and other men’s mouths in her village. Names that she could not even repeat in her mind when they reverberated in her memories. Names, that she always hated but never dared to say or share with her mother. Never asked her about them.

In future, there would be nights when she would let him use her body silently without any repulsion, but he would still hit her.

He would check her face for her tears and then would bang her head on the wall until she cried and pleaded with him to stop. Of late she had started crossing her arms around her belly whenever she sensed his mood and anticipated that a blow might come. She would pull her legs up to stop him. On such nights memories of the stain of blood on the bed-sheet came rushing in her head. She did not want her child also to die the same way. It had been three months that she had missed her periods. She did not realize it until she started vomiting every morning. Her head started spinning with nausea and the smell of wheat flour made her sick.

Every night, After Ashok had left, she would sit with her head leaning back against the wall, her hand touching that little bump in her stomach. She would rub her thumb over and over it till her skin burnt with friction. She would look outside at the wide empty veranda with her dry eyes. It made her feel all alone and small. The space stared at her as if laughing at her.

Then one day she got up and took out the red saree and the white bed-sheet from her trunk. She cut the bed-sheet in two parts from middle and tore down the saree in two pieces with her hands. Then she took that part of the white bed-sheet which had blood stains on it and tucked it from one end of the kitchen to another.

■

*My eyes see things,
That I don't want to see, My heart feels things,
That it should not feel,
But then, what is life,
If we don't see it as it is!*

A year passed with Veer. In one year, she saw many shades of him. Their love talks turned into sex talks, which used to end with sounds of his pleasure and moans of her fake orgasms. He had turned wild in bed. Purple and blue marks never left her breast, her neck, and her waist.

He would pinch hard on her waist, saying, "These are power boosters, my princess!" He would keep pinching till it left marks on her waist.

He took Naina to his house whenever he could find it free. On some occasions when he could not, he would take her to his friend's house. It was a secluded house. Nobody lived there. Naina did not hear any sound from other apartments as well. It seemed as if either the entire building was vacant or the people there were dead. The bedroom where they used to spend their time had only one single bed. There was no water or electricity. Whenever they went there, Veer always brought his bed sheet. He would spread it smilingly. They never talked to each other during those meetings.

Naina was too scared in that room to speak, and Veer never had anything to say except, "Let's finish it quickly,"

Naina would undress herself as a well-learned procedure. It seemed as if each step had been practiced for eternity. Her hands would flow automatically on his back when he would come over her. He would pass her tissues after they were done. And then they would quickly get out of the room and building.

Naina sometimes looked at him, thinking where all his words vanished. What was different in him that bothered her. He talked in the same manner as he used to. He always held her hand in the lift, and he always made her comfortable in the car. But she knew that it was not the same. It had started feeling mechanical.

Naina wanted to avoid going to that house.

"I don't feel safe here," she said to him one day when he was putting on his shirt.

"I know Princess, and it's expensive as well," he said.

"Expensive?"

Veer looked at her and then quickly added, "I mean, it's far from college and I need to fill petrol every time we come here."

She was still perplexed

"But I'll think of something," he said, sitting on the bed.

He gave a soft kiss on her forehead. Naina always liked that. This was the only place where his lips didn't hurt her. When he kissed her on the forehead, her body did not repulse. In fact, it surrendered to him.

For the next two weeks, they did not go to that place. Naina was happy. Everything became normal again. They would go on long drives, and she would smile, looking outside. She would hold his hand in her hands. Life was perfect, like her dreams.

But then one day, when he came to pick her up, she noticed that all the glasses of his car were covered with a thin black plastic. From outside it was impossible to see inside. Naina saw it and her panic returned. Veer took her by hands and pulled her inside the car.

“See, what I did for you?” His smile was wide enough to reach his eyes. “Now you don’t need to be scared, my princess! That’s your new bedroom,” he said and then changed the gear to move the car.

Naina looked outside, the freedom which she used to feel before in that car had vanished. The suffocating walls which she was running away from had come back. They were enclosing her from all over. She felt suffocated. She slid down the glass for fresh air, but then slid them up again when Veer said, “What are you doing? A.C is on.”

From behind those black glasses, the world seemed far out of her reach.

Now, when they could not go to his house, Veer would unzip himself and would motion her to it. Naina would follow his orders like a puppet. She did not realize when the essence of their love had changed from love to lust. And how did she let it happen it silently? She did not know it then. However, she realised the impact of her silence years later, when she could not do anything about it.

On occasions, when Naina denied him, he would stop taking her calls for days. Naina would wander in college like a dry leaf, not knowing where to go? What to do? She would call him again and again. She would cry, plead, and apologize for the mistakes which she had not made and he would make her pay for them in different ways. Naina did not complain, she always looked forward to the little love poured on her after the punishments. Veer knew what made her happy and Naina followed him like a lost puppy. She could have left him, but she did not. There was no way she could go. She did not want to be left all alone in this world.

Desperation of being accepted and loved had blinded her. She did not understand the meaning of love. She understood only what she saw. She had always seen everybody accepting things as they were. She had never seen anyone protest about anything. She did not know anything about self-

respect, mutual-love, and care. She was worthless in her own eyes. And it was Veer who was adding some value in it, at least he wanted her, at least he made her visible in some sense, at least he made her feel that she did exist.

Naina was ecstatic that she had met her love. But it was not the kind of love she had seen in movies, and not the kind of love she had imagined for herself. It had left her ruined and devastated. The devastation included damage to her own acceptance, the damage which she could never mend. She had been drifting away from her body. At times when Veer came over her, she could see herself lying there like somebody else. Some other person in her body, a person she did not know. That was the only way she could unsee, unfeel, and untie herself. That rotten love of hers was eating her up bit by bit like a maggot, but she did not realise it then. And by the time she realised, there was nothing in her which could remind her that it was she who lived in that body. That the body was hers.

Naina was in the car with Veer when a traffic policeman stopped them for that black film on the glass. They were on their way to Naina's house. Veer would take less used roads, when he wanted her to help him release his load. But lately, he had started giving excuses to Naina.

"I don't have that much time princess. I can't go that far every day." he would say to her.

But going through populated roads always made her anxious. She was sure that somebody could see them. There was no way those thin layers of plastic could block the piercing eyes of people. When they could see beneath her clothes, they could obviously see her like that.

Naina's head was down when Veer pulled her up from his unzipped pants.

"Shitt... Shittt... shitt...!" he panicked.

The steering wheel of the car moved a full circle as he struggled to zip up his pants. Naina looked up to find out the reason for it. Veer had never reacted like that before.

The Traffic policeman tapped his stick on the bonnet and looked at them. Veer opened the gate and went out cursing.

“Oye Bhenchod! How dare you touch my car?”

Naina saw him going out towards the policeman. His mouth was moving frantically. She could tell that he was swearing at him. Another policeman kept trying to look inside while Veer was fighting with them. He tapped on the glass on the passenger seat-side. She slid down the window. He looked at her. That middle-aged man gave her a mischievous look and that made her uncomfortable. She noticed him looking at her head. Her hair was all unkempt and undone. She had not had time to fix them. His eyes moved down her hair, stopped at her chest, and then moved down to her thighs. He quickly walked back and told something to another policeman. Naina knew what he was saying. When they both looked at the car, Naina dropped her eyes quickly. With their eyes piercing her, her heart was racing in her chest. She adjusted her shawl on her chest, but their gaze made feel as if she was sitting all naked in front of them, and they could see all that Naina wanted to hide. They were looking at her as if it was their right to look at her like this, a sacred right that all the men on this earth have. She raised the glass of the window.

That policeman came back towards the window seat and tried to rip off the plastic from the glass, the shield which was saving her. He ran a small knife on the glass. Black layers came undone from many places. From inside, they looked like cuts, like wild scratches on her skin. Every slot on the glass made her more open to the eyes of the world. Through the slits she could see that people had gathered around. All eyes were on her. To her right, there was a white car, and a middle-aged couple sitting in it was laughing at her. The smirk on that woman's face intimidated her.

She should have at least understood her, Naina thought, but she knew that humanity and cruelty have no gender. they are equally distributed in both men and women. In her life she had seen women turn cruel and also seen men as pure as water. Eyes were burning her shoulders, cheeks and head from all sides but she kept her face expressionless and head straight. She wondered where do these eyes go when people call for help. Why do these curious eyes always want to look forbidding?

She looked at Veer through the windshield.

They must have taken all of his money, she thought as she saw them checking his upper and back pocket on his shirt and jeans. Veer slammed the door shut when he came back.

“Now you are happy? That’s all you wanted.” he hissed while driving.

Naina kept her eyes down while scolding her.

“You were scared at the house? But you are not scared on roads, huh?” he continued in a furious voice, “See, what a fool they have made of me! Those bastards know my father.”

They did not talk for the rest of the way. Car zigzagged on the road. Naina had to hold the handle above her seat. He changed gears and sped now and then. Naina looked at his face. She had never seen him like that before. But she had seen someone else like that. She knew this temper. She kept quiet. She knew it from her experience that the best thing to do at that time was to keep quiet. She would talk to him later. Late at night, when he would be sober and soft towards her again.

Naina’s mouth was stinking. She could not swallow and breathe properly with all the filth in her mouth. Her eyes were glued to the transparent bottle of water on the dashboard. The water in it wobbled when the car moved. She imagined the cold water in her mouth, whirling around and taking out all the dirt in her mouth. She wanted to take a sip and gargle to get rid of the rancid smell. “Can we stop for two minutes? I need to clean my mouth and face.” Her words came out in hesitation.

He looked at her and then suddenly sped the car. She had to keep her hand on the window to avoid her head colliding with it. When he stopped at her bus stop, Veer thrust the bottle in her hand and moved the car even before she could get out fully. He applied brakes suddenly and then drove away.

Naina looked around to find a corner where she could wash herself up. A car stopped behind her, its tyres screeching on the road. She looked at the car and moved aside. A man came out from it and walked towards her. At

first, she could not see the face of the man coming at her. The bright sunlight had blinded her. She turned her face and opened the bottle to sip.

It was only when he slapped her at the back of her head and the bottle fell from her hand that she saw her uncle standing in front of her.

“That’s what you do at college?” he barked at her.

She did not open her mouth, wondering if her uncle could smell it. She covered her face with both hands when he raised his hand again. Even her hands reeked of that stingy smell.

People gathered around.

“Arey Bhai Saab....!” somebody said.

He stopped his hand in the air and got into the car and drove home. Naina rushed home in quick steps. She looked back at the bottle. Water was spilling from it, only if she could wash it up! That stingy feeling was making her sick. She wanted to get rid of it.

But she did not know that the smell was going to remain on her lips for years. It would take ages for her to get rid of that smell, that puking feeling. It would take more than water to wash her up. It would take fire to clean her up and become pure again.

When she reached home, her uncle took her straight to her parent’s room. Her mother was resting. He went inside pulling Naina and shut the door behind her. Naina stood in the corner, that feeling of puke persisting in her mouth.

“See, what your daughter has been doing!” He yelled without calling her mother’s name or without waking her up. She woke up and covered her head and chest. This breach of her privacy made her hands fumble. She looked at Naina for a reply then she looked at him questionably.

Her uncle looked down and said in murmurs, “Ask her what she was doing in the car with that guy?”

“Guy? Who.....? Who Guy?” Her voice trembled when she spoke.

“Ask your daughter. You wanted her to go to college, right? You wanted her to study.” He continues in a single breath, “See, that’s what happens when you let them go. They go and sleep around with boys.”

Naina closed her eyes when he said that, as if closing her eyes would stop the words from entering her ears.

“Wha.....!” Her mother started crying. She could not complete her words, “She won’t step out of the house from now on. And I am going to tell her Baap what she is doing.”

He stormed out of the room. They sat in silence for a while. Her mother asked her about it but Naina kept her eyes on the floor all along.

“That’s what I asked you to do when I asked you to study? It’s because of your kind of girls that people don’t let their daughters’ study.” She was sobbing and speaking, “I wish you were never born. I would have been happier to see you dead like my other daughter. If I had known that you were going to shame me like this, I would have killed you myself.”

The pain was rising in Naina’s chest, but it did not turn into tears to come outside. It kept whirling in her chest. A suffocating kind of feeling, which did not let her breathe properly. After her mother left the room, Naina went to the bathroom and cleaned herself. She brushed her teeth twice and scrubbed her tongue until it became sore and sensitive. Blood came mixed in that white froth when she spat. She scratched her skin to get rid of the filth and shame that gathered on her skin. She first scrubbed it with a brush, and then took the pubic stone and rubbed it on her arms, between her thighs, and around her chest. The abrasion of the stone made her cry. She could feel her skin tearing under that aberration. She rubbed again and again to intensify that feeling. The physical pain in her body made her forget the suffocation. There were red marks all over her body when she came out of the bathroom.

Naina went to the bed early. She had a fever. Her whole body was burning with all that vigorous scrubbing. Late at night, she thought about him. What

he might be doing at that hour. It was their time to call each other. She turned in her bed. Her arm hurt when she folded it under her head. The rashes were still sensitive. She pictured him looking at his phone again and again to check her call. She knew that he would not call her for the next few days because of what had happened today. He would make her wait and then take her to that same flat once again. Naina felt a kind of relief that her meeting would stop, at least for some time now.

She did not want to go through that shame and fear once again. The next time when she would meet him, it will be in front of everyone, with their family's permission. Maybe that day was far, but she knew that it would come. There was no way she would give up on him and there was no way he would give up on her. She knew that he would make it possible. He would fight for her till the end of the world, and she would do the same for him. She just needed to meet him once and he would take care of everything.

The next day when she got ready for college, she did not take a bath. She knew that her mother would suspect her and then she wouldn't let her leave. She got up early, before everybody else. She took out an old but clean pair of kurta and salwar and the crumpled five hundred rupees note that Veer had given her. She could never bring herself to accept it and use it. Whenever she looked at that note she was reminded of the way he had kept it on her palms, as if it was a fee of her services which she had provided to him that day. She felt it was inappropriate. But that day, she did not have a choice but to use it. That note was her only hope.

She slipped into her kurta and salwar, folded the note, and stuffed it in her bra. Her sore nipple ached when her thumb brushed against it in the hurry. A painful sigh escaped her mouth. She kept her hand over her breast and waited for the pain to pass. She sat on her bed waiting for the morning hustle of the house to start. Lying on her bed, she heard water splashing in the bathroom, her grandmother was gargling. Something clicked in the kitchen, and then the utensil clinked. 'Mother must have been woken up,' she thought. After a while, the sounds increased. She heard neighbours calling their wives asking for morning tea, mothers shouting at children for getting ready for school. A pressure cooker whistled somewhere.

Her mother came to wake her. Naina closed her eyes. Her mother called her name and asked her to join in the kitchen. When she asked Naina about her changed dress, she lied that she had gone into her periods at night and had changed the dress.

Naina helped her mother in making breakfast. While standing near the gas, her skin burned even now. She kept an eye on the surroundings. Her uncle woke up. He was reading the newspaper after which he will go to the bathroom. It would be then that she would escape. Her mother would get busy somewhere in her routine. Naina knew that her uncle had not told about yesterday his father or anyone else in the house. His father had gone to a wedding and had come quite late at night. Even in that mental and physical state, Naina had kept her eyes and ear open.

It was around 8.00 o'clock that she found the perfect moment. Her mother sent her to ask her grandmother about the breakfast. Naina stepped out of the kitchen and looked around. There was nobody in the hall, newspaper was spread on the table, its pages fluttering in the air from a fan. Her mother's room was still closed. 'Father must be still asleep. I might never get this chance again,' she thought. It was not the first time that she was sneaking out of the house. She had done it many times when she was a little girl. But those were different times. That Naina was different. She would run fearlessly and disappear before anybody could catch her. She knew her tricks, she knew her courage. This Naina was different. Her body shivered at the very thought of this act of hers.

While taking breakfast to her grandparent's room she calculated her final moves. If she left the house right then, she could run and take an auto from the corner of the street. By the time anybody would come to know her absence, she would be far away. Once she would talk to him, she was sure he will take care of things. She would come back home and wait for him. She smiled thinking about it. She thought about the things that might happen after she would come back, all the beating and cursing. She did not know what she would say then. But she knew that she had to leave right then, for her love's sake. She had to do it for him.

She looked around one last time and then got ready for the final act of courage. She came out of the house, ran as quickly as she could, and then

took the first left turn on the street looking back only once, to check for any audience of her performance.

There was no one to stop her, just like when was a little girl. There was no one to stop her, no one to look at her.

She ran until she reached the bus stand on the main road. It was then that she noticed herself. She looked down at her breast. There was no dupatta. It was the first time that she had left home without it. She felt naked and vulnerable as if everybody could see the blue marks on them, the marks that Veer had left. She loosened her hair and parting them she pulled the two parts to the front. With her fingers, she spread her hair on her chest. Now, at least there was a layer between her and those piercing eyes.

After getting on the bus, she enquired about the time with the lady who was sitting next to her. She smelled of soup and moisturiser. Her hair was oiled and pulled back in a tight pony.

“Eight forty-two!” she said in a tone as if she was still asleep. But her face looked fresh, with a bindi and a coat of red lipstick, that was coming out of corners of her lips.

‘She must have been in a hurry, preparing food for her kids and husband,’ Naina thought, and then scooped over a little wondering if she could smell her and tell that she had not taken a bath.

Naina always felt filthy. She would clean her hands multiple times even while eating. She would wipe her hands with her hanky after every morsel. She would take bath three times as if there was some invisible dirt on her that kept appearing after every few hours. Her mother had scolded her many times about it. It made her chest blocked with congestion in winter, but she never listened. Before sleeping, she would sneak into the bathroom and take a quick bath in icy cold water. During the last year, her routine has changed. Every time Veer masturbated over the phone; she would run to the bathroom. She would gargle and clean herself between her legs until her privates became numb and she could not feel them. She cleaned herself rigorously as if she had been physically present with him and he had come all over her mouth.

She got down at the stop next to her college. She had seen a phone booth there. Astha used to make calls to her crushes from there. She got down, holding the change the ticket collector had returned her. A thought flashed in her mind, 'How he had looked at her breast when she took out the note from her bra! He was smiling at her when she did that.'

She stood in a corner at the booth. There was nothing in her hands which could keep her busy or she could pretend to be busy. People looked at her in amusement. Or was it just she thought that they were all looking at her in amusement, figuring out why a girl in rubber chappals and ordinary clothes was standing in the corner.

She asked an old man standing next to her about the time. He moved his hand towards her face. She looked at the watch on his spotted and wrinkled hands. It was showing five past nine. She could not call him right then. The phone booth would open around 10 am. She had one hour still to pass. Standing there itself, she kept looking at the vehicles passing on the roads. Her heartbeats became normal after some time. Honking of vehicles, the hustle around, and the motley of faces pacified her. Her mind wandered between the past and the future. A smile appeared on her face when she thought about her future kids and how she was going to tell them the story of her running away from home to meet their father. How brave she was that day!

Veer picked up the call after two complete rings.

"Hello!" he said in a groggy voice. He was still asleep. Naina was on the verge of crying when she heard his voice as if she was hearing him after ages.

"Hello.....!" she cleared her throat and said, "It's me Naina."

"Princess!" he said after a long pause of rustling and the sound of movements.

'He must have opened his eyes and would have looked at the screen to check the number once again.' Naina could tell by the way he replied.

“Princess, whose number is this? Where are you? Are you outside?”

Naina smiled and pulled back her tears. Her heart filled with love and gratitude after hearing his worried tone.

“Yes, I am out. At the phone booth, next to our college bus stop.”

“Whaaat!? What are you doing there? Why aren’t you in college? And why are you calling me from a public phone?” He kept asking in his panicky voice without stopping and waiting for her reply. She opened her mouth to reply, then stopped and then opened again, but stopped till he had finished.

“I need to meet you right now!” she said. The booth owner looked at her intently. She passed a look at him and then turned her back to him.

“Can you come here to pick me up?” she said in whispers. Her voice lacked the confidence that she had had till now.

“Stay there! I am coming in twenty minutes.”

She imagined him getting off the bed, as his voice changed and she heard the keys clinking.

“I am coming, just wait!” he said again and then disconnected the call.

She kept the phone back on the cradle after hearing the beep. She looked at the wall clock on the front wall. 10.05. She gave money to the shopkeeper while calculating the time by which Veer would reach.

‘By 10.25 he should be here.’

Notes in her hand had become damp with all the sweat. The booth owner gave her a disgusted look and handed over the change. She walked out of the booth and stood on its side. There was no point in going back to the bus stop. Questioning eyes made her uncomfortable there.

She looked at the road, craning her neck to the maximum. Her eyes tried to find the white Honda City beyond the cars, up to the end of the road. She could see his car from miles and she could find it even in a swamp of cars.

In the last fourteen months, she had seen him and observed him closely. How his eyes looked, how he smiled, how he fixed his hair. How many shirts did he have, and which one he wear the most? What kind of things he says when he was happy, and what he did do when he was not so happy? She had recorded each and every moment, every look, and every word he had shared with her. She could pull them out from her memory and relive them whenever she wanted, as lively as they were in the real-time.

She saw his car, moving on the road in a zigzag motion. It seemed to be moving between cars to find something. He was honking now and then. She could hear him swearing at people. She remembered how she had to ask him once the meaning of one cuss word he had used.

“Oye Bhosdike! Move your car! What are you doing? Jerking off?” He had said. Naina had repeated his words in her mind. Although she had heard those words before, she had never dared ask anyone their meaning.

“What does Bhosdi mean?” she had asked after thinking about it.

He looked at her in surprise as if she had said something which she should not have.

“Are you stupid or what? It’s nothing.”

“Is it a really bad word?” she asked again, looking at him to read his expression.

“Yes, it is! And girls don’t use these kinds of words, Okay?”

‘Then why did you say it?’ she wanted to ask, but she didn’t. She knew there are many things which girls are not supposed to do but men can do. She had seen this line which separates them as humans. But she did not know that it was not just a line, it was a deep trench. There is no easy way to fill this up and level it, that could make them one. It was later that she realised that it is never about gender. It is never about men or women. It is always about common people and those who hold the power.

Her eyes followed his car. When she saw it coming near, she came ahead on the road and waited for him to stop. He stopped the car and opened the door quickly, shouting, “Hurry. hurry... hurry! I can’t wait here for long.”

She got in and was greeted with a look like what she had been getting since morning. He looked at her slippers and her clothes. His eyes moved to her hair.

“What happened to you?” he asked while driving but moving his head in her direction to read her appearance.

She took a deep breath before saying anything. He parked the car in the corner and waited for her to start.

“My uncle saw us yesterday,” she said, playing with the skin around her thumbnail.

“What... when?”

She knew what he was asking her.

“Yes, he saw that too,” she said. Water pooled up in her eyes. Since morning, she had been holding on to herself so tight that nothing could break her. But in front of him, she always melted. Her holds came loose whenever she was with him.

“Oh, Shit...!”

His hands moved from his mouth to his neck. She could sense the tension and fear building up in the car.

“So! What next?” He kept his left hand on his thigh and moved his body in her direction. His eyes were searching her face for answers.

“I won’t be able to come to the college now. They won’t allow me to step out.”

The way she referred to her family as “They” sounded strange to her ears. How easily she had said that. How far she had come from her own family

that they felt like strangers.

‘Hmm.!’ came the reply.

Naina could not interpret his reaction.

“I think we should get married now?” she said and looked at him to see his reaction before he could hide it. She knew that he did that whenever she asked him about his drinking. He always moved his eyes to the left and the right before smiling at her. But right now, his eyes looked distant. He was looking straight through the window, beyond that black layer of glass, torn yesterday. He had not got time to fix that. His eyes were fixed on some unknown spot.

“I think we should talk at our homes,” she said.

He took a long heavy breath and nodded. Naina waited for him to say something that could give her assurance. But he was looking straight out of the windshield even now. His right hand with sleeves folded up to his elbow was straight, resting on the steering wheel, while the left hand was on his thigh. Naina was waiting for him to hold her hands in his, like he always did whenever they met.

“Okay... let’s do that!” he said, moving his neck in determination.

He held her hands and looked into her eyes.

“Give me three days. I’ll talk to my parents and will come to your home, and will talk to your parents,” he assured her.

She gave him the wildest smile she could, a smile of relief as if a burden had been lifted from her heart. She was nodding continuously, fighting back her tears. Whatever she wanted to say to him, she was saying with her eyes. Her word had ditched her again.

On their way back home, he held her hands like he always did. He kept rubbing his thumb on her fingers. Naina always loved the way he touched her hand. In those moments, she would forget everything that troubled her.

Her heart would fill with love and satisfaction. She was looking out of the window, thinking that she was just a few days far from her dream life. Soon, she would be out of that world and would enter a different one with him. A world where she could hold his hands without fear and where she could display her love without being judged.

Panic in her body returned when the car took the last turn towards her house. She looked at him with longing in her eyes. He smiled at her and whispered, “Just three days, we will be fine! I promise.

He signalled her with his eyes to get down. She nodded and quickly got down. She looked around to check for her brothers or uncle, but there was no one. She ran as fast as she could. He zoomed off in his car, looking back at her in the rear mirror.

When Naina reached her house, she gave a proud smile to herself. Her smile had that confidence. She has done it. She realized the power to fight she had inside her, and the spirit of her love. She could endure anything for him. Anything was small for that closeness that she shared with him. All great love stories have had their share of struggles and she would come over every obstacle for her love.

Her uncle and father were standing in the veranda when she entered.

“I had gone to meet him,” she said plainly, and then waited for their questions, yelling and slaps to come.

She stood in front of them with her head down and smiled when the first slap came on her cheek. The smile widened with every slap. With every blow in her stomach, her heart filled with gratitude.

‘Just three days.’ she said in her heart before closing her eyes.

■

Love asked me to dig my grave.

■

And I did.

It asked me to dance on it.

And I did.

Her father and uncle were discussing the family, who were coming to see Naina.

“The boy is educated and working in Railways.” her uncle said to her grandparents. Naina was serving dinner to them. He looked at Naina, whether she was listening or not.

“We are planning a big wedding. We met the boy and saw the house. It’s really good.” he said between morsels.

Naina had brought one plate for her father and kept it on the table. She stood there with her head down and said, “I have told it earlier. I’ll not marry anyone else.”

“Nobody has asked you to say anything! Have some shame, girl!” Dadi yelled, but Naina interrupted her.

“I won’t marry anyone. He is the only one who can touch me. I won’t go to live with anyone.” she said in a firm tone, keeping her eyes on the floor.

Her grandmother and mother gaped at her. Nobody had ever dared to reply to gents of the house, not even them. And here Naina was talking about her marriage to his father and uncle. Her uncle threw the plate she had just served him.

“What do you think we are? We are saving every single penny to get you married in a rich house, and that’s what I am hearing here.”

“See that is why people don’t want daughters! That’s what they do to their families. They bring shame if you allow them to study if you free them.” he continued in a frenzied voice.

She stood there still, keeping her eyes on the floor. That was the first time her tears did not pool up. She knew she had to fight for herself. She would not sacrifice her love for anything. She would fight till her last breath.

“Oyeeeeee! Stop it!” her father held her uncle’s hand in the air when he was about to slap her. “I’ll talk to her, she is my Beta, she will understand. She is just a kid. Don’t worry, she won’t go against us.” her father said, hugging her from one side and caressing her cheeks.

“Come on, tell everyone that it was your mistake. I know it happens at this age. I understand you, but you should also understand us. Come on, say sorry to your uncle. See, how upset he is for you.” he said pointing towards his brother who was still panting.

Naina stood there silently, trying to ignore the effect of warmth and love her father was showering on her. He was not supposed to do it right then, it was making her weak, and Naina cannot cheat Veer. She could not let that sudden warmth fool her.

“No, I have not made any mistake! I won’t get married to anyone else. I’ll marry him and only him, no matter what happens.” she said with a stone face, her eyes glued to the floor. She knew that the moment she would look at her father or her uncle, either she would melt or fear would take over her.

“I am telling you; this girl has crossed all the limits. That day I saw her with that guy. You should have seen what she was doing. This shameless girl has no morals.”

Naina closed her eyes when her uncle said it. That sick feeling came over. Saliva collected in her mouth.

“This happens when you trust your daughters. We are fools that we let them study. It’s our fault that we let them go out of the house. See, what they give us in return.” Her uncle shouted at Naina’s father and then raising his hand in the air he continued, “Brother, I have decided! I won’t let my daughters do that to me. The moment they will be 18, I’ll send them to their husband’s house. I can’t risk this kind of a shame. My daughters will also learn the same thing from her.”

“Malti, start training your daughters in cooking and household work! They have studied enough. And, I’ll kill you if I ever found them around Naina.” He screamed at his wife but his eyes were on Naina.

Now she could not hold back her tears. She loved her sisters more than anything in the world. At that moment, she remembered all those moments when she used to play with them, fight with others to save them, and did pranks with them. She wished she could say that she won’t get married to him, and let her sisters be with her. But she knew that she should not say that. There was no way they could break her.

“Come on, Beta! Say sorry to your uncle. Everything will be Okay. You don’t need to be afraid. I’ll talk to your uncle; he won’t do anything. Just tell him that you don’t know that guy anymore and you won’t have any contact with him. Come on!”

Her father gently pushed her towards her uncle and her uncle looked at her in a hope that she would finally apologize and they all would be saved from the shame that she had brought. But she stood there like a stone. She did not budge, did not utter anything.

Her uncle and father were yelling at her, but she was not able to understand them. She was seeing their lips moving, she could hear the words, but there was no meaning in them. Their words were not reaching her. They were like mere sounds that were making her head dizzy. That day, all eyes were on her, and that day, for the first time, her mind and heart were in sync. Something inside was asking her not to give up. ‘This is the first and last

opportunity to fight for your love, freedom, and for yourself.' the voice said. 'Don't give up Naina, even if they kill you. Just don't give up on yourself, on your love, on your life!' That was the only sound she was listening to at that time, and she smiled, thinking about the freedom she felt at that moment. She started feeling light in her heart, in her mind. She felt as if someone had removed the baggage of pain she had been carrying on her shoulders for years. She was proud of herself that finally she had got the voice of her own, that she had at least fought for herself, that she had the courage, which she never thought she had.

She came back to the physical world again, with a long sharp beep sound in her ear. Her head spun for a while and before she could understand anything, she had fallen. Her head hit the marble floor with a thud and she felt resounding vibrations inside her skull. The buzzing in her head was so painful that she could hardly move or even open her eyes to see the faces that had gathered above her.

A few minutes later, when she regained her senses, she found herself standing. Her younger brother and sister were taking her to her room, holding her hands, and helping her walk. There was a red splotch of blood on the spot where she had fallen. Her head was still aching and spinning. She felt a hand with a mild pressure at the back of her head, but she could not tell whose hand it was. They were not talking, but she could feel the warmth in their touch, the way they were holding her tightly, and the way her brother gently placed her head on the bed. Her grandmother, who never let Naina sleep hugging her, was hugging her like an infant. That was the warmest night she ever knew, that night she slept without a single thought of fear, without being conscious of her body, and without being worried about her safety.

She did not step out of her bed the next day. Her head was still pounding. There was a sensation at the back of her head, which increased and decreased as per its own choice. Her eyes were stuck on her room's window, which opened towards the entrance of her house. She kept her eyes on it, 'Veer might come any time from there.' She did not want to miss him. She wanted to see him with his parents and study them, before anybody else. She pictured his father as tall and muscular as Veer, but old and wearing a plain shirt with normal trousers. He would set everything. She imagined her father

and uncle talking to him in the drawing room. Her imagination always ended with their laughs and hugs. Veer would touch their feet and her father would bless him.

Naina got worried about her look, 'What if they call me inside?' She pulled back her hair with that thought. Her hand got stuck in a knot at the back. Her hair was matted due to last night's blood. She closed her eyes every time she saw anyone coming into the room. She did not have the energy to say anything, and she did not want to hear anything either. She did not want any distractions while she waited for him. She would have stopped even breathing if she could, waited for him.

When Veer did not come till late noon, she consoled herself by thinking about his conversation with his father. He might have slapped him too, and he might have shouted at him. She waited till the view outside turned dark and streetlights were turned on. 'He will come tomorrow.' She consoled herself. There must have been a reason that he had asked for three days. She thought about all the possible scenarios. 'Maybe his family also won't allow him to come. Maybe they are just talking to elders in the family. Maybe his mother will also come to soothe out the things here.' Her heart was consoling her or she was consoling her heart, she did not know. As the days passed, her hopes started fading. By the evening of the third day, she lost her hopes. Next week, a family was coming to see her. And if he did not come, she alone wouldn't be able to stop the family. She figured that it was difficult for him, and maybe he needed more time to pacify his father.

By the night, she was shivering in fever and fear had gripped her. Her father gave her a pill. Her mother patted her head until she slept. She woke up with a jerk at night. She had been dreaming about Veer. She was calling him by his name but he was walking away from her. When she ran to touch him, he disappeared. She had to call him and ask him. 'What if he wants to tell her to wait for some more days?' She didn't have a phone. Naina slipped out of her grandmother's grip and tip-toed to her parent's room. Her hands trembled when she picked up her father's phone from the bedside table and went up the terrace. She had bolted all the doors behind her on the way. Even if they found out, they won't be able to stop her from making the call. She knew what would happen if anybody came to know about it, but it was important for her, more than her life.

It was a cold January night. Her body was shivering under the thin fog. The floor beneath her bare feet was rough and cold. She pressed the buttons haphazardly. She kept looking at the flickering lights somewhere at a distance while the phone rang. She removed it from her ear and looked at the screen to check if she had dialled the correct number. He did not pick. It was like she had reached back in time, to the night when he had called him for the first time. She had felt the same fear and rush then that she was feeling right now. She pressed the green button again to recall him. He picked it up at the first ring this time.

“Hello?” he said in a raspy voice.

“Veer, it’s me. Naina!” she whispered.

“Nainaaa! Hi...How are you?” he stuttered.

She could hear the surprise and worry in his words. But she did not have the time to enquire about it right now.

“When are you coming? I am waiting for you. I can’t call you again. Please come by tomorrow.” she whispered in a hurry, glancing back at the steps of the stairs to check if anyone was coming.

“Naina, I did not talk to my father! I could not, and.....and,

I don’t think I am ready for it right now.” he said after a pause.

Naina waited for him to say something else, but when she did not hear anything she spoke again.

“Hello...Hello.....!” she said in a feeble voice.

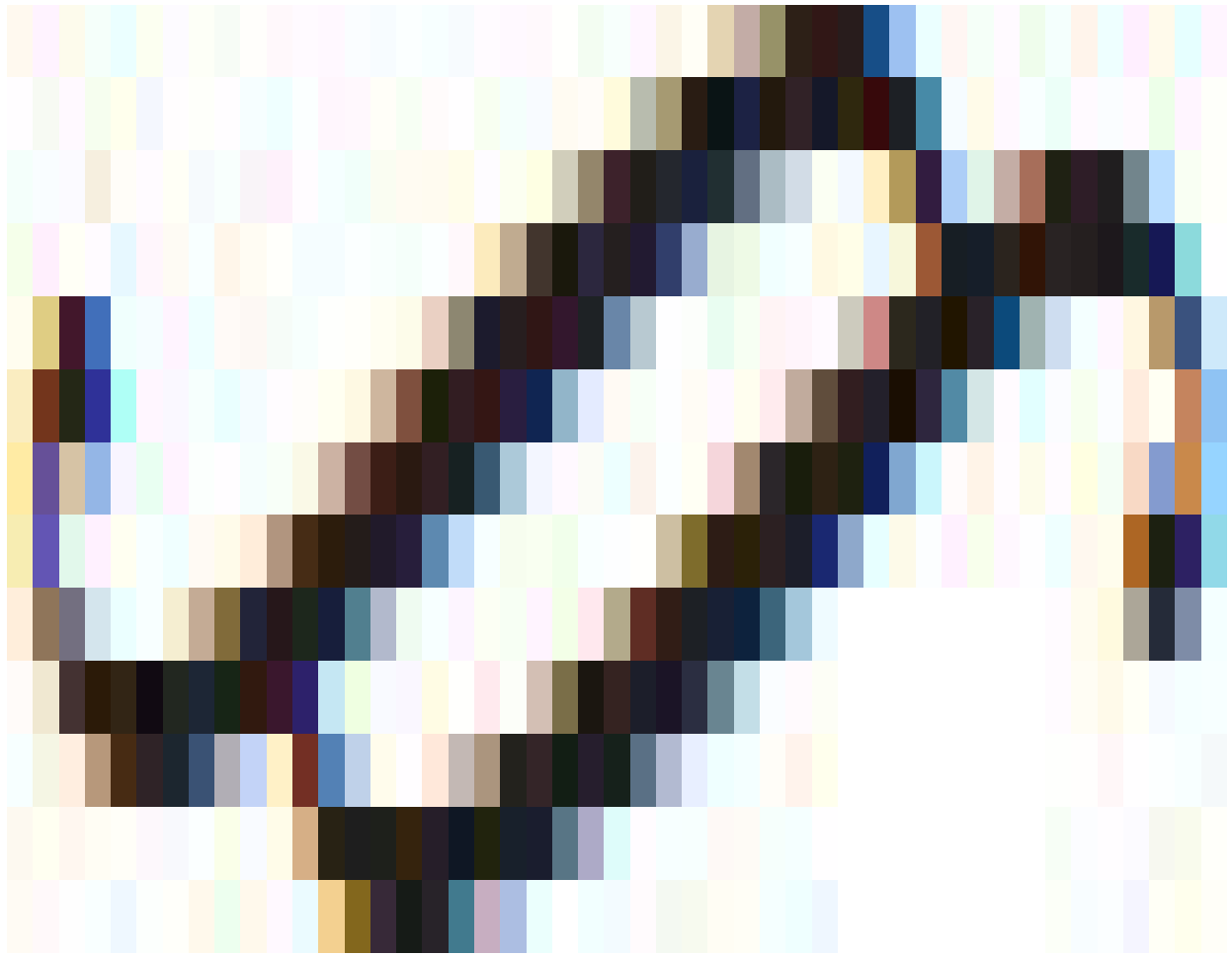
Then she heard three short beeps. She looked at the screen. The call was disconnected. The screen showed the time, “2.31 am” and floral wallpaper behind it. She could not understand whether the phone was disconnected or it was a technical fault. She called again.

“The number you are trying to reach is switched off.”

She heard the computerised message in the female voice. She could not believe that he had switched off the phone. She kept staring at the phone's screen. After a few seconds, the phone light went off, but her eyes were still on the screen. She did not know for how long she stood there. Looking at the screen with blank eyes, she tried to sit on the stairs. Her bare feet went numb, and she tripped on the stairs, tumbling over from the second step to the last one. Her head banged again and again against the edges of the steps. She let out a loud cry. But it did not reach anywhere. She could feel the sound of dying behind the locked staircase. When stood up, her right leg was paining. She tried to look down, but she could not see anything in the dark. She opened the door and went to her parent's room and called out for her mother.

“Mama.....!” she said in a painful voice.

Her mother got up from the bed, and her father followed. They were looking at her in surprise. She stood there silent, looking at nowhere in particular. Her eyes were staring at the wall in front of her. She held out the phone to her father and then collapsed on the floor. It was then that her mother noticed blood on the floor. There was a big cut on her right calf, a piece of glass stuck deep in her flesh.



Naina slept till late afternoon. When she opened her eyes, she found her mother's face looking at her. Naina looked at her with a blank face and stoned eyes. Naina's gaze was such as if she was seeing her for the first time. Her gaze shifted to the ceiling. And, after that, Naina never blinked her eyes. She didn't look at anybody. Her gaze always stayed at the ceiling. Her eyeballs remained motionless and emotionless. They would shut automatically, probably when they would get tired of staring at the off-white ceiling.

She did not talk. She did not answer anyone. Her conversation with Veer was her last word. Not even a muscle of her face moved ever after. Whenever her mother slipped one or two morsels in her mouth, she would throw up immediately, even before it could go down her throat. The only function her body was doing was breathing, and that too was barely audible.

Whenever her mother's face came over her, Naina always found her crying. She had pity and helplessness in her eyes. It irritated Naina. She could sense the suffocation inside her mother of not being able to help Naina. Or her mother understood the suffocation inside Naina and that was reflected in her eyes. Only time could tell, time that was witnessing both of them at that moment. After all, we are all extensions of each other. We all feel the same things.

Naina's mother, Krishna had never seen her that silent. She had always seen her daughter chirping and dancing around her. Naina would always be found standing by her side with a plate in her hands whenever she made something special in the kitchen. She won't speak and would just push the plate forward. She talked with her hazel eyes and her gestures which only a few could understand.

Many times, Krishna would scold her when Naina danced around her like a mad girl. But today, when she wanted Naina to dance around her, she wanted her to bring her plate, but Naina was not responding to her. All she could see was the blankness on her face and the distance in those dead eyes. And, all that Krishna could do was cry. She cried.

Krishna never left her alone, she never left her bedside. She kissed all over Naina's face and said, "I'll talk to Papa. Tell me what is bothering you! Are you angry at me? Tell me! See, I am saying sorry!". Holding her ears, she looked at Naina for a response.

"Talk to me!" She screamed at Naina, holding her at her shoulders and jerking her violently. But there was no response from Naina. Her eyes remained glued to the ceiling.

A week passed but there was no response from Naina. She did not eat anything. Her face became pale, eyes sank in. She would just open her mouth and close it when it went dry. She didn't ask for water, but Krishna understood the signal. She would pour a few sips of water. Naina gulped them down strenuously.

Many relatives came to see her. Her room was always filled with visitors. Her grandmother would come and sit at her bedside, caressing her head.

Naina could feel her rough hands on her forehead. Her hands were dry and rough like her mother's. Tears streamed from Naina's eyes at those moments. Her grandmother would wipe them saying, "You will be fine my child. Let your pain go, let it flow."

Unlike her mother, she never asked anything of her and Naina liked it that way. There was nothing she could tell them; she had lost all her words. After that conversation with Veer, she did not even talk to herself. There was nothing she could do to console herself and others.

"She hasn't eaten anything in the last seven days. She does not talk. She just stares at the ceiling and her hands and feet are always cold." her mother explained her condition to the doctor when he visited her. He only had stitched her wounds the day she had fallen. There were three stitches on her head and seven in the calf.

"Does she have any stress or tension? Is she thinking about something that is bothering her?" The doctor asked after checking her pulse and BP. He flashed his torchlight in her eyes. Her eyeballs danced and then stopped after a while. He plugged the stethoscope in his ears and pushed its other on her chest. He was listening to her heartbeats as if listening to some song earphone.

"She seems normal so far. I don't understand why her body is rejecting food. Did you try feeding her liquid, juices or shakes?" the doctor asked her father.

"She vomits out everything immediately." He replied shaking his head sideways.

The doctor looked back at Naina and asked her if her stomach hurt. He pressed her stomach and abdomen at various points looking for some expression of pain. But, Naina did not move. She stayed still, staring at the ceiling. She closed her eyes slowly when the doctor kept asking her about her head and leg injury. They had not healed as yet. The doctor motioned her father to come out and talk. Krishna looked at them worriedly.

"What is wrong with my daughter?" she asked the doctor, who was walking out of the room. She with her husband followed him.

“There is nothing wrong internally, as far as I can tell. However, it seems she does not want to live anymore. I think something has disturbed her deeply. Has something happened which is disturbing her? I can help her only when you tell me what has happened...” he said.

Her father was looking down, trying to find words. He looked up and said, “Nothing Sir! I found that she was meeting some guy in the college, so I just scolded her and slapped her a little hard. She cried for days and then suddenly one day she stopped eating and talking.”

The doctor weighed his words, then said, “Talk to her about it with love and make her understand. She will be fine soon. Give some liquid diet and these medicines.”

He scribbled some multivitamin tablets and left.

In the next two days, Naina showed some signs of improvement. She would get up and sit on her mother’s instructions. But she did not look at anyone, her eyes still stared blankly at the walls and the ceiling. The problem of her throwing up the food also persisted. She only sipped water mixed with sugar and salt. Her hair was even now matted with blood. Her armpits and clothes stank of vomit and sweat. She had not cleaned herself for nine days now. Her mother and her younger sister helped her to the bathroom.

That day her mother left her in the bathroom saying, “I am coming in five minutes, remove your clothes. I’ll get the soap by then.”

When she came back, she found Naina standing on the stool. One end of her dupatta was wrapped around her neck in a loose knot and she was trying to hook the other end to the shower. Krishna let out a fearful scream.

Everybody rushed hearing her scream. Standing there, Krishna was shivering, seeing her daughter like that. Naina’s father removed the dupatta from her neck and lifted her up like a baby in his arms. Her birdlike frame looked small in his hands. After that day, Krishna always stayed with her. She was scared of Naina’s gaze when she stared at ceilings aimlessly as if she was possessed. Krishna would take her with her to the kitchen and make her sit next to her around the fireplace. She would sit next to her mother or

her aunt, with her knees close to her chest and her hands crossed around them. Her cousin, brother, and sister would gather and try to make her laugh with funny stories but Naina only stared in a void.

One day, in the kitchen, she was sitting next to her aunt, who was cooking Chapatis for dinner. Naina was looking at her aunt's hand, how it moved fearlessly while tossing the round bread on the hot iron plate, how she smoothed it and turned it over and over again using her fingers. Naina's eyes did not get off the fire burning in the hearth. A little later, when her aunt turned her face to pack the Chapattis in a casserole after cooking them, Naina put both her hands on the hot iron plate palms down. She winced when her soft skin first touched the burning plate, but she didn't cry, she didn't remove her hands. She kept there, with eyes stuck to them. The pain inside her seemed to have lessened. It was a relief for her, it had distracted her mind from that stagnant silence. In those moments, she had forgotten everything else and was aware only of that burning sensation. She closed her eyes and concentrated on it. She could feel the burning of her skin, but it could not overpower the pain she had inside her.

She was sitting with her hands on the hot tava, when her aunt turned back and saw her, she removed her hands. She held Naina in her arms and clenched her to her chest as if trying to hide her inside her.

“What happened to you, my doll? Talk to me! Why are you doing this to yourself? Why are you doing this to me?” She asked in a crying tone.

Naina kept looking at the live coal pieces in the hearth. Her head moved when her mother came and picked her. Krishna let loose a painful wail, which she had been holding inside her for so many days. She felt as if her heart would burst out of her chest with pain. She cried as if she was holding a dead body in her arms. Her pain had no bounds and tears flowed from her eyes like streams. She was moving to and fro holding her lifeless baby in her arms. She placed her hand on Naina's eyes to close them when she could no longer look at those scary eyes.

Naina felt so small in her arms. Her face was expressionless and her eyes stoned. It felt like there was an invisible shield or a wall around her, which

did not allow any emotion, any voice, any feeling of love and warmth to reach her. Everything touched it and then bounced back.

Everyone had gathered around them on hearing the wail of her mother. All her aunts were crying. It was only Naina, whose eyes were dry even then.

Later at night when she was on her bed, an eerie silence took over the house. The whole house overflowed with deafening silence. It pierced every wall and every person living behind those walls. Cries which Naina could not give out roared all around there in that silence.

CHAPTER

■

21

■

I know not how much I cried that day,

But I remember that my eyes bled,

After tears had dried up.

It had been twenty days since Naina had had her last conversation with Veer. She remained mute for all these days. Her mother had lost hope of hearing her daughter's voice again. After the complete silence for these twenty days, she started talking to invisible people around her. She was having hallucinations and nightmares. Her mother got afraid, but she tried to talk to Naina normally as if everything is good and normal. Naina's father has instructed her to do so. She would tell Naina stories at night, and sometimes sing some songs, but Naina did not react.

But then one day, she woke up with a jerk. Her breathing was heavy and fast, as if there was not enough oxygen reaching her lungs. Something was suffocating her. Her body was burning like hot coal. Sweat beads were running down her neck into her back. She held her shirt and sweater, raised her hands straight, pulling them together over her head, and took both of them off in one go. Her neck, armpits and skin under breast was all sticky with sweat. She first rubbed her hands on her neck, then moved them below her breasts. She picked up the shirt which she had just removed, rolled it over and wiped her underarms with it. Her bandaged hands hurt when she moved her hand but she did not stop.

It was a cold December winter. Temperature was below 10 degrees, but her body was burning. She got down and removed all her clothes one by one and sat on her bed stark naked. She dug her nails into her skin, scratched her arms until they started bleeding. There was something burning on the left side of her chest. She could not find words for it but there was an uncomfortable and unbearable pain in her heart. She scratched her chest, arms, and legs violently and the more she scratched the more the burning increased. She howled in pain, when she couldn't bear the fiery feeling. She took a break and then howled again.

Everyone rushed into the room. Her mother quickly covered her with the blanket, but Naina threw it off, and let out heartrending shriek. Her hands were moving all over her body as if on their own. She looked like the madwoman in their neighbourhood.

Naina started shouting something. In the midst of sobs and howls, her words came only partly. She looked at the crowd standing in front of her. Her howling increased. Everybody was scared to see her like that. Nobody moved, they stood there horrified with pity in their eyes. Tears rolled down her brothers' and sister's eyes. She was howling, pointing fingers at them, as if she was complaining to them.

Suddenly, she got up and ran towards the main gate and unlatched it. Her father and uncles came running behind her, calling out for her to stop. Before she could step out of the house, her father picked her up in her arms. Her mother put her dupatta on Naina's naked body. Naina kept howling and throwing her hands, trying to get rid of her father's grip. Her father clenched her, lifted her up and brought her to bed. Her uncle and aunts held her hands and feet while she kept moving every free part of her body. Her back and waist moved violently. She shook her head right and left in a frenzy. The fire was burning her head, she just wanted that heat to get out of it. She just wanted to be free from the heaviness in her head, on her heart, on her soul. She became calm after some time. She closed her eyes and slept. This was the first time her panic attack had taken such a wild form. The beast she had been running away from had taken over her that night. Its nails and sharp teeth tore her from inside. She could picture the beast getting inside her through her head. It pulled her heart out and then ate it sitting in her belly.

Once satisfied, it came out, through her head again.

She would break out and cry incessantly. Images and memories floated in her eyes. They danced in front of her eyes and they danced behind her eyelids. There was no way she could escape them. It was like the beast brought all kinds of painful experiences to torture her. She would close her eyes and would travel to somewhere in the past. Every time she went to a new place or a new memory, she could see her younger self there with others and the older self-staring at her from afar. She could not help her even if she wanted.

One day, she found herself on the terrace. Little Naina was standing in line, waiting for her turn to bathe. Every Sunday all kids would gather on the terrace and his uncle would apply oil all over the body. This practice was basically for boys but Naina did not understand the difference till then and so did other kids. Everybody took out their clothes and stood only in their white banyan and underwear. They would sit in a circle and start applying oil all over the body. After that, her uncle called everybody one by one and massaged their arms and legs. He gently rubbed their arms, legs and backs so that their body could soak all the oil. Before the message, her uncle ordered everyone to remove banyan except Naina. He hesitated at first to give her a message but when he read the expression of being left out, he massaged her arms and her feet gently and asked her to take a bath quickly.

When Naina took out her banyan, her younger brother looked at her and shouted. “Look everyone!”

His finger pointed towards Naina’s breast. Her right breast had started to sprout but her left breast was still flat and untouched by puberty. She gave a proud smile to everyone. She pushed her chest out a little more, to give everybody a good look at them. All the boys came over to see her protruding breast. They circled her, looked at her chest intently as if they were trying to read something there. Naina felt strange, but happy that she was the reason for everybody’s attention. All eyes were on her breast and everybody was amusingly confused.

“Aaaaaahhhhhh.....!” Naina whimpered when her younger brother, out of curiosity, squeezed her breast. And that’s when Naina felt uncomfortable

about herself for the very first time.

“Naina got lemon... see everyone, she got a lemon!” He shouted again.

Naina tried to cover herself with her hands while her brother continued teasing her. Her baby mind was still trying to decipher the change her body was going through. Her smile was suddenly replaced by shame. She did not know why, but she felt that it was not a good thing to show or to be seen.

She thought about it while bathing. She looked down at her breasts and studied them. She could not understand why one of them was swollen. Thinking about it, she could not eat and sleep properly. She thought that she had got some disease. She also felt disgusted seeing her one breast growing while the other remained as flat as a button. She used to confine herself in a corner when her brothers and their friends started calling her Nimbu.

Whenever she would go out to play with them, they would take turns to touch it. And when she shouted at them, they would throw her out of their teams. They would gather and sing ‘Nimbu pani’ in unison until she broke into tears and ran away from there.

“Hey Bhagwaan! I’ll do all my homework, I won’t take money from almirah ever, please fix my disease! Please God, please fix them once. I won’t do anything wrong after that!” She would hold her hands in front of her chest and pray secretly at night. She would check herself every morning, to see if God had granted her the wish, but nothing happened. Her right breast kept growing and then after some days, when her left breast also started sprouting, sadness engulfed her. She cried out aloud sitting on her bed. When her grandmother asked her, she pulled her shirt up and showed it to her. Crying and sobbing, she sat there, holding her shirt up till her shoulders.

When she saw her grandmother looking at them, she stopped crying and asked in a choked voice, “Will the doctor cut them off?”.

She pulled down her shirt and started crying again when her grandmother started laughing at her. She was laughing so hard that she could not talk. Her mouth was wide open and her shoulders were shaking while she was laughing. Naina ran away from there and locked herself in the bathroom. Disgusted and frustrated, she leaned against the wall and pressed her breast

hard so that they could get back to their normal size. Her tender breasts ached as if hundreds of needles had been pierced in them, but she kept pressing them to the wall. The pain waxed with every single second, she whimpered but did not stop. She pressed them hard, thinking about her brother and Dadi, who laughed at her. She cupped her breast softly when she could not take the pain, she caressed them so subside the pain. Those swollen breasts scared her, and left a feeling of disgust in her.

These sudden changes in her body left her more confused and sadder. Along with her body, everything around had started to change. Layers of these new changes kept unfolding every day. She noticed the change in expression in the eyes of others, not at home, but outside. She sensed people, especially from the opposite gender, were looking at her differently. She felt as if they were trying to read her body, to see the changes which she was experiencing. Although she could not understand the difference that much, their stares made her conscious about her own body. Whereas everybody was reading changes in her body, she was trying to read the changes she was seeing in their eyes. Sometimes, out of curiosity, she would hold eye contact with them just to understand that look which was making her uncomfortable. She tried, but she could not. All that she understood was a desire to cover herself.

And that's when it all started. Real-world was all set to welcome her. Life was about to teach her the lesson which she could not understand ever and which left her vulnerable for the rest of her life.

"1,2,3,4,5,6....," she was counting loudly with her eyes closed. At the count of twenty. She opened her eyes and started looking around. It was her turn this time to find her friends while playing hide and seek. She was playing with her friend and other children at her friend's house in a four-storey building in the neighbourhood.

At one of the secluded corners of the house, she felt someone caught her by her wrist. When she looked back, she found it was her friend's uncle. He was staring at her breasts. He looked differently at them. It was the kind of stare which she would never forget; it was not the usual looks she used to get. It scared her; she looked around to find someone around. She knew something was wrong at that moment. She tried to open his grip, using her other hand.

“Leave me uncle!” she cried. Her heart was pounding and mind was bursting with confusion. She held her gaze at his face. She read him. He was not looking at her face, instead his eyes were on her tiny breasts only.

Naina was on the verge of crying when he started fiddling with her breasts. He ran his fingers over them softly, as if he was touching a flower, but then he started pressing them hard and pinched them violently as if he wanted to pluck that flower out. Naina did not say anything initially, but when the piercing pain rose in them, she let out a loud cry. She tried to run but could not. When she opened her mouth to shout again, he kept his hand on her mouth and closed it before she could.

“Shhhh... Shhhh... Shhhh!” he said, running a quick eye around. He kept his index finger on his lips and signalled her to keep quiet.

“I’ll let you go... shhhh...shhhh...first stop shouting and crying,” he said, still holding his hand on her mouth.

Naina nodded, after which he removed his hand. She stood there silently, against the wall, waiting for his next instruction.

“Take, take this and give me a kiss!” he said, placing a one-rupee coin on her palm.

He, without waiting for Naina to respond, pouted his lips and leaned forward to kiss her lips. Naina leaned back and moved her face left and right to avoid his touch. He held her little frame more tightly and this time instead of ordering her, he pleaded with her, “Please take this! Keep it and kiss me.” he said again while caressing her cheeks. He was not pleading, only with his words. In fact, his face deceived his helplessness, as if he would die of hunger if she did not let him touch her. He ran immediately when he heard someone’s footsteps on the stairs. She silently watched him jumping, taking leaps to run before anybody could see him.

Naina ran away from there and ran all the way to her home. She kept looking back, turning her head in fear of whether he was following or not.

She went to her bed and covered herself with a thick blanket, still shivering in fear.

She felt tired as if someone had sucked all her energy. Her legs ached. She fell asleep in no time. Her mind could not forget his face. She did not know how to name the ugly feel that was dripping out of his eyes and his touch. What was that she had felt? That day, she could not understand, but she understood later. She understood that her tiny breasts had aroused him, that how a nine-or ten-year girl could ignite the fire in him.

After hours, when she woke up late in the evening, it was as if that thing had happened months back. That's the thing with children. They forget things easily in one day. They live by the day, make memories, and then forget them. But little do they know that everything comes back.

That was her first introduction to the meaning of being a girl, but she was not able to decipher that. That was the first time she had seen the ugly side of world.

And after that another part of the world started to unfold. Her childish mind could not understand them and with its every failure the layers of ugly worldly truth grew thick.

And once it started, it never stopped. Naina was clueless that she had entered a world where there is a different meaning of being a girl, a world where every girl is treated like a piece of meat, a world where she was being preyed, and that she needed to protect herself from them. Little Naina was about to break her cocoon, she was at the verge of being a girl. There were so many things taking place around her. Mentally and physically everything was changing. She was seeing things which she did not understand, but she could not ask anybody about anything. She did not have the idea that she needed to ask someone, and nobody cared to tell her anything about those changes.

And then her life stopped moving after an afternoon. Her smile was in her control only till that fateful afternoon. After that day, her lips forgot the taste of smiles, excitement, happiness, all of them. Since then, she lost control over herself and with time she lost her right in her own life. By the time she understood the meaning of being a girl; she had lost it all. Reality had hit her hard, hard. World injected the bitter truth quite venomously in her veins.

Now, when she thinks of herself, she still sees herself as a ten-year-old girl, who is washing her privates with tears overflowing her hazel eyes. Naina, sometimes she herself thought, was blessed, or cursed with those hazel eyes. They attracted the wrong attention, at the wrong time, and her innocence paid the price for the mischiefs of those hazel eyes. Those glittery eyes, which changed colours with light. Her smile paid the price for the mischief which her eyes played unknowingly.

That innocent curiosity in her eyes soon changed into blankness, with a touch of maturity which she attained before she touched her puberty.

She was on her way back from school when she saw Ashok coming toward her.

“Naina....!” Ashok said, smiling at her when he reached near her.

Naina joined her hands and bowed her head a little to greet. “Namaste Uncle!” she said.

“Come, come here,” he said, motioning at her. He took out a 10 Rupee note from his pocket and placed it on her palms.

“Go eat something,” he said, patting her cheeks. Naina looked at the note and then at him in surprise.

“What should I get for you?” she asked him.

Ashok laughed, looking up and shook her head saying, “No... No..No! This is for you. Go buy and eat something.”

Nobody had ever talked to her so lovingly except her mother and sometimes her father. She thought for a moment, holding that note in her fist. She looked up and grinned at him and ran. This was the first time anybody had given her a 10 Rupee note, entirely for her to splurge. She thought of all the things she could buy with it. Her speed increased with excitement. She bought as many candies as she could afford in those 10 Rupees. She filled her pockets to the brim. Her happiness sparkled in her eyes, smiling eyes. She always smiled with her eyes.

That was one of the happiest days of her life. She ran back to Ashok and hugged him tightly. He lifted her up in her arms, her legs reaching to his knees. He helped her on his feet, saying, "Ohh.... you have grown up. Now I can't lift you in my arms."

Naina giggled. When he held her hand, Naina looked at him in admiration and they walked towards Haree's house.

"Show me, what did you buy?" He said, sitting next to her on his chair. They met every day at Haree's house.

It was after the death of Haree that Naina had started coming there regularly. She would play there all alone. Nobody disturbed her there when she got her wooden bride and groom married. Nobody called her for household work. Nobody teased her as Nimbu. She had got scared one day when Ashok came there with labourers behind him. She was in the middle of her invisible feast of wedding.

"Please please eat." she was saying to the groom and then she smiled back at it, pulling her dupatta over her head like her mother used to do.

When she saw them, she quickly removed the shawl from her head and got up. Ashok was giving some instructions to the labourers. He moved his hands from one room to another, then made a square in the air with both of his hands. One of them said something and then nodded. He took out his pen from the back of ear and wrote down something in a tiny diary. He licked his index finger, then turned the page and wrote down again.

Naina looked at them, her eyes half closed due to the sun. Her eyes followed their hands, she looked at the room with them, then turned to the ceiling, and then took a few steps to join them and went inside the kitchen. She looked at Ashok as if she was one of the labourers and she had to understand everything to complete the tasks. Ashok smiled back at her in between. And she smiled back proudly at him.

She would see labourers, going in and out of the rooms, taking a big bowl of thick paste of cement and water on their heads in a wide iron pan. It had layers of dried cement around it.

Ashok would watch them and bark instructions at them while she played in the corner. Ashok would bring chocolate and candies for her and she would eat them right there. Opening her mouth wide open. She would smile at him, showing her brown teeth.

He would make her sit on his lap and talk about herself, about her school and friends. He would tell her stories of his young age, how he used to walk kilometres to study and to buy stuff in the market.

“We were very poor when I was of your age.” he said once rubbing her back softly, “We used to eat only once in a day. Candies.. .oh.... never. Our father never gave us any money to buy them. That’s why I bring them to you.”

Naina unwrapped a toffee and put it in his mouth.

“You can eat them now with me.” She said, giving him a fake smile. She did not know how to react to it.

“See...., I got all different kinds of toffees and candies... see...!” she giggled and hooked her skirt’s pocket with her thumb to open it wide and took turns to let him look at it clearly. She took out all the toffees, giggling all the way as if she was showing a treasure. “Come, let’s count them.” he motioned her to come closer.

“One, two, three....” she was counting and giggling in between when he tickled her again and again. She pulled in her stomach and moved it left and right whenever his fingers touched her from the sides.

This day indeed was the happiest of her life, she thought to herself. Nobody had ever invited her to play along, and nobody had ever shown so much of interest in her. Oblivious of the fact that she was being preyed on, she was really happy, while he was eating her from her eyes.

He was touching her waist and his eyes were on her tiny breasts, which had not even sprouted properly.

“Sssssssss.....” she whimpered when she felt his rough hand touch them directly.

“Ohh, what happened?” he asked. “Do they hurt?” He caressed them again.

“Yes, Uncle!” She nodded. Tears pooled up in her eyes. Thinking about how her Dadi had laughed at her.

“Why? What happened to them?” he said softly as if his high tone would also hurt her.

“Uncle, I am not well...! I don’t know why they are getting bigger. They hurt when somebody touches them. They hurt when I run and jump. They always hurt.” Tears rolled down her eyes as she said the last words.

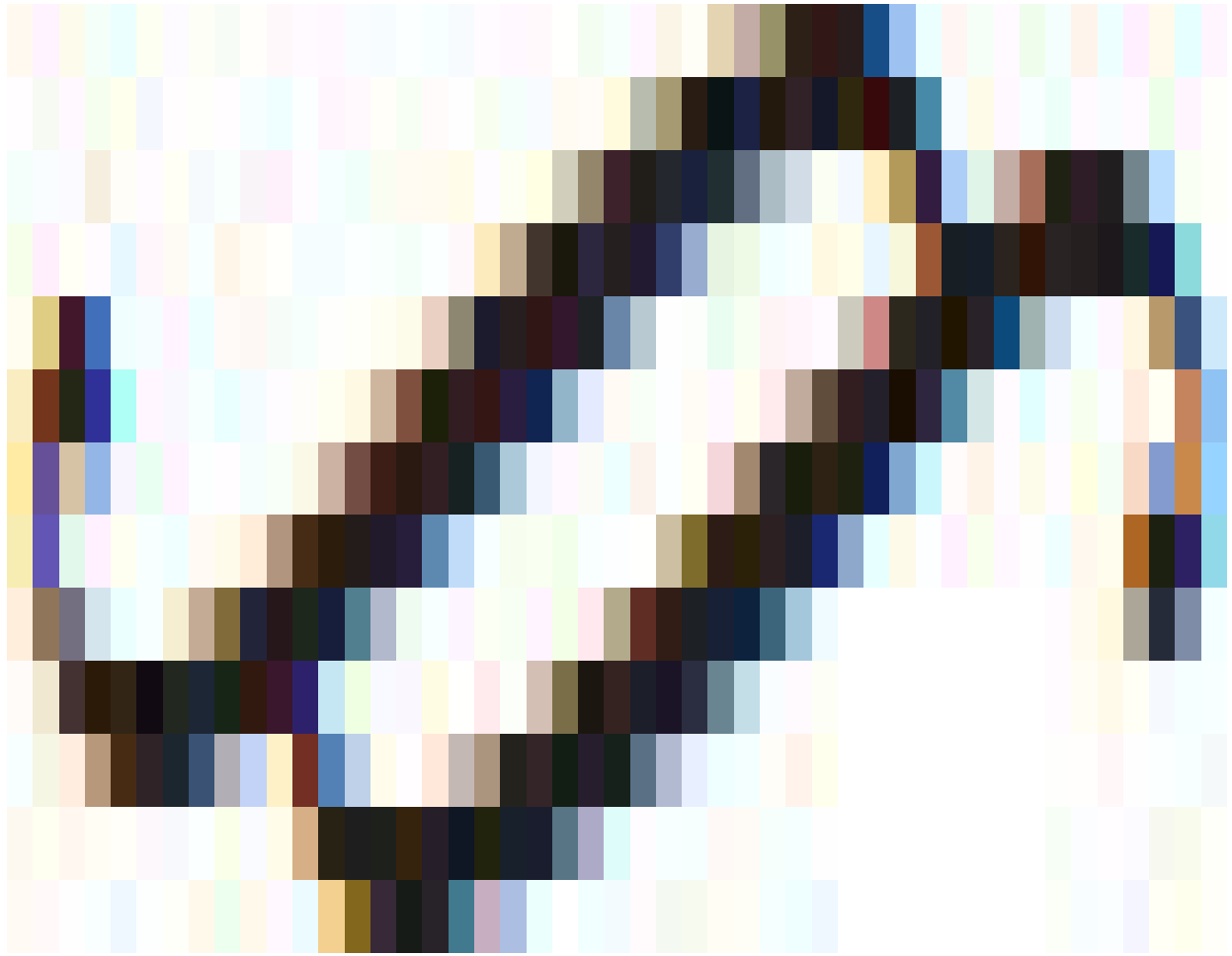
“I’ll die soon. They are getting bigger every day and I will die in a few days.”

She took a long breath and then wiped her eyes one by one with the back of her hands.

He caressed her back slowly. His hand moved up and down, touching her all the way. He hooked her hands under armpits and then made her sit on his lap. Naina hid her face in his neck as his hand caressed her hands and legs. He let go of her when one of the labourers called him. She stopped crying and stood to leave.

“You are such a good girl. Now go home,” he said before she left.

He looked at her from her back when she turned to go. Her stick-thin legs looked long in that blue skirt from far.



“I will freeze you and you will have to stay as if you are frozen until I release you. Okay, got it?” Ashok was telling her the rules of their new game. “You can’t move at all. And you can’t even smile or laugh,” he said again with stress and seriousness.

“Yes, uncle, I got that. I won’t move.”

And she made a serious face, folding her lips tight. Naina crossed her hands on her chest and stood still. Her eyes darting out.

“But we won’t play here today, it’s really hot, let’s go inside and then we will play. Ok? I’ll give you more chocolates, if you win the game.”

She slouched her shoulders and then let go of her tight posture. Her hands hung loose when she walked behind Ashok, her back still bent in the middle.

They went into Haree's old bedroom. It still smelled of fresh cement and dust. It still had a damp feel in it. There was a cot in the middle of the room, with a blue old bed sheet spread on it. She had never seen the cot before but she did not mind it. There were no labourers there that day. They had gone home after lunch. She looked at him when he stopped and turned towards her.

"Go sit there!" he said, pointing his finger to the cot.

He made her sit on it, her legs dangling a few inches above the grey cemented floor. Every time she saw his finger moving towards her ears, she giggled, scratching them.

"I won't play if you keep doing this," Ashok said with fake irritation.

She closed her eyes tight, sensing his irritation. He moved his finger on her forehead. Naina felt the itch there. He slowly moved his fingers down to her cheeks and then turned towards the back of her ear. He made circles on the back of her neck. She shuddered. Her shoulders went up automatically, grasping his fingers between her head and the skin collected around the bottom of her neck.

"Don't move!"

Naina straightened her back again. Her skin tickled, but she sat unmoved and silent when his fingers traced her back. He ran his fingers over the knots of her backbone.

"Ohh, you are strong. Let me try something else."

He took out a 100 Rupee note from his pocket, rolled it like a cigarette, and tickled her ear again. Naina could not stop this time, and laughed aloud.

"You lost it!" Ashok said in a flat tone when Naina looked up at him.

"No, uncle, one more time, we will play one more time. Please..., Please..., Please!"

"Ok, last time. And if you lose this time, you will do what I say, ok?"

“Yes yes, last time! I won’t move this time, sure.” And she closed her eyes tightly.

He ogled her up and down, his eyes moved on her thin legs, her knees, her sleek fair neck. He stood in front of her and unzipped his pants slowly and took out his penis. His one hand was still touching her face when he started rubbing it with the other hand. His hands kept moving at their respective places. Naina was feeling the tickles, but she worked hard at keeping her body still and her eyes closed.

She opened her eyes with a screech when he squeezed her breast violently.

Crying, she pushed him back. He stumbled a little, but then steadied. He kept looking at her while his hands moved in slow motion. She moved her gaze from his face to below.

She leaped off the cot and ran. From the corner of her eyes, she saw his hand reaching out to her. His fingers touched her wrist and then grabbed her tightly. He pulled her back forcefully. She was on the verge of shouting when he slapped her hard and she fell. Her head hit the wooden leg of the cot.

“I don’t want to play with you!” She got up and ran again.

He grabbed her from her waist this time, cupping her mouth with one hand.

He threw her on the cot. Her skirt moved up and then gathered at her thighs. Exposing her blue underpants. He stretched her hands and pinned them down with his knees.

“Momma.....! Uncle, please don’t beat me, I am sorry.”

She threw her legs and twisted her body under him, but his grip was too strong for her to break. Skin around her wrists turned white with pressure. She could feel his fingers digging into her.

He placed his hand on her mouth before she could shout again. He grabbed her both thin hands in one hand, above her head, and nearly sat over her. He took out his penis again from his unzipped pant and rubbed it sitting over

her. He unhooked her tie, unbuttoned her shirt with one hand and left it open. He pulled up her slip down till her breast and gazed at her breast as if he was looking at a lost treasure which he had been looking for so long. He squeezed them hard again, his face was different. He was not the same Uncle Naina had known.

Naina shouted again when he lifted his hand mistakenly while undressing. He took out his handkerchief, stuffed it in her mouth, and tied her hands with her own tie. She choked, that handkerchief was stretching her cheeks. She tried throwing it out, but could not move her tongue. He lifted her skirt and pulled out her blue underwear with both hands. Naina kicked his face when he reached the end of her legs.

“Saali...Kutiya....!” he roared and slapped her hard.

“Randi... I know that’s what you always wanted. And now, you are giving me attitude. I have fucked a lot of randis like you.” he said and inserted his middle finger in her.

“Tell me, why did you show me your breasts when you did not want this? Tell me.....!” She could not shout, but her eyes depicted the intense cry that was choking her. Her eyes widened. She gasped for air. She twisted her body in the middle and shook her head violently as he penetrated her with his finger.

“Ahh, you such a good girl, you did not get hair. Look at your soft whiskers! You are so soft, I like soft girls, like you.” he said with a lecherous smile, hungry eyes.

Naina had never seen eyes and a smile as horrifying as that. There was something dangerous in his smile and eyes, which Naina could not understand. She didn’t understand why he was beating her. What did she do?

He touched her thighs, moved his hands to her small belly and then to her breasts. He was smiling at himself while squeezing her breasts again and again. With every streak of pain, Naina moved her head violently left and right, closing her eyes tightly, as if trying to surpass the pain by shutting them.

He stretched her legs, made space between them, placed his private, and with one hard push, he went inside her.

Naina's eyes turned bloodshot. They sprawled, as if they would break their edges and her eyeballs would pop out. Her body bent in the middle, making an arch. Her vision became blurry before she lost her consciousness. He kept moving up and down on her while she stayed motionless. Her head turned to one side and her eyes closed slowly. After releasing him in her, he moved her face, lifting it up with one hand. He took out the handkerchief from her mouth and placed it between her legs. It soaked the blood; he cleaned her in a hurry and then wiped her penis on the same. He folded it again in a square and placed it between her legs and closed them tight.

After an hour or so when she gained consciousness, she found herself fully dressed. She was sweating profusely, and her body was aching, especially her limbs.

Still heavy in her head, she stood slowly and stumbled when she felt a piercing pain between her legs. She felt as if someone had slit her and left the knife between her legs. She touched herself and cried in pain. Her vagina was so sensitive that she could not bear her own touch. It felt as if she had placed burning coal there. It was swollen like a bun. There were red marks on her underwear. She felt like someone had sprinkled chilly on a wound when she touched herself.

Till now her pain was when Keshav pulled her hair and it hurt her a lot, but today the pain which she was bearing was beyond her measurement of pain.

Misery was not that she was in pain, the real misery was that she did not understand what had happened with her, and did not know what words to use for it. What did that mean? Why did her favourite uncle do that?

All her baby mind could tell her that her uncle beat her because she had pushed him. Only if somebody had warned her about this world, she could have saved herself. The only misery of her life was that she did not know it, that every lesson which she learnt was only after she went through them.

That day, when she went home, she locked herself in the bathroom, vomited, and tried to get rid of that stinky smell he had left all over her and she felt it in her mouth. Splashes of cold water eased her pain for a while. She slept for hours that day in her school dress itself. She did not tell anybody about it. Because she just could not put meaning to that incidence. When she did not feel that what had happened to her was wrong, she did not feel the need of telling it. She did not understand that she was raped. She did not feel that somebody would listen to her and maybe punish that old guy just for her sake in her mind, she was not important enough. Instead, after that her worth degraded in her own mind. She believed that she was not loveable and she should not even look for that.

All the memories which Naina tried to forget became alive and came back to her. It was one of such nights when she walked out of her house. And after that night, her father chained and locked the bedroom from outside and slept outside. The beast visited her again. First it came after 3-4 days, but after a fortnight it started coming daily. She would wake up jumping, shaking her head violently, howling. After 15 minutes of screaming, her body would be shivering like dried leaves falling from a tree. Her mother, aunties, father, and uncle would rub her palms and soul of her feet to keep her warm till she fell asleep again.

All through the day, in her mind her memories would play like a movie. Her fits and nightmares were results of that. One day, she saw a face overhead. She was lying naked beneath and he had pinned her down. Her legs were wide open and that man was trying to enter her. She tried to get free from his grip. She threw her legs in the air, twisted them to stop him from entering her, but she could not move him. She tried to scratch his face but somehow, she could not touch him. Her hands passed through his face. She tried again and again but she could not touch him. Her family saw her hands moving violently in the air as if she was trying to hold something. They tried to get hold of her twisting legs but she threw them whenever she felt their touch on them.

She cried out loud when that invisible man entered her and stroked her continuously. Her eyes were wide open and turned up. She wanted to close her legs and put her hands between her thighs but they were in a tight grip and she could not move them. Few minutes later, that face disappeared. She

relaxed her muscles and closed her eyes. When her family loosened the grip around her wrist and legs, she quickly pulled them up to her chest and cried until she fainted.

Her fits and nightmares were different every time. Her mind would pull a memory from her past and play it in front of her. She would see the images vividly, would hear the conversations clearly, and that would hurt. She would end up crying and shouting.

Whenever the words of her father, “She has brought shame... she is shameless....!” rang in her ears, she would cry like an infant. Her mother tried to calm her down - holding her in her arms. But her tears did not stop, she would cry till her eyes dried, and she lost the strength to keep them open.

Her anger, pain, helplessness, and shame, which she had not been able to express, was now overpowering her. Drenched in an avalanche of emotions, she did not know how to express them in words. She did not know how to tell them as to how she felt at that time and how she was feeling. All her life she had been thinking that she was unwanted, unloved, and suddenly now every member of the family was pouring love on her. In their eyes, she saw the love that she always craved for. In the same eyes she had seen the anger which she had caused. She was confused, which version of them was true. Her father had held her in his arms late at night when nobody was seeing them. She had seen him slapping her. She had seen hate in them and now she was seeing in them the concern, too.

Suddenly, the whole world had started revolving around her. From kids to adults and elderly, everyone was trying their best to take care of her. Naina never knew that she could be that important to anyone. That her family will ever shower love on her like that. They were supposed to hate her, and Naina was also supposed to hate them for hurting her directly or indirectly. How can they love her so blindly now?

More than anything, Naina was ashamed of herself. The pain she was carrying in her heart suddenly turned into guilt. Her heart felt heavy when she saw tears in her mother’s eyes, when she saw her running here and there to cook for her, trying out every dish she could cook for Naina. She had never seen her father like this. He always walked with pride, as if he ruled

the world. But today, she saw him crying, sitting next to her at night. She saw him tossing and turning in his bed by her side. He talked very little; his face seemed a little older, as if he had grown by 20 years in the last 20 days.

She had never seen such innocent faces in her life. She started hating herself for having blamed them all her life. Her fight had always been against them, that they used to corner her, that they didn't love her, and that hate gave her the strength to stand against them. But now she felt as if she was the one who had cheated them, cornered them, and eventually stabbed them.

Every moment with them felt heavy. She wanted to shrink inside her, wanted to disappear from their life. She did not have the courage to look at them in their eyes. She felt so small in front of them. Everyone asked her to look at them. But, how could she do that? How could she look into those eyes whom she had betrayed, whom she had distrusted all her life?

Naina's condition was getting worse and worse every day. The doctors did all the possible tests they could do, but everything seemed normal with her body. But alas they could not read her mind and her heart which were fighting with each other, pulling her to their sides, tearing her apart internally. Her fits became frequent and violent. Kids stopped coming in her room. Her face and her behaviour scared them. In fact, she scared everyone and herself as well. She did not recognise herself.

Who was she? She could not be anything. She could not be a daughter, she could not be a sister, and she could not even be herself. She had not been like that always. Her eyes had dreams, her face was innocent, her lips had a smile. But today, except guilt she didn't have anything and all she gave to herself and to her family was pain and tears. Everyone's face made her feel like she was the reason for all their sufferings.

Like Naina, everyone was experiencing the same emotion. Initially, they were angry at her, then it turned into dejection, and now it was pity. Nobody knew where this avalanche would take them. Many of them had lost hopes that their Naina would ever come back to them.

■

*I don't know how does a broken heart look like,
But some days I can feel, A split inside my chest,
And then every breath hurts, pierced by a spike*

■

Then one day she smiled, just like that! Her eyes were on her father, who was sitting on her bed. But her smile was not that of any satisfaction or happiness. It was the scariest smile her mother had ever seen on a face, and she thought that their daughter was possessed. Naina was smiling like a mad woman smiles. That smile scared her father as well. And within the next one-hour, Naina, her mother, and her father were in the emergency ward of a hospital. Naina started throwing her limbs as soon as they reached the hospital. The doctor on duty checked her, but apart from weakness, he did not find anything serious in her. He called her father into his chamber and after having a discussion with him, referred her to a psychiatrist.

“What happened, what did the doctor say?” her mother asked her father as soon he came to them.

“Our daughter has gone mad. They want us to see the doctor who handles patients who have mental problems,” he said, fighting back his tears.

His wife looked at him with a question in her eyes as if she was asking him whether they had lost her or did they still have hopes? She looked at her daughter who was still smiling in vain looking with blank at other patients in the emergency ward who were fighting for life.

“Stop it, stop smiling! What are you smiling at? Behave yourself! Do girls laugh like that?” she scolded Naina, but that smile never left Naina’s face. Her father, who was standing next to her, held her face in his hands, pulled her face to his waist, caressed her cheeks, and she continued smiling with her eyes, shedding their counted left-over tears.

They went to the chamber of the Psychiatrist. Naina had calmed down, but the smile was coming back on her face intermittently. First thing she noticed in the new doctor’s room was a big glass window. She looked through it, it had a view of tall buildings. The lady looked at them from above her glasses. She was in her 50’s. Some of her hair was springing out over her head.

“Why don’t you let her marry him? What is important to you, your daughter, or your so-called family pride?” Her voice was soft, but those words were piercing. She had listened to the whole story of Naina from her father patiently and had tried to construct the case.

“I have seen so many cases like her, where daughters kill themselves due to depression. At this age, they can’t judge what is right and what is wrong for them. Why don’t you give that guy a chance and talk to his family? And if you feel that the guy is not good for your daughter, you can discuss things with her, you can help her understand things. She is a kid, you are not. What would you do if she jumps out of the window some day? What will you do with your pride after her?” She continued, and her father heard all silently keeping his head down.

Naina imagined herself jumping out of it. Her body sprawled on the on ground, in pool of her own blood. Her head felt light with this thought. And in that moment she realised how broken she was that she was enjoying her own death.

“Madam, my children are everything for me. I can die for them. It is not a matter of pride for me Madam ji. It is about my other children, who are there at home. The society I live in won’t understand that society won’t let them live peacefully. I have responsibility on my shoulders. It’s not just about her or about me only. It’s about everyone at my home.

“The fight is not between me and her, it is between us and society, our caste. If I get her married to that family, she won’t get the respect there as well. I know, I live in that society where people are not that open-minded like yours. Even me! I am part of that but because of this girl, now I understand the need for respect and love. I am that helpless father, Madam ji, who cannot even express his love openly. I would have got her married to that guy if she was my only child, or if he belonged to our caste. But Madam ji I don’t have the courage to fight all alone. I can’t let my other children suffer all their lives because of one. And even if I get her married, the society won’t let them live. I have checked the background of that guy. He is a drunkard, roams around with school girls during the day. In any case, the loss is mine Madam ji. No matter what I choose, my hands will remain empty.” Her father broke down like never before.

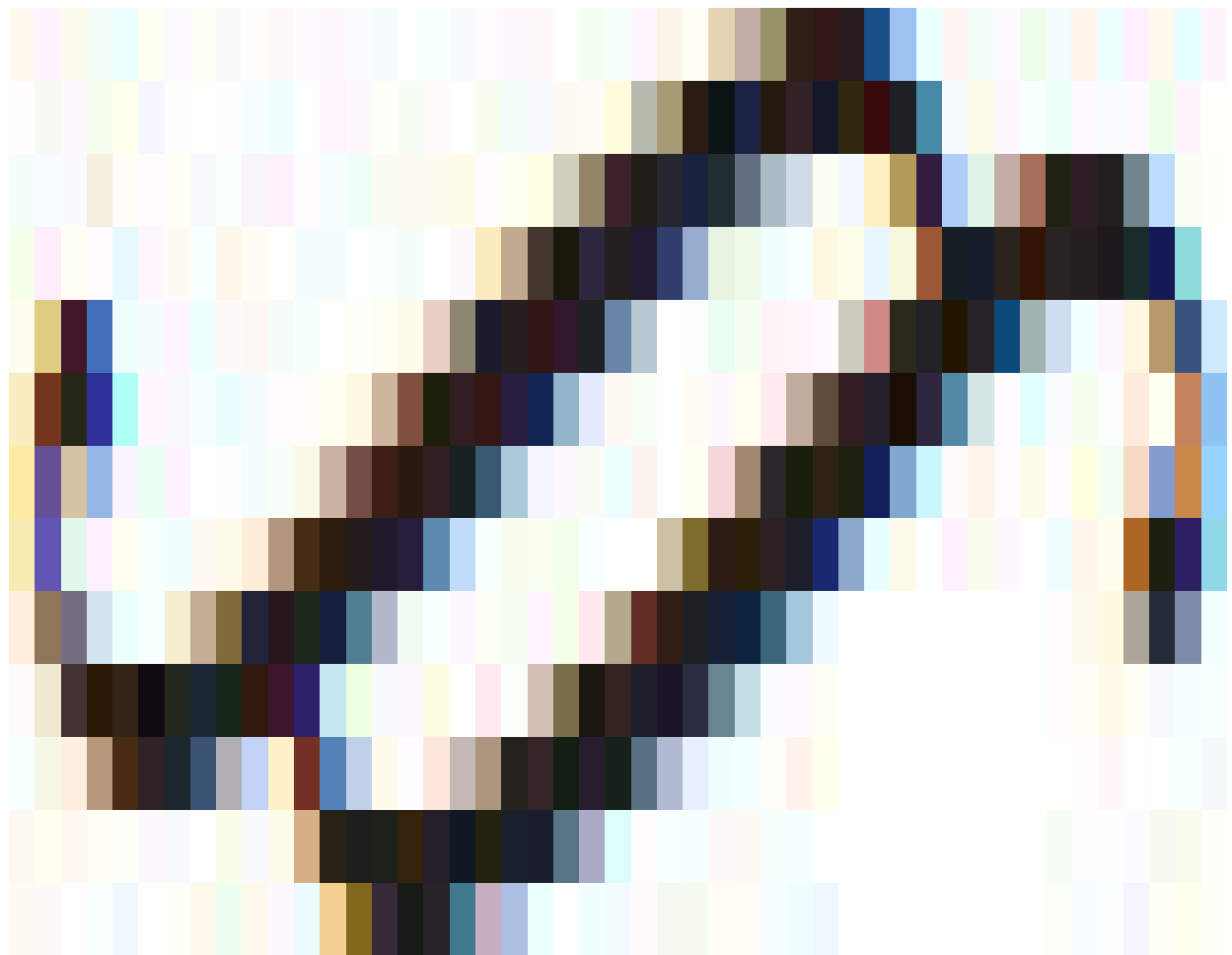
He continued speaking with his palms joined together in front of her, “Save my daughter Madam ji.....Save her if you can! I can’t see her dying in front of my eyes Madam ji.... Please save her.”. His shoulders moved up and down as he cried and opened his heart for the first time.

“I understand. She will be fine, don’t worry! She is just depressed. There are some people who cannot express themselves so easily. She is one of them. I am prescribing some medicines which will keep her calm and will help her in sleeping. But the main thing must be done from your side. Words have the power to change people. One word can ruin things and one word can motivate as well. Talk to her with all the love and care, make her feel comfortable so that she can express herself. Once things that are stuck deep inside her will come out, she will feel better. You just need to make her feel loved.”

Naina was in the same room at a distance from them, but she heard each and every word her father spoke. She saw her father’s moving shoulders from back and it pierced her heart. He was her hero at some point and today he became her hero again. In that moment, something changed in her. She got up from her chair and stood next to her parents. She placed her hand on her father’s head in the middle and caressed his grey hair as if she was blessing him. At that moment she had again grown up beyond her age.

On their way back, nobody talked a word, but the silence between them was less disturbing. Naina looked outside the window of the vehicle like old times. She imagined herself being a bird which was flying above. She saw girls and women at metro station and at bus stops, some were heading towards their colleges some were going for their work. She looked at them with empty eyes.

She was feeling suffocated inside. Why can't she be one of them? Why is she not free like them? Why wearing jeans and wearing kajal is a taboo for her? Why did college feel like a luxury to her? Why was it difficult for her parents to fight for her? Why does nobody tries to change this? Everything being so advanced, why she is lagging even after having all the resources? Why can't she even decide her clothes, food, and songs? When the whole world is free, why is she constricted?



“Call Naina!” her father had ordered her brother to bring Naina when he was serving him Dinner.

“Papa, let it be! Don’t say anything to her. Tell me, I’ll try to talk to her. Please, Papa she is really scared! Please, don’t say anything to her.”

“Just call her.”

“Papa is calling you.” He came to Naina’s room and helped her get up.

“Don’t say anything, Ok! Just listen to what he says. Keep quiet!” He whispered in Naina’s ears as they walked into his room.

“Come, Naina sit here with me!” he motioned her to sit next to him. Her mother called her brother to stop her father if he would again hit Naina. They stood there holding their breaths.

Their father took a morsel, brought it to her mouth and waited for her to open her mouth. Naina first looked at the morsel then looked at him. She looked at her sister and her brother who were surprised like anything. Her father moved the morsel little up to touch her lips. She opened her mouth a little and ate her first morsel in 30 days. She cried and chewed. It was the first time that her father has fed her with his own hands.

She looked at her mother and said, “Give me one more roti. I am hungry.”

With those words, everything seems normal for everyone. They all smiled and cried. Naina felt light after so many days. She had finally made them smile.

After that day, nobody talked to her about Veer, nobody even discussed those things amongst them. Everybody wanted to forget that thing, they behaved as if nothing had happened and Naina was recovering from some flu or fever. Her fits became less, but she still woke up with nightmares. However, she didn’t tell anyone about it. Whenever she woke up scared, she would close her eyes and take deep breaths to let it pass. For everybody, her nightmares and her pains had stopped, but for Naina they had turned inwards.

She started smiling and responding, but she never initiated a conversation. She always kept her eyes down while talking. She still felt the guilt, and she did want them to read her eyes. She could fake her smile, she could fake her responses, but she could not lie from her eyes. She did not want her family to see that she was still upset and whenever she felt that she cannot bear the interaction instead of staring at the ceiling, she would close her eyes and pretend to sleep. For them, Naina slept peacefully. Life had become normal for everyone, but for Naina, it remained the same. The guilt, the pain, the shame, all were intact in her. At night, after being sure that others had slept, Naina's eyes would go back to the ceiling again.

Even after being so loved, she was not happy. It seemed that her hunger of love had died in those last 30 days. The harm was done and nothing could be done about it. What seemed normal to everyone was not normal for her. Nothing had changed for her. Her situation had become worse than ever.

Her head now felt heavy with all the love which was being showered on her. She did not need love now; she needed to be understood. The weight of being worthless was getting heavier. Books had always been her companion. But after her college, she did not have anything to do. She would spend all her day in her bed. Her mother never let her go anywhere. She was not allowed to step outside.

She had nowhere to go, but still she wished if she could roam all alone on roads like she used to when she was a little girl. That always made her feel free. Everybody still had a fear that she might run away or do something to herself. Though nobody said anything to her, but she could read their eyes, how suspicious they were, how they observed every move of hers. She always found a pair of eyes on her. Even when she slept, she could feel them watching her. She felt as if someone was holding her throat all the time.

At night, her dreams of studying and becoming something in her life haunted her. She had ruined her life with her own hands. She lost whatever little freedom she had. When she was in college, she at least had hope that she could do something. She could prove everybody wrong, that girls can't do anything. She had hopes that she could win her freedom. But now, she had nothing. She had realised that education was the only way through which she could get rid of the burning sensation in her.

She missed her friend Sandy. She heard everybody, but nobody heard her. She wanted to pour her heart out to someone, but she was not allowed to touch the phone. Over and above now she herself was scared to do anything that might make them doubt her again. It seemed as if she had lost her voice. Earlier she could at least ask for or complain about anything to her mother, aunt, grandmother, and sometimes her father also, but now she felt indebted towards them.

She felt so low in herself that even asking for food felt like seeking a favour to her. She had cornered herself from them. She did not have strength left in her to ask them for anything, she did whatever she was asked to do without protesting, without any question. Now, there was nothing she wanted, there was nothing she could give.

Her days belonged to them, and her night belonged to herself. At night, she could be herself in her mind, but even then, she could not cry openly like before. Her mother slept next to her, but she did not want her to know that she was still hurt inside, that she was still not okay, that still needed them to hear her and to understand her. She would cry silently every night, and would prepare herself for the next day of smiles. And this became her daily routine, her only way to survive, to fight.

In those 30 days everybody changed a little bit, but Naina got a completely new version of her. Her desire for love had suddenly died as if it was never there. She rarely smiled, she talked less. At night, in her own time, when she looked inside her own self, she found it all dark. She could not see anything in her. Even her own voice did not echo when she tried to call herself. Little Naina who always talked to her, who supplied dreams, hopes, and smiles to her eyes and lips was nowhere to be seen. That chirpy Naina had died silently.

“Girls, like you, want this. I know, I can see it in your eyes.” She felt filthy within her skin. She would rather rip it layer by layer and wear a new fresh skin, if she could. This one was rotting with many touches.

She felt nothing about Veer, for whom she had tried to give away her life, for whom she had fought with her family. Whenever she thought about him now, she did not feel any kind of pain in her. Somewhere, she was relieved

that now she didn't need to lie at home, she does not need to do things which she never wanted to do. She was astonished at her insensitivity, at her detachment towards him. One night, she thought of making a list of what she would miss about him, or the changes that his absence would make. But she could not figure out even one thing about him that she would miss. She thought about their love talks which had later turned into sex talks. With every thread of their memory, she realised that it was not love that connected them, it was their desires that had brought them together. Her desire to be someone's love and his desire to fulfil his lust. She was disgusted with herself now. How could she not see it then?

With time she also understood that her life did not stop when Veer left her. Her life stopped when she realised that because of their so-called "love", she had lost her opportunity to educate herself. She had lost her chance of freedom. She had become like other girls, who were just living their life, without any purpose, without even realizing that they are human, too. She never separated from her books until that day when somewhere she lost her ways with Veer. She had completely forgotten herself and her dreams, and now when everything was finished, she regretted what she had done.

She wanted to continue her studies but she did not dare to ask her father. She was scared that everybody would make fun of her. She could hear their comments in her mind that when it was time to study, she did all those things which she should not have done and now she wanted to study.

Every time she tried to talk to her father about it, her voice would get choked in her throat. One day when her father called her.

"Naina, you remember, I told you about a family, who was supposed to come to meet you."

Her heart started racing, blood rushed to the back of her head, and it made her dizzy. She was not ready for it, but she could not tell her father about that. What would she tell? She stood there, keeping her head low, twisting her fingers to contain her anxiety.

"They are coming tomorrow. Go to the market with your mother and buy a new suit." he continued.

Her eyes pooled up. She was helpless. Images from her college, from the days of her studies, from that metro station where she had seen girls going to their work rushed into her mind. A voice in her head was asking her to talk to her father about her studies.

‘Tell him that you want to study, that you will work hard this time, that you won’t break his trust again. Speak out!’ it said. She tried to speak, but no words came out of her mouth. The voice kept growing louder and louder in her head. And then suddenly it died.

Years later, she would come to that moment, wishing she could have gathered enough courage to talk to her father. The courage which she had shown on that day when she went to meet Veer, and on the day, she had made the last call to him. But it seemed that it was the last ounce of strength that she had used that night to make the call. Every drop of love, strength, and trust had drained out of her that night.

Now she was just a hollow body, her heart and soul and every other thing she had been eaten by that beast.

Even she did not know when and where it started. Or was she born with it? She just could not hurt anyone. Maybe someone got hurt by mistake, but not by choice at least. Her ways were simple. She believed that love can never be begged; it flows freely. If you love, you show. Nobody needs to ask anyone to love them. She was incapable of telling her feelings. She could never find words to express herself. She did believe that feelings talk about themselves. They can find their ways to be felt, there is no need to tell them aloud or convey them. That’s the thing, even about herself. She felt everything deeply but could never express it. She wanted to love herself, for the way she was, without demanding or requesting for being loved. She could never ask someone to love her, she also could not stop herself if she loved someone. For her, things were either black or white. She could not add layers of lies to the truth.

▪

Every night the Devil and I,

Sat together,

He taught me all the ways,

To harm myself and others.

Haree was four months pregnant when she noticed her belly swelling. It was then that she realized that she had not bled after the death of Ram. It was late evening; she had not been feeling well for days. That day, she woke up with sickness and a headache. First, she assumed that to be the effect of Ashok's beating, but when she noticed her abdomen, she understood it. She touched her belly slowly, as if she could touch the baby's head already. Sitting alone, lost in contemplation, she did not know how to feel about it. Whether she should be happy or she should feel sad! Whatsoever, there was a kind of emptiness in her, a kind of fear.

That day when Ashok came in, she stopped his hand when he was opening the knots of his pyjama. It had been three months that Ashok has been visiting her often, sometimes every day of the week, and sometimes only on Friday. It was the day his wife fasted and she would not have let him touch her on those days. Often heard sounds of their yelling at each other and then his beating her. She always found cuts and bruises on his wife's face the next day. Whenever Haree tried to talk to her, she would snarl at her.

“What do you want now? You have eaten your husband, and now want to eat mine!”

Haree heard her insults keeping her head down. She knew that Ashok’s wife liked it when Ashok beat her up too. Every Time she saw a cut around’s lips or dark blue colour around her eyes or cheeks, she would laugh at her, keeping her hand on her mouth and her body swayed with pleasure. But Haree never said anything to her. It satisfied her. At least this way she could balance sharing the pain they both were going through.

Ashok jerked out her hand and undid his pants. Haree stood up. He, at once, slapped her hard across the face.

“You don’t like sober me. Do you like it when I beat you? That’s what you want?” He yelled.

“I can’t do it...! I ... have a baby inside me,” she said, covering her face with both hands when Ashok raised his hands again.

She waited for his hand to hit her. She breathed heavily with fear of her child getting hurt. Ashok weighed the words he had just heard. He read them again and again in his mind as if it was a complex problem and he was not able to find a solution to it. He moved his hand down slowly and murmured something which Haree could not hear. She brought her hands down and maintaining a safe distance from him stood in the corner to listen again carefully if he said it again.

“Is it mine?” he asked softly but his voice shook. It lacked confidence.

After the death of his first baby, his first wife had not conceived. Something in his voice told her that she should be cautious and should think before answering it. She pondered over his words and searched for suitable words to reply to, but her heart did not give the permission to lie. How could she lie to Ram? Wherever he might be, she knew that he was looking at her! That he knew what his Haree was going through. And even if she couldn’t see him, she could not strip that baby of its real father’s name.

“It’s your brother’s!” she said with pride, which she regretted immediately when Ashok leapt at her.

She turned her back to the wall and his punch hit her in the middle of her back. Mother’s instinct told her that Ashok had tried to hurt her baby. He held her by the back of her neck and thrashed her head against the wall. Her head spun, she thought she might puke, but she did not. When Ashok turned her to face him, she kneeled and touched his feet.

“Please don’t hurt my baby! This is the last thing I have. Please!” she cried, holding his feet.

He kicked her and stomped out of the room. She looked out with fearful eyes, waiting for him to come back again with a stick or something with which he could harm her. She jerked with every small noise outside, her eyes wide open, looking in different directions to find him and be ready to fight back.

When she woke up, her head was reeling a bit due to a lack of proper sleep. There was a small bump on her forehead. Ashok must have told his wife about it because Haree could feel that the bitterness in her had increased.

If Haree could read the thoughts of Ashok’s wife, she would have read, ‘Who knows whose child is this, its own father’s or of that pundit whom she visited every day? Why didn’t this miracle happen when Ram was alive? How come his seed is sprouting now?’

At night when Ashok came again, her face turned white. She jumped out of her cot and ran outside, but he grabbed her by her wrist.

“I told you I am pregnant. Please have some mercy and respect for your brother.” she cried, trying to free her from his grip.

“He was my brother, that’s why I am not doing anything to you. But it doesn’t mean you won’t give me what I want. He is dead. I am still alive. He was your husband, and now I am. And I’ll take what is mine. No matter what.”

“But.....!” she fumbled with her words, what else she could say to stop him?

She called out everyone by name, but nobody came to rescue her. He did whatever he wanted. Haree kept squirming and twisting while he heaved over her. He did not beat her up that night as he always did. She was thankful to him; his hand did not reach to her belly. He was not tender, but he was not harsh either. She kept praying to god to save her child. She was worried about her baby. She had heard that first three months and the last three months a woman should be careful. But here she was, under him. Taking his jerks!

The next few days, she kept touching herself between her thighs, to check for any blood droplets coming out of them. She got relieved when there was none. She would keep caressing her small bump as if it can soothe him out, it could ease out the discomfort he might have felt last night. She always referred to her baby as ‘he’. Somewhere within, she knew that it would be a son, a son who would be like Ram! She could picture Ram’s face on that baby. She could see him smile like Ram, his lips moving upward in one direction. She smiled every time she noticed her bump. While working, she would take extra care, although no one would restrain her from lifting the heavy water pitcher. If Ram had been there, he would have told her, stopped her, and taken care of her. But as of now, she had to do it.

On those nights, when Ashok did not come, she would think about her mother. She had seen her delivering three babies before her eyes. In those days, she used to be with her mother. She had noticed what her mother ate and which side she slept on, how she kept her hand on the baby bump while working. God prepares you for everything. Maybe He knew that one-day Haree would need this knowledge and she would have to come back to these days. Haree would curl in one corner on her green mat and go back in time to see the details that she might have missed at that time. She looked cautiously and with curiosity at everything again and again, to find the answers she was looking for.

As the months increased and her bump became evident, she noticed the shift in her manners. Ashok visited her less, not more than twice a week, on Friday and Tuesday. His wife had increased the amount of prayer after her

pregnancy. She was sure that this baby belonged to Ashok and Haree was lying to restrict the claims. She knew that if Ashok came to know it was his child, he would separate himself from Haree. But Haree knew it in her heart, that the baby she was carrying was Ram's only. Her every inch of skin belonged to him, and God can't be that cruel to her that He would let her suffer so long. She knew that all the blessings and the entire wait were now being paid off by God.

Ashok's ways to use her body had changed. She knew that her swollen bump gave him disgust. She could read it on his manners. He made sure that he never touched the area around her belly, and if by mistake he touched it he would throw his hand in the air as if he had touched the live wire. He avoided coming over her, her belly looked at him straight, questioning his authority. Haree could never decide what he felt during those moments. First, she could at least understand his anger and his hunger through his actions and words, but now, he mostly remained tight-lipped. Doing things without a flare in his nose, without the strength in his grip.

When her belly was in the last months, he used her mouth more than her legs. It was easy for both, though Haree had protested it initially. But then she gave up, knowing that she was not in a condition to protest beyond a limit. Any mistake from her end would cost the life of her son. She would hold her stomach with one hand, sitting on her knees. Every breath she took made her puke, but she endured and fulfilled him without fail. Ashok would leave without saying any word after releasing himself. It was their new settlement without friction, without any words.

Every night she would cross the line that she had marked in her little red diary. She would count the remaining days again and again on her fingers, slapping slightly on her temples when she forgot the numbers in excitement and then would count again. Despite the poor diet which Ashok's wife provided her, the injury marks on her body healed and disappeared. Her skin glowed. Her belly had now swollen like a perfect ball. She would smile at the women whenever anybody visited their house or whenever she met anyone on her way to the field.

Ram's piece of land was still in the middle of a harvest. Haree would go and sit there, helping her father-in-law in winning wild weed from the crop.

At times, she would find her father-in-law's eyes on her stomach. From behind the veil, she could see him wiping his tears by pressing the corners of his eyes. During lunch hour, he would come and keep her share of chapatti and curry on her plate. He would keep his hand on her head and then walk away to let her eat. Haree would quickly eat the chapattis. Her throat would choke with gratitude and indebtedness. She would feel guilty about sharing a part of her father-in-law's food, but she knew that she had to do it for her baby. 'She would cook hundreds of chapattis and would cook sweet kheer and halwa for her son and father-in-law after the birth of this baby. She would pay everything which she owed to him and Ram.' she would think.

As the days passed, her imagination grew large and vivid. She would start smiling while spreading washed clothes on the clothesline while cutting vegetables for cooking, or while she cleaned the house. She would imagine tiny cotton colourful shirts and pants hanging on the clothesline. She will have to tie one more rope across the veranda. A baby soils so many clothes in a day that this would not be sufficient for him. She made a mental note to tell it to her father-in-law. She had never talked to her father-in-law when Ram was alive. The ladies of the house never talked to the males of the house directly. But after Ram passed, her father-in-law had come to her and had said to her that she could let him know whatever she needed. He had assured her that though Ram was not here, she should not feel that she was alone. Since then, Haree has been talking to him, standing at a distance, covering her face with a long veil. She asked for his help only when direly required. She knew that she could not be dependent on him, and from her childhood, she had learnt the tricks to survive. She comfortably spent her life, living with herself. But this baby had changed her. With him inside her, she realised the strengths she had in her, the willpower to soak up the situation, and the resilience to go ahead with life.

In her last month, she felt a sudden surge of energy in her. She walked fast. Her mother-in-law warned her but she did not know how to keep the excitement within her. The last few bars in her diary looked expectantly at her, she smiled at them as if they were also smiling. Ashok had stopped coming to her, but she would not have minded, even if he would have

decided to use her again. In this happiness, she could give anything to anyone.

The lady, who assisted in delivery in their village, came to visit her. Haree giggled when she touched her stomach from both sides. She kept her hands on both sides and checked the position of the baby. Haree giggled more.

“Everything is good,” she said, “we can expect the baby any time. Call me whenever you feel the pain or your water breaks down.”

Haree nodded at her, making mental notes of the instruction she was giving.

Finally, the wait was over. She felt pain rising at the lower bottom of her abdomen for two days. First, it started with a small uncomfortable feeling, which came and disappeared before turning into something big. It was late at night when the pain grew. Her stomach tightened, and she turned on her mat. By the morning, she could not hold herself and got up and knocked on Ashok’s door.

It was the first time that she had done this. Her previous bedroom! Ashok had taken it over right after her marriage to him. He had thought that Haree would come and live in it again with him. But when Haree refused, he lived in it all alone.

First, she knocked softly, but when he did not open, she banged the wooden door with the hanging iron chain which was used to lock the door from outside. Knots of the chain rattled, but the door did not open.

She looked around to find somebody else who could help her but all doors were shut. She knew that Ashok’s wife wouldn’t help her and Ravi was not home. She held her belly with both hands and moved slowly towards the men’s room. After the death of Ram, his father and mother started sleeping outside the house. House reminded them of Ram. ‘House does not look like a house!’ they had said, before shifting. Haree moved slowly, she wanted to run, but the pressure did not allow her. She worried about her baby, ‘what if she is already late and she cannot save the baby!’

Panic and rush washed over, as she tried to run across the veranda. The veranda stretched itself that night, she walked and walked, but the distance did not reduce/become less. She did not know how much time did it take to reach there, but she was panting as if she had walked miles under the hot sun. Her mouth and throat were all parched, with continued in and out motion of air.

She was in the kitchen when she opened her eyes. She did not know how she reached there. She must have stumbled there. She could not recall anything after knocking on the door. As she thought of her last night, her hands suddenly reached to her belly. Her belly was still swollen and tight. She looked around with questions in her eyes. Her mother-in-law was talking to somebody outside. She could see her back. When she turned to come inside, Haree saw the Aaya, who had visited her a week before. She kept her curious eyes on her mother-in-law.

“Everything is good, don’t worry. Baby is still 3 inches away,” she said Aaya would come again at night and stay with you.

Haree was left out a sigh. Her hands moved on her baby in anticipation, thinking about the fear of loss she had felt last night. She had never been that scared in her life, not even when Ram died and not even on her first night with Ashok. That fear of losing her baby was different, a pain which she dreaded. The entire day, she did not move, and she did not do any work. She could not take any risk of moving, slipping, falling, and losing her ‘son’.

When the night fell, she saw Aaya coming into her kitchen. Aaya pulled the curtain and let fresh air come in. Her room reeked of piss and vomit. Haree had not got a chance to clean it. She had been using a corner of her room as a toilet at night. And during the pregnancy, the frequency had increased, and it was difficult for her to get up every hour and cross the veranda and go to the common washroom. In the last two days, she had not washed, she had not taken bath, and she had not cleaned the room. It was Aaya who helped her clean her face and body. She heated water in a pot and after dipping a white cotton towel in it and sponged her body. Sitting there silently, Haree closed her eyes and soaked in the warm and relaxing touch of water. Her armpits had a pungy smell when Aaya lifted them up to clean.

Haree did not pay any heed, she was not ashamed of it right now. She relaxed with every touch of the warm towel on her body.

Aaya made her a concoction of 'gud' and water.

"It will help relieve the pain and tightness in your stomach," Aaya said giving it to her.

It was the first time after the death of Ram that she had tasted something sweet. She thought that her lips had forgotten the taste of the sweetness, but when her lips touched it and her tongue soaked it, she could feel the desire running up to her chest. The hunger which was long forgotten was still alive. She cried thinking about the smallness of her own identity. A widow, a mother who is standing on verge of losing her baby as well, how could she cherish that taste! She cried and sipped. Thinking about the helplessness she felt in her body, and the constrictions she felt in her mind.

'People are right, I don't have any remorse! I am not capable of loving anybody.'

After the death of Ram, she had not cried even during the days of mourning. She had often asked herself why tears didn't come in her eyes even after losing the whole of her life. But she could reach never a conclusion. She could not find the reason for her ignorance or her emotionless heart. Even with Ashok tormenting her body and soul, she never cried. She pleaded, requested, but never cried. His cruel hands also did not have the power to break her. Everything was still intact and erect inside her. Somewhere inside her there was a strong thread which still held her.

Late in the night, when her pain grew intense, she called out to Aaya. Within 15 min, her room was filled with people. With unconscious eyes she could tell that all were women. They were mostly unfamiliar voices; she had never heard them before. There was only one familiar voice in it, her mother's voice. She had not met her mother after Ram's death. Haree had not gone to her father's place and her mother never visited her. She longed to see her familiar face in the crown of faces hanging over her. But she could not find her. She tried to focus her eyes but she could not, they were

strained and tired. It took all her effort to keep them open for even a few seconds.

Somebody tapped on her cheeks, “Haree.....!”

Her face wobbled, mouth half opened. She tasted the water drops on her lips, then she opened her mouth a little more and gulped a mouthful of it. The footfall around her cot increased. Two hands folded her legs and widened them. She felt fingers going inside and then coming out immediately. Tapping on her cheeks increased and she opened her eyes wide when the wave of intense pain hit her lower abdomen again. The baby was pushing down itself. Her stomach stretched itself. Her screams filled the room, she gritted her teeth and then pushed again. After fifteen minutes of continuous labour, she relaxed her muscles when she heard the cry of a baby.

She wanted to look at ‘him’, but her eyes did not have the required strength. She took a few long breaths before opening her eyes. Everything was blue and hazy in front of her. Somebody was cleaning her down. The rough hands running on her body made her wince with every stroke, but she ignored it and looked at the baby.

She let go of the smile she had been holding. Her body was numb with gratitude and happiness. All through the nine months, she had imagined him so many times and had also felt the happiness, but this feeling was beyond that. It was multi-folded. Everything which she has suffered came back to her like a blessing in his form. Everything looked minuscule and felt tiny in front of those small pink feet.

She raised both her hands to hold her child. Her life! Her fingers wiggled in desperation when Aaya took time to wrap him in a fresh towel before handing over to her. She thought she would cry when she touched the soft flesh of her son, but she did not. She kept staring at his brown lips. His eyes were closed, as if they were still sealed and would require a little peel of the skin to free the eyelids. Her finger carefully ran over his shoulders. How soft his skin felt under her charred fingers? She rubbed the finger bud of her index finger with thumb so as to smoothen it and then ran it on the edges of his face, his lips. She caressed his matted hair, pulling them back in one

stroke. His delicate wrist and fingers! She held them carefully, without any pressure, afraid that his thin and weak fingers might twist and break. She rubbed her thumb on the side of that small hand, her thumb covered it completely. She could not believe that human form could be so small and complete with limited skin. She could not believe that inside its ribs and chest there is a full functioning heart which is pumping blood and inside its belly a liver and a pair of kidneys could fit in. Haree did not know all these details of human anatomy. It was Ram's words which had brought this knowledge to her mind. She saw the world through his eyes.

Haree lifted his limbs, she felt the formation of his nose and lips to make sure there was no deformity in her son. She unwrapped the towel from his legs and looked down. She looked between his legs to confirm his masculinity. She knew it by heart, but still she wanted to cross-check her belief. It was then that she realised the silence in the room. There were five women in the room, but it felt as if even air was moving without a sound.

She had not given birth to a boy; it was a girl in her hands. Extension of Ram! Haree looked back at her tiny pout and features of face, they also did not belong to Ram. In fact, she was a reflection of Haree. She had Haree's nose and lips, her dusky complexion. How could she miss that, why did she not notice it before? Haree hands trembled when she ran her hands on both of her legs. She did not know whether her heart was breaking with hurt or it was bursting out of happiness. Mixed emotions whirling in her chest, she did not know what to name them. Her last hope of seeing Ram's face and his shadow was shattered and she had her own different version in her hands. She did not know what to do with that gift. She had not planned about it before. She had a long list of dreams for her son, but for daughter, she had not thought anything.

She remembered how Ram always used to tell her that he wanted a little girl.

"Girls love their father more than mother." He had said proudly, "And I'll love my daughter more than anything in this world."

"More than me??" She had asked him.

“More than you!” He had said and hugged her.

They both had laughed at their childish conversation. It was before Ashok’s marriage. After things had started to change in the house, Ram did not talk to her about starting a family. He maintained a distance from her.

“I need to focus on the house first, and once everything is settled, it will be you, me and our little daughter.” He would say when they were alone.

“And a son like you!” Haree always added.

She kissed the forehead of her baby girl. She was sleeping peacefully in her lap, her hands closed in fur balls. There were three little frowning lines between her eyes as if she was holding the whole burden of some tiny world in some different world on her forehead.

For a month, Ashok did not visit her. Her memories of the nights with him seemed like they belonged to some other life, some previous life, which she still remembered in bits and pieces. Ugly flashes of those nights still haunted her but they did not hurt her like they it used to. She did not know when her days came and went. She explored the wonders of the human body in those days. While feeding her baby, she looked at the two pink small lips and how tight their grip was around her nipple. She would smile and wonder when she sucked bouts of milk from her breasts, sometimes more than her tiny mouth could handle.

“Easy... Easy... It’s all yours! Nobody is going to share this.” Haree would say and caress her baby’s head, stroking the silky soft hair back.

She came to know that a baby pees more than 25 times a day and they can wet the bed again right after 5 minutes. Their hunger has no end and they do not know things like night and day. They are all the same for them. They can cry, pee, and sleep anytime, whenever they want. They have all the freedom which adults cannot afford.

After forty days, Ashok came into her room. She was startled. She was feeding the baby; her blouse was carelessly open and both of her breasts hung open. She knew that he had seen them but still she pulled her dupatta

over them. The baby released the nipple with a pop, her lips still pouted and a drop still on them. Haree made her sleep next to her. She did not even remember when was the last time Ashok had visited her. She could not pull out the time from her memory. Now her mind was always all filled with images of gurgling, and crying, and sudden laughs of her baby. Everything before her child's arrival was a faint and faded memory with incomplete and unclear details.

He opened his knots and hung the trouser on the hook, like he earlier used to. He had not forgotten the steps. Haree pulled up the skirts to her thighs. She kept her one arm around her baby when he moved up and down on her. The closeness of the baby on the same cot irritated her. 'She should not be here, even if she is a baby, still she should not be here.'

When Ashok left, she made a small bed on the floor for her little girl and changed the bed sheet on her cot. It reeked of his sweat and discharge. She quickly washed her hands and legs; she could not touch her baby with his smell on her.

The next few days she spent in making a mattress for the baby. She collected old pieces of clothes from the neighbourhood. She took every piece she could get, old bed sheet, old kurta, salwar, torn pillow covers, towels, whatsoever. After cleaning her room and after finishing her chores, she would sit in the veranda, under the sunlight to find the softest pieces and cut them into multiple fringes. After collecting the clothes, she had cleaned them thoroughly before cutting them. She had soaked them in buckets of detergent and water, and washed them 3-4 times. Then she had dried them in sun for days to get rid of dirt and smell of their previous users. In order to become her daughter's bed, they must first forget their earlier usage. After cutting the fringes, she sews four different two feet by two feet covers, a bag kind of thing in square shape. She filed the cuttings in them till they felt perfect and smooth enough for the girl. She slapped them hard to get rid of excess fluff and flattened them to the baby's need.

Afterwards, she started to sleep on her mat again, with her baby beside her on her own small bed. Cot was kept propped to the wall. She used it only when Ashok came, else it remained standing leaning at the wall, as a continuous reminder of a different side of her life. But it did not dread her

like before, all the pain has subsided after the baby. Now, she rarely felt anything when Ashok came inside her. It felt like a daily chore which has to be done to survive. If it did not add any value to her, it did not take anything as well.

But she did not know that God does not like things to be stagnant. He likes the momentum, the continuous action of life. Time always changes. It had to change.

CHAPTER

■

24

■

My mouth was stuffed with needles and pins

And they asked me to sing.

The rush was different that day. When Naina woke up, everybody was busy, and they hurried with urgency in their eyes. It was only males of the family who looked serious, yet calm. Their bodies were active, yet subtle. They moved their eyes quickly, observing every moment of the labourers who were decorating the house. Their vigilant eyes scanned all around. They were talking in a low but harsh tone with Naina's brothers.

Her head was thudding with pain even now. Last night, all the ladies had gathered to celebrate her last night in that house. They had made her sit in the middle and took turns teaching and teasing about the things which a girl should know before marriage.

“Don't run and shout when he shows you his weapon” one of them said. Her four fingers closed together in “O” shape. She opened her legs wide and kept the gesturing hand between them. She moved it up and down like a man jerks. Naina dropped her head. That gesture reminded her of Ashok, how his hand used to move up and down like that while she undressed herself. She blinked her eyes a few times to get rid of that image. She could not even see herself naked, not even in her dreams. She had started hating every part of her body. Even while bathing, she never looked down at her body. While rubbing soap on her body, she kept her eyes straight ahead on the wall. While dressing up, she would close her eyes and then slip in the

kurta first, so that, when she looked down at her legs to wear salwar, her kurta covered half of her legs.

Looking at them she could not understand, what did give them this courage to do all the obscenity in open. Why didn't their ears hurt and eyes burn like hers? Why are they different from her? When the other ladies burst into laughter, she wished she could spit at them and throw something at them, but she kept her head low. All through the night, they mocked and teased each other. They discussed their bedtime stories as if they were discussing their dresses.

"I hate it when he puts it in my mouth." said one of them and wrinkled her nose while speaking.

"Then you should bend and show him your ass hole." said another and picked the edges of her kurta and pulled, showing her buttocks to all.

Naina's head raced when an image of Veer in the car floated in her mind, it left that sticky feeling on her lips. How long will it take to forget these images? Her eyes pooled up again and again. She gulped the choke in her throat, but it kept building up.

"Bua!" she called out her aunt, who was serving tea to the guests, and asked her in a timid voice, "Can I go to sleep now? I have a headache."

Her aunt must have read the helplessness in her voice. She gave her a kind look, as if saying that she understands. "Yes, yes! Go! These ladies will keep you busy like this the whole night. You should go and have some rest."

Then she handed over the empty plate to someone and helped Naina stand up by holding her arms. She adjusted Naina's shawl around her shoulders as Naina's henna-laden hands were stretched straight forward.

That thick green paste was still wet at the back of Naina's hand. She kept them straight, all five fingers wide open. Naina had a liking for henna, but that day, when aunt was applying it in exquisite designs on her hand, she did not even look at it. It was like, not looking at things will make them

disappear. It took a lot of strength to not smudge her hands. She wished she could rub her palms and ruin the curvy lines and circles on it. At least that would give some satisfaction. Her silly ways to vent out her dejection! When her aunt was making the bed for her, Naina looked at aunt's hands, how she patted the mattress and smoothed it, stretching her arms. When Naina lied down on the bed, her aunt unfolded the red fur blanket and spread over her. Her aunt waited for her to stretch her hands out, and then tucked the blanket up to her neck. It was late January. Winters were still heavy and thick. Her hands were getting cold and numb.

Naina turned towards her grandmother's side, her hands hanging from the edges of her bed. She looked around the room. Boxes of sweet, stacked up in one corner, she could smell sugar in the air. It had been three days; sweetmeat makers were coming in and going out of this room to keep the material. Some of them sat the entire day to pack the sweets in those red and white boxes. The sweets were covered with thin white muslin clothes before packing. Though she had been sleeping in the same room regularly, but still she did not know what type of sweets was being distributed in her marriage. She had been busy with her mother and aunties in packing things for her Bidai and trying new dresses.

In the last three days, time had moved fast for her. She had been floating from one ritual to the other. Somebody would call her, and give her some direction about the next puja. Somebody would cover her head with red Dupatta and apply turmeric on her arms and legs. She sat down motionless and lifeless all through, waiting for time to pass on its own, without bothering her. First day, when all this had started, fear and restlessness had grown in her. When she heard the voices and songs in the veranda, she wanted to run away from there. Her heart raced and her hands trembled. Her body kept her on red alert all the time, as though there was some unseen danger which was ready to destroy her. She always had that scared look. Everything moved fast in her mind. She responded late and would ask for the directions repeatedly. While doing the final puja, she spilled the spoon full of ghee while putting it in the diya.

“Be relaxed” pandit has said looking at her with concern.

She had nodded immediately, held her right hand from elbow with the left hand to make it steady. She batted her eyes and breathed from mouth to let go of the tension and hurry, to fight back the suffocation. When ladies started dancing and to the drum beats, she felt that her head would explode any moment. The sound made her cry instantly. Everyone thought that she was crying because she was leaving her house, but only Naina knew that those tears were of burden, helplessness, and suffocation. There was no way she could stop them. She did not want to stop them!

She had not cried since her last call to Veer. After that day, her eyes had remained cold and dry. All through the time, when the groom's family had come to visit her, when her aunt decided her wedding dress, when list of guests was being finalised, the time the henna was being applied on her palms and feet, she hadn't felt anything. There was nothing that scared her. There was nothing that touched her. It was like she was immune to all those emotions which she had felt all through earlier. Everything had vanished, leaving her light, yet heavy, somewhere inside at the same time. There was stillness in her.

She knew that the pain was still there, but somehow it had stopped hurting her. And all her desires of happiness and love had died. She did feel good when her mother chose the green saree for herself to wear on her wedding. Naina's eyes had glistened when she had looked in the mirror, putting that folded saree on her own shoulder, feeling the smoothness of the fabric with her hands. She had to work to smile, but it had started and died up immediately. It did not reach her eyes and lips. It stayed at the pit of her belly. A tiny ticklish kind of thing which lasted only for a moment, and then disappeared into nowhere. Even the slightest movement of her lips took effort and for that, she did not have energy. The act of keeping her eyes open was an enormous task. Since that day, calmness had entered her, a kind of relief that even though she was not feeling any happiness yet, she was now immune to pain at least. Her life would be easy from now on.

Every memory of her past tormented her, but she was too tired to think about them. That day, when the celebration started, her illusion broke. She realised that nothing had gone anywhere. It was still there, right in the centre of her chest. The shield which protected her had broken, exposing all

her scars. Blood was still oozing from them. Flesh still felt freshly cut and pink. Slightest of touch made her gut twist with pain. Her heels ached when she walked. Her knuckles and fingertips hurt when she opened her palms. Every muscle and bone were aching as if they were cracking and tearing themselves apart from the inside. Her head spun when the drum beats accelerated with pace. Every stick that stuck the drum left a red indentation inside her soft sponge-like muscle in her skull.

She clenched her fists into tight balls. The skin on her palms and finger buds turned white with pressure, a trick she had developed to control her pain. Whenever Ashok came over her, she would close her eyes and make her fists tight to endure that tearing feeling between her legs. But when Ashok slapped her and forced to keep her eyes open, she shifted all the strength of her body into her small fists.

“Open your eyes, let me see them. I know what they want.” he had said one time.

Now, she wondered sometimes that had she not developed this habit, her body would have had exploded and its pieces would have scattered all around. She knew that.

On the last day, her eyes looked for her mother. She had become habitual of looking for her face all the time. She hardly left Naina. It felt like she was the extension of her. Like her arms and legs, she followed her everywhere. She always found her kind and worried with her concern writ on her face. That day, when she did not find her in the room, she went out in the veranda. Her eyes moved around, scanning the profiles of women there, and trying to find her mother’s petite frame. Her edge of the saree, locked at her waist, her hair tightly secured in a bun! She turned towards the kitchen when she did not find her there. She was washing something in the sink when Naina found her. Her hands were smudged in curry.

“Mama.....!” Naina called standing at the entrance. Her mother could not hear her amidst of the loud noise of drums. Naina called her again, a little louder. She washed her hands immediately and came to her.

Sensing the anxiety on her face her mother looked at her inquisitively.

Naina asked softly, "What should I do?"

"What do you want to do?" her mother asked back with a question in her eyes, "Can I help you with anything?"

Naina was silent, looking with blank eyes.

"Don't you want your henna to get dark?" her mother said wiping her hands with edges of her saree. She lifted Naina's hands with her brown coloured henna and showing her open palms said, "Girls don't do anything after henna on these hands. You don't need to do anything today. Go and take rest."

The smile on her mother's face and look in her eyes was such as if she was seeing Naina for the last time. She raised her hand to bless her, but Naina suddenly turned and left before her mother could touch her.

Naina knew that she wouldn't be able to bear any emotional gesture that day. She did not want to have any weak moments with her mother or with anybody. She had been holding herself for so many days and a single moment of love could break the floodgates and then she won't be able to handle the storm.

She went back to her room, carefully avoiding eye contact with anyone. That day even the walls were sending her warmth. She could barely look at her room, at her bed, at her old belongings, at her old pair of sandals, at her bangles, at her books. She slipped into her bed and pulled the blanket over again. She slept as if she did not want to wake up again. She did not leave the bed until one of her aunties barged in the room with her wedding dress.

"Naina, you are still sleeping! What kind of girl are you? How can you sleep today? Don't you think you should spend these moments with your family? I never knew you are so lazy." Her aunt was yelling at her while taking out her jewellery from the almirah.

Naina woke up and folded her blanket neatly. That was the first time she had made her bed. She knew that once she leaves today, she won't be coming back to her only bed again. It was her way to say her final goodbye

to it. It seemed that time was playing tricks on her. In the morning time moved slowly and night seemed hours away like a distant possibility to her. But as the sun started moving so fast that noon almost disappeared, she did not know when the noon ended and evening started. Just a few minutes ago she was with her mother asking her to do something to kill the time and now, she does not have time even to properly look at anybody.

By the time, her aunt dressed her up, the sky outside had become dark. Long strings of small lights from the terrace to the floor were blinking. It looked like the house had covered itself in a sparkling piece of cloth. All the lights started glowing, one by one. Bright yellow and white lights filled every inch of the house. Her house glowed like a palace. It was covered in layers of light from head to toe. Those little lights were blinking like stars across the dark night. Bright pink and shimmering curtains were neatly tucked across the main gate and big flower bouquets of fresh roses were gracing its outline.

When she stepped out of her room, she saw the mandap set up at the centre of the veranda. Two workers were tucking the bouquets and curtains on it in the same pattern. White lights were so bright that it seemed the Sun itself was still ablaze there. Naina wore a pink skirt with cream coloured blouse over it. It had little golden flowers embroidered on it. To complete the look of the bride, her aunt had chosen a bright magenta sheer dupatta. It had tiny white stones on it, which looked like stars under that light. Her aunt had smeared kohl in her eyes at the water line and coloured her lips with pink shade. The cream and pink coloured glass bangle ended only a few inches under her elbows. Her yellowish skin glowed with beautiful henna on her hands. Just like her, the house was looking beautiful.

She sat next to her grandmother with the other ladies. They were waiting to be called to the mandap to perform the final rituals. The bride and groom were supposed to take their vows. Then they would tie the knots and would take circles around the holy fire, which is accepted as a witness of their wedding. All the ladies were sitting in the living area, a grilled window which separated them from the gathering outside. They craned their necks time and again to look at the proceedings. And then those who could look out announced them to others who were sitting in the corners,

“Pandit is still making the arrangements. I guess it’ll take some more time.” One of them said to no one in particular.

“This marriage and all generally go on full night, these things take time.” another said in a calmer tone as if assuring everybody to wait patiently.

Naina sat on the chair beside her grandmother. Her head down, she was looking at her knees and long flare of her skirt. Her bangles clinked when she itched at the back of her neck or when she crossed her fingers on her thighs. Her hair was tied in a high bun and beautifully styled with white and pink flowers. Her nails were painted with magenta nail-polish. Her hazel eyes, which were neatly outlined with kajal, had never looked so beautiful and so sad before.

It was getting difficult for her to sit there. The noise and the crowd were making her sick. She wanted to run away from there. Every beat of the music was piercing her ear drums. With a lot of effort, she controlled her hands from reaching her ears to cover them. She knew that won’t be appropriate for a bride to avoid listening to the music.

When she heard the pandit order her aunt to call her, her head started to spin. When she got up, she had to place her right hand on her temples to stop it. But as she started to walk the spinning grew. She could no longer see the ground below her. When she looked up, she could not see the faces. She just saw some multicoloured wavy lines, moving in front of her eyes. She blinked her eyes, but the blurriness remained as it was. She looked down to watch her steps, but there was no surface to stand on. Her aunt held her by her arms when she missed her step and stumbled. She manoeuvred her and Naina did not know where her steps were going, every step was demanding the focus and energy which she did not have. Her eyes burned, and she felt sick. If allowed, she would have puked right there.

“Naina, walk carefully.” Someone whispered in her ear. She looked towards her left and saw those multicoloured lines only moving like spirals. There was no face attached to that voice.

“Naina, walk carefully, you might fall.” Lines waved with every word she heard, and they moved with speed.

She remembered this day in pieces. That unsteady walk was the last memory for her before it went all dark and silent around her. She did not know what happened. She was walking towards that mandap and now her mind could not tell her where she was. She felt as if she was all alone in the whole world. There was nobody to be seen around her, no sound to be heard. But she still walked and then somebody made her sit.

Till now, her head was heavy and aching. Suddenly she was not feeling anything, she was as light as air. She could not feel the dress which had been pricking her till now. She touched her bangles and they did not clink. She touched her fingers and she did not feel her own touch. It seemed as if she was travelling inside herself.

“Naina, hold it.” one of her aunties tapped on her shoulder, but Naina could not hear her.

“Nainaaaaaa.....! Hold it.” this time she handed over the garland in her hand but Naina dropped it.

“Naina! What are you doing?” Her mother shook her by her arm. The hook of her nose ring slipped from her hair and hung below her chin. Her aunt came immediately to fix it so that nobody could see that.

“Naina, are you ok? Do you need water?” her mother asked her looking at her face as if trying to read her expressions. She had seen Naina in those days when her mind used to play tricks on her. She could read every line on Naina’s face.

When Naina did not reply, she held her hand. Naina’s hands were ice cold. Her mother rubbed her palms slightly without making it obvious to be seen. She made her sit on a cushion and rubbed her palms. Naina could feel the warmth in her palm but her mother’s face was still blurred.

Naina found herself standing holding the garland after some time facing the groom. Her eyes were still glued to the floor. She noticed his cream coloured traditional mojaris.

Her aunties and other ladies were standing next to her. A group of ladies was singing folk wedding songs loudly in the background when the ceremony of exchanging garlands took place. Everybody showered flower petals on the couple. Guests standing in front of the stage were holding their phones towards them. Cameras flashes looked like fireworks.

When Naina came back in her senses again, she found herself standing face to face with Suraj. She looked at him and studied his face. A hand touched her at the back and made her look down. She was standing on a red and black printed carpet. Last time, she had looked down, her feet were on white marble, at her house. She looked up again, ran her curious eyes from left to right. There were people in front of her, some known and some unknown faces, looking at them. She read their eyes. They were not looking only at her. She turned to her left to see. Suraj was standing next to her. He looked straight to the public, nodding, and smiling, and was holding his hands together to greet people.

When she looked around, she felt that everything and every face were mocking her. Their smiles were irritating her. In that crowd, her eyes spotted a half bald guy sitting next to a little girl. He was feeding her 10 or 11-year-old daughter with his hands. He looked at her lovingly, feeding her small morsels carefully. He waited for her to finish the food in her mouth and then put another small piece of chapatti with curry in her mouth. Seeing that little girl, a smile crept on Naina's lips.

Seconds later, that man turned, and Naina saw his face. Naina looked closely again. Her smile disappeared, and disgust took over. How could she forget that face, his betel-stained teeth, his stale breaths? Had she not seen him like that, she would have never believed this side of him. She was the same age when she had seen his brutality.

'How come brutality and love both can be part of the same person? How his granddaughter would feel if she ever came to know about him?' Naina thought, looking at Ashok. She wanted to save that girl from his grip. She kept her gaze at him to check his hands' movements. Did he make her sit in his lap, like he did with her?

That light, music, people around her, voices, their laughter, all those things were pricking her from inside and there was only a sound in her mind, “No... NO.... Don’t cry.... Don’t yell.... Not now...!” It was her gatekeeper who was holding her floodgates. Her vision was fluctuating like a faulty bulb, turning on and off. For a while she saw the crowd ahead, and then everything turned black. Sounds came and then faded. She witnessed her wedding rituals in bits. Next thing she remembered was that she was sitting crossed legged next to Suraj. Her hands were subtly resting in her lap. All males from both families were sitting on white mattresses behind them. She did not see them, but she knew she had seen this in her auntie’s marriages.

Ladies went back into the room. They all sat on a carpet. Some of them, who were seated at the entrance of the door, had covered their faces beneath long veils. Naina always asked her mother about her cover, “Why can’t you just leave it? Don’t you feel suffocated?”

And her mother always replied that it was their tradition and it protected them. She did not understand the meaning of those words then, but today she understood. Behind her own cover, she could at least breathe freely. Her eyes could at least express the real emotions. That moment, her veil was the only solace, only layer between her and the world. Under it, she could be her own self. She could escape hundreds of eyes, which had been making her vulnerable till then. Her gatekeeper, who was holding every muscle on her face, could let go some of them and allowed them to relax a little.

Many thoughts ran in her mind at that moment. She kept her eyes on the yellow and orange fire for some time, and then closed them slowly. She remembered how she had placed her hands on the hot-plate that day. Her palms itched for that same pain again. She crossed her fingers tightly to stop that urge. Priest started chanting some mantras but her ears were not on them. Memories were flashing one by one, behind her eyes like a movie. She saw herself running in that same veranda, her arms wide open, mirroring the aeroplane wings. Then the scene changed into the drawing room, Naina saw herself taking a small morsel with her little hands from her father’s plate. She giggled when he glared at her for this. She took one more piece and then ran away, giggling and jumping.

She saw herself standing at the entrance of the house, facing the street, her palms joined to form a Namaste gesture. She bowed down and said Namaste to whoever passed her house, “Namaste Uncle.... Namaste Aunty...!” She bowed down to everyone, known -unknown uncles, aunties, beggars, rickshaw pullers, and greeted them with a proud smile on her face until her Bua dragged her inside and slapped her.

Amidst the flood of her memories she did not know, when did she nod and accept her wedding vows, when did she complete the rounds around the fire? She remembered the pushing and holding of hands but she did not realise when and how she got married. She did not witness the moment when her life took the next turn, when her name changed from Naina to Mrs Naina. All her life she believed that she never belonged to this place, that she was a misfit here. That place was not meant for her but when the time came to break all her strings, her heart was stopping her from doing that. She wanted to lie down there, flat on her stomach and to feel that cold marble on her cheeks like she used to.

At the time of her bidding farewell, she did not feel the hate, rejection, anger she was carrying within herself for so many years. She was overwhelmed. Her cousins came one by one, hugged her, and she hugged them as if she was hugging them for the last time. Her mother, who was always with her like a shadow all the time, was nowhere to be seen. Naina’s eyes were looking for her. She looked up from her veil, ran her eyes across the room, tried to see her in the crowd of guests, but she could not spot her anywhere.

The thought of not meeting her before leaving made her restless. When her aunt manoeuvred her to the door, her heart pounded with every step she took towards her new life. Keshav came and hugged her. That was the first time he has hugged her and expressed his affection towards her. She could hear his sobs on her shoulders. When they separated, Naina looked at his face in surprise. She hated herself for all the resentment and hate she had had for him all those years. Why could he not love her like this before, when she was there? And why did she not understand and tried to talk to him? He hugged her back when he saw Naina’s blank eyes. She burst in tears when she hugged him again. Those were tears of regret and

disappointment, as if saying thank you for his love and saying sorry that she could not see his love before. Naina's gatekeeper had held her calmly for so many days, it broke in that movement and she finally let her tears flow freely.

From little kids to her grandmother everyone hugged her that day. They waited for their turn to share a few words with her. She was surprised to see tears in everybody's eyes. She had never imagined her farewell to be like this. They were supposed to be happy, that finally that label of their shame was leaving them. Not only on them, was she surprised at herself. She did not know why and where her tears came from. She always felt unloved till that day. But that day, her heart was overfilled with love and gratitude and it was dripping from her eyes.

When she stepped out of her house, she looked back again to find her mother. She saw her standing at the back, behind the crowd. She stood there, wiping her eyes with her green saree, which she had bought with her. Naina stopped and looked at her. She did not move her eyes until her mother came to her. When they came face to face, Naina's lower lips trembled, looking at her. How could she be so cruel towards her? How could she ever think that her mother did not love her? She thought of all those moments which she had wasted thinking, that her mother did not love her. When her mother raised her arms to hug her, Naina stopped them in the air and knelt in front of her. She placed her hands on the floor and then slowly placed her forehead on her mother's feet. She then touched her mother's rough feet with her hands and then brought her hands back to her face, touched her eyes and forehead. Her shoulders shuddered with her heavy sobs as she stood, joining her palms facing her mother. Her lips mumbled to say sorry, but words did not come out of her mouth. But her mother understood what she was trying to say. She shook her head in 'No', tears running on her cheeks. She wiped Naina's eyes and hugged her for the last time before parting.

Her father was standing near the car, holding his palms together and bidding goodbye to guests who were leaving. Naina and her husband also stood in front for him like other guests. Naina wanted to hug her father, but she stood still there waiting for him to hug. She did not know whether she still

had the right to hug him. When she bowed down to touch his feet, he stopped her in the middle and kept her hand in the centre of her head. She waited for him to say something but he did not. His eyes were blood red and his voice choked in his throat and he was about to hug her.

Her uncle stopped in the middle saying, “It’s ok! Don’t do this drama here. Let’s go!”

She looked at him surprised, hurt, and confused. Why is the gap between male and female emotions so huge? She looked at him thinking, ‘Why is there not even a hint of any pain or discomfort on his face. Do they really love her? And if not, then what about that care and concern she saw on their faces? And if yes, why can’t they understand what she was going through at this moment? Why can’t they see that she is bidding them her final goodbye as their daughter and she needs them? Or was it like a fathers’ way to tell their daughters, that they need to fight their own battle themselves. In their new life they won’t find them standing next to them and then, they will have to handle their problems all alone. Maybe it’s their way to tell them that they have to be strong and self-sufficient.’

She kept her eyes on her uncle’s rigid face when he motioned her towards the car. He kept his face straight. He knew that Naina was expecting and waiting for her last share of love, but the strong layer of masculinity did not allow him and her father to melt, to bend, not even an inch.

CHAPTER

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25

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Who knows who am I?

My demons ate my flesh away.

Now there are bones that they feed upon.

Soon, I will be gone and demons,

Would devour somebody else.

If anybody would ask me about my marriage, I don't think I'll be able to recall anything. It amazes me sometimes, how I cannot forget some things which I don't want to remember. And, how I can't remember one thing about that night? When I look at him, I don't know what I feel or do I even feel anything. Suraj is different from others.

Some days, I feel that my heart would explode with all the love and his needs of physical touch he has been pouring on me. I feel pressure around my heart's wall. Every time, whenever that night comes, I try to imagine the pleasure one person gets from the body. It must be blissful, that it creates such a powerful and unstoppable urge. The desire that can make people do the worst of the things, things that can go even beyond humanity.

In her private movements, Naina always tried to understand her own body, trying to explore the hunger it had or did it have any requirement like others. She did not always dread the human touch. She craved for a human touch at times, a loving touch, a soft kiss on her lips, without the hurry in it. A touch,

which said that that person wanted to understand Naina, not her body. His fingers ran beyond her skin, his eyes explored her beyond the face, and touch that girl who was still untouched. But whenever she tried to replicate that feeling with her own hands, she felt nothing. She moved her hands on her stomach, on her breasts, all without any sign of desire. She could never take her hand between her legs. That part scared her. Her own touch brought those memories back, which she dreaded.

Even after three years, Suraj's touch pricked her. It tore her apart every time he came inside her. Her guts twisted, and she retched up afterwards. Their every intercourse left her torn and forlorn for days. Her hunger to love and being loved remained unfulfilled. In those years, she understood her own incapability of receiving and giving unconditional love. The devotion which she had, had vanished long back. Her past blocked the way. It was not the people around her who didn't love her. It was her own belief about herself that hindered the flow.

Every time she looked at Suraj, her heart would fill with guilt and helplessness. How small and dirty she felt around him. His pure and kind embrace irritated her. She hated the moment when he looked at her with those soft eyes. She could not believe that this kind of humanity and honesty still existed. He broke every belief and misconception she had about men and about the world. She had seen him caring and crying when her mother was ill. She had noticed him taking care of her when she woke up crying and shouting in nightmares. She saw his childlike smile, his eyes closed, and mouth wide open. His honesty showed in his words and in his silence.

During first few months of their marriage, Naina looked at him with suspicious eyes, reading and analysing every moment in which he could turn into something else. She waited for the time his silent and gentle demeanour would break and his real side would come out. Though she did not give any chances of argument, yet she waited for something to happen in the house which would spark him. She kept on looking for any crack which allowed her to see inside him.

Even in bed, she expected him to be rough and hurried in his manner. But his hands moved softly over her body as if he was painting and trying a new colour every time with very light and slow movements of brush. His touch

and eyes did not have the urge to reach somewhere and find the hidden treasure. Sometimes, she wondered what he felt about her when he looked at her with that calm smile on his face. In those moments, she would quickly move her eyes or break the contact by saying something weird or inappropriate. She could not let anybody come near her and let her read from inside again. She did not have the strength to show her scars and increase them in numbers.

Morning was still hours away when Naina reached their new home after the wedding. All through the way, after she had stopped crying, she leaned back on her seat and looked out. Her head was heavy with the tight braids her aunt had made all the roses in them. From the corner of her eye, she could see that he was looking at his side of the road. She liked the silence between them. There were two men sitting at front. The guy on the driving seat wore a black suit and looked behind every time he wanted to say something. Suraj even warned him about that. Naina could not see who was sitting in the seat in front of her, but she knew that he was sleeping. His head moved and touched the glass every time the car bumped.

The car was decorated with white and red roses. She observed the petals from inside of the glass panes. The flowers looked dull and tired; their neck hung in disappointment. She imagined how they must have looked during the day, when the decorator had taped them, all fresh and excited! Her shoulders moved in a long sigh when she moved her eyes on the road. Suraj was sitting next to her. Everything was silent and peaceful. Road looked wider and beautiful. They reminded her of her carefree and happy-go-lucky days of her childhood. She imagined herself walking barefoot on that concrete road under yellow light. Cold breeze of January kissed her face. She rubbed her one hand on the other, feeling the cold of her imagination. Looking out, she could tell when she entered the new place. All the familiar roads and places which resonated with her native place had gone behind and now when the landscape started changing, she took her time to observe them. She wanted to fill them in her memory. She knew, she will not be coming back to these empty roads again after that time.

Here the street-lights were different, roads were wider and cleaner. She could see the thick green belt across the road. There were lights embedded in the road, which glowed from far. She looked ahead at the road to find the trail of

them as to where they finished. She wanted to ask, 'What is the purpose of them. But then she ate her words realising the situation.

She tucked in her dupatta and creased her skirt when their car entered a big iron gate. There was a huge sign over it, but she could not read it. She looked ahead through the windshield. There were rows of buildings there. A big park to her right. They drove till the dead end and parked the car in front of a similar building. Naina saw Suraj getting down and decreasing his shirt when a girl opened the door of her side. She must have been of her age only; her eyes were still sparkling and lively. She heard the excitement and laughter when she got down. That girl lifted her skirt a little and helped Naina get down.

"Bhabhi..! Here.....!" She motioned her to walk ahead. The word 'Bhabhi' sounded odd and big to her ears. It hovered around her ears, repeating itself to tease her. She wished she could jerk that off by rubbing her ear, but she could not move her hands like that.

During the day, she kept her head down, like she had seen other brides in her village. She had seen women commenting on those brides who looked up and answered boldly to the question. Later when they would come out from the bride's house, they would comment among them saying, "This girl is very fast and bold. Beware of her!"

While growing up, Naina had acquired all the required behaviours a woman needed to survive. They were the constant warnings at her house, 'How she should sit, how loud she should laugh, how much and how fast she should eat'. Everything was well defined and was taught to her.

"Your mother-in-law would be very happy if you do this, if you learn cooking this and that." She had heard these words many times.

She knew how the judgy eyes ran over her when she sat in the middle of them.

The whole day had passed in rituals and prayers and it was around 10 PM, when everybody left her room. Her body was burning, her back and legs ached. It was then that she realised that she had to share the room with

somebody else. She leaned her head back and closed her eyes slowly. She touched her neck with the back of her hand to check for fever. Her body was radiating heat.

‘You will be good, don’t worry!’ she said to herself while making her breath normal and steady.

She opened her eyes with a start when the door opened and Suraj came in. He stood there for a while looking at her feet and then he turned and locked the door. She heard the ladies giggling outside. Naina’s heart stopped beating for a while. She felt as if suddenly her heart had grown heavy inside and was making it difficult for her to breathe. Something was stuck in her ribcage and air did not seem to pass through.

Suraj came and sat next to her. The air in the room was thick and dense. She could understand his nervousness, the way he looked at the other side. Ticking of the clock was the only sound which filled the room. She looked at her hands over that red bed sheet. It smelt new. Somebody must have bought it for this room. A folded blanket was there at the end of the bed. There was nothing fancy or designer in the room. There was a chocolate brown table with a desktop on it and a simple black clock on the wall in the front. There were some engineering books stacked up neatly in the corner of that table. She could not spot the chair in the room. His room did not have any fragrance. It was plain and simple, as if colourless and transparent.

She waited for him to say something. There was nothing she could say. Words did not come out of her mouth. They both sat at the edges of their sides motionless, like statues. Naina was frozen at her place, she did not budge. She took shallow breaths to stop whatever little movement her heavy breaths could cause. Naina could feel his eyes on her feet. She drew them in and hid them inside her skirt.

There was an awkward silence between them. It was not their first conversation. Suraj had called her 3-4 times before marriage, but those conversations never moved beyond formal greetings and family concerns. Today, it seemed that they had come from different universes and did not know the language which both of them could understand.

“I guess we should sleep. I am exhausted. You must be tired as well.” he broke the silence and Naina let go of the tension and burden silently.

The knot in her head loosened. He waited for her reply. But, when she did not say anything, he took his pillow, flattened the puff of it with his hand and lied down at his side of the bed, leaving enough space for Naina to feel comfortable. He turned his back towards her and closed his eyes. Naina looked at him from the corner of her eyes. Her heart beat came back to normal pace. But she did not move. After an hour or so, when her eyes refused to stay open, she took another pillow and lay down at the other side of the bed. She curled into a ball; her knees dug in her stomach. Her eyes burned with tiredness, but she forced them to remain open to be ready for any danger. She looked at the yellow wall. By the shine she could tell that it was recently painted.

She must have been asleep, because when she woke up with a start, the room was completely dark and that yellow wall had disappeared in it. She had woken up when she had felt a hand creeping on her stomach. She jumped out of the bed with heavy breaths.

“It’s me ...It’s me...!” Suraj said apologetically.

“I... I am sorry.....!” She fumbled between heavy breaths.

“It’s Ok, I understand,” he said and kept his hand on her shoulder. She wished she could shrug off his hands. She wished she could also disappear into that darkness.

Suraj held her by her shoulders and helped her lie down. Naina was shivering and sweating. He took her hand and placed it gently on his palm. She drew her fingers back and half closed her fists when he moved, he caressed it. His fingertips burned her skin.

“I...,” she cleared her thought and said, “I am. tired!” and pulled back her hand gently and turned towards the wall again, her last attempt to avoid the thing which she was anticipating.

Suraj lay down next to her and she could feel his warm breaths on the back of her neck.

“You are beautiful,” he said in a whisper.

Naina closed her eyes shut, that whisper in his voice stung her. He ran his fingers on her exposed arm, placed his hand on her stomach, and drew her closer. Naina shut her eyes so tightly that her eyes hurt. He nuzzled his nose in her neck and turned her face towards him holding her chin.

‘Don’t touch me! I have been touched so many times, that now everything hurts. Let me suckle the previous touches first before I start bleeding again from your cuts.’ she said to herself.

All the words she wanted to say were stuck in her throat. She joined her hands and said a small prayer, ‘Save me!’ She whispered with tearful eyes.

His chest and stomach pressed against her back. She was sobbing when Suraj pressed lightly on her arm and turned her to face him. He ran his finger on at the edges of her face. Felt her cheeks with his hands. He got up and switched on the light. She shrunk in herself and closed her eyes tighter when bright white light filled the room, as if it exposed her.

“Naina! What happened?” He sat close to her and asked looking at her wet face. There were splotches of tears on both sides of her pillow. She remained lying there still, curled. Her eyes were tightly shut and her hands still joined in small fists over her chest.

“What happened? Why are you crying?” he asked, taking her henna-laden hands and placing them softly on his palms.

His calmness told her that he could understand what she was thinking. She sobbed uncontrollably, gasping for breath in between. Her heart was overwhelmed by the kindness and softness of his words and gesture. It melted her.

“I.... I am not feeling well. My. my back and legs are aching.” she said in a meek voice. Each word came out after a struggle. She sobbed, spoke, and then sobbed, and then cried a little more before stopping.

“Oh....!” he said and after a long pause continued, “I got so worried. It’s okay! It’s okay! You should take a rest. We will talk tomorrow.”

He got up and pulled the blanket over her and tucked it right under her neck. She pulled it immediately and covered her face in it. She did not want him to see her like this, any window which led him to her inside world, she wanted to close it. Suraj caressed her head under the blanket until her breaths become slow and deep.

The next day, when she woke up, Suraj was not in the room. She later came to know that he always woke up before sunrise. There was a cup of tea and two butter-smearred toast on the computer table. A grumble in her stomach reminded her that she had not eaten anything since the day before. She did not even remember what she had eaten last time. There was a white circular pill, still secured inside its blue jacket. Somebody had cut it in a perfect square out of the bunch.

She thought about last night when she had cried like a baby. She hated herself for the begging and pleading. She hated Suraj's grand gesture of kindness and worry. He should have completed what he had started. She would not have felt burdened with it. Someday, he would ask her to pay for it and she would be obliged to grant it. She had not thought of it like this. She looked forward to the torture she was used to, where there was no space for love and kindness. Her world was easy that way. She did not know how to handle softness, and it always slipped through her fingers. But she knew how to endure the pain. It resonated with her. It ran in her blood. Bitterness had been injected into her. There was a new muscle of agony in her and it ran from head to toe, connected every cell of her body. It ached when kindness touched her. Ugly words and ugly touches were the only cure for it. Cruelty and brutality gave her strength.

Love brings an illusion. It silently tricks you to suffer for years. At least, cruelty and unkindness are honest. They do not attack from the back. You can fight if you want to, you can surrender if you want to. But what would you do with love? There is nothing you can do to protect yourself. It wrecks you in an impossible way. Your pieces remain missing for life.

And she was not sure whether she was even capable and worthy of all the affection and concern. She was filth, filth which stank, filth that could make you retch and throw up. Her insides were rotten, overused. They smelt of waste from different people. There was nothing in her which was pure. Her

mouth, hands, legs, her mind, everything had been to places where they should not have been. Things they had touched and tasted that no human child and human should do. The day he will come to know about it, he will be no different from others. The love she saw in him would turn into lust in no time. And then he would demand his share and would gauge it out of her, even if she rejected.

Before marriage, whenever she thought about her husband, she always looked at it as an exchange. 'He would give me food and shelter, and I would pay him for his services in ways I know, in ways she had done previously'. Over the years, she had understood how to keep a man happy. What to do and how to do it. She knew when to use her mouth and when to use her hand. With Ashok, she has learnt different ways to please a man. With Veer, she learnt how to conceal the affliction behind the dirty words and moans. What to say, what to show on her face. When to bite her lips and closes her eyes depicting pleasure.

She had decided that this time, she will not let herself be fooled by this love again. She did not require it to survive. All you need to live in silence and endurance. The dark colour of silence she had seen on others' faces, she understood them now. She could read the still and empty eyes of her mother, grandmother, and her aunts. What she hated the most was that they never told her about it. They never warned her about it. How could they just let her go through it and understand it all by herself? She cried thinking about her little version, 'how innocent she was' and now, she sat there all torn up and bleeding from places, she couldn't tell the world.

It was months later when she made her first payment. With her own will, with her consent. Every night, after the mishap of the first night, she waited for him to come closer and claim his right. But Suraj always ended up having conversations about him and her. He initiated talks that would make her uncomfortable. When he asked about her childhood, Naina could only say that it was good, just like others'. Often after switching off the light, she thought of sharing her past with him, to see his reaction, to see what he did with the ugly truth of hers. It was heavy on her chest, sharing it might have made her feel better. But she knew that it won't, it would drown her. She did not have the courage to go back in time and relive those things again. She was safe this way, while the beast was miles away from her and him.

During the day, her heart would pound thinking about the possibility of what might happen at night. She prepared herself every night for the final battle, raising all her guards tight and active. But it never happened. She slept on the edge, her mind and body active with the anticipation of danger. Her head ached and thud every evening. Each day, the fear grew and the strength withered away. She was scared that her body and mind would get used to this comfort and one day when that would happen, it would again rip her apart. All her illusions would shatter then. The burden of his softness was getting heavy to carry. She could not look into his eyes when he tried to read her. All her life she had waited for someone to look at her like that, and now when it was happening, it irritated her. It felt like her stomach was in the tight grip of a metallic hand of steel. And the grip increased every day and so did the pain.

“I think we should do it now,” she said in a low voice, digging the skin around her thumbnail.

He was working on something on the computer, his one hand on the mouse and the other bent under his chin. He paused and looked at her in surprise, smiled and asked, “Do what?”

He looked back at the screen again, waiting for her reply.

“Do what?” he said again, still looking at the screen.

“You know what I am saying,” Naina said, folding the already folded bed sheet. She kept her eyes on the vintage women’s faces on the bed sheet. She never liked this bed sheet, but she had not told him. She spread it only when the other bed sheets had not fully dried. She had seen Suraj changing the bed sheet daily. He would make the bed beforehand while she was busy in the kitchen. It was after regular persistence of her that he left that habit.

“I like doing my things.” he had said.

“It’s my duty!” she had replied.

“It’s nobody’s duty,” he had retorted sharply and left the room.

Naina kept thinking about his words, 'It's nobody's duty.' Did he mean that? Or was it only a show to pull her around? She still could not understand him, could not separate the real layers of him from his personality.

Suraj came and stood next to her when Naina did not answer.

"Sit" he tilted his head to the left and motioned her to sit down. He kept her hands in his hands, he always did that before sleeping. Naina could not sleep until he slept. Her body would remain on vigil until he didn't free her hand.

Naina squirmed beside him. She regretted her invitation. She wished she could reverse the time and unsay it. She would have got one more peaceful night to sleep, to think through it.

"Sssssss!" she winced when he kissed her.

He stepped back and looked at her. 'What was that which hurt her so badly?'

"It's my toe ring. I think it's tight." She bent down and pretended to fix it. She half smiled at him when he looked back at her. She jerked inside and pulled her toes inward to suppress the feeling. His lips, were soft but still pricked her. She immediately wiped her lips with the back of her hand when they departed.

"I think we should switch off the light. It's too bright and hurts my eyes." Her bangles clinked when she leaned back on the bed. It was a relief she could not see his face and he could not see hers. She could easily hide and mock things as she wanted. Every touch of his hand hurt her. It was more painful than she had thought. She had not been touched in a long time. She gritted her teeth when his hand and mouth reached her breasts. Her stomach pulled in tightly, as if her intestines were absorbing the strain of whatever was happening on her body.

Naina wanted to cry. She wanted to yell and scream but she did not, she could not. She wanted to run but she could not. Suraj came to her again and landed his lips on hers. She wanted to draw her lips but she lay there like a lifeless body, tears dripping from the corners of her eyes. Suraj kissed every bit of her slowly, lovingly. He kissed every inch of the body. He did not want her to feel awkward. He did not want her to feel unloved. But he did not

know that the more lovingly he touched her more he hurt her. His lips were like needles to her. He didn't know that his every touch was like a cut on her body. In her mind, his fingertips were like the tip of a knife running on her body and leaving a red line wherever they touched her.

She moved her face to the side when Suraj came over to her. His face looked like a blank placard, cut in the shape of men's faces. By the puff of his hair, she could tell it was him. Apart from that, there was no feature which she could see. A blank black face hung over her. She closed her fists and got ready to endure the pain as he struggled to enter inside her. Naina winced with every jerk of his. Every push and pull tore her. Her insides hurt when it stretched itself to fit him. She saw Ashok's face, his betel-stained teeth grinning at her. Her grip tightened when Ashok's face was replaced by Veer's. She thought about the day when he handed her the 500 Rupee note. Unlike Ashok, he had never called her whore, but made her one.

Suraj was wet with sweat and her tears were making her pillow wet. He wanted to prolong it and she wanted to end it soon. Both were panting when it ended, She in relief, and he in the pleasure of release. The part of her exchange had been done. She could now relax for a few days. Until the time of the next payment comes!

That night, when she went to the bathroom to clean herself, she saw a younger version of her in a school dress, sitting on the floor. Blood dripped between her legs. She looked at her, Little Naina was looking at her helplessly. Her innocent eyes had the same intense pain that she had on her face. Tears tumbled down her eyes seeing herself like that, sitting in the corner. She was looking at her with complaining eyes as if she was the one who had ruined her. As if, she was the one who had given up on her. Her eyes blamed her. Every time she shared the bed with Suraj, she saw that girl sitting in one corner. Sometimes crying, sometimes simply looking at her, expressionless! Her sunken eyes and pale face were the only thing that had changed over the years.

In those 3 years, she learned the frequency of these nights. Initially, they came every week or with a gap of fifteen days. Suraj would talk to her the whole night. He would tell her about his life without asking. She would listen to him, uninterested. Her mind always travelled somewhere else while

he talked. She thought about her mother and father, ‘What they must be thinking about her. Are they still scared that she might run naked again on the street? Whether her nightmares would come back?’

But he remained unknown to those thoughts. It’s good that people can’t read minds. How difficult it would have been to live if somebody could hear or see your thoughts as clear as water. Maybe God knew this.

God knew everything, but He didn’t know how to do justice. I would ask Him, one day when I’ll meet Him. After the lights went off, Suraj would move towards her. His fingers would feel the fullness of her breasts from over her kurta. Then he would slip them inside to cup them. Naina always waited for some time before opening her eyes. Somewhere, she wished that she still could turn him off and she would be spared. But when Suraj whispered her name, something in her would break. All the guilt and burden of not being a good wife stared at her and she would turn reluctantly towards him. Her palms were ready to go numb and white again. Like her eyes, they had been overused with time. They had controlled and had taken all the pressure growing inside her. She would keep her hand on his cheek, her indication of surrender. After they freshened up and came back to their bed, Suraj would hug her tightly and sleep, hugging her. It killed her. This proximity of his is all illusion and suffocating. Why he couldn’t be satisfied just like others? Why does he need to do this? She would count his breaths to avoid the memories and faces flashing in her mind. And, when his breaths turned deep and slow, she would slip out of his embrace.

It was almost a year after their marriage when Suraj said something to her that reminded her of her grandmother.

“Why are you always so dry?” He had asked one day.

This sudden question threw her off balance. She did not know that men observe things like that. Strangely, she had heard these words before. From her grandfather’s mouth! But the tone was different. She remembered one night when she was awake and she had heard her grandfather saying it.

“This is all dry! How should I go?” he had yelled at her grandmother. And she had not replied.

That day she had felt bad about her grandmother. But today, when she heard the same words, she understood the pain her grandmother had gone through. How painful it was for her as well. The whole night she cried, thinking about that night. How closely we all are connected in a single thread. How we share the same journey, but at different timelines. Eventually, we meet each other at some point, melting into each other.

She spent 3 years like that, without saying a word, without expressing herself. Initially, she used to think that time would heal her, but nothing changed in her. She could never come out of her sadness. There was no life in her. She talked less, faked and smiled. That tension between Suraj and her never loosened, or was it that she never let it loose? In those years, she found little Naina sitting in the same corner looking at her with the same complaining eyes. There was a strange relationship between the two of them. Sometimes her presence intrigued her, she just could not bear her gaze, and it filled her with guilt and disgust. Sometimes she saw her sitting next to her bed crying with her as if she was mirroring her as if she was the only one in this world who could understand without any word. Just like her, Little Naina never smiled at her, she was growing pale and weak.

Naina pondered over herself every night, but she could not figure out the actual reason for her state. 'Why does she never feel connected to anyone?' It was not like she missed Veer or she still loved him, but she felt that those moments with him had sucked all the love she had. All her desires had died in those moments. Now, nothing made her happy. She always felt that she was on verge of crying. Every breath felt heavy, every moment that she had spent with him suffocated her. As a kid, she did not understand what she had lost that day when Ashok penetrated her, until one day it became clear to her that she had lost her natural desire for physical love. She could feel now that his touch was still on her, that the disgust and pain that he instilled in her over the years was still running in her blood.

She felt the same uneasiness with Suraj that she had felt on their first night. One night in the middle of their lovemaking, she saw Ashok's face over her instead of Suraj's. She slipped out of her room and went on the terrace to howl like a wounded animal when she could no longer bear the silence in her. She spent hours crying her heart out that night. She pinched her arms and slapped herself for thinking like that about her husband but no matter

what she tried his face haunted her every time Suraj came closer. And after that night it became a routine for her to howl and cry on the terrace so that she could prepare herself for a few more days.

Whenever Suraj hugged her, she found it all empty. As if there was a glass wall between them, his emotions never reached her and she never reached him. She cried pitying sometimes on herself and sometimes on him.

She blamed herself for ruining his life, for not giving him his share of love. Sometimes she would look at Suraj thinking ‘How can this person, who claims to love her, not read her?’ and sometimes she would feel sorry for him.

From washing his clothes to taking care of his house, she completed all the chores with dedication and fulfilled all her responsibilities to fill the gap between them. She respected him and cared for him, but in her heart, there was no place for love, neither for him nor for herself.

“You know what Naina! You are different from other girls; one sees these days. You are just like your mother. You reflect her sometimes.” Suraj told her one day and he unknowingly touched her pain points that she had been struggling to get rid of.

She slipped out of her bed that night when Suraj slept. She went to the bathroom and bolted it. She looked at her reflection in the mirror. She noticed her eyes and dark circles below them. She ran her finger on them. Her eyes were as empty as her mother’s. Yes, she reflected her mother! Her eyes were as hopeless as her mother’s. She noticed her hands. When she touched her own hands, they reminded her of her mother. She remembered how she used to play with her mother’s dry skin by running her little fingers on her hand, pulling her skin making a pinch with her two fingers and then dropping them.

She slightly pinched her skin, pulled it up and then left it. Her skin was as dry as her mother’s. ‘What else do I have as my mother? Does she also feel like me? Is she also empty like me? Did she also never share anything with anyone?’ she thought, looking into the mirror. She saw her eyes glistening with tears in the mirror. Two tiny droplets made their way to her cheeks.

She remembered the lines her mother told her once. “A girl’s life is not easy Beta. You need to sacrifice yourself to keep your family happy.”

‘For how long Mamma.....?’ She could only manage a silent whisper before sitting down hiding her face between her knees.

She curled herself on the bathroom floor, folded one arm below her head to make a pillow of it and stared blankly at the white tiles.

Their relationship was perfect from the outside but only Naina knew how many cuts it had.

The connection between them felt as if they were following some rules from a manual. They were doing their duties as husband and of a wife that society has defined. He never expressed his love openly or used any special gesture. Naina never demanded any special attention, nor did he give it.

Naina knew her reasons for her feelings, but she did not know anything about him. He never shared anything. She did not know what had made him like that, what was the story behind his intense eyes? How come he was different from other men she had seen till then? She never asked him about this. With him, she was very careful about her selection of words; she said only those things which made him happy. She never opposed anything irrespective of whether she liked it or not. She always nodded to whatever he said. She hid her storm behind her silence, the silence she had inherited from her mother.

Although Suraj never said anything which offended her, somewhere Naina knew that this respect was only because of the silence that she maintained. He was bound in his territories, where there was a rule and a defined way to do everything, and Naina never interfered in them. He always respected her and treated all women with respect.

She never asked him to change himself. In her entire life, she had never seen any man changing his habits or lifestyle after getting married and it was engraved in her mind that all changes are part of women’s duty. She knew that it is their duty to keep their husband and family happy, even if it means putting her own happiness at stake. She never dared to ask him anything

which could offend him or his family. She was a daughter, a wife, a daughter-in-law but not Naina. There was nothing in her that belonged to her, not even her own parents, and in this process, she killed herself and became somebody else. There was nothing which she could say that belonged to her.. She did not have any control over her life, not on her body and many times not even on her tears, sadness, and pain. She was invisible in her own body, in her own eyes.

As years passed, the sadness was taken over by bitterness. She even forgot how to fake a smile. Her eyes always stared in space. Her conversation with Suraj shortened. Apart from 'yes' or 'no', she never used any other word.

Today, lying in her corner, she was cursing her life, wishing to die again. She slipped out from her bed and bolted the bathroom door again. Somehow her pain was unbearable today, somehow her strength was dying in her. On such nights, she would tiptoe to the terrace and cry until her breaths gave up. Helplessness is not when you can't speak, you feel it when you can't even cry as you please. She would put her two fingers in her mouth and vomit. The taste of her torment years back was still there on her lips and tongue. No amount of water could wash it.

She would cry until her eyes started burning and her chest choked for want of oxygen. She would cry until she did not have the courage to stand any more. "Why this pain doesn't fade away?" she would yell looking up at the sky, then would draw her knees to her chest and hide her face in it. Everything would become normal by the next day and Naina would live freely.

She was in the kitchen when the first memory flashed in her mind. It was from her school days. She was running back from the school before Ashok could find her. After that incident, Ashok has been meeting her on her way back home. Sometimes he took her to his old home and sometimes he took her to the basement of the shop. There was a single bed in it besides the logs of woods in one corner. A bed sheet was always spread on it. She still remembered the print of it. It had faded from the sides and was washed over, as if it had been washed beyond its life.

At those moments, when her past called her back, her knees would go numb and the sounds around her would fade away. Only thing which she could hear was the fearful heart of her, the way as she used to hear it at those moments. Her face would go white and lifeless. Her fist got closed tightly to let the wave pass quickly without damaging her further.

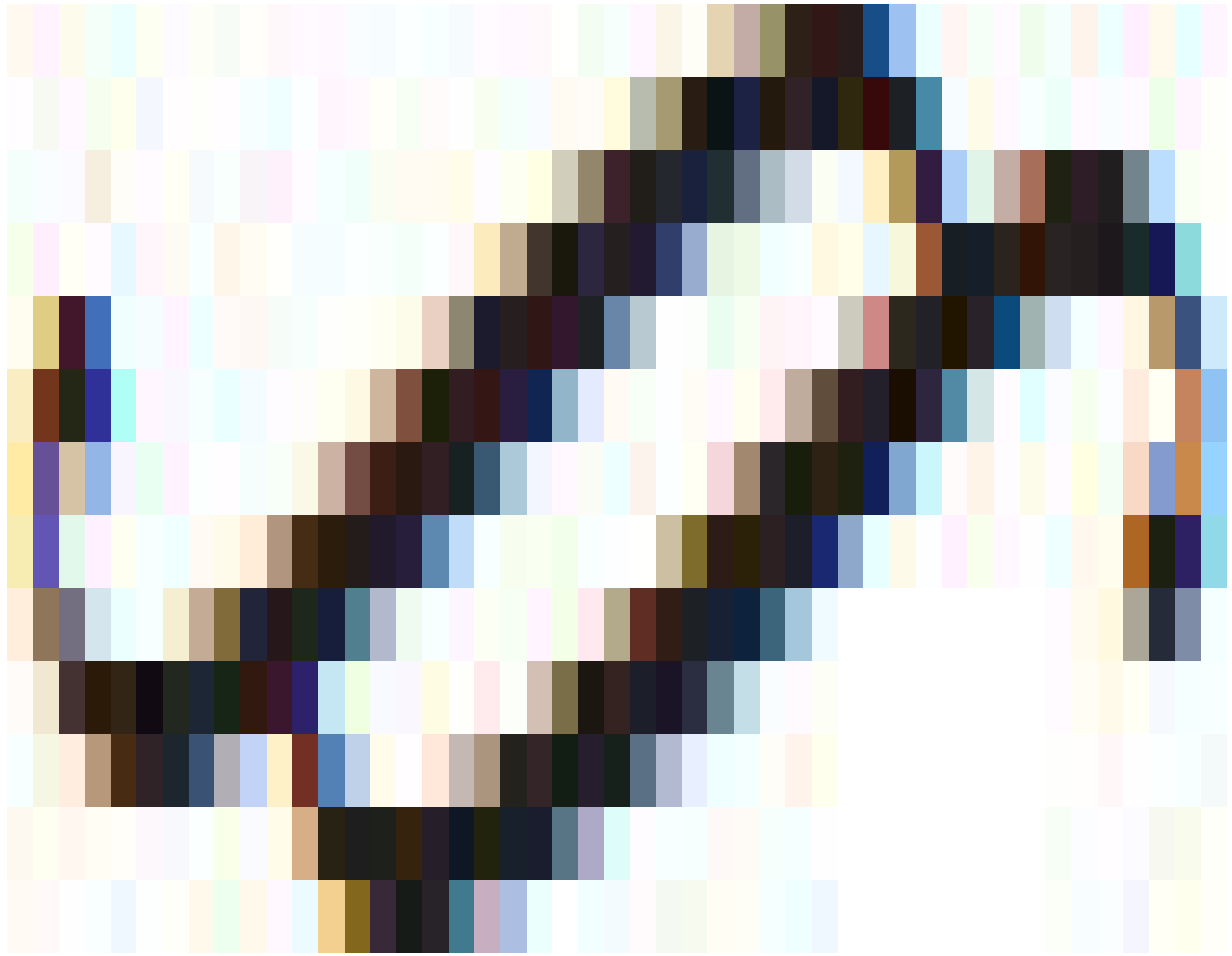
She did not have any control over these flashbacks. Of late she had been losing the controls on her safety guards. Sometime, she saw her mother's face when she was young and Little Naina would be pulling her dupatta from the corner, but she rarely looked back at her. Naina would drink water in a hurry to gulp down the tears lumping in her throat. These flashbacks remained for days. She would drag her day with their weight, with pictures changing and overlapping each other. Those mute memories made her ear bleed, made her head heavy with all those details that it could not process in that limited time. She saw faces after faces. Her father, the doctor she had visited, Veer in the college, Suraj smiling. On those days, she would end up with a horrible headache which later resulted in vomiting.

As the attack of her past grew intense and continuous, the ropes of self-control that had saved her all her life started to fray from the corners, waiting to be broken any time. Her muscles around her wrists always ached with the continuous pressure of her tight fists. When she rolled the rolling pin on the board to make chapati, her hands would go numb and sore. She had to take breaks to complete the chores.

On those days, when Suraj did not touch her, she would thank God for the precious time alone for herself. She could lick her wounds and relax a little, but one part of her heart and her mind always remained on guard to save her.

She knew that all nights won't be the same, and dreaded that the other nights would come. Every evening she would let out a plea to the God to save her that night, to give her one more day to tighten the knots of her strength.

Her headache started increasing and persisted for days. Occasionally, for days at a stretch, she would wake up and vomit a yellow paste. The circles around her eyes started growing and her skin went all pale.



They were on their way to the doctor when Naina looked at her reflection in the mirror. She looked like a living skeleton, her skin black at the temples and around the eyes. Her eyes were dead and distant.

She closed her eyes and leaned on the window. Roads that always made her heart flutter were now draining her of her energy, her eyes were getting strained as the scene outside changed. It reminded her of the trails of memories she had been seeing in her mind. The speed of the car made her sick, acidic feeling started to build up in the pit of her stomach. She closed her eyes and slept holding her urge to vomit all the way to the clinic. Her safety guards relaxed for a while. She knew that nobody would touch her abruptly in the car, not even Suraj. She dozed off. When she woke up, she could feel the peace and calmness in her head, like she used to feel when she used to sleep with her mother. She had not slept like this in months. Her headache had disappeared.

The doctor asked her questions about her diet and sleep pattern. He raised his eyebrows when he checked her blood pressure. Your blood pressure is a little high, he said in a worried tone and scribbled some pills and handed over the prescription to Suraj.

“Nothing to worry about. Just take these pills twice a day to control your blood pressure and some multivitamins. Meet me after one week.” he said coldly when they got up to leave. Suraj gave her the medicine right after they sat in the car. She slept again on their way back.

Her head felt light and peaceful after 3-4 days. Flashbacks came and went, Naina would pop the pill and sleep for hours to let them pass. Everything was going well until one night when Suraj touched her again. For a few days, Suraj had been taking care of her, and this was about one month since they had made love. He desired her body. Naina could not reject his claim. The burden of the exchange had already piled on her side. She had to make her payment. She wished she could say ‘no’, but then she removed her kurta and turned towards him.

That night when Suraj made love to her, she felt his hand trying to reach inside her chest ripping her skin and breaking her rib cage. It grabbed her heart in its grip. She heard frenzied laughs of Ashok and Veer, while the grip kept tightening and she struggled for her breaths. Everything happened inside her, nothing outside. She still had the control which stopped everything from coming out on her face. She knew that her control was loosening and could break at any time.

She ran towards the bathroom as soon as he had finished and rolled over her. Her headache, the thud in her heart, and the burn in her stomach returned. She vomited as soon as she bolted the door. The yellow thick paste around the drain looked back at her in disgust. She leaned back on the wall, wiped her mouth with the back of her hand, and held her head in her hands.

She pulled her hair tight to stop the rush in her head, she could feel the heat of blood running up her head with speed. When looked up, Little Naina was looking back at her. Sitting near the pot, she was staring at her, but today her eyes were not complaining. Today, they were pleading to save her.

“Don’t look at me like this!” she yelled at Little Naina throwing her hands. But Little Naina’s pleading eyes did not move. She cried at her and her helplessness. She didn’t know how to fix herself. She knelt on the floor and joined her hands together in front of Little Naina.

She looked around the bathroom, looking for the things she could harm herself with. Her eyes fell on her husband’s shaving razor. Her hands trembled as her hand reached to pick it up. She snorted her tears back and tucked her hair in her ear. Her chest was jerking with sobs. She placed the blade on her wrist, but then she realised that she didn’t have the courage to run it on her wrist. Her whole life came dancing in front of her eyes again. The burden of responsibility was heavier than her pain. The value of her family’s reputation looked far more important to her existence.

“Start my life again, the Naina you sent in this body is dead. Don’t let me rot here! Either give me my life or give me death. You have never given me anything I asked, but have some mercy now. Give me death, at least! Or give me the courage to live like this!” she pleaded, looking up.

She threw the razor blade on the floor. “I promise I won’t ask you for anything in my life. Just stop this mind of mine! Save me Save me... Save meee...!” she rocked sitting there on her knees. Her throat was burning with the acidic taste of vomit. Her eyes were burning with tears.

When Suraj knocked on the door, she quickly wiped her eyes and opened the tap to run the water at full force. She splashed water on her face.

“Just two minutes! she said between the splashes. And then she opened the door with a wide smile.

Naina came back to her bed again, not knowing, whether she had lost her battle with death or had won her life.

She waited for Suraj to come out so that she could complete her last act of the day before falling back in her hell. When Suraj came and hugged her, she gave a smile, a smile which genuine and fake at the same time. He placed a soft kiss on her forehead and slept.

That night, Naina did not move her head from his shoulder. She did not want to fight her demons all alone that night. When she slept, she kept waving away the memories and faces, all through the night. There were muscles on her temples that pulsed and ached. At one point she thought of getting up and taking her medicines. She had forgotten to take her doses that evening. She pressed her head a little to his shoulder. The compression calmed the rush of blood. She did not know when she slept.

The next day when Suraj woke up, her shoulder was sore with the weight of her head. He held her head softly with his hands and helped her to sleep on the bed and ran her thumb on her face to soothe her in her sleep. There was something sticky on her lips. Suraj turned on the light to see. There was a big splotch of blood running up to her shoulder. There was a trail of dried blood coming from her ear, reaching to the corners of her nose, and collected between the rims of her lips.

All her life she had asked a million things from GOD and He had not listened. But, that night He did, He had granted her last wish!

Seeing my body from afar, now I feel that I am finally free. They will burn this filthy body and everything with it. No eyes will fall on my chest. No hands can reach me even if they want to. Now I can breathe, I can cry freely. Once again, I can be little Naina. I can look at the roads, and run freely like I used to. At night, I can close my eyes without fear and sleep till God gives me my life back, which I didn't live.

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I did what world did to me I destroyed myself
with my own words
with my own hands
with my own thoughts.

Even after a year, she could not decide the name of the girl. For her son, she had decided that she would call him Ram, after the name of his father. However, she had never thought of a name for her daughter. She had started calling her Rama. She did not have the courage to strip the essence of Ram from her. It resonated in her gentle smile, it reminded her of Ram.

Haree did not know when Rama built up her strength and started to crawl and then run around. The black thread on her left foot, which was tied to ward off evil eyes, tightened every other month. Haree cherished her baby steps when Rama ran towards her, maintaining her balance with effort. Her heart puffed when she looked at Rama and kissed her. Rama couldn't say it, but Haree could understand her love with her small gestures.

One night, when Ashok came, Rama woke up with his moans. Lately, he had returned to his old habits. Cursing and slapping her while panting. He made weird sounds as if something was troubling him from inside and he was trying hard not to shout. His moans sounded more like grits. Haree always kept her eyes on Rama to see her movements. Even in the dark, she could judge the quality of her sleep with her body posture and breathing patterns.

She always slept curled to one side. Her breath was always deep and long. She noticed the movement on Rama's mattress. She had woken up. Without realising that Ashok was still on her, she tried to turn towards Rama. Subconsciously, she pushed him back with her hands, but he slapped her hard and continued moving in his rhythm.

"Saali, Randi! You think you can overpower me!" he said while panting.

Haree waited for him to finish so that she could go and check on her. But before Ashok could finish, she saw Rama getting up and coming towards her in the dark. Haree got up quickly, pushing Ashok with all her efforts.

Rama was in her arms when Ashok caught her by her braid and pulled back. Her head hit the edge of the wooden cot. The long-forgotten pain returned and her head spun. Rama shrieked in her arms looking out as if she had also understood that this was the time to run away from the danger, they were in.

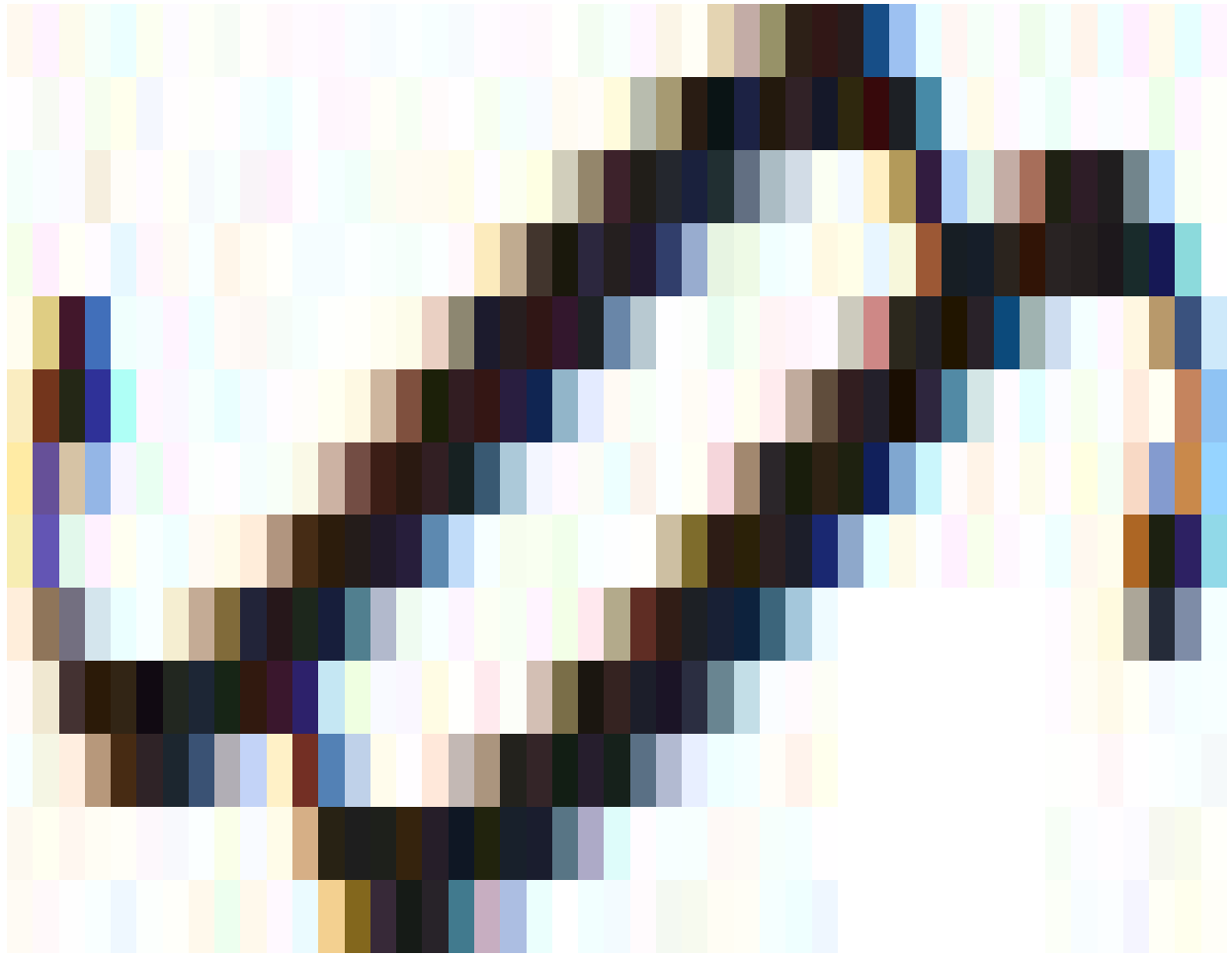
"Kutiya!" He yelled and then pulled her by her braid again. Her head bent to its maximum capacity.

"You think you escape me? You think I'll let you go so easily!" He hissed in her ear.

Then he said something which Haree could not believe that she had heard. She looked at him, her eyes, wide open in surprise. Ashok, kept laughing while dressing.

He spits in the corner and said, "Just wait and watch!" before leaving.

His words kept ringing in her ears. She kept listening to them thinking that somehow, they would change in the air automatically and the meaning behind them would change and tomorrow she would think that all her worries were in vain. But nothing changed. His words kept ringing, the meaning, and intentions in them increased with every repetition.



Rama was lying still on a brown circular table. Haree watched her from afar. She was wearing the same white frock which Haree had sewn for her, from the pieces which she had collected. She slept peacefully on her one side; her eyes closed peacefully. There were three-four men around her. One of the men from them pulled Rama towards him by her leg. He opened his zip and started to jerk off. Haree screamed out her name but Rama did not wake up. She ran to wake her up, but the distance between her and the table did not end. She kept running and all those men kept passing Rama to one another. They touched her, Haree closed her eyes shut and then opened them again. By the time Haree reached the table, all the men were laughing at her. She took Rama in her arms but her head fell on the floor like a football. She looked at the half body in her arms and wailed.

Haree woke up completely soaked up in a sweat. Her hands fumbled on the mattress to find Rama. She was sleeping in the same posture as she had

dreamt. She carefully took her in arms. She looked at her face, kissed her forehead and then hugged her. She backed up Rama's head with one hand and rocked. The images of the dream flashed; she shook her head to shrug them off but they kept appearing.

That was the first time when those dreams had started. After that day, every night, she would wake up like this. Sometimes the dream repeated and sometimes she found herself running behind Rama, trying to find her in the forest, but in any dream, she could not save Rama. Her head always dropped and she always let out a shriek before waking up.

During the day, when Rama walked and ran on the veranda. Haree kept a close watch on her steps and her head. While watching her, Haree's neck moved in shrugs. She did not notice this behaviour of hers until her mother-in-law told her one day.

"What is wrong? why do you keep shaking your head?" She asked.

"Nothing! Maybe I just slept on the wrong side and my neck is aching." She said, jerking her neck once more, this time intentionally.

She was in the kitchen, cooking boiled rice for Rama when from the corner of her eyes, she saw Ashok stepping into the kitchen. She ran to pick Rama up, but he had already taken her in his arms. She stood there, looking at them helplessly opening and closing her weak fingers. Rama looked at Ashok, it was the first time that he had taken her in his arms. So far, she played in her grandfather's and mother's arms only. Ashok and his wife never came near her. They walked past her as if she was invisible and her voice did not reach them.

Haree shook her head again, shaking off the visions of her dreams, as Ashok kissed Rama on her lips. Rama cried, stretching her tiny arm towards her mother. Haree leaned forward to touch her but Ashok moved back and laughed. He kissed her one more time on the lips and Haree winced on Rama's behalf. She knew how it felt. How disgusted she felt when he did that to her! She could not let him touch his daughter like this, but she did not know how to do it.

“Your daughter will replace you one day!” His words, his eyes, and his laugh tormented her day and night.

The silent arrangement between her and Ashok had broken. All the hair pulling and banging of the head had returned. Haree did not let him touch her so easily, she always tried to save herself from him. But her body soon gave up on his strength. When he talked while he was on top of her, she wished she could just chop off her ears and stop all those words from reaching her, but those words reached and planted themselves deep in her soul. They ran like a fireball in her veins. She could feel the bitterness mixing with her blood and running through her body every day.

Her room was stuffed with his words, with his warnings, the dirty vision which he made her see. The walls of the room soaked them all and then dropped them when she slept. Haree would wake up all wet in that dirt.

It was after the second birthday of Rama that Haree woke up again, screaming and crying. She had seen what she did not want to see. Even thinking it gave her shivers. Her hands trembled when she lifted Rama’s frock to check between her legs for stains of blood. She knew it was just a dream, but the mother inside her did not accept the difference between reality and dream. She ran her fingers to check for any harm. Rama, she was safe. Her daughter was still untouched, sleeping sound by her side.

It was the last time she saw her shadow. It came out of her, sat beside her, both looking at Rama - unmoved, without words. Tears were rolling from the shadow’s eyes. Haree looked at her confused, then touched her cheeks. They were dry. Her eyes were dry. The shadow cried and wailed sitting in front her. Haree wanted to ask her but she had never talked to her before and Haree knew that even if asked, she won’t answer back. That shadow did not have any mouth or ear on her face. The skin around her mouth was all plain, and the side of her head was flat. Like god has forgotten to give her lips and ears.

When her shadow stopped crying, she took Haree’s hand and reached toward Rama. She made Haree touch Rama’s face lovingly. She looked at Haree and smiled with her eyes. The shadow’s finger traced the edges of Rama’s lips, pouted and pink like rose buds. Her hands stopped at the bridge of her nose.

She ran her index finger over it. And then, she pinched Rama's nose tightly. Haree looked at her horrified when Rama moved her head frantically and opened her pouty lips. The shadow closed her mouth with Haree's other hand. Rama threw her hands and legs in the air, struggling for air.

Haree tried to remove her hands but the pressure was so intense that she could not. She kept staring at little Rama. How her body was fighting for oxygen. Shadow let out a deep heart-tearing cry when Rama stopped moving. When shadow removed her hands, Haree took Rama in her arms and patted her cheeks to wake her up. Rama's head moved lifelessly on her arms. Her eyes closed as if she was still in deep slumber. Horrified, Haree looked at the shadow. She pulled her kurta at the shoulder but there was no touch. Her hand moved in the air, trying to hold something but it went through the shadow. Before Haree could say anything, the shadow disappeared as silently as it came.

Haree howled like a wolf into that darkness. Rama, lying still in her arms, moved to and fro as she rocked and cried and shrieked. All the tears that she thought she did not have poured in multiple streams from her eyes. Her chest ached when she shouted. She called Ram, but he did not come! She called her mother to save her daughter, but she, too, did not come! She cried but nobody came!

Later that night she picked up Ram's diary and struck out the last remaining thing on his dream list.

1. Good food every day.
2. Cycle for Baba.
3. College fees.
4. House with different rooms.
5. Marriage.
6. A little girl :)

ABOUT THE AUTHOR



Monika Bhatti was born and raised in a small village called/named Gamri in Delhi. Her father was a farmer and her mother, a housewife. Monika was fortunate that she was raised in a large family of aunts and cousins, which helped her to understand their inner worlds.

She did her graduation in

Literature from Delhi university where she falls in love with stories. Later, she completed her master's in computer application and currently working in an IT company.

Her love for stories never faded. Though she is a software engineer, she always wanted to become a writer. This is her debut novel which talks about women's suppression and child abuse. In her words, her childhood plays an important part in this story. Her surrounding is what shaped it.

This book is her way to educate people about this topic. And how important it is to be kind towards others. Be it, Men or Women. Be it a girl or boy child. No human on this earth deserves such violence. This book is her attempt to spread the message of kindness and love.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

If you are reading this, thank you for your time. More than anybody, I think pain inspired me to write this book. The pain I saw around me. The pain I saw in the eyes of the women around me. This is a story I had to tell.

Growing up, I saw a lot of things around me. I could not understand them at that time. But later in life, when I went through the same situation and emotion, I understood every silent word we hide. All the women in my life have impacted me in some way which in turn inspired me to write this book. And for that, I wish to thank all of them from the bottom of my heart. Without them, this would not be possible.

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